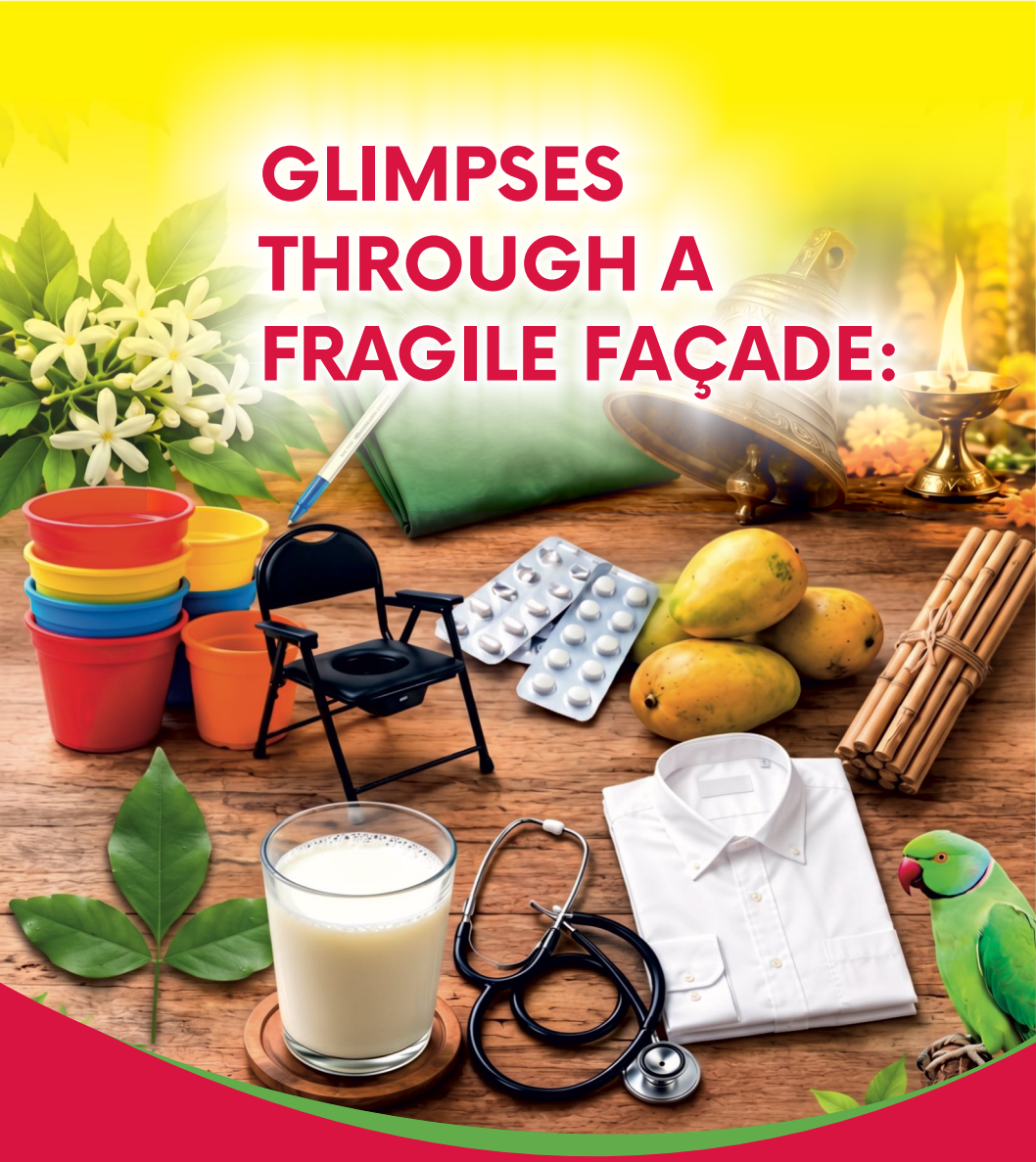
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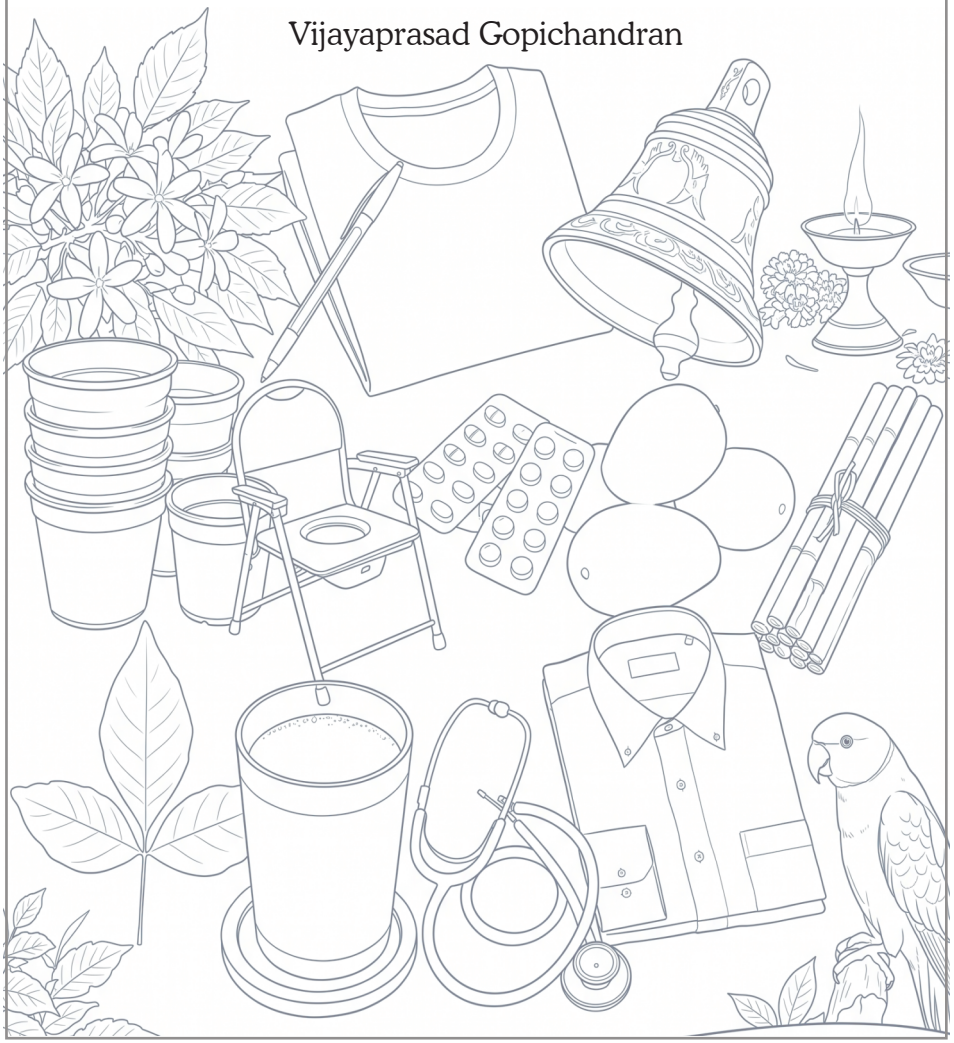
Stories of illness, vulnerability and healing

Vijayaprasad Gopichandran

Glimpses through a fragile façade:

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This is a work of narrative non-fiction and clinical fiction. While based on true clinical encounters from twenty-five years of medical practice, all names, identifying characteristics, and specific circumstances have been altered to preserve patient confidentiality and medical privacy.

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Preface

As a practicing primary care doctor, I get an opportunity to be part of the life stories of many of my patients. Some of these are stories of deprivation due to illness, illness due to deprivation, resilience in the face of illness, and illness precipitated by a chronic struggle against oppression. These are irritating, enraging, funny, inspiring, warm stories and everything in-between. In the otherwise mundane work of a primary health care provider, the only interesting aspect is the opportunity to witness these stories and be part of them. Sometimes, I am a witness to these stories from outside. But in some of these stories, I am an integral character, participating, changing the course of events and sometimes even the outcome.

I often ask myself are these my stories to tell? Am I misappropriating their narratives and converting them into public entertainment? But then, what is story telling if not decently and respectfully peeping into a person's life? All of us have an innate curiosity to know who the other person is. The society requires people to wear masks to conceal anger, fear, disgust, lust, shame, grief and vanity. But we all have the inherent desire to break through this mask and see what is hidden inside, the true person. Medical story telling operates in this plane of decent and respectful peep into the patient's life. It goes beyond the formal interactions between the doctor and the patient

in the clinical space. It takes us into the intimate thoughts of the patient and the doctor. It lets us go into their consultation rooms, houses, bedrooms and explore who they are and why they behave the way they do.

What makes story telling decent and respectful? Sometimes peeping into another person's life violates their boundaries and happens without their knowledge, is pathological, it is voyeurism. Whereas in medical narratives and story telling, the wall of privacy is dissolved intentionally with the full participation of the patient and the doctor. Decorum and safety are the key operative words of a decent medical story telling. Refraining from unnecessary dramatization, making silly caricatures of people, and deifying the doctor as a hero helps maintain decorum. Protecting the private information of the patients help maintain their safety.

Medical story telling respects the individual. In medical stories the reader is not just given a keyhole through which they peep into the patients' life for a cheap thrill. They are invited inside the room, to participate respectfully and know. The story telling practices a non-judgmental stance, where even while narrating a morally reprehensible act, it does not make judgments, but just shows what is happening as it is. The gaze is humane, inquisitive and respectful.

A good medical story turns the reader's gaze inwards. The reader starts relating to the story either as the patient, or as the doctor, and go into their own mind to understand how they would have reacted in the same situation. When the vulnerability of the story is expressed with honesty, the reader is exposed to their own frailties, and it removes the safety that a detached onlooker has. While reading about the patient's pain, suffering, and strength, the reader starts cataloguing their own thoughts and feelings. The reading of the medical story becomes an act of deep empathy.

The clinical interaction itself is a form of legitimized and formalized peeping into the private life of a patient. The patient exposes their body and their mind to the doctor. Doctors are taught that it is not enough to just view the pathology that the patient has, but it is crucial to see them as a whole person. This involves knowing the person who has the disease rather than just what disease the person has. Medical stories are crucial for doctors, care givers and patients. When clinicians, nurses and care givers read them they gain an insider perspective to what it means to live with an illness, and sharpens their empathy. When the patients and care givers read it, it helps understand the workings of a doctor or health care provider's mind. Such medical stories reduce the immense loneliness that is characteristic of an illness experience. Respectful medical story telling makes the society see through disease, decay, suffering and death without flinching their face and closing their eyes. It demystifies medicine, illness and suffering and helps enhance empathy and understanding.

Here is another set of 22 stories in my series of medical short story collections. In the first volume, I had explored loneliness, social complexities, diseases among the most vulnerable and the thought process of a young clinician in the making. In this book, I delve into the inner world of the doctor and the patient.

1. The clinician's gaze: This section has four stories, all of which describe the thought process of the doctor. Unconscious prejudices, professional rivalries, procedural anxiety, and moments where the doctor learns to trust both colleagues and the body's natural resilience are covered in these stories.

2. The inner world: This section dives into the mental space of patients who experience mental health issues. The narratives capture the lived experiences of mental illness, psychosexual taboo, and the philosophical intersections with medicine.

3. Hidden burdens and silence: This section has three stories. Stories exploring medical diagnoses concealed behind domestic and social façades, familial secrecy, cultural taboos around gender and marital suitability, and the heavy price of shielding loved ones.

4. Solitude: This is a recurrent theme in both the volumes. It is difficult to remove loneliness and isolation from illness. These are stories reflecting on the physical and emotional architecture of growing old, poverty, isolation in rural communities, and the unusual solidarity that emerges around frail bodies.

5. Rural medical practice: The five stories in this section capture the unique cadence of grassroots medicine including, intergenerational mentorship, severe resource limits, existential fatigue, and unshakeable hope.

I invite you to read these stories and enter the lives of my patients to understand their illness and their stories. I have changed their names, village names and identities in all the stories. I have also fictionalized many of the stories to maintain dignity and respect. However the human emotions, sentiments and feelings are genuine and reflect the truth.

Vijayaprasad Gopichandran

The clinician's gaze

Chapter 1

The fragrance of Nithyamalli

Ponnuthayi did not know her age. When asked about it her response would be, "In our times nobody noted down dates and times of birth. I know I was born during the peak summer month of Chittirai. My mother used to say the temple Chithirai thiruvizha was happening." There were so many lines on her face, crisscrossing all the way from the forehead to the corners of her eyes, from the cheeks to corners of her mouth. The hair on her head was milky white, dense and silky. There were so many broken ends in her hair that they would always be flying around without anything to anchor them in place. Even if she tried to knot her hair on the back of her head, the loose ends in the front just over her forehead would keep fluttering in the wind. She must be more than 70 years of age, but she did not have diabetes or hypertension or any chronic illness. The only deformity she had were the bent knees, which gave her a unique waddling gait. Her saree would always be draped around her, as though worn in a hurry, asymmetrically, unevenly and in a haphazard manner. Of late Ponnuthayi had developed dense cataracts in both her eyes. She was also slowly losing her ability to hear. To compensate for her hearing disability, Ponnuthayi spoke

with a loud, resonating, ringing voice. If she said, "Who is there?" the voice would ring so loud that all people within 500 m radius would turn in her direction.

She walked into the clinic and sat in front of me.

"How are you? Everything ok?" she asked with a musical intonation towards the end of the question.

"Please come Amma. I am fine. How are you?"

"Why would anything be wrong with me? I came just to get some medicines for my knee pains."

"Have you had your breakfast?"

"All this land was ours earlier. We used to cultivate here. Paddy two crops a year. Those days, we did not have the three crops a year rice variety. The rice was stronger, tastier, more nutritious and better when we planted two crops a year. Now no taste, no quality."

Ponnuthayi belonged to a rich family. They were landowners and farmers. The clinic space was built on land that was bought from her husband thirty years ago. She made it a point to mention it during every visit.

"I don't know if you were even born at that time. It was MGR's reign period. Those were golden days" she said and got up to leave.

"Yes, you have told this to me Amma."

"So what, you can listen to it again. Can't you?"

Ponnuthayi had just a few cents of land left in her name now. She had her own home and lived alone. She lived in a big house with a nice big garden. I had visited once and saw the thick untamed

nithyamalli flower bushes all along the stone walls around her house. Coming to the clinic was her weekly outing. On all other days, she would just sit on the thinnai of her big house and watch the activities of the village as they unfold.

It was a Monday morning, and patients kept coming in a steady stream. An intern from a medical institution had been posted in the clinic for community based clinical experience for a month.

"Please sit in the next room and start seeing patients. If you have any doubts or concerns, please don't hesitate to ask me. Welcome to our clinic Dr. Nivetha and hope you have a productive stay with us."

Nivetha gave a shy smile and walked to the adjacent room where she started seeing patients. Usually, my clinic tends to be very loud as many of the patients are elderly and have various degrees of hearing loss. "THATHA…THIS TABLET HAS TO BE TAKEN TWICE DAILY", "AMMA…YOU MUST REDUCE YOUR SALT INTAKE" I would find myself raising my voice often and the clinic would sound like a loud fish market space. But Nivetha's room was quiet and peaceful. When I walked cross her room to get some water to drink, I noticed there was a patient sitting opposite her. She was busy seeing patients. But there was no noise. As I stood there watching, one elderly man walked into her room. Nivetha made him sit comfortably.

"What brought you to the clinic thatha?" Nivetha asked softly.

The old man sat there without any response. He gestured with his hand pointed to his ears and said "I cannot hear…"

Nivetha moved her chair closer to the old man, leaned in and softly and slowly spoke right into his ear.

At times she would move away and show hand gestures and move her lips slowly and clearly so that the old man could recognize the hand gestures and read her lips. They had started communicating without much noise.

That evening as the clinic closed, I packed my bags and started to leave. Nivetha was also getting ready to leave. When she saw me going out, she ran up to me,

"Sir, may I also leave now?"

"Of course, they will be closing the clinic shortly. So please leave. Where are you staying? How do you plan to go back?"

"I am staying in the nearby town in a paying guest accommodation sir. I will take the bus"

"If you are taking the bus you must leave by 3.30 PM. Didn't the staff tell you? That is the last bus out of here at this time of the day. The next bus out of here is only at 7 PM. You won't have any other mode of transport till then."

"Ohh…is there anything I can do here till that time sir?"

"No no…please come with me. I will drop you in the town. From tomorrow, just head out by 3.30 PM and take that bus to the town."

"Thank you, sir"

I have an autorickshaw on hire that drops me in the clinic, waits for me there till the clinic is done and drops me back in the town, from where I take the train to my home. We got into the autorickshaw and headed out towards the town.

"How was the clinic today? Everything ok?"

"Yes sir, I am just getting used to the formulary that is available in the clinic and the doses of medicines. I hope I will get used to it soon."

Four years in an urban tertiary hospital and the intern thinks rural outpatient work is just about reading the formulary.

"I am sure you will be fine. Do you find my clinic to be disturbing and noisy?"

"Ahh!! Not a problem sir. I am used to noisy surroundings. In the medical college it used to be noisier than this"

"I was wondering how your clinic runs so quietly"

"I don't know sir. Somehow, I never feel the need to raise my voice"

I dismissed what she said in my mind though outwardly I smiled at her politely. I will wait till the fascination of a new rural setting starts wearing out. Then her clinic will sound like mine. Kids nowadays think they have everything figured out!

The cab arrived inside the town and we both got down. I said my goodbye and walked towards the railway station. She walked in the other direction towards the market.

I went to that clinic on two days a week, Mondays and Fridays. The other days I worked in another rural clinic about 100 KM south of this place. That Friday as usual I reached the clinic around 8.40 AM. As I walked in, I noticed Nivetha was already in her room with a book. Patients had not yet started coming. I walked past her room and went to mine, unpacked and sat down with my breakfast. At 9, the clinic would start buzzing with activity and so I had to quickly finish eating.

“Excuse me sir. May I come in?” It was Nivetha.

“Yes, yes, please come in and sit down. Have you had your breakfast? Want to join me? Nothing great, just a few sandwiches”

“No sir, I had breakfast before I came here. Just wanted to say hello before I started the clinic”

“How have the past three days been? All ok?”

“Yes sir, I am slowly getting a hang of the clinic. I like it here. Like you said on Monday, there are a lot of older people. Many of them were in fact asking me when you will be coming.”

“Yeah… that happens a lot. When they get comfortable with one doctor, they prefer to see them again.”

“Yes sir, other than that, everything is going on smoothly”

I smiled at her and got up to clean up and start the clinic. She excused herself and went to her room. As I washed my hands and rinsed my mouth in the sink, I saw myself in the mirror. “Other than that, everything is going on smoothly” her voice rang again in my ears. Patients asking for me is bothering her? Why would it bother her? I have been here longer than her. Obviously, patients would ask for me. Nowadays young doctors want recognition, respect, autonomy from day one. I washed my hands and walked out to the clinic and started seeing patients for the day.

“It is Friday. That is why I came.” Ponnuthayi announced as she slowly waddled into my room and sat on the chair.

“Good morning, Amma. I saw you just this Monday. What happened? What brings you here?”

“I did not come to see you.”

“Ohh.. ok.” I said and I did not understand why Ponnuthayi had come.

“I came to visit my granddaughter…my dear pethi…”

Many of the staff in our clinic are from the local villages. There was a nurse, Rosy who was from the same village as Ponnuthayi.

“You came to see Rosy sister?”

“No…not that girl. Why would I come to see her? If I want to see her I can walk out to the portico of my house and call out her name..Rosy…and she will run and come”

Yes, that made sense. Why would Ponnuthayi come all the way to see Rosy who lives in her neighborhood?

“Then who is it that you came to see?”

“I came to see the new doctor. She is such a sweet girl.”

It was interesting that Ponnuthayi had made friends with Nivetha already. I was also surprised that Nivetha had made friends with someone like Ponnuthayi. She must have left a deep impact for a person as tough as Ponnuthayi, with her knee disability, to walk to the clinic exclusively to see her.

“That is surprising. You came all the way to see the new doctor?”

“Just like how I like seeing you, I like seeing her too. She is such a sweet girl. I consider her my own granddaughter. I brought her nithyamalli flowers from my garden” Ponnuthayi flashed a black color plastic cover that was knotted. She got up and walked out, and headed to the next room. Through the window I could see

Ponnuthayi and Nivetha hugging each other. Ponnuthayi gingerly opened the black plastic cover and took out a strand of nithyamalli flowers. She placed it on Nivetha's head and put a pin on it so that it would stand on her hair. They held hands and sat down and talked for some time. Then Ponnuthayi got up and walked out. There was a happiness in Ponnuthayi's waddle as she went out. How did Nivetha make friends with Ponnuthayi? Nivetha's clinic continued to be quiet and calm. Around mid day, I went to the registration counter to see how many patients had registered. As I walked past Nivetha's room the sweet scent of nithyamalli wafted through the air, cutting through the harsh antiseptic smell of the clinic. We had been visited by 50 patients from morning, and I had seen less than 20. That means Nivetha must have seen the rest. Not only was she seeing a lot of patients, but she was also seeing them quietly and efficiently. She was also making connections and friends with patients. The day progressed with thoughts of Nivetha's calm efficiency and patient friendly nature popping up in my mind periodically.

Two weeks passed and it was a Friday morning. Routinely once a week an outreach clinic was conducted by our doctors and nurses in the villages to treat common minor medical problems and to refill prescriptions for chronic conditions like diabetes and hypertension in the village. This Friday, the staff nurses had prepared for a special outreach camp in one of the villages. This was a camp in which we were taking some specialist doctors, gynecologist, pediatrician, orthopedic surgeon to offer consultations to the people. I invited Nivetha to the camp,

"We are going to Pattipakkam village today for the specialty camp. Will you also come along?"

"Sure sir… I would love to"

"It will be a nice experience for you to visit the village and meet the people"

"Ahh..yes sir. I have already visited all the seven villages around here sir. I have been to Pattipakkam twice sir"

"Oh..so this is not your first rural visit. That is good to know"

"Not at all sir. I have asked the sisters and have accompanied them on all the outreach camps to all the villages over the past two weeks sir." Nivetha said this with a smile.

Was that a benign smile? Was that a sardonic smile of "been there done that"? I did not know. But I smiled back and we got into the mini bus to go to Pattipakkam.

At Pattipakkam the camp site was well organized. There was a shamiana with tables and chairs laid out methodically for separate specialty clinics. There was a small gathering of villagers patiently waiting for us to arrive and set up camp. As we walked towards the shamiana, a middle aged woman, who looked vaguely familiar started running towards us with a broad smile. She folded her hands together in an expression of greeting and rushed quickly towards us. I folded my hands and greeted her and smiled. She rushed past me and went and embraced Nivetha. For a second I was surprised. I have been visiting Pattipakkam for two years on a regular basis for outreach camps. Even last month we came here to plan and organize this camp event in the village. I recollected that the lady was the Panchayat leader's wife. I met her when we visited the Panchayat president. And the welcome was for Nivetha! The puzzled look on my face must have been revealing. Nivetha immediately turned to me and introduced the lady to me, "This is Parameshwari, the Panchayat president"

"You mean the Panchayat president's wife? Yes, I have met her when I came to discuss this camp last month" and I smiled at the lady.

"No…no sir. She is the actual Panchayat president. Her husband functions on her behalf and makes most decisions." said Nivetha.

Nivetha, Parameshwari, our staff nurses and some other villagers who had gathered there started laughing.

I stood there as though my feet were planted in the ground. I felt a feeling that was a mixture of embarrassment and frustration. Nivetha was obviously not a routine young doctor posted to a rural clinic. There was something special about her.

The camp went on smoothly. Nivetha ran between the various specialty tents and coordinated the consultations and referrals like a professional. As I sat there and watched I could see her interacting with the community comfortably. She was handling everything so smoothly. We wound up the clinic by lunch time and left back to the clinic. That evening as I boarded the train to get home, I sat next to the window. As the train left the station and picked up speed the wind blew on my face. The wind was cool and refreshing. Nivetha was not just a "know it all" young intern with an attitude. She was smart and efficient. She just seemed to know who she was, what she wanted and what she could offer the clinic. Maybe I should stop seeing her as a student who is there to learn, and see her as a colleague who is working for the people.

That Monday morning when I entered the clinic as usual Nivetha was there before me. She had started seeing patients. Ponnuthayi came right up to me.

"Is it true that Nivetha is leaving next week and wont be working here?"

"Yes, she came for training. Her training was for 1 month. The one-month period is finishing and so she must leave"

"You cannot let her go. She is very good. Make her stay here and work with us"

"I cannot do that Amma. She is a good doctor. She is young and she must decide her future. I cannot compel her to do anything she does not want to do"

"You are always talking all these high and mighty things. I will ask her myself" saying this Ponnuthayi got up and walked away. I could see through the window that she was in Nivetha's room. They were talking for some time and then Ponnuthayi got up and walked out. This time her walk was tired and slow.

The following Friday, the clinic took on an air that was entirely unfamiliar.

Usually, as the clock struck three in the afternoon, there would be the quiet rustle of files being packed, the clatter of medicine bottles being returned to their racks, and the hurried goodbyes of staff eager to catch their transport. But today, the wooden benches in the waiting hall remained occupied. In the center of the room, on a small table cleared of prescription pads, sat a large steel vessel piled high with sweet kesari, roasted groundnuts, and bananas.

Ponnuthayi had arrived before noon, wearing her trademark unevenly draped saree, barking orders in her bell-like, thunderous voice. Rosy and the other nurses scampered about under her direction, hanging a modest garland of colour paper decorations

over the entrance of the consultation room. Ponnuthayi had organized the entire farewell herself, brooking no arguments from anyone least of all from me.

Around 3:00 PM, a small group of villagers drifted into the clinic. Among them was Parameshwari, who walked in with two other women from Pattipakkam carrying small steel tiffin carriers filled with homemade snacks. One by one, they stepped forward to speak.

Parameshwari spoke first, her hands folded reverently. “When the young doctor came to our village, she didn’t just sit beneath the shamiana waiting for sick people to line up. She walked into our courtyards. She sat on our steps, asked about our water supply, and listened. We didn’t feel like we were being examined; we felt like we were being visited by our own daughter.”

An elderly farmer from the edge of the village cleared his throat, his hands calloused from decades of tilling the soil. “Most big doctors talk down to us, or shout at us like we are deaf children,” he said, smiling bashfully. “Dr. Nivetha spoke so gently that I had to lean in close just to hear her. And strangely, that made me listen to every single word she said about my sugar medicine.”

I stood leaning against the doorframe of my room, listening quietly. All my initial misgivings, my irritated comparisons, my wounded pride over her quiet consults, my assumptions about the arrogance of the youth dissolved completely. Her quietness had never been a sign of inexperience. It had been her way of leaning into the patient’s world, making space for their dignity rather than imposing her own authority.

Then Ponnuthayi stepped forward.

Her waddling gait was slow today, weighed down by the occasion. In her wrinkled, trembling hands, she held another knotted black plastic cover. She opened it to reveal a fresh strand of nithyamalli, fragrant and white. With her cataract-clouded eyes fixed on Nivetha, she reached up and pinned it into the young doctor's hair, her fingers lingering against the soft strands. Then she took out a nice pink soft Turkey towel and wrapped it around Nivetha's shoulders as a mark of respect.

"Who will come and sit with me now?" Ponnuthayi's booming voice finally wavered, cracking under a sudden swell of grief. "Who will listen to an old woman talk about the old paddy crops and the lands we lost?"

Nivetha's composure broke. The quiet, self-possessed intern stepped forward and wrapped her arms tightly around the old woman. Ponnuthayi buried her face into Nivetha's shoulder, her fragile, curved back heaving with quiet sobs. Nivetha held her close, tears streaming freely down her cheeks, murmuring soft words of comfort into the milky-white halo of Ponnuthayi's hair. For a long minute, nobody spoke. The clinic was utterly silent, save for the muffled weeping of an old grandmother and the young doctor she had claimed as her own.

Watching them, a profound warmth settled in my chest. Medicine was not merely a science of accurate dosages, crowded OPD tallies, and sharp clinical instincts; it is an art of human connection, of empathy and quiet grace. In one short month, this young woman had won the hearts of an entire community not by asserting her knowledge, but by demonstrating her love. She was not merely a promising student completing a rural rotation. She was, beyond a shadow of a doubt, an exceptional physician in the making.

After the sweet kesari was shared and the villagers slowly trickled out with blessings and farewells, Nivetha went to pack her bags for the final time.

I turned back into my consultation room. The afternoon sun was casting long, amber shadows across my desk. I pulled open the side drawer, took out our official clinic letterhead. I uncapped my fountain pen and began to write. I didn't use the standard phrases from the intern evaluation proforma. I wrote about Pattipakkam, about the quietness of her room, and how an entire village had come to say goodbye with kesari and tears. When I signed my name at the bottom, the sharp, sweet scent of Ponnuthayi's nithyamalli was still lingering in the air.

Chapter 2

The precious vault of clinical memories

"Doctor, she has been struggling to breathe since last night. Neither of us have slept even one wink. Please help us"

Kannan, clad in white dhoti and a crisp white cotton shirt, was frantic. Kothai, his wife was bent over, sitting on the stone bench outside the clinic. She was breathing fast and with a lot of effort. Her eyes were closed, but she was struggling hard to take in each breath. With every agonizing breath, her mouth opened, her nostrils flared and whole neck and chest moved up and down violently, trying to take in as much air as she possibly could. Her face was in a painful frown. There were streaks of white lines extending from her eyes down her cheeks. They were the telltale tracks of the salt of dried up tears. There was an overwhelming exhaustion on Kothai's face.

"Come inside ayya. Here… let me give you a hand, let us bring amma inside the treatment room."

I supported her on her left side while Kannan took the right and we gently brought her to the treatment room. The day was just starting and I just got off from the bus and entered the clinic. Kannan and

Kothai waiting outside the clinic was the first sight that welcomed me. I dropped my bag on the table by the side and took out my stethoscope. When I placed the stethoscope on Kothai's chest, all I could hear were the crumpling of her saree. There were no breath sounds. In medicine, this is silent chest, an absolute nightmare for the doctor. It means air is not entering the chest, mostly because the air passages are all tightly blocked.

"Does amma have moochu izhuppu (local Tamil word for asthma)?"

Kannan looked confused and agitated. He showed a hand gesture to indicate that he did not know.

"I mean, does she get this kind of a breathing problem frequently?"

"Never before, this is the first time"

I rushed to the consultation room which had all my equipment, took them and came back. Kothai was in deep distress and was unable to sit in the room. She kept trying to get up. But Kannan held her by her shoulder and kept whispering, "Everything will become alright. Just a few minutes… patience…patience…"

I bent down and tried to tie the blood pressure cuff around her right arm. She had to use both her hands, press them against her thighs, to create a force to draw in air into her lungs. So, her hand was not free. I struggled to tie the cuff. The blood pressure was very low. I clipped the pulse oximeter on her right index finger tip. But she could not keep her hand steady. Kannan came to help. He held Kothai's arm steady and firm and kept whispering, "One minute, just one more minute. Allow the doctor to check you…please ma…please ma…" The pulse oximeter showed a very low reading, which indicated a critical emergency. Her lungs were not getting

enough air. Her body was not getting enough oxygen. I took all the equipment and placed them on the table. I walked quicky to the nebulizer machine and hooked her up to the nebulizer and started her on medications to try and open up her tightly closed airways.

"Ayya, please be here. I will come back in just 2 minutes" I said and I rushed to my room. I kept my bag in my cupboard, arranged all the equipment back in their regular places. Meanwhile the clinic staff started coming in for the day's work.

"Good morning sir!" said staff nurse Shantha.

"Sister, there is an acute asthma patient in the treatment room. I have started her on nebulization. I will write down the case record. Could you load Inj. Dexamethasone 2 ml and give it intravenously to her?"

"Yes sir! I will get on it"

I went to the stock room to check for nebulizer medicine stock. My thoughts ran back to all the acute severe asthma patients I have managed in the past.

"Don't you know you must titrate the aminophylline infusion slowly? Your stupidity is going to cost this patient her life!" the voice of my Professor. Prakash, head of department of general medicine, reverberated through the ward. I was an intern and had started a patient with acute severe asthma on an aminophylline infusion. It was my first time starting that infusion. It was an era before infusion pumps which automatically deliver the right amount of medicine into the patients' veins. The intern had to calculate the drip rate based on the dose of the medicine by looking at the speed at which the drips were falling and matching it by the seconds hand of the watch. It required absolute attention and focus. A small mistake

can deliver excess medicine or low dose to a patient. I had set the infusion very fast and it had led to a complication. The patient had developed ventricular tachycardia, a nearly fatal heart condition. The mistake weighed very heavily on me. I still get nightmares of that day.

"Doctor, I have given the dexamethasone intravenous injection." Shantha reported as she walked into the stock room.

"Thank you sister. How is she now? Any better?"

"No doctor, she is still struggling to breathe"

I was worried about what I was missing. Maybe her air passages were so tightly closed that the nebulized medications is not even reaching the airways. Nowadays we don't give aminophylline infusions. It is a treatment of the past. There was no other treatment option available for me at the clinic. I may have to refer her in an ambulance on oxygen to a higher centre.

I got back to the treatment room. The patients in the out patient clinic had not yet started coming.

Kothai was still struggling to sit still. The nebulizer mask had moved towards the left. A large portion of the nebulized medicine was going outside and only a little bit into Kothai's open mouth. The struggle to breathe was relentless. I needed some more information.

"Ayya…did anything strange happen yesterday that led to this condition?"

"Nothing strange, happened doctor. It was a routine Sunday evening. We went to Church in the morning and came back by lunch time. She cooked lunch and we ate it. Around 6 PM in the

evening she started coughing. It started as a mild cough and slowly worsened and by 8 PM she was unable to breathe. She started crying and asking for help. But what can we do at 8 PM at night. There is no doctor in our village. This is the closest hospital for us. So I boiled some water and made her drink some hot water. But nothing was helping. She was struggling all night."

I just needed to ask the right questions. I put my stethoscope once again on her chest. I could hear soft and faint breath sounds now. The chest was no longer silent. But the loud wheezing that is typical in a patient with asthma was not yet there. The airways were still tightly closed. I decided it was time to try something aggressive to help this woman.

"Shantha sister. Get me an ampoule of adrenaline and a 3-millilitre syringe," I said, my voice cutting through the hiss of the ineffective nebulizer.

As Shantha snapped the glass neck of the ampoule, my mind slipped backwards across the years, straight into the pharmacology department demonstration room. Second year MBBS.

Professor Rachel sat across the examination table, immaculate in a starched cotton saree, her pen balanced gracefully between her fingers.

"Tell me the dose, dilution, and route of administration of adrenaline in status asthmaticus," she had demanded in that crisp, elegant Anglo-Indian accent.

Back then, the words had turned to chalk in my mouth. I was clutching a cheap Reynolds pen so hard my knuckles were white, my feet drumming an anxious rhythm against the rung of the wooden chair. "Will you stop fidgeting and answer me now?" she

had snapped. I knew the answer, I had rehearsed it until midnight, yet my vocal cords seized up like clamped airways, trapping the knowledge behind a wall of pure terror. "Get up and leave. I had greater expectations from you," she had dismissed me coldly. I had walked out in burning shame, carrying that silence like a stone in my gut for years.

Shantha handed me the loaded syringe. The clear liquid inside looked almost weightless, yet it carried the entire burden of Kothai's life.

I wiped Kothai's thigh with a spirit swab, gathering the muscle of the thigh firmly between my thumb and forefinger. Kothai didn't even flinch at the cold alcohol; her entire existence was consumed by the violent, desperate heave of her neck muscles pulling for air.

I angled the needle at ninety degrees and pressed it home smoothly through the skin.

Zero point five millilitres, I answered across the span of a decade, looking straight into the phantom gaze of Professor Rachel.

I depressed the plunger steadily.

One in one thousand. Undiluted.

The fluid emptied into the vascular muscle bed. I withdrew the needle and pressed a cotton swab against the puncture.

Intramuscular, Professor. Right here. In the thigh.

I hadn't been able to say it then, paralyzed by the fear of an examination. But here, stripped of academic pretense, in a modest clinic where a woman sat suffocating on a stone bench, the answer

finally delivered itself, not as memorized syllables to earn marks, but as medicine to save a life.

Within moments, the tight knot in Kothai's chest began to yield. The frantic, agonizing flaring of her nostrils slowed. Her shoulders dropped an inch, then two. The breathless storm was breaking.

The medicine had worked its magic. But I knew that the effect of adrenaline is transient. It just bought us time. Kannan was happy to see Kothai quietening down.

"Doctor, looks like the injection is working. She is getting better"

How do I tell him this is only temporary and I was not sure how long this relief will last. I smiled at Kannan and walked into the consultation room.

"Shantha sister, keep the nebulization going. Add all three medicines in it and keep it going. I will see some patients and come back."

The out patient clinic had started crowding and I had to attend to other patients. I went and started seeing patients. In between patients, I would keep looking through the partially open door of the treatment room. I would check on Kannan and Kothai. They were doing ok. The nebulization was going on. It was difficult to focus on other patients when there was a sick patient in the clinic who required all my attention.

"Doctor, the rash in my left foot is bothering me too much" It was a 26 year old man.

The rash looked red, inflamed and was oozing some fluid.

"The rash is itching so bad, I scratch it and it starts bleeding. The itch reduces only when it bleeds"

I diagnosed it as eczematous dermatitis a skin condition that requires treatment with ointment applied on the rash and tablets to relieve the itching. My mind was pre-occupied with Kothai and how I am going to handle her.

“Sir, the itching started last week when I went to my brother in law’s birthday party. They served prawn and fish. Sea foods don’t sit well with me. It must have been that sea food. Isn’t it doctor?”

“Possible, some form of allergies can worsen eczema”

“Could it be because of alcohol doctor? I drink one quarter every Sunday. Should I stop drinking?”

On any other day, I would have patiently sat with this man and addressed every question. But today was not ‘any other day’. I wanted to just tell him off by saying, “No doctor in their sane mind will prescribe that you drink alcohol. Stop drinking now.” But I restrained myself and smiled at him and stood up.

“One last question doctor, can I wear socks and shoes to work?”

It seemed like there would be no end to his questions about something as simple and mundane as a skin rash. With all the concerns about Kothai overwhelming my mind, I did not think that for me this is just a simple skin rash, but for him it is something scary and irritating.

“If you are comfortable you can wear socks and shoes, otherwise please wear slippers” I said impatiently, getting ready to go to see Kothai.

“In that case can you give me a medical certificate that I should not weak socks and shoes?”

I started losing my patience. Through the half open door, I noticed that Kothai was still lying down peacefully and the nebulization had stopped. The staff nurse had disconnected the nebulizer and she was lying down peacefully. Kannan was sitting on a plastic chair next to her. His eyes were also closed. Things were peaceful.

My mind raced back to a patient I had treated a few months ago with a urinary bladder obstruction.

"Doctor, the pain is unbearable. Please help" The elderly man was accompanied by a young relative and arrived in an auto late one evening as I was winding up the clinic.

When I put my hand on his abdomen, instantly I could feel the hugely inflated urinary bladder. I had inserted a urinary catheter and drained close to 2.5 litres of urine from his bladder. Immediately after doing that, the man had gone into a peaceful sleep. The calm on his face rushed past my mind. Kothai's expression was the same calm.

I wanted to go and confirm that everything was alright.

"You must wait for the certificate. I have a sick patient in the treatment room whom I must attend to."

The man frowned and started mumbling. "I must go urgently. I can't wait. People are waiting for me. How long is it going to take to write a certificate that I should not wear socks and shoes?" His voice was lowered, but it had a whiny quality to it. The passive aggression started irritating me. I either scribble a certificate on my letter head and be done with it, or walk out not minding his mumbling. The temptation to walk out was overwhelming. I took one more peep through the door and saw things were quiet in the treatment room. I took out the letter head and quickly wrote down one of the

most inane medical certificates I have written. “Mr. So-and-So has eczematous dermatitis on his feet. As he has to apply ointments for the treatment, he may not be able to wear socks and shoes. So he may be permitted to wear slippers for the next 15 days starting from So-and-So date to So-and-So date.” I wrote and signed it and gave it to him. I did not even look at him, got up and stormed out.

I entered the treatment room and saw the scene in the room. Everything was quiet. There was a gentle hum of the fan in the room and the sound of water boiling in the autoclave in the adjacent room. Both Kannan and Kothai were sleeping. The adrenaline had broken the cycle of acute asthma attack. The adrenaline must have opened the airways enough for the medicine to enter her lungs and act there. I stood there watching them both sleep peacefully. Kannan’s hand was placed over Kothai’s. Should I wake them up and send them home? Should I let them sleep for some more time?

I felt something loosen in my own chest. Medical training fills your head with a relentless stream of algorithms, toxicities, and the sharp echoes of professors reprimanding your hesitation. But practicing medicine, really living it out in a clinic like this, fills another place entirely. It builds a quiet, private repository of faces.

I knew then that Kothai’s peaceful face would settle right alongside the old man whose agony had washed away with a urinary catheter, the young man with eczema of the foot who would not budge without a medical certificate and alongside the young medical student who had once frozen before Professor Rachel, clutching a Reynolds pen. Days from now, or years from now, when another breathless soul would arrive at my door, when the panic of a silent chest threatened to make the room feel small and helpless, I would

reach into that vault. I would draw out this quiet room, this steady breathing, and remember that even in the narrowest corners of medicine, relief is possible if you just hold your nerve.

I quietly closed the door to the treatment room, leaving the slit just wide enough to let the morning light in, and walked back to the outpatient desk to call the next patient.

Chapter 3

The square collared green shirt

It was September, but still very hot and sultry. Outside the glass pane of my door, the waiting hall sounded like an aviary of misery, dry hacks, wet rattles, the fretful whimpering of exhausted infants, and the shuffling of chappals against worn mosaic tiles.

It was a brutal dry spell in the village. The rains had failed to materialize, leaving behind an unbearable, baking humidity that hovered between thirty-eight and forty degrees Celsius. The city felt parched, irritable, and vulnerable. And then, riding on the back of the dust-choked breeze, came the influenza outbreak.

It did not discriminate. It struck the tech workers who sat in air-conditioned glass towers along the Chengalpattu-Mahabalipuram Road just as mercilessly as it struck the conservancy workers sweeping the arterial streets before dawn. By nine in the morning, the clinic's registration desk looked like a railway ticketing counter on the eve of Pongal. By noon, my white shirt was glued to my spine with sweat, the linen on the examination couch was crumpled, and

my mind had slipped into that dangerous, automatic gear where a doctor stops listening to human beings and begins managing symptoms like an assembly-line technician.

I had seen nineteen patients since nine. Number twenty, an elderly clerk from the postal department who spent five minutes describing the exact shade of yellow in his phlegm, had just hobbled out with a strip of paracetamol and an antihistamine script clutched in his trembling fist.

I pressed the heels of my hands into my burning eyes, exhaling a hot breath. My wrist ached from scribbling repetitive prescriptions: Tab. Paracetamol 500mg TDS x 3 days; Tab. Cetirizine 10mg HS x 3 days. Over and over. Even before the patients could finish saying the word kaichal, fever, I would interrupt, finishing their sentences for them.

Body ache? Yes.

Dry throat? Yes.

Runny nose and burning eyes? Yes, doctor, exactly.

It made consultations efficient. It cleared the waiting room. It gave the impression of a sharp, omniscient physician who knew a patient's illness better than they did themselves. In truth, it was intellectual laziness bred of exhaustion, a wall of clinical efficiency erected to keep empathy from draining whatever energy I had left.

The door handle rattled and the door swung open.

"Doctor?"

It was an older man's voice, cracked with worry and deference. I blinked, dropping my hands to the green blotter on my wooden desk, and reached instinctively for a fresh sheet of the clinic's printed letterhead.

"Come in, come in. Please sit," I said, without looking up immediately as I scribbled the clinic's prescription slip with the date.

When I finally lifted my gaze, my small consulting room seemed suddenly overcrowded. It wasn't just a patient; an entire family had entered, moving with that peculiar, collective gravity seen only when someone in the household is deeply, frighteningly unwell.

At the center of the group was a young person, a heavy-set youth, perhaps eighteen or nineteen years old. He wore a dark green, short-sleeved cotton T-shirt with a curious square neckline, faded grey track pants, and blue rubber slippers. His hair was cut short, chopped unevenly as though done with kitchen scissors, tufts sticking out at odd angles around his ears. His face was round, smooth, and entirely devoid of stubble or shadow, though the skin had a grey, sallow pallor of profound sickness. He walked with his shoulders rolled inward, his chest concave, his arms held rigidly across his midriff as if shielding a cracked rib.

Flanking him was an older man in a starch-free white shirt and a traditional cotton dhoti, his brow lined with deep, sun-baked furrows that marked him as an outdoor laborer. On the boy's other side was a middle-aged woman wearing a faded, bright yellow printed polyester saree, the pallu wrapped tight around her waist, her eyes wide with unvarnished terror.

And hovering just behind the youth, supporting his left elbow with a fierce, protective tenderness, was a younger woman. She

appeared to be in her early twenties, dressed in an unassuming dark brown cotton chudidar with a simple black shawl draped across her shoulders. Her face was taut, her dark eyes darting nervously between the boy's bowed head, the examination couch, and me.

I mentally categorized them in three seconds flat: father, mother, elder sister, and the sickly younger son.

"Sit down here," the father muttered, guiding the boy by the shoulder.

The youth sank heavily into the vinyl chair opposite me. The moment his weight settled, his head dropped into his open palms. His elbows rested on the edge of my desk, his fingers digging into his scalp with such force that the knuckles turned chalky white. A low, ragged groan escaped his throat.

"Tell me, thambi," I said, adopting the familiar Tamil address for a younger brother, keeping my tone brisk and professional. "What brought you to the clinic? What is the trouble?"

The boy did not answer. He didn't even shift his weight. He remained locked in that hunched, agonized posture, staring fixedly down at the floor between his feet.

"Doctor, severe headache..."

The voice did not come from the boy, nor from the parents. It was the young woman in the brown chudidar. She had stepped forward, her hand resting firmly on the back of the boy's chair. Her voice was taut, clear, but strained with a tight coil of anxiety.

"He has not slept since yesterday afternoon, doctor. He cannot lift his head. The light hurts his eyes."

The boy slowly raised his chin by an inch, just enough for his cracked lips to part. “I have vomiting continuously from yesterday...” he whispered. His voice was unusual, raspy, deep in pitch, yet strained and dry, catching in his throat like gravel. “Severe headache. Body pains. Cough and cold... from morning.”

There it was. The textbook quartet.

I gave a short, knowing nod, a faint smirk of clinical confirmation playing on my lips. Fever, headache, body pains, running nose, with diarrhea thrown in for good measure. Just like the twenty patients who had sat in that exact chair before him. The dry September heat had bred a viral strain that presented with vicious headaches and intractable nausea.

“Any loose stools?” I asked, unscrewing the cap of my fountain pen.

“No, doctor,” the woman in the brown chudidar answered quickly. “Only dry heaving now. Nothing stays down. Not even a sip of water.”

“Right. Seasonal influenza,” I announced, my voice carrying the unshakeable certainty of a doctor who had spent hours and hours the entire week diagnosing the exact same pathology. “The dehydration is worsening the headache. If you don’t keep fluids in the body during a viral fever, the brain feels like it’s being squeezed in a vice.”

I pulled the prescription pad closer and began to write with rapid, practiced strokes.

Inj. Ondansetron 4mg IV stat.

Inj. Paracetamol 1g IV in 100ml NS stat.

Tab. Dolo 650mg TDS.

"Listen to me," I said, looking over the top of my reading glasses at the father. "I am prescribing an injection to stop the vomiting immediately, and another for the fever and pain. Once the nausea settles, give him plenty of water and oral rehydration solution. In three days, he will be back on his feet. The virus is everywhere right now. Nothing to panic about."

The father took a deep, audible breath of relief, the tension draining from his leathery face. "Thank you, doctor. Thank you. We were very scared. I was worried with the groaning all night."

The mother pressed the edge of her saree to her eyes, whispering a quiet prayer under her breath.

"Go to the pharmacy counter across the hall," I directed, tearing the top sheet from the pad and offering it to the father. "Get the ampoules from the chemist. The nurse in the injection room will administer them."

"Come, let us go," the father said, nudging his wife. He reached out to pat the boy's slumped shoulder. "You stay here with Priya. I will get the medicine and come."

The older couple turned and filed out of the room, their footsteps hurried, desperate to execute the doctor's orders. The door swung shut behind them with a muffled click.

Inside the room, the silence returned, punctuated only by the ceiling fan's relentless tick.

The young man had not moved. His head was still resting in his hands, his breath coming in shallow, shuddering gasps.

Beside him, the young woman, Priya, did not move to follow the parents. Instead, she stood rooted to the floor. Her hands, resting on the plastic armrest of the boy's chair, were trembling.

I glanced up, mildly annoyed. There were twenty more patients waiting in the humidity outside.

"Yes?" I asked, my pen poised over the desk organizer. "Is there something else? The pharmacy is right across the corridor."

Priya did not answer immediately. She took a step back, turned her neck, and looked through the glass window set into the door. She watched until the yellow saree and the white shirt had disappeared past the reception partition down the hall.

When she turned back to me, the air in the room seemed to drop several degrees. Her face had lost what little color it had. She swallowed hard, her chest heaving beneath the brown fabric of her dress.

"Doctor..." she began, her voice dropping to an urgent, conspiratorial whisper. "There is... there is something we did not tell his parents."

I leaned back in my revolving chair, the leather groaning under my shift in posture. A familiar clinical weariness washed over me. Patients' families always kept secrets, illicit drinking, tobacco use, unprescribed native powders bought from quacks in the village.

"What is it?" I asked, my voice tinged with mild impatience. "If you are concealing medical history, it helps no one. What did he take?"

Priya looked down at the boy. She placed a gentle, steadying hand on the crown of his head. He stiffened beneath her touch, his shoulders trembling.

"Doctor... he has been taking injections," she whispered, her eyes pleading with me to understand without forcing her to say the words. "Hormone injections. He took one three days ago. Could... could that be why his head is bursting like this? Could it be the medicine?"

I stared at her. Then I stared at the youth hunched before me.

Hormone injections.

My mind immediately jumped to the only context my conventional, middle-class medical experience associated with young men and hormones: vanity. Over the past five years, the town had seen an explosion of dimly lit, unregulated fitness centers in every basement and shopping complex. Gym trainers with weekend certifications were peddling cheap veterinary androgens, anabolic steroid vials, and oral stanozolol to insecure boys looking for quick, bulging biceps to display on social media.

I looked at the boy sitting before me. He was heavy-set, yes, but he had no defined musculature. His arms, emerging from the dark green sleeves, were soft, smooth, and lacked any muscularity. His posture was slouched, almost doughy. He looked like the furthest thing from an athlete or a bodybuilder.

A sharp, moralistic irritation flared inside my chest. It was the righteous indignation of an overworked clinician dealing with what appeared to be self-inflicted stupidity. Here I was, battling an epidemic of a genuine virus, and here was a foolish boy poisoning his body with black-market chemicals.

“Hormones?” I snapped, my voice rising, sharp and unmistakably judgmental. “What kind of madness is this? Who told you to take hormones?”

The boy shrank further into himself, his chin pressing into his collarbone.

“Look at me, thambi,” I demanded, leaning forward over the desk, pointing the end of my fountain pen at him like a schoolmaster reprimanding an errant child. “Are you going to a gym? Is some local gym trainer giving you these injections under the table? Do you have any idea what you are doing to your system?”

Neither of them spoke. Priya’s eyes brimmed with sudden, terrified tears, but she clamped her mouth shut. The boy’s breathing had become rapid and shallow.

“Anabolic steroids are poison when abused like this!” I lectured, the frustration of the entire morning pouring out in a torrent of unsolicited condescension. “You boys want shortcuts. You see cinema actors on posters with six-pack abs and you think you can buy muscles from a medical shop. You don’t want to do the hard work. You don’t want to wake up at five in the morning, run on the ground, eat clean food, and lift weights naturally. No! You want an injection to do the work for you!”

The silence from the boy was total, agonizing. He didn’t nod, he didn’t protest, he didn’t move. He sat like a stone statue waiting to be shattered.

“Steroids shoot your blood pressure through the roof,” I continued, standing up and grabbing the sphygmomanometer from the side table with unnecessary vigor. “They cause swelling of the brain, very high blood pressure, kidney failure, liver disease. That is where

your headache is coming from! You are lucky you haven't blown a blood vessel in your brain!"

I unrolled the velcro cuff with a sharp, tearing sound. "Give me your right arm."

He hesitated. For three long seconds, his arm remained glued to his torso.

"Give him the arm, please," Priya whispered, her voice shaking.

Slowly, reluctantly, the boy extended his right forearm across the green blotter. His skin was pale, devoid of hair, and surprisingly cold to the touch despite the oppressive room temperature. I wrapped the dark blue cuff around his bicep, pumping the rubber bulb with rapid squeezes. The mercury column in the glass tube leapt upward—140, 160, 180.

I set the bell of the stethoscope in the crook of his elbow, twisted the valve, and listened intently as the mercury column descended.

Thump... thump... thump.

I blinked. I released the air completely, waited ten seconds, and pumped it up again.

The first sound appeared at 95. The last sound faded at 60.

Ninety-five over sixty.

His blood pressure was not high. It was not even high-normal. It was dangerously low, hypotensive, typical of someone severely depleted of intravascular volume from dehydration, shock, or adrenal insufficiency.

I pulled the stethoscope earpieces from my ears, feeling a momentary prickle of confusion at the base of my neck. If he were in the throes of a steroid-induced hypertensive crisis, his reading should have been very high.

Instead of pausing to reconsider my premise, I doubled down, shifting the diagnosis without shifting my moral superiority.

"Well," I huffed, ripping the cuff off his arm and tossing it onto the desk. "The blood pressure is low because you've dehydrated yourself with the vomiting. But that doesn't excuse this. The steroids irritate the gastric mucosa. You've likely given yourself acute, drug-induced erosive gastritis. Steroids rip the stomach lining to shreds. You ruin your gut, you ruin your liver, and for what? To look bigger in a tight T-shirt?"

I shook my head, sitting back down and pulling the prescription pad back to me. "I see boys like you every month. Ruining their health before they even turn twenty. If you want to build a body, do it the right way. Stop these injections immediately. Eat eggs, drink milk, lift weights, and sweat. There are no shortcuts in life, thambi."

I stopped talking, expecting some sheepish acknowledgement, a mumbled apology, or a promise to throw the vials away.

Nothing came.

The boy remained motionless, his head hung so low that only the uneven tufts of his dark hair were visible. But I noticed something now: a single drop of liquid fell from beneath his bowed face, landing with a soft pat on the faded denim of his knee. Then another. He was weeping, silently, without a sound, his entire upper body vibrating with suppressed, suffocating misery.

Beside him, Priya looked at me. Her expression was no longer one of mere fear; it was a look of profound, devastating disappointment. It was the look of a person who had come to a sanctuary seeking refuge from a storm, only to find the gates barred and stones hurled from the parapets.

"Doctor..." she said, her voice dropping to a register so quiet that I had to strain to hear it over the fan. "He is also having severe pain in the stomach."

I frowned, looking between them. "Abdominal pain? Where? Upper abdomen? Burning pain?"

"Lower," she said simply. "All over, but mostly down here."

I sighed, exasperated. "You should have told me that at the beginning. Symptoms are coming out one by one like a serial drama. Lie down on the couch."

I stood up, walked to the examination couch, and adjusted the linen over the vinyl mattress. "Come. Let me palpate the abdomen. If you have an acute abdomen or peritoneal signs, you need an ultrasound, not just injections."

The boy did not get up. He shrank deeper into the plastic chair, his arms wrapping tighter across his midriff, his fingers clutching the fabric of his dark green T-shirt at his sides.

"I said, come lie down," I repeated, my professional patience worn to a thread. "I cannot examine your belly while you are sitting hunched like a question mark."

"He... he doesn't want to lie down, doctor," Priya said, her voice trembling. "Can't you just give medicine for the stomach pain?"

“No, I cannot ‘just give medicine’!” I raised my voice, my clinical authority thoroughly provoked. “If he has appendicitis, or a perforated ulcer from these reckless steroids, painkillers will mask the symptoms and kill him! I must examine him. Young man, get on the couch.”

The boy shook his head. A violent, definitive jerk of the neck.

“No,” he whispered into his chest.

“What do you mean, ‘no’?” I demanded, stepping closer to his chair. “I am a doctor. You have come to my clinic complaining of pain, your family is outside waiting for you to get well, and you are refusing a basic physical examination? Do you think this is a game?”

“Please,” Priya begged, stepping between me and the boy. “Please don’t shout at him. He is in terrible pain.”

“Then let me do my job!” I snapped, gesturing toward the couch. “If he wants me to treat him, he needs to cooperate. Otherwise, you are wasting my time and the time of the twenty sick people waiting outside that door. Either he gets on that table, or you take your file and leave.”

The ultimatum hung in the stifling air of the room. It was an ugly, bullying tactic, born of exhaustion and arrogance, and the moment the words left my mouth, a small, quiet part of my conscience winced. But my pride kept my jaw locked.

Priya looked at me, her eyes glistening, then turned to the boy. She knelt down beside his chair, heedless of the dusty floor, and took his clenched fists into her hands.

“Mano,” she whispered, her voice breaking into soft, urgent Tamil. “Kanna, listen to me. Please. Look at me.”

The boy did not look up, but his fingers loosened slightly in hers.

“He needs to see, Mano. We cannot let you suffer like this. If something happens to you, what will I do? What will happen to us? Please. Just let him check. I am right here. I will not leave the room. Please, for me.”

A long, ragged sob tore its way out of the boy’s chest, a sound so hollow, so freighted with terror and despair, that the clinical detachment I had clung to all morning fractured right down the center.

Slowly, trembling so violently that his knees knocked together, the boy pushed himself up from the chair. He walked the three steps to the examination couch as though walking to a scaffold. He climbed onto the high table, his movements stiff and awkward, and lay down on his back. Even as he reclined, his arms remained crossed defensively over his chest, his hands gripping the square collar of his dark green T-shirt.

I pulled my rolling stool up to the edge of the couch and sat down.

“All right,” I said, my tone slightly softer, though still formal. “You need to relax your abdominal muscles. Put your arms by your sides and pull your T-shirt up so I can inspect the abdomen.”

The boy did not move his hands. Instead, his grip on the neck of his shirt tightened until the seams strained.

“Come on,” I said, reaching out a hand toward the hem of the green shirt. “Take it off, or at least pull it all the way up to your ribs. I cannot feel through thick cotton.”

The boy violently recoiled, twisting his torso away from my outstretched hand, his boots kicking against the foot of the couch.

"No!" he cried out, his voice sharp, terrified, and jagged. "No! Don't touch it! Don't!"

"What is the matter with you?" I lost my temper completely, pulling my hand back. "How am I supposed to examine your stomach if you refuse to expose it? I am a physician! Why are you behaving like a child?"

"Doctor, please! Stop!"

Priya's voice cracked through the room like a whip. She stepped up to the edge of the examination couch, placing her entire body between me and the boy, shielding him from my gaze. Her chest was heaving, tears were streaming down her face, cutting clean lines through her cheeks.

"He is not a boy who goes to the gym," she said, her voice shaking with an intensity that pinned me to my stool. "He is not taking steroids to show off to anyone. He is not trying to take shortcuts."

She took a ragged, trembling breath, her eyes locking onto mine with an agony so raw it took the breath from my lungs.

"His name... the name his parents gave him... is Malathi."

The room seemed to stop spinning. The persistent hum of the ceiling fan faded into background static.

"Malathi," Priya repeated, her voice dropping into a desperate, reverent whisper. "He was born a girl. But he is not a girl, doctor. He has never been a girl. He is a man."

I sat frozen on my rolling stool. My stethoscope, resting in my lap, felt suddenly like a coil of lead.

"Those injections..." Priya continued, her fingers reaching out to touch the boy's trembling shoulder, "they are testosterone. He has been taking them for eight months. We save money from my salary at the garment shop and his work at the printing press. We buy them without his parents knowing. They think he has a hormonal disorder that made his voice change. They think he is just sick."

She looked down at him, her gaze overflowing with a fierce, unconditional love that illuminated the dingy room.

"He wears a tight binder under that green T-shirt every single day, twelve hours a day, because he cannot bear to look at his own chest. He is in agony because the binder is crushing his ribs, and the hormone dose was too high, and he hasn't been able to eat for two days. We are saving every single rupee for his top surgery. We have forty thousand rupees saved in a tin box under my bed. He wants to have his surgery and live his life as a man. And I love him. I am going to marry him once his transition is complete."

She turned her face back to me, the tears spilling freely over her chin, her hands spread wide in an open, defenseless plea.

"He wouldn't take his shirt off because he was terrified you would see his chest. He was terrified you would laugh at him, or call his parents in, or tell them what he is doing. He is sick, doctor. He is dying of pain and fear. Please... please don't hate him. Just help him."

The words hung in the air, heavy, absolute, and devastating.

I sat there, unable to move, unable to speak. The clinical certainty, the condescending lectures about gyms and vanity, the impatient scolding, the arrogant assumptions, all of it collapsed inward, crushing me under the weight of my own colossal ignorance.

Every single piece of the puzzle that I had so casually misread now rearranged itself before my eyes with blinding clarity. The uneven haircut, hacked away in secret to look like a boy's. The square-necked T-shirt, chosen deliberately to conceal the thick straps of a chest binder underneath. The rounded, smooth face, struggling through the early, awkward stages of viral illness and androgen therapy. The protective stance of the young woman who had braved the stigma of an entire society to stand by the person she loved.

And most of all, the boy's hunched, defensive posture. It hadn't been insolence. It hadn't been stubbornness. It was the desperate, instinctual terror of a wounded animal trying to protect the most vulnerable, painful truth of his existence from a man who had shown him nothing but cold, dismissive judgment.

I looked at the boy lying on the table. He had turned his face toward the wall, his forehead pressed against the cold plaster. His shoulders were shaking with silent, rhythmic spasms. He had laid his entire soul bare in a room where he had expected only cruelty, and he was waiting for the blow to fall.

A deep, burning wave of shame rushed from the pit of my stomach to my ears. In twelve years of medical practice, I had never felt so small. I had looked at a suffering human being through the narrow, tinted lens of my own exhaustion and biases, and I had failed him completely, not just as a clinician, but as a human being.

I stood up slowly from my stool.

The movement startled Priya; she flinched, stepping slightly back as if expecting me to shout for the parents or order them out of the clinic.

Instead, I turned around, walked to the door of the consultation room, and turned the brass deadbolt. The lock clicked shut with a solid, definitive snap.

I walked back to the examination couch. I reached for the light switch on the wall beside the table and turned off the harsh, buzzing fluorescent tube directly overhead, leaving only the soft, warm glow of the desk lamp illuminating the room.

I pulled my stool close to the couch, sat down, and folded my hands in my lap.

"Mano," I said.

My voice was barely a whisper, but it carried clearly through the quiet room.

The boy's shoulders stiffened. He did not turn around, but the crying paused.

"Mano, look at me. Please."

Slowly, inch by inch, the youth turned his head on the paper-covered pillow. His face was blotched red, his dark eyes swollen, drenched in tears, swimming with a mixture of terror, shame, and sheer exhaustion. He looked at me like a condemned man looking at an executioner.

I looked directly into his eyes, holding his gaze without a trace of the clinical distance I had worn all morning.

"I am sorry," I said. The words were thick and heavy in my throat. "I am so deeply, truly sorry."

Mano's lips parted slightly, his brow furrowing in disbelief.

"I spoke to you with arrogance," I said, leaning closer, ensuring that every word reached him with absolute clarity. "I made assumptions about your life, your choices, and your body that I had no right to make. I was tired, I was rushed, and I was foolish. I forgot the first rule of my profession, which is to listen before speaking. I humiliated you when you came to me for help. Please... forgive me."

A soft, choked gasp escaped Priya's lips. She pressed her hand against her mouth, her shoulders trembling.

Mano stared at me. The defensive hardness in his jaw, the tight, terrified coil that had held him rigid since he walked through the door, began to unravel. A fresh wave of tears spilled over his lashes, but this time, they were not tears of fear. They were the tears of a person who has braced for a physical blow, only to be offered an open hand.

"You are safe here, Mano," I said gently. "The door is locked. No one is coming in. Your parents will not know anything you do not want them to know. This room is a safe place for you. I give you my word."

Mano closed his eyes, let out a long, ragged exhale, and covered his face with his forearm, his chest heaving with silent relief.

"Now," I continued, keeping my voice low, calm, and reassuring.

"You are very sick, and you are in pain. I want to help you feel better, but we will do it entirely on your terms. You do not have to take your shirt off. You do not have to remove your binder. If you are comfortable, you can simply pull the hem of your shirt up three or four inches so I can gently touch your lower abdomen. If even that is too much, I will examine you through your clothes. You tell me what you are comfortable with."

Priya stepped forward, resting her hand on Mano's forehead, smoothing back the uneven tufts of his damp hair. "Mano... it's okay, let the doctor check. He is here to help."

With agonizing slowness, Mano lowered his arm from his face. He looked at Priya, who gave him a tearful, encouraging nod. Then he looked at me.

Reaching down with trembling fingers, he took hold of the bottom hem of the dark green T-shirt and lifted it just above his navel, exposing a band of pale, soft abdomen. Beneath the green cotton, I could see the thick, binding elastic of a commercial compression vest, pulled tight across his chest, its lower edge digging deep, red furrows into the skin of his upper ribs.

"Thank you, Mano," I said softly.

I rubbed my palms together briskly to warm my hands, then gently placed the pads of my fingers onto his right lower quadrant.

"Tell me if this hurts."

I pressed down lightly. He winced, his breath catching.

"Here?"

"Yes... it hurts all the way down," he whispered.

I palpated systematically, moving across the abdomen. The abdomen was soft, there was no muscular guarding, no rebound tenderness, no rigidity that would suggest a surgical emergency like appendicitis or peritonitis.

I pulled my hands away, reached for my stethoscope, and listened to his chest and heart through the fabric of his shirt. His heart was beating fast, racing at nearly 115 beats per minute, compensating for the lack of circulating blood volume. His lungs, though constricted by the tight binder, were clear.

I took my seat back at the desk and turned the overhead lamp back on, keeping the light angled away from the couch.

"Sit up slowly, Mano," I said. "Take your time."

Priya helped him swing his legs over the side of the table. He sat there, his head still low, but his posture was different now—the desperate, coiled tension had left his frame, replaced by an immense, bone-deep exhaustion.

"Here is what is happening to your body," I explained, looking between both of them with complete seriousness. "The influenza virus is real. You caught the same seasonal flu that everyone else in the city has right now. That is what started the fever, the body aches, and the cough."

Mano nodded slowly.

"However," I continued, "because you were taking high-dose testosterone without medical supervision, your liver was already working under a significant metabolic load. The binder you are wearing is severely restricting your lower chest expansion. When the viral cough started, your ribcage couldn't expand properly,

which triggered diaphragmatic spasms—that is what caused the violent, continuous vomiting."

Priya gasped softly. "The binder did that?"

"Partially, yes," I said gently. "When you vomit continuously for twenty-four hours, you lose massive amounts of water, sodium, and potassium. That is why your blood pressure dropped to 95/60. And when your blood pressure drops that low while your brain is fighting a viral fever, the cerebral blood flow diminishes, causing this agonizing, blinding headache. You don't have a brain bleed, and you don't have appendicitis. But your body is running on completely empty. You are in a state of severe dehydration."

Mano looked up at me, his eyes wide with a mixture of comprehension and relief. "So... the testosterone didn't poison me?"

"The testosterone didn't cause the virus, Mano," I replied honestly. "But taking unregulated hormones without monitoring your blood tests is extremely dangerous. Testosterone thickens the blood; it increases your red blood cell count. If you get dehydrated while your blood is already thick, you run a very real risk of developing blood clots. You cannot continue taking black-market vials bought off the internet or from friends. It is too dangerous."

Mano's face fell, the panic returning to his eyes. "Doctor... if I stop... everything will go back. My voice... my body... I cannot go back to being Malathi. I would rather die. I swear to you, I will jump in front of a train before I live as Malathi again."

"No one is asking you to go back," I said, my voice firm, steady, and clear.

Mano froze, staring at me.

“Transitioning is a medical process, Mano,” I said, leaning across the desk. “It is not a crime, and it is not a sin. But it is medicine. It requires an endocrinologist who understands gender-affirming care, who can calculate the exact dose your body needs, monitor your blood work every three months, and ensure your liver and heart stay safe while your body changes.”

Priya reached out, her fingers lacing tightly into Mano’s. A fresh tear traced a slow path down her cheek, but a fragile, radiant smile broke through her exhaustion. “Is there... is there a doctor who does that here, doctor? Legally?”

“Yes,” I nodded. “There are excellent endocrinologists and psychiatrists in private clinics who specialize in gender transition care. Once you recover from this infection, I will personally write you a confidential referral to a colleague of mine who runs a supportive, safe transition clinic in Chennai. They will guide you through hormone therapy safely, and they will connect you with qualified surgeons for your top surgery when you are ready.”

Mano stared at me, his chest rising and falling beneath the dark green shirt. For the first time since he had entered my room, his mouth curved into a faint, trembling line that wasn’t pain. It was a smile so tentative, so fragile, it looked as though a breath of wind might shatter it.

“You... you will help us?” he whispered.

“I will help you,” I replied. “That is my job.”

A sharp knock sounded at the door, rattling the frosted glass.

“Doctor?” It was the father’s voice from the corridor. “We have bought the medicines from the pharmacy. The nurse said the room is locked.”

Mano instinctively flinched, looking at the door with wide eyes.

“Don’t worry,” I whispered, holding up a reassuring hand. “Leave this to me.”

I stood up, walked to the door, and unlocked the deadbolt, pulling the door open just enough to step into the threshold. The father and mother were standing there, holding a small plastic pouch containing glass ampoules and disposable syringes.

“Doctor, is everything all right?” the father asked, peering anxiously past my shoulder. “Why was the door locked?”

“Everything is under control,” I said, my voice smooth, calm, and reassuring, slipping effortlessly back into the authoritative tone of a senior physician. “I locked the door because the boy was feeling extremely dizzy and lightheaded from the dehydration. I needed to conduct a quiet neurological examination without the noise from the waiting room disturbing him.”

“Oh... thank God,” the mother murmured, clutching her pallu.

“Listen to me carefully,” I said, taking the paper bag from the father’s hands. “His condition is a bit more complicated than a simple viral fever. He has severe dehydration and acute gastritis, which has dropped his blood pressure significantly. If we only give him an injection and send him home on a bus, he will collapse on the road.”

The father’s face turned pale. “Aiyyo... what should we do, doctor?”

“He needs intravenous fluids immediately,” I said. “We need to admit him to our day-care ward for six hours. Two bottles of normal saline, intravenous paracetamol, and medication to protect his stomach lining. I will personally supervise his drip. By tonight, his headache will be gone, his blood pressure will be normal, and he can walk out of here safely on his own feet.”

“Yes, doctor. Whatever you say,” the father said eagerly, nodding with complete trust. “Whatever is best for her. We have enough money for the drip.”

“Good. Go to the reception desk, complete the day-care admission slip, and wait there. The nurse will wheel him to bed number four in a few minutes.”

“Thank you, doctor. Thank you.” The parents turned and hurried toward the counter, their worry transformed into purposeful action.

I stepped back into the room and closed the door behind me.

Mano and Priya were looking at me. The fear was gone from their faces, replaced by an overwhelming, silent gratitude that filled the small space between us.

I pulled out a fresh sheet from my prescription pad. I took my fountain pen, unscrewed the cap, and poised the nib over the patient information header.

“Before I write the admission orders,” I said softly, looking up at the young person sitting before me, “what name should I write on your medical chart?”

The boy looked at Priya. She smiled, squeezing his hand tightly, giving him a proud, decisive nod.

He lifted his chin. His shoulders squared, his chest rose, and he looked me squarely in the eyes for the first time that day. The raspy quality in his voice was still there, but beneath it lay a steady, resonant strength—the unmistakable voice of a man claiming his right to exist in the world.

"Manoj," he said.

I looked at him, feeling a sudden, warm sting behind my own eyelids.

"Manoj," I repeated slowly, letting the name settle into the room. "That is a good name. A strong name."

With a firm, deliberate stroke, I wrote the name across the top of the white paper: Mr. Manoj, 19 years old.

"Take this to the day-care nurse," I told her. "I have marked bed number four, it has a private curtain. Manoj can rest there quietly without anyone disturbing him. I will come and check on his drip every hour."

Priya took the paper. She looked down at the name written at the top—Mr. Manoj—and her fingers traced the ink as though it were the most precious piece of parchment on earth. She looked up at me, tears spilling over her lashes, and folded her hands in a silent, trembling vanakkam.

Manoj stood up from the chair. He did not bow his head this time. He stood straight, his height surprising me now that his spine wasn't curled inward like a dry leaf.

"Thank you, doctor," he said, his raspy voice clear and steady.

“Get well soon, Manoj,” I replied, extending my right hand across the wooden desk.

Manoj looked at my outstretched hand for a second, startled. Then, with a firm, warm grip, he took it and shook it. His hand was strong, the grip of an nineteen-year-old who had fought every single day of his life just to breathe as himself.

They walked out of the room together. Priya held the door open, and Manoj stepped through it into the corridor, his head held high, his gait steady, walking side by side with the woman who loved him.

I stood by my desk for a long moment, watching their retreating figures through the frosted glass until they turned the corner toward the day-care ward.

Outside, the waiting room was still noisy. A child was crying; a man was coughing violently; the staff was calling out token number twenty-one. The September heat still radiated through the walls, and the influenza outbreak was still waiting outside my door, hungry and relentless.

I reached out, picked up my stethoscope, and placed it back around my neck. The rubber tubing, which had felt like cold, lifeless plastic all morning, now felt warm against my collar.

I wiped the sweat from my forehead with my handkerchief, took a deep, clean breath, and pressed the buzzer on my desk to call the next patient. But as the door swung open and an elderly woman shuffled in, leaning on her grandson’s arm, I didn’t reach for my pen immediately.

I leaned forward, smiled, and waited for her to speak.

Chapter 4

The ancient healer, the human body

It was a routine clinic day. I looked down at the case sheet. Meena was twenty-eight years old, though the sun and the unrelenting rhythms of rural household life had etched fine lines around her dark, attentive eyes. Across her lap lay a quiet bundle wrapped in a faded yellow sari, her eight-month-old boy, sleeping with that heavy, oblivious grace unique to healthy infants.

"Doctor," she began, her voice low, hesitant, as if she were apologizing for taking up space with something trivial. "It is here. Just where they made the cut for the big operation to bring him out."

She rested a hand over the lower right side of her lower abdomen.

"Tell me what you feel," I said, putting my pen down.

"At first, after the wound healed, it was fine. But for the last two months, it pricks. It itches deep inside, not on top of the skin. And when I bend to lift the water pot, or when I carry him against my hip, something bites. Like a tiny pebble caught under the flesh.

Sometimes I think a thorn got in while I was sweeping, but how could a thorn go through a scar that had already closed?"

"Lie down on the examination couch, Meena. Let me see."

She laid her child gently on the padded bench beside the wall, tucking his cloth around his shoulders, before climbing onto the table. He slept there peacefully. When she loosened the drawstring of her petticoat and exposed the lower abdomen, I saw the pale, horizontal cesarean scar. It was well-healed, a neat, thin silver-pink line about eleven centimeters long, resting in the crease above the pubic bone. There was no redness, no gaping, no frank discharge. To the casual eye, the obstetrician had done a tidy job eight months ago.

I warmed my hands by rubbing them together and laid my fingertips along the scar.

The skin was soft, pliable, yielding naturally under gentle pressure, until my right index finger drifted toward the outer one third of the incision.

There it was.

My finger arrested against an unmistakable point of resistance. I pressed down slightly, rolling the skin between my thumb and forefinger.

It was tiny, hardly larger than a mustard seed, perhaps three or four millimeters across, yet it possessed an astonishing, stubborn hardness. It felt like a small river pebble, or a grain of lead shot buried just beneath the skin layer. It was mobile slightly, but was anchored deep, with a sense of tethering.

“There,” Meena gasped softly. “That is it. When you press, it feels like a needle sticking straight down into the bone.”

“Just breathe normally,” I said, keeping my fingers stationary. “I’m not going to hurt you.”

I closed my eyes.

In medicine, when sight offers nothing but an unbroken sheet of pale skin, the fingertips become the physician’s eyes. I stood there in silence, feeling the rhythmic rise and fall of her belly, letting my mind dive beneath the surface of the flesh.

What could be this hard?

My mind began its systematic, almost frantic search.

Could it be a foreign body introduced during surgery? A fragment of a broken needle? No, a surgical needle would be metallic, elongated, sharp; this felt rounded, beaded, spherical. A piece of glass? Unthinkable in an operating theatre unless an ampoule had shattered into an open wound, but that was an absurd fantasy.

Could it be natural tissue transformed? An abnormal calcium deposit forming in the healing scar tissue? Calcium can feel like chalky stone, unyielding and crisp under the skin.

Or was it an inclusion cyst? A cystic swelling pushed beneath the skin during the skin closure, slowly accumulating trapped tissue until it became a tense, pressurized sphere? But cysts usually had a give, an elastic bounce, however subtle; this had none. It was like stone.

Could it be a foreign body granuloma? A cluster of giant cells, histiocytes, and dense fibrous tissue walling off some microscopic

intruder? Or was it bone? Formation of abnormal bone in the abdominal wall? Bewildered by surgical trauma, abdominal muscle tissue sometimes differentiated erroneously into bone, laying down true, miniature islands of bone in the muscle plane?

In my mind's eye, the skin turned transparent. I visualized the layers beneath the skin, recollecting all the things I had seen long ago when I studied anatomy. Somewhere right in that transitional zone between the skin and fat tissue, this little stony structure was living its quiet, provocative life.

I opened my eyes. Meena was looking up at me, reading the furrow in my brow.

"What is it, Doctor? Is it something bad? A tumor?"

"No," I answered immediately, reassuring her with a tone far firmer than my thoughts. "It is not a tumor, Meena. It is much too small, much too discrete. It feels like a tiny foreign particle, or a tight little knot of scarred tissue. It's right under the surface. Barely two millimeters down."

She sat up slowly, adjusting her sari. "Can you take it out? If it stays, I cannot carry my son without flinching. Every time he kicks his legs against my side, it shoots fire into my stomach."

I leaned against the edge of the consultation desk, considering the simplicity of the proposal.

"Meena, it sits directly under the skin. A drop of local anesthesia to numb the spot, a tiny nick, no longer than the head of a matchstick, and we can see what is sitting there. If it is a loose particle or an irritated bead of tissue, we can slip it out. A single stitch, or just a strip of tape, and it will be over in ten minutes."

Her face brightened with unmistakable relief. “Please, Doctor. Let us do it today. My husband has taken leave from the fields to mind our older daughter, and I don’t want to come back to the hospital again and again.”

“Very well,” I said. “Let us take care of it now.”

The decision felt clean, logical, and decisively therapeutic. Why let a patient live with chronic, daily pain when a five-minute minor procedure could resolve both her distress and my diagnostic uncertainty? It felt like the very essence of good clinical practice: identify the lesion, excise the nuisance, restore comfort.

I led her into the minor procedure room at the end of the corridor.

The room smelled of chlorhexidine and autoclaved steel. The morning sun angled sharply through the high, frosted-glass window, illuminating dust motes dancing over the stainless-steel instrument tray. Meena climbed onto the narrow procedure table. The nurse, Sister Mary, switched on the handheld torch light, directing a harsh, circular glare onto the right lower quadrant of Meena’s abdomen.

“Just relax your legs, Meena,” Sister Mary said softly, patting her shoulder. “The doctor will just give a small prick, like an ant bite, and after that you will feel nothing.”

I scrubbed, dried my hands with a sterile towel, and pulled on a pair of snug latex gloves. Sister Mary painted the area with brown antiseptic solution in widening concentric circles.

I picked up the syringe containing local anaesthetic drug.

“A small sting now,” I warned.

I introduced the fine needle just adjacent to the hard nodule, and injected the medicine. Meena sucked in a sharp breath, then let it out slowly. Within thirty seconds, the local anesthetic had done its work. I touched the area with the tip of the forceps.

"Do you feel pain here?"

"I feel you touching, but no pain."

"Good."

I reached for the number eleven scalpel blade.

The object was right there, unmistakable, trapped between the index and middle fingers of my left hand. I positioned the tip of the blade directly over the summit of the stony elevation and made a deliberate, controlled incision, scarcely four millimeters long.

A single, dark bead of venous blood welled up.

Sister Mary handed me a sterile swab. I blotted the tiny droplet away and held the skin margins apart with fine-toothed forceps, leaning in close beneath the glare of the lamp.

There was no chalky calcium. There was no pearl-like cyst wall. There was no splinter of wood, glass or bone.

Staring back at me, vivid against the yellowish background of subcutaneous fat, was an intense, unmistakable shock of royal blue.

It was a knot.

A thick, bulky, multi-throw surgical knot tied with heavy, non-absorbable monofilament suture material, braided or extruded synthetic polymer, unmistakably polypropylene or nylon.

I froze, the scalpel suspended motionless above the field.

"Doctor? Did you find it?" Meena asked from beneath the drape, hearing the sudden, dead silence in the room.

"Yes," I managed, my voice sounding distant to my own ears. "I see what it is."

My mind spun backward into the surgical mechanics of an operative delivery.

When a surgeon performs a caesarean section they open layers of abdomen to reach the uterus within, cut open the uterus and bring out the baby.

In standard obstetric practice, the inner layers of the abdomen that was cut open, are closed with absorbable sutures. Over six to twelve weeks, the body slowly digests the synthetic material, breaking it down, leaving behind a dense, healed layer of mature scar tissue. By the time the suture dissolves, the body has long since taken over the burden of holding itself together. Unlike the absorbable sutures, non-absorbable synthetic material remain inert and stay forever. Non absorbable sutures are used for the skin, so that the surgeon can call back the patient, remove and discard them.

Why on earth was there non-absorbable blue monofilament inside, where it cannot be opened and removed at a later date?

Perhaps the obstetrician had run out of their usual material during an emergency midnight delivery.

Only, it hadn't stayed buried.

Over eight months of walking, bending, nursing, and lifting, the natural motion of the abdominal wall had worked the hard, plastic

knot upward through the soft subcutaneous fat, like a needle working its way through silk, until it came to rest directly beneath the paper-thin skin, rubbing against every nerve ending with every breath she took.

"What is it, Doctor?" Sister Mary whispered, leaning closer. "A stitch knot?"

"Yes," I said quietly, under my breath. "A non-absorbable rectus sheath knot."

Now, a profound, cold dilemma seized me.

The knot was right there, exposed to the light of day. It was the absolute, undisputed cause of her misery. If I simply closed the skin over it, it would continue to torment her; she would be right back where she started, with a surgically opened wound on top of her chronic irritation.

It has been eight months, I reasoned frantically with myself. Eight full months. The layers of the abdomen that were supposed to be held together by the knot must have repaired and healed themselves by now. The suture has done its job. It's an inert relic. I can just cut the knot free, snip it off, and extract the source of the irritation.

I took the fine scissors. I slipped the lower blade beneath the blue knot, where it emerged from the deeper plane.

Snip.

The knot gave way with a crisp, plastic click that resonated through the metal handles of the scissors.

I picked up the freed knot with the tissue forceps. It was dense, hard as a bead of glass, its trimmed ends stiff and sharp as wire bristles,

no wonder it had felt like a stone; no wonder it had caused her such relentless pain. I dropped it into the stainless-steel kidney dish. It landed with a tiny, sharp metallic clink.

"The pebble is out, Meena," Sister Mary said cheerfully, smiling down at the patient.

"Thank God," Meena whispered.

But I was not smiling.

Beneath the excised knot, where the scissor had cut, I saw a distinct, dark blue threads plunging straight down into the depths of the wound.

Curiosity, or some foolish, compulsive urge to tidy the field, betrayed me. I reached out with the forceps and took hold of the blue thread. I gave it a gentle, exploratory tug, expecting it to be securely anchored in the deep scar tissue, hoping to trim it as much as possible.

The thread did not resist.

It slid.

It slipped through the tissue smoothly, effortlessly, gliding out of the deep tissue plane like a silk ribbon. One millimeter. Two millimeters. Five millimeters.

A wave of pure, sickening adrenaline rushed from the back of my neck down into the pit of my stomach.

Stop.

I let go of the thread instantly, my hand trembling slightly.

What had I just done?

Was this a continuous, running suture that had closed and held together the inner layer of her abdomen? Was this single knot the terminal lock that held a continuous loop together from one flank to the other? And had I just severed the anchor and pulled the loop loose?

My mind conjured a catastrophic sequence of internal collapse. I imagined the entire inner layer of the abdomen unzipping beneath the surface, stitch by stitch, like a loose knitted sweater when a single snagged yarn is pulled. I envisioned her lifting her eight-month-old child tomorrow morning, the inner layer of her abdomen tearing wide open along its entire horizontal length, the loops of bowel thrusting upward through the defect, forming a massive, strangulated incisional hernia requiring emergency surgery in a tertiary hospital sixty miles away.

You fool, my inner voice screamed. You arrogant, meddlesome fool. You took a harmless, minor foreign body sensation and, out of naked curiosity and overconfidence, you have dismantled the structural integrity of her abdominal wall.

"Doctor?" Sister Mary looked at me, her brow creasing as she noticed the sudden rigidity in my shoulders, the way my eyes were glued to the tiny, gaping nick. "Are you going to place a suture?"

I couldn't speak for a few seconds. My mouth had gone completely dry.

"Doctor? Is something wrong?" Meena asked from beneath the drape, sensing the sudden change in temperature in the room, the heavy, suffocating silence that had fallen between the nurse and me.

I forced my voice into a register of calm that felt entirely fraudulent.

“Nothing is wrong, Meena. Nothing at all. Just making sure the area is completely clean.”

I looked down at the loose, protruding blue thread. It sat there in the shallow wound, mocking me. If I pulled it more, I risked unraveling the entire abdominal wall. I had no other option. I had to stop. I had to pull my hands out of the fire.

Carefully, reverently, using the blunt tips of the closed forceps, I tucked the loose blue tail back down into the subcutaneous tissue, burying it beneath the fat where it had come from.

“No suture for the skin,” I said to Sister Mary, my voice flat, tight. “The incision is only four millimeters. It will close by secondary intention. Bring me the sterile adhesive strips and a pressure dressing.”

Sister Mary cleaned the surrounding skin. I applied three narrow strips of adhesive tape across the tiny wound, drawing the edges into perfect, bloodless apposition. Over that, I placed a thick, folded gauze pad, taping it down with broad bands of elastic plaster to create a firm, compressive barrier.

“There,” I said, peeling off my gloves. They were damp with sweat on the inside. “We are finished.”

Meena sat up slowly, looking down at the white pad taped to her lower abdomen. She reached out and touched the dressing lightly, experimentally.

“The hardness,” she said, her eyes widening in wonder. “It’s gone. Even through the bandage, I can tell. The sharp bite isn’t there anymore.”

Her face was radiant with gratitude. To her, I was a miracle worker who had banished her months of torment in the span of a quarter of an hour.

To myself, I was an irresponsible amateur who had potentially left her on the brink of an abdominal catastrophe.

"Meena," I said, pulling my stool close to her, looking directly into her eyes. The weight of my hidden fear made my voice sound far more severe than I intended. "Listen to me very carefully."

Her smile faded slightly, taken aback by my gravity. "Yes, Doctor?"

"The piece we took out was a surgical stitch knot. A knot that had been left behind to hold the deep layers together during your operation. Because I have removed the knot, the deep layer must be treated with extreme gentleness while it settles."

"Did something break?" she asked, her voice dropping into a register of worry.

"No," I said, not sure if I was telling the truth or lying. "Nothing broke. But the support there is delicate right now. For the next two weeks, you must not lift any water pots. Do you understand me? You must not pull water from the well. You must not lift heavy sacks of grain. You must not bend down to scrub the floors. Even when you lift your baby, lift him close to your chest, sitting down first. You must not strain on the toilet. If you cough, press your hands against this dressing to hold your belly firm."

She swallowed hard, nodding slowly. "I understand, Doctor. I will tell my mother-in-law. She will help."

"I am going to ask Lakshmi, our community health worker, to visit your home this evening," I added. "And tomorrow morning. If you

feel any sudden swelling, if you have severe pain or vomiting, you must send someone to fetch me immediately. Day or night. Do you promise?"

"I promise, Doctor."

She gathered her sleeping baby into her arms, holding him with a delicate, terrified caution that tore at my conscience. I watched her walk slowly out of the health centre, stepping gingerly, as though she were made of thin porcelain that might shatter with a single misstep.

The rest of the day was an exercise in pure misery.

Patients came and went, fevers, seasonal bronchitis, poorly controlled diabetes, a child with an ear infection, and I listened to chests and wrote prescriptions with only a fraction of my mind. The rest of my consciousness was trapped in that four-millimeter hole, staring at a severed blue thread slipping through the dark layers of an abdominal wall.

Every textbook paragraph I had ever read about incisional hernias paraded through my thoughts in vivid, terrifying detail. Had I damaged the single knot that was holding her abdominal wall together? Had I loosened the most important knot that was preventing a major catastrophe?

Why hadn't I just left it alone? Why hadn't I simply explained to her that it was an inert knot, prescribed a topical local anesthetic, told her to wear an abdominal binder, and let time take its course? Why did I have to play the heroic doctor with a scalpel in an outpatient dressing room?

The sun dipped below the palm trees, painting the clinic veranda in long, blood-orange shadows. The staff packed up their bags and went home. The building grew quiet. I sat alone at my desk, unable to shake the image of Meena's abdomen giving way beneath the simple strain of a cough.

At eight o'clock that night, my mobile phone rang.

The ring made me jump. I snatched it up instantly.

"Doctor? It is Lakshmi here," the community health worker said. Her voice competed with the distant barking of village dogs and the crickets in the bushes.

"Lakshmi. Have you seen Meena?"

"Yes, Doctor. I just came from her house. I checked her bandage, just like you told me to."

"And? Is there any swelling? Is the dressing soaked? Is she in pain?"

"No, Doctor," Lakshmi said, sounding mildly puzzled by the frantic urgency in my voice. "She is sitting on the porch, eating her dinner. She said she has no pain at all. In fact, she told me that for the first time in months, she doesn't feel that needle sticking into her flesh. The bandage is completely dry and flat. She asked me why you were so worried."

A knot of tension in my chest loosened by a fraction of an inch, but my medical brain refused to allow me complete relief.

"Did you tell her not to lift anything?"

"Yes, Doctor. Her mother-in-law is there. She has taken the baby for the night."

"Good. Go back first thing in the morning, Lakshmi. The moment the sun rises. Call me if anything changes."

I went home, but sleep remained an elusive, mocking thing. I lay on my bed, staring at the slowly revolving shadow of the ceiling fan.

In the dark of my bedroom, that training became a torment. I imagined that severed blue thread slowly sliding out of its path with every breath Meena took. I wondered if the human body was truly so pitifully dependent on a single millimeter of plastic thread.

I fell into a fitful, shallow sleep around four in the morning, haunted by dreams of tearing fabric.

When I arrived at the clinic at eight the next morning, I couldn't even wait for the morning outpatient queue to assemble. I called the staff room.

"Sister Mary, please get on the clinic motorcycle and go to Meena's house with Lakshmi."

Sister Mary looked at me with an expression of quiet sympathy, "I will go, Doctor. But I am sure she is fine."

The forty-five minutes she was gone felt like an eternity. I paced the veranda, checking my watch every two minutes, unable to settle into my chair.

At nine o'clock, the rattle of the old motorcycle signalled their return. Sister Mary walked up the brick steps, taking off her helmet.

"Well?" I demanded, meeting her at the door.

Sister Mary smiled a calm, maternal, slightly amused smile.

“She is fine, Doctor. The wound is dry. There is no swelling, no bulge, no tenderness. She laughed when she saw me. She said she felt so well this morning that she had to argue with her mother-in-law just to be allowed to sit still.”

I stepped back into my office and sank heavily into my swivel chair.

The breath that escaped my lungs felt as though it had been held for twenty-four hours.

I saw Meena one week later for her follow-up.

She walked into the consultation room with a brisk, natural stride, carrying her eight-month-old son balanced comfortably on her right hip, the very side where the knot had been removed. She wasn’t wincing. She wasn’t guarding her belly.

“Doctor,” she laughed, sitting down and setting the boy on her knee. “A mother cannot keep her hands off her child for seven days. It is impossible. But look, nothing happened.”

I had her lie on the couch once more. I removed the adhesive strips.

The four-millimeter nick was completely sealed. It had closed cleanly, leaving a faint pink mark that was already beginning to blend into the older surgical scar.

I placed my hand firmly over the site. I asked her to lift her head off the pillow—the classic maneuver to raise intra-abdominal pressure and demonstrate any defect in the inner layers of the abdominal wall.

The rectus muscles contracted crisply beneath my palm. The wall was as firm, as resilient, and as solid as a sheet of cured leather.

There was no softness, no defect, no impending hernia. The abdomen was normal.

There was only sound, living, impenetrable human tissue.

As I took my hand away, a quiet, humbling epiphany settled over me.

In my fear, I had forgotten the most fundamental truth of our biology: the body is not an inanimate clockwork machine, nor is it a house of cards waiting for the slightest human error to collapse into ruin.

We physicians, in our pride and our anxiety, often succumb to the illusion that it is our clever stitches, our precise knots, and our synthetic materials that hold the patient together. We imagine that our interventions are the primary architects of recovery, and that without our meticulous mechanical scaffolds, the flesh would simply surrender to chaos.

The blue thread I had terrified myself over was nothing more than a temporary splint, an artificial guide rail that had long outlived its utility. Months before I ever laid my hands on Meena's scar, her own cells had already performed miracles of architectural reconstruction that no surgeon could ever replicate.

The inner layers of Meena's abdomen had not been kept closed by that single, wretched knot of plastic. It had been sealed by the immense, ancient resilience of living tissue a self-healing mechanism refined through millions of years of mammalian evolution, long before the first human thought to fashion a suture or sharpen a blade.

The plastic knot had not been an indispensable structural anchor; it had become an abandoned relic, a foreign squatter causing inflammation because the body had already finished the building and was trying, in its own clumsy way, to spit out the scaffolding.

I looked at Meena as she adjusted her clothes, completely whole, completely cured, picking up her laughing child and swinging him effortlessly into the air.

How much of our clinical anguish, I wondered, is born of this profound underestimation of the human body? How many sleepless nights do we inflict upon ourselves, how many frantic worries do we project onto our patients, simply because we forget that nature is not fragile?

We worry about the threads we have loosened, while the body has already rebuilt the wall in stone.

"Is everything good, Doctor?" Meena asked, adjusting the child's yellow frock.

"Everything is very good, Meena," I said, smiling genuinely this time, feeling lighter than I had in days. "Your body has done all the work. You don't need to worry anymore."

She folded her hands in a respectful vanakkam, turned, and walked out into the warm morning light, leaving me alone in the consultation room with the quiet thrum of the fan, thoroughly humbled, deeply relieved, and finally at peace.

The Inner World

Chapter 5

I am flying doctor

"I am sorry to disturb you doctor."

I have never had any patient in my clinic with this statement for an introduction.

"Absolutely not. You are not at all a disturbance. I am here to help you. How can I help you? Please let me know."

"No doctor. You won't tell me this after you hear my problem. The problem is quite interesting. I don't think it is a problem, but there is a chance that you might. "

"I will definitely not consider you a disturbance. Why don't you try me? Shall we begin by describing why you came to see me?"

"Ok doctor. I started flying from yesterday."

Rosiah had an absolutely calm face when he said this to me. There was not even a small flicker of any muscles on his face. No smile, no frown, just an expressionless peace.

I did not know what follow up question to ask. When someone says I have a headache I would ask "Where is the headache?" "For how long have you had these headaches?" "How severe is the headache?" "Is it associated with visual disturbances?" But I did not know what to ask when someone says "I started flying"

"See, I told you that this might be a disturbance"

Rosiah was getting restless and had a sour expression now.

"Not at all…tell me more about it. What do you mean?"

"I woke up yesterday morning and went to the bathroom. I finished my morning rituals and came out and suddenly started soaring into the skies. As I propelled into the sky I could feel the early morning cold wind rushing through my hair. It was a brilliant experience. I felt light, I felt high and I was cruising all around."

I was in disbelief. Something must be wrong with Rosiah. He is probably hallucinating. I decided I would ask more questions to understand what is going on.

"Tell me more about it. How did you fly? Were you on an aeroplane or helicopter? Was it some other mechanism that helps us fly?"

"No doctor! I was actually flying on my own. High high, up above in the sky! Amidst the clouds, beside the stars of the early morning sky. I smelled the pleasant clouds, and coursed through the beautiful orange of the early morning rising sun. It was magical."

"Rosiah, as far as I know it is not possible for human beings to fly. We do not have that ability. Can you recollect more information so that I can make sense of what you actually experienced?"

"See, I knew it that you would not believe me. I am telling you, I actually flew up like this" and Rosiah flapped his arms and gestured like how a bird would flap its wings. "When I flapped my hands, the wind lifted me up further. I reached up and up. As I reached high enough, my heart started fluttering in excitement. I felt so happy. It was an intense feeling doctor."

I was puzzled. I was tempted to crack a joke and dismiss his gesture. It looked funny when I saw it superficially. But I restrained myself from laughing or judging his action. I needed to understand Rosiah better. I must work with his belief and try and get more information.

"OK, so where did you fly to?"

"I did not go anywhere. I just cruised above my house for a few minutes and landed right back on my backyard."

"Could you explain how you felt when you flew?"

"It was a delightful feeling. I felt light weight. I soared up smoothly. I did not have to make any efforts, it was easy. It was only after I started soaring up that I decided to flap my hands. I would have been able to fly even if I hadn't flapped my hands. My mind was empty and thoughtless. It was a meditative feeling. I felt like I was God. I was possessed by some divinity. I had love and grace oozing out of every pore in my body."

It was probably a light-headed feeling that sometimes makes people feel that they are flying. Probably Rosiah was having a vivid experience of light headedness.

"What did you see from up there when you were flying?" If it was light-headedness due to low blood pressure or a position imbalance, he would not have seen anything differently.

"I saw my house, my father was washing and cleaning his motorbike. My mother was feeding the cows in the cow shed at the back of our house. I was making several rounds hovering above my house. I felt an overwhelming feeling of love towards my parents. I wanted to call out to them and ask them to look up and see me. I knew if they saw me flying they would become too emotional."

"How long did you keep flying?"

"Must have been about 5 minutes. I landed abruptly after that"

"Did anyone else see you flying?"

"No. When I told my parents and my elder brother, they did not believe me. They asked me to go and see the doctor. That is why I have come to see you. I don't know if you believe me"

I did not want to believe him.

"Sometimes our inner ear plays tricks on our sense of balance, Rosiah. Or a sudden drop in blood pressure makes the body feel weightless, almost floating. Have you had dizzy spells, or strange headaches before this happened?"

"No doctor. I do not have any disease. I am perfectly normal. I wouldn't have come to a hospital in the first place. It is my parents and brother who have forced me to come here to see you."

As Rosiah sat there I noticed the distinct dark circles around his eyes. He was agitated now and was figeting with the small bag that he had in his hands. His legs were tapping on the ground. He held a lock of hair that had fallen on his forehead and was twisting it around.

“But normally people do not fly. Right? Can you tell me how is your mind? Are you sleeping well? Are you functioning socially well?”

“There you go. I expected you to think I am a mental case and there you said it. Doctor, I am not mad. I am perfectly normal.”

“No Rosiah! Do not mistake me. I never said you are mentally ill. I just want to understand your state of mind and check whether there could be some problems in your mind which makes you feel like you are flying”

“I am telling you again doctor. I did not ‘feel like flying’. I did actually fly. I saw myself soar up to the skies, I saw my house and my folks from up there and within 5 minutes I landed back in my backyard”

“OK! If you are normal and if you think flying is also normal, please tell me why you have come to see me. How can I help you?”

“Doctor, that is why I asked when I came in whether I am disturbing you. I just have a lot of questions to ask you regarding my flight. I am as puzzled as everyone else that I flew in the sky. I do not have the choice to disbelieve it, like how you are doing right now, because I flew. So I have no choice but to understand how I flew, why I flew and the process behind it. I came to talk to you to understand.”

“I am a doctor working with people at the physical level. I understand the functions and mechanisms of the human body to an extent. But flying is not something I am familiar with. I know only flying that happens in an aeroplane, or helicopter, or hot air balloons or parachutes or paragliding. Are you referring to any of these by any chance?”

Rosiah looked frustrated. He had clearly mentioned that he flew with his own body, without any gadgets, parachutes, paraglides

etc. But my disbelief was making me ask him the same questions repeatedly. He looked flustered, restless and exhausted.

"I understand it is confusing doctor. Can you help me figure out the mechanism of my flight. May I pick your brain with some questions?"

"Of course Rosiah! Please ask me any questions that you have"

"There are so many old sayings and proverbs that are linked to human beings flying high. I am sure you have heard them. 'Those who fly high are targets for stones', 'The higher man soars the smaller he appears to those who cannot fly' and so on… How would such proverbs come about if humans cannot fly?"

I thought for a moment. It was an interesting question.

"Rosiah, I think the flying referred to in these proverbs are metaphorical. It is a metaphor for human potential and achievement. I don't think they meant the actual physical act of flying."

"But doctor, if people collectively believe that we can fly, we can fly. Right?"

Now Rosiah was asking me deeper questions relating to nature of reality. Some things in the society exist as reality because we as a society have collectively agreed that it exists. I know belief creates reality in the social sphere. We believe that a piece of paper is currency, because collectively as a society we have agreed on its value. But the moment the currency is devalued, it is just a piece of scrap paper. Is that what he was talking about?

"That is true, some realities in social life are based on belief and our collective arrangement to believe in them. But flying? I am not sure, Rosiah"

"Why not doctor? Think about it, wasn't it collective human belief that led to discovery of the first aeroplane by the Wright brothers?"

Rosiah seemed to be an intelligent young man, but his reasoning was off. The collective belief fueled the discovery of human flight using aeroplanes, but did it lead to individuals starting to fly?

"You can argue that the collective belief led to discovery of aeroplanes, but how can it explain a human being soaring up in the sky and flying without any gadgets or equipment?"

Rosiah went quiet for a few moments.

"Ok doctor, I will go now. I don't want to waste any more of your time. But I will come back when I fly again. This time do you want me to bring any more information for you?"

"Can you shoot your flight on your mobile phone camera and bring it to me? Can you also pay close attention to your thoughts and feelings when you are flying and let me know about them?"

Rosiah got up and walked away. There were several other patients after that, but my thoughts were running back to Rosiah and his fascinating clinical history. He was articulate, socially functional, and seemed possessed of sharp clarity, yet had zero insight into the unreality of his flight. Days passed and slowly Rosiah faded into a distant memory.

Three weeks later, on a lean Friday morning, Rosiah came back to the clinic. He continued to look agitated and frustrated. He was in an excited state as he walked into room in a haste and planted himself firmly in the chair opposite me.

“Doctor, it happened again last evening. I flew up in the sky. This time it was not my home. I was in the Church. I had gone to meditate. As I was walking out, I suddenly started soaring high in the sky. I felt like I am God! From that vantage point, I noticed all human beings below me and wanted to protect them all from their own mistakes.”

“Did you get me the video or photo that I had requested”

“Sure, I have it” Rosiah said and pulled out his mobile phone. He opened it and showed me a video. The video showed the top angle view of the local church. There were very few people. It was evening and slowly darkness was setting in. The view was slowly gliding all over the church compound in the same top angle view. It looked like Rosiah was flying and had taken this video during his flight. My emotional brain believed that Rosiah was indeed flying. But my rational mind refused to believe it. Rosiah cannot be flying on camera!

“Did anyone see you flying? Has anyone captured you flying?”

“Doctor, this is very sad. You still do not believe me? What is wrong with you? I have been telling you that I am flying and you are not believing me. I brought you a video that I shot when I was flying and you think I am cheating you? Why should I cheat you? Why should I lie to you?”

Rosiah was shouting now. He stood up abruptly, his chair screeching violently against the clinic floor. His breathing was heavy, eyes burning with a mixture of righteous fury and sheer, terrifying vulnerability. The phone lay between us on the polished wood, the screen still glowing with the dusky twilight over the church rooftop.

I didn't answer right away. Arguing against his flight was futile; the sky was where he thrived, and I was threatening to drag him into the dirt. Instead, I looked past his anger and saw what had been hiding beneath the euphoria all along: the tremulous exhaustion, the dark bruised hollows beneath his eyes, and a profound, desperate loneliness. When you are the only person who can reach the skies, the solitude at that altitude must be unbearable.

"Rosiah," I said, keeping my voice low, dropping the pitch until it was steady and grounded. "Sit down. Please."

He remained standing for a long moment, chest heaving, before collapsing back into the chair. His legs immediately resumed their frantic, rhythmic tapping.

"I don't think you are lying," I said gently. "And I don't think you are trying to cheat me. I believe that you felt every gust of wind, and I believe you felt that boundless love for the people below. But look at your hands."

He looked down. They were trembling violently—a fine, rapid tremor borne of sleepless nights, an engine running on fumes for weeks.

"When you soar like that, your mind is moving at the speed of light. It carries you up so high that the ground vanishes. But look at what it's doing to your body. You haven't slept, have you? Not really. Not for weeks."

A flicker crossed his eyes, the first crack in the armor of certainty. His shoulders sagged slightly. " Sleep feels like a waste of time when you can fly. How can I sleep when the sky is waiting?" he mumbled, his voice suddenly smaller, stripped of its grandiosity.

“That video was taken from the church terrace, wasn’t it?” I asked softly, nodding at the phone. “The high terrace where the bell hangs?”

Rosiah stared at the blackening phone screen. He didn’t confirm it, but he didn’t deny it either. In his memory, the stone stairs hadn’t existed; the ascent had been weightless, a divine lift. To an elated mind, running up the narrow spiral steps to the parapet doesn’t feel like climbing, it feels like taking off.

A cold shudder ran through me. If he believed he could fly, the day would inevitably come when he stepped off that parapet expecting the wind to catch him. How stupid I had been to ask him to shoot a video of his flight. What if he had gone overboard and tried some angles that led to his fall?

“Rosiah, the view from up there is beautiful,” I said, leaning forward and resting my hand near his on the table. “The desire to look down on the world with pure love and protect people, that is an extraordinary gift. But right now, you are flying on a wind that isn’t yours. It’s a storm inside your brain, and it’s burning you out from the inside. If the storm keeps blowing, you won’t be able to steer. You will crash.”

He looked up, tears brimming at the corners of his eyes. “I don’t want to lose it, Doctor. Down here... everything is so heavy. Everyone is so slow.”

“You won’t lose who you are,” I promised. “We don’t need to clip your wings. We just need to give you an anchor. Something to keep you tethered to the earth so you don’t get lost in the clouds.”

I picked up my pen. This time, I didn’t write a prescription. I wrote a referral to a psychiatrist colleague who understood how to quiet

a storm without crushing the spirit, and I walked outside to the waiting room to call his brother in. I had noticed him accompanying Rosiah when he had come.

As they walked out together down the corridor, the brother gently holding Rosiah by the elbow, Rosiah walking with small, tentative steps, his feet finally touching the concrete, I leaned against my doorframe. Medicine often demands that we bring people down to earth. But watching Rosiah leave, I tucked his sky into my own memory: a quiet reminder that behind the grandest, most soaring flights of the human mind, there is often just a fragile soul terrified of the weight of living.

Chapter 6

Work of the hands; maker of the clay

It was an early Thursday morning. The morning was warm and humid. I got down from the bus at the bus stand. The clock in the nearby temple sang a devotional hymn in praise of Lord Shiva and announced the time. It was 8 AM. There is usually a half an hour gap between arriving at the town and taking a bus to the village to reach the clinic. I started walking briskly towards the temple. It was a temple town and the downtown area was predominantly occupied by the huge temple. The town Thirukazhukundram gets its name from Thiru – sacred, Kazhugu – eagle, Kundram – hill. It is the sacred town of the hill of the eagles. I looked up at the hillock where the eagles used to circle decades ago. The birds haven't come down for the noon rice in years, but the hill still holds the weight of their myth, casting a long, quiet shadow over the idling buses of North Mada Street. The Vedagirishwarar temple on the hill top and the Bakthavathsaleswarar temple in the foothills are the religious attractions of this town. The temples carry in them more than 14 centuries of devotion. The Thirukazhukundram temple is said to be consecrated by the songs of the three celebrated Nayanmar saints between 7th to 8th century with Tevaram hymns.

The economy of the town was centered around the temple with thousands of tourists visiting it every year. Our clinic is located in a village 6 KM away from this temple town. I like to take a walk to the temple in the foothills every morning before I go to the clinic. It is a brisk 5 minute walk from the bus stand. I had to walk through the North Mada Veethi which had shops selling flowers, coconuts, bananas, camphor and incense sticks. The narrow North Mada Street is also the throughfare for major bus routes that connect Thirukazhukundram to Kalpakkam, Sadras and Pondycherry. It is quite a challenge to navigate this street to the temple with these shops on either side giving a divine vibe and the buses and other heavy vehicles plying in the narrow road, creating a sense of fear and discomfort. I walked into the temple, took off my footwear, and passed through the main temple towers into the temple premises.

As I stood in front of the sanctum of Lord Shiva saying my prayers, a new priest, one whom I had never seen in the temple before came and stood in front of me.

"Do you want to do some special worship?"

"No, I come here routinely. I am just here to say my prayers"

I am not one for small talk, especially in the temple. I wanted my quiet time for prayer. I closed my eyes and started chanting a Tevaram hymn that I knew by heart. The young priest walked back into the sanctum and was engaged in his work. I went around the sanctum paying my respects to the other Gods who are located all around the main sanctum and returned to the main sanctum. I stood there for a few more minutes as I completed my hymn. As I was getting ready to leave the sanctum, I noticed the young priest. His back was turned to me. He was tall. He was wearing a dhothi in the panchakacham style (like a pantaloon). He was bare chest

and had smeared the vibhooti ashes all over his chest, arms and back. He was wearing stylish metal rimmed glasses for his eyes. He had a look of strange peace and calm on his face. His left foot and leg were massively swollen and it was visible obviously through the pantaloon dhoti.

Thōdudai yānoru kādhil thūya kuzhaithāzha

Ēdudai yānthalai kalanāga irandhuṇṇum

Nādudaiyān naḷḷiruḷ ēma nadamādum

Kādudaiyān kādhalsey kōyil kazhukkuṉṟē.

He sang the famous Teveram hymn with a loud resonant and clear voice. I couldn't move without listening to his song fully. He carried the plate of offerings, camphor and vibhooti ashes and came towards me. He showed me the plate and gave me some vibhooti ash to apply on my forehead. I place a 50 rupee note on the plate as an offering to the priest. He gave me a small paper packet with the vibhooti packed in it and said,

"I am Ganesh gurukkal. Take my phone number. If you want to do any special prayers in the temple, feel free to call me."

I was hesitant. I am not very ritualistic. I go to temples for peace of mind. I am not into ritualistic practices, offerings, special prayers and so on. He saw me hesitating.

"Take out your phone. I will tell you my number. Note it down"

Such clear instructions were hard to ignore. I did not want to be rude. So I pulled out my phone from my pant pocket. I noted down his number and saved it as Ganesh Gurukkal TKM.

"May I know you name? What do you do?"

I said my name and told him that I am a doctor working in a rural clinic in the nearby village. He smiled and went back into the sanctum. I walked out and quickly got back to the bus stand to board my bus to the village.

Thoughts of Ganesh gurukkal lingered in my mind. His loud and sonorous voice, his cheerful and curious nature, and the large swelling of his left foot and leg kept visiting my mind repeatedly that day.

That Sunday when I went to Thirukazhukundram I again went to the temple. Sundays are usually crowded early in the morning. As I walked towards the sanctum I noticed a big crowd was already standing there. I could hear the same loud and pleasant voice of Ganesh gurukkal from the distance. I inched closer and stood in front of the sanctum. I stood there watching Ganesh gurukkal perform his rituals to the deity in the sanctum. He was chanting some Sanskrit hymns as he was performing the rituals. Then he walked out with the plate of offerings. As he saw me he flashed a big bright smile. I smiled back at him. The crowd parted and Ganesh gurukkal came closer to me.

"Good morning doctor. How are you? You work on Sundays also?"

"Oh, yes Sundays are my busiest clinic days of the week." I said and received the vibhooti ashes in my hands and applied them on my forehead.

"I am having this medical problem for which I have been seeing many doctors. Can I show you my reports and meet you when you are free?"

"Why not? Sure."

“Will you see me now? Can we go and sit in the courtyard of the Tripurasundari sactum?”

I was unprepared for this. I was not comfortable with the idea of seeing a patient inside the temple. “Can you come to my clinic later today? Or maybe next Thursday? I can see you there.”

I noticed the disappointment in Ganesh Gurukkal’s face. But he quickly nodded, smiled and said, “That is a good idea. I will come today after 12 noon”

I left and walked back to the bus stand and got to the clinic. The clinic was going on smoothly. Around 12.30 PM I noticed a fancy looking sports bike come and park in our clinic parking space. A guy in a dark blue hooded long sleeve round neck T shirt and dark blue stone washed jeans got down from the bike. As I watched through my window I noticed the guy taking off his helmet. It was Ganesh Gurukkal. I couldn’t recognize him in his modern garb. The moment I saw his vibhooti ash smeared forehead, the stylish bespectacled face emerge from inside the helmet, my mind played the Tevaram hymn that he sang so beautifully. He left the helmet on the bike and walked towards the clinic. The buzz of the clinic had just calmed down and there was nobody else waiting. Ganesh Gurukkal walked straight to my room.

“Good afternoon doctor. I came just as you told me”

“Good afternoon Ganesh gurukkal! Please have a seat.”

I did not push him to starting any conversation. There were no other patients waiting and I was not in a rush.

“You have a wonderful voice and the way you sang the Tevaram was so divine” I said.

"Thank you doctor. I have learned Carnatic music for more than 8 years. I have performed in various temples."

"That is wonderful. Tell me, what did you want to consult me regarding?"

Ganesh gurukkal got up, rolled up the left leg of the loose stone washed jeans and showed me his left leg and foot.

"I developed this foot swelling almost three years ago. It started as a mild swelling and has progressively increased in size."

I looked at his foot, examined it and touched it. It was a firm swelling. It looked like filariasis. Usually there is no cure for this stage of the disease.

"You must have seen doctors for this earlier."

"Ohh yes, I have seen many doctors. They said it is filariasis. I have gone to infectious diseases specialists, general doctors, surgeons and all kinds of specialists. But they all say nothing can be done about this."

"I am afraid that is true. Nothing can be done about this condition once the firm swelling has set in. We can only ensure that it doesn't get infected or swollen more than this."

"Yes, that is what everyone is saying. But I don't like this swelling."

"I can understand, does it hurt?"

"No no, not at all. There is absolutely no pain. It is just this discomfort. I can't wear shoes, I can't go out wearing shorts."

Why would Ganesh gurukkal want to wear shoes or shorts? I imagined him in a pair of shorts with sneakers, coolers and a cool

T shirt singing his Teveram hymns in the temple. It was amusing. Ganesh gurukkal must have noticed the change in my facial expression.

“I understand what you are thinking now. You are wondering why I would wear shoes and shorts right?”

I looked down in uneasy embarrassment.

“I am only a part time priest in the temple. I have mainly come to spend vacation months here with my grandfather and he has inducted me to substitute for him at the temple.”

That was interesting information. I was now curious to know what his regular job was.

“I will discuss with some senior colleagues and find out what we can do about it and where such treatments are available.”

“That would be extremely helpful doctor. Cost is not a problem. Please let me know any information you get.”

“I will get back to you soon. May I ask you what you do other than the part time job as a priest in the temple?”

“I draft patent filings,” he said simply, his English crisp and accent-neutral. “Medical devices, software algorithms, bio-tech patents. The corporate side pays the rent; the morning puja honors my grandfather. Two jurisdictions, doctor.”

Ganesh gurukkal had seamlessly switched over to English at this stage of the conversation. I was amazed to hear the voice that sang such chaste Tevaram, now ringing in stylish English. It suddenly made sense why he would want to wear shoes and shorts for corporate parties and events.

"You are a very interesting man Mr. Ganesh, corporate intellectual property lawyer part time and temple gurukkal for the other part! I am amazed!"

"The former is for my interest and the latter is to preserve family tradition. My grandfather wanted me to master the Vedas and take up the profession of being a temple priest after him. He was very disappointed that my father never followed his footsteps and went on to work for a private company in the city. He enrolled me in Veda school right from my 8 years of age. I also simultaneously studied in regular school, went to law school and got my law degree."

"How do you balance both the worlds? They must be poles apart."

"Let me ask you one question doctor. I see you come to the temple regularly. You pray and are quite seriously involved in your prayers. Being a doctor, being a man of science, how do you manage to maintain such faith in God?"

It was an intense question. I have struggled with this question a lot.

Ganesh gurukkal developed a serious look and got intensely engaged in the conversation.

"As a doctor, your entire life is dedicated to gaining control over nature, over God's work. And how do you pray and seek guidance from God to do that?"

I was quiet. Ganesh gurukkal had got me thinking. He noticed that I did not reply.

"I hope I did not disturb you by asking these questions. I have to leave now doctor. Please let me know if you have any information. You already have my number. Good bye doctor" he said, got up and walked out.

Long after Mr. Ganesh left, his questions were ringing in my ears. I got home later that evening and called my friend who is a plastic surgeon working in the Delhi.

"Arjun, I met a very interesting gentleman today in my rural clinic. He is a temple priest by day and corporate IPR lawyer by evening! He has lymphatic filariasis with massive swelling of his left foot. Do you guys do anything for that?"

"Ahh…we have many newer surgical options nowadays. If the fibrosis is dense, conservative management won't touch it. We do a debulking first, then an LVA—lymphaticovenular bypass. Send him to my clinic in Delhi. If his channels are patent, we can give him his ankle back."

"He says there is no financial constraints. So I will ask him if he can visit you. You will find him to be very interesting. He challenged my faith in God by asking some insightful questions."

"Aahhh! You and your faith! I am glad someone is questioning it!"

We had some light hearted banter following that and ended the call.

I called Ganesh gurukkal the next morning on his phone.

"Hello doctor! That was very quick. You have some information for me already?"

I explained what Arjun had told me and suggested that he go to Delhi to meet Arjun and have the treatment there.

"That is fantastic doctor. Nobody has given me such clarity before. I will surely follow up on Dr. Arjun and visit him as soon as I can. Thank you doctor"

That call triggered another train of thoughts of what Ganesh had planted in my mind.

"As a doctor, your entire life is dedicated to gaining control over nature, over God's work. And how do you pray and seek guidance from God to do that?"

Even Arjun couldn't resist taking a jab at it. To him, to the medical fraternity at large, faith is an affectionate eccentricism—an unscientific relic you indulge in before putting on the white coat of rationality. We are trained to think of disease as a broken cog in an unthinking machine. We study pathology to remove authority away from chaos, to map the chemistry of suffering down to the milligram, to manipulate tissue until we force a biological outcome. We are taught that we are the final arbiters between flesh and decay.

And for a long time, pride lets you believe it. You feel like a minor deity with a stethoscope.

So what am I doing in the North Mada Street every Thursday and Sunday morning, dodging state transport buses and flower vendors, taking off my sandals to bow before a sanctum carved out fourteen centuries ago?

Is it hypocrisy? When I stood in the temple listening to Ganesh sing Sambandar's lines Thōdudai yānoru kādhil thūya kuzhaithāzha… his voice seemed to carve order out of the morning heat. Yet, when he rolled up the denim of his jeans an hour later, revealing the stark, irreversible fibrosis of filariasis, the clinician in me immediately took over. The textbook reflex fired: chronic lymphostasis, permanent architecture destruction, irremediable. I saw the biology, cold and uncaring. And when Arjun spoke of lympho-venous bypasses and debulking, it felt like the ultimate triumph of technique over biology.

Man rewriting what nature had ruined.

Ganesh asked how I can seek God while spending my life attempting to subvert His work. But maybe the premise itself is flawed. Maybe medicine isn't an act of rebellion against God. Maybe it's an act of participating in Him.

The parasite that blocked the channels in his leg didn't possess malicious intent; it followed the blind, unguided laws of biology. When Arjun takes a scalpel to excise the thickened skin and repair small blood vessles thinner than a hair, he isn't waging war against God. He is simply clearing the rubble so that life can do what life was designed to do: flow, mend, survive. We don't create the pulse. We don't command the tissues to heal. We only set the stage, clear the clutter and watch a power infinitely older than our textbooks knit the wound together. I don't go to the foothills of Thirukazhukundram to ask God to violate the laws of nature. I go there to remind myself of my own smallness. The medicine gives me the tools to manipulate the flesh, but the faith reminds me why that flesh matters in the first place.

Without the science, I would be helpless before his suffering. But without the faith, I would eventually start believing that the healing was mine to give.

The two worlds don't cancel each other out. Just like the corporate lawyer standing barefoot in the sanctum with ash across his forehead and chest, they live in the very same vessel. One is the work of the hands; the other is the quiet realization of who made the clay.

Chapter 7

The only one not alone

"Come walk with me. Let us talk.

These people call me Lakshmanan. You can call me Laks. That is what my mother used to call me when I was little.

Careful, don't trip over that rock. Here…let me put it aside."

He bent down toward the bare clinic floor, his calloused hands heaving an invisible weight and nudging it against the baseboard.

"There you go. Now everyone can walk without the fear of tripping over that rock.

If that rock had the ability to speak it would constantly complain about the indifference of people who jump over it, or even trip over it and fall. Nobody bothered to put it aside. The rock would cry. We think it is an inconvenience to us as we walk there. But we are equally an inconvenience to it as we trip over it. We are disturbing its peace, hurting it and tossing it around, aren't we?

When did we start thinking everything is about us? When did we start believing that the world belongs to us? And not them? Not to those silent, dumb, stupid, mad rocks!"

I sat silently listening to Lakshmanan. We were seated in our clinic. Lakshmanan had a high strung voice and was in a rush to narrate everything he had to say.

"Ok, coming back to the topic…what was I telling you? Mmmm…. yes, my mother used to call me Laks. I was a very naughty boy. I used to lie that my stomach is aching or my head is aching to escape from going to school. My mother never scolded me or forced me to go to school against my will. She would tuck me in the bed. She would give me some rice porridge. Then she would come sit by my side and tell me the story of the butterfly. Do you know the story of the butterfly?"

I nodded no. Lakshmanan did not wait for me to say anything.

"Ohh…you don't know the story. Let me tell you.

Once upon a time there was a little butterfly. She hated to go to school. She would stay in her flower bush and pretend to be sick. Amma butterfly would allow her to stay back in the flower bush. After some time, the butterfly wanted to play. So, she went outside and called the bee. The bee was busy collecting honey and refused to come and play with her. Then she went and called the sparrow. The sparrow was busy building her nest. She also refused to come and play. Then she went and invited the dog to play. The dog was busy watching his master's house and he refused to come to play. From there the butterfly went straight to the cow. The cow was grazing and trying to eat enough so that she can give her master some milk. The cow also refused to come and play. The

disappointed butterfly flew back to her flower bush and sat down crying. Amma butterfly came and asked what the matter was. The butterfly told her how she was so lonely and bored. Then Amma butterfly said, "One must work when they work and play when it is time to play. Avoiding school or work to stay home and play will only lead to boredom"

Lakshmanan was breathless when he finished narrating this. He looked to his left and right and his eyes and cheeks started twitching. There was a heightened sense of urgency to finish saying what he wanted to.

"What did you learn from this story? Tell me, what did you learn?

I learned the importance of going to school. I never stayed home after that.

But then one day they said I can't see my mother anymore. She had gone away to the Gods. She died. I asked when she will come back. They did not know. They asked me to wait. So I am still waiting for my mother to come back. It has been a long wait."

Lakshmanan looked completely lost. His face fell into an expression of absolute loneliness and grief.

"I started working in my uncle's farm. Have you been to that farm? It is far away.

You haven't seen the farm? It is a nice farm. It smells of cow dung, hay, soil and rain.

Cow dung, hay, soil and rain. In that order.

Uncle asked me to take care of the chicken. There were 22 of them. I knew to count till 22. I would count them every day. 22 would

go out of the pen…cluck cluck cluck they would go and feed on the grains and dirt. Then 22 would enter back into the pen…cluck cluck cluck. Muniyandi stole all of them except 3. It was the worst day of my life. I was searching everywhere. I just could not find the rest of them. I had named all the chicken. Only Rama, Lakshmana and Rukmini remained. All others were gone. That evening uncle beat me hard. He took out his belt and kept repeating, "What a waste of precious food grains. Why should I feed you if you cannot even take care of chicken?"

Why was uncle worried about food grains? There seems to be so much lying around in gunny bags in the shed. Why was he so worried about it?"

Lakshmanan went quiet for a few seconds. He took the glass of water from the table. Took a sip of the water.

"I wished my mother came back from the Gods. But she never did. I was still waiting.

Sami, Murugan, Ammasi and others went to school. But I never went. I don't know why I was never sent to school. Maybe Amma had to be around for children to go to school. My mother was not there. So I did not go."

"MGR came to our village that month. Do you know MGR? I went to meet MGR. He was shining like gold. He was so fair and so handsome. I was watching MGR from a distance and he looked like God."

Suddenly Lakshmanan's face starting shining brightly like a light bulb.

"It was a movie shooting in the village. MGR was acting in the movie. They called for young boys from the village to come and act with MGR in one scene. I raised my hands and ran to get involved. I wanted to act with MGR. They gave me a torn shirt and old, loose trousers to wear. They asked me to run towards MGR and ask for money. They said I am a beggar. I ran towards MGR. I asked MGR for money. I was MGR's beggar. After that scene MGR came and patted my back. I was a good beggar. MGR patted my back. God patted my back. I wanted to act in more movies with MGR."

Lakshmanan went into deep thought. His face was filled with an excited smile. He was very proud of what he was narrating.

"One heavy built agent came to my uncle's house that evening. MGR is calling this boy to accompany him to Chennai. MGR will take care of the boy, educate him and give him a good life, he said. I wanted to go away with MGR. I cried, I fell on the floor and rolled this way and that way and begged my uncle to let me go. I went with MGR to Chennai."

The look of happiness on Lakshmanan's face was not diminished even a little bit.

"Have you gone to the temple? In the temple have you talked to the God?

Has God ever talked back to you? No, right? MGR is like God. Only I talk to MGR. MGR did not talk to me. They said MGR will educate me. They said MGR will find me a job. They said MGR will give me a good life. MGR is like God. He did not do any of this.

MGR's house was big. I was made to stay in the servant's quarters. It had the smell of wet mold on the walls and dried sweat on the clothes of the servants.

They gave me idly. The idly was cold and hard. Not the soft cloud-like puffed balls of cotton that was served for MGR at the movie shooting spot. There was no sambar to go with the idly. Just some old stale chilli powder with oil. I waited daily around the gate, to catch a glimpse of MGR. A glimpse of the God of cinema. But only we can talk to Gods. Gods never talk back to us. MGR only smiled at me once. And blessed me indefinitely.

I ran away from his house."

Lakshmanan got up from his chair. Walked around the room. I waited for him to return to his chair. He made two rounds.

"Lakshmanan, please come sit down and tell me what happened next."

He slowly walked back and sat down.

"I joined a koothu troupe. Have you seen koothu? It is the street drama during festival times. Actors wear elaborate costumes and make up and dance all night during temple festivals. There was one koothu troupe in Villupuram. Do you know Villupuram? I joined that troupe. I travelled all over with them. I fetched water for washing, drinking, cleaning. I brought food for dancers to eat. I cleaned up after their performance. I helped them put on their elaborate costumes and make up. The head gear was the most elaborate. It was in seven different colors, all bright and resplendent. Yellow, red, green, orange, pink, violet and indigo. The head gear was a riot of colors. You can see the rainbow in it. You can see the head gear in the rainbow. I wanted to wear that head gear and make up. It would look so colorful on my head. My amma would love to see me wearing it. I wanted to learn to dance. I wanted to be Duryodana. I wanted to be Karna. I wanted to be Dharmaraja.

They kept saying I am not ready. I don't look good. I look good. MGR said I look good. My mother said I look good. Go ask your mother to teach you dance, they said. I was still waiting for my mother to come back. Still waiting."

Lakshmanan's expression changed to deep sadness. Creases appeared on his forehead. He bent down and put his head on the table. Then he lifted his head. There was a sudden deep exhaustion in his eyes.

"I met Valli in one performance. Valli came to see our dance. As I ran here and there trying to get the artists ready, Valli was watching hidden behind the pillar. She came day after day for all seven days of the koothu. I caught her watching. Valli is watching me. Valli likes me. Valli likes Lakshmanan! Valli loves Lakshmanan! Lakshmanan loves Valli!

It was like Arjuna and Draupadi. Though she was married to all five brothers, she loved him first. Draupadi loves Arjuna. Valli loves Lakshmanan. I had to ask Valli.

I asked Valli that evening to come with me. Valli, you are Draupadi. Don't you see that? Valli, I am Arjuna. Don't you see? Draupadi belongs with Arjuna, and you with me.

She screamed and ran away! She seemed scared. This boy is mad. His eyes are red and mad. She screamed again. Why was Valli scared of Lakshmanan? Lakshmanan is good. Amma knows he is good. Why doesn't Valli see it? I felt very lonely. I ran away from the troupe. I left them to find my mother. I was waiting for my mother."

He went silent for a few seconds. Then he got up, walked and stood next to the window.

“From Villupuram, I went to Trichy. I went to the Samayapuram temple. There were a lot of people. I wanted to know what was happening. It is the temple festival. They were saying Amma is inside the temple. Mother is inside the temple.

Was my mother also inside the temple? I wanted to meet my mother. I went inside the temple. There she was. Sitting inside the sanctum. I recognized her immediately.

She smiled at me. She gestured to me and asked me to come closer. I ran towards her. Amma…here I come…Amma…here I come…They stopped me. Go out, you are not allowed inside. They stopped me. Amma kept calling me inside. Go out, you are not allowed inside they said. I shouted, I screamed. Amma, they are not letting me in, I said.

Some tall, dark, fat men, policemen came in and carried me out. They threw me outside the temple. My shoulders, arms, and back hurt. I lay there crying. Amma came out to see me. Don’t you see her. She is sitting right there. Amma has been coming with me everywhere from then. She never leaves my side.”

Lakshmanan pointed to the empty chair next to him. He smiled at nobody there. He then turned to me.

“Can’t you hear her? She is asking me to tell you about my headaches. She is asking me to tell you that I have seizures. She is saying as long as she is there to protect me, nothing will happen to me. Can you hear her? Can you really not hear her?”

He started whispering now. He put his index finger on top of his lips and asked me to go silent. He turned this way and that way and gestured me to listen closely.

“Listen. Tilt your head like this. Like a bird listening for water underground” he whispered.

“It isn’t a loud voice. It is the sound of hens pecking on the ground – cluck cluck cluck. It sounds like the scraping of a brass ladle against an empty brass pot when the porridge is almost gone. You have to listen extra carefully to hear her. Once you get a hang of her voice, her talks will never end. She will constantly come with you, talk to you and be with you.”

“Lakshmanan, can you tell me about your headaches a little more.” I asked.

“My head does hurt. Sometimes it feels as though a hundred temple bells are being struck inside my temples all at once, not in rhythm, but in anger. And then the ground shakes. You think the earth is steady under your feet, don’t you? It isn’t. When the shaking starts in my belly, the trees lean sideways, the road folds in half like an old paper, and my teeth bite through my own tongue until I taste blood. One time, I fell down and hit my head against the stone. They thought I was dead. They put me on the verandah and covered me with a white cloth. People gathered in a circle when that happened. They stood at a distance, holding their children back by the shoulder. They whispered that I was dead at last. They started planning how to dispose of my dead body. And then Amma came and whispered in my ears, “Laks..get up…otherwise they will burn you.” I sprung up and sat. They were all scared. They said it was God’s miracle. MGR’s miracle. Amma’s miracle. God! MGR! Amma! That is when the headaches started”

I listened intently.

"They don't understand. I did not die. Death is not the end. I am dead and I am alive. I am both. When this life gets too heavy, I die. Then when things become manageable I come alive again! And every time I wake up from death, with dirt in my hair and my throat raw from shouting sounds I don't remember making, who do you think is wiping the blood and spit off my face? Not the shopkeeper. Not the bus conductor. Not my uncle. Not MGR. Not the koothu troupe master. It is Her. Amma is there. She sits right on the edge of the open drain, not caring if her red saree gets stained with mud. She strokes my forehead until the headache stops. She tells me I am a good boy. MGR gave me a torn shirt and a pat on the back. The koothu troupe master gave me cold leftovers and bruised arms. But Amma… Amma stays through the seizures. She stays through the rain."

Lakshmanan paused for a breath. But he seemed to be in a frenzy. His voice came out in a hush.

"My knees are old now. My face is also old. My back is old. Look at that tamarind tree ahead." He pointed out to the tamarind tree outside the window of the clinic.

"The shade looks cool, doesn't it? Let us sit for a minute. To rest the old knees, the old face and the old back. Look at the people walking past us. Look at that man in the blue shirt checking his watch. Look at that woman sitting there with her baby in her arms. They are clueless. They are lost. They think I am the one who is lost."

Lakshmanan started laughing. It was a soft and strained laughter.

“Sometimes, when I sit at the tea stall and talk to Amma, the tea-master bangs his aluminum kettle on the stove. “Hey, mental! Go talk to the wall somewhere else! Don’t scare the customers!” They laugh. They tap their fingers against their foreheads and shake their heads. They pity Lakshmanan. They see a middle-aged man in grease-stained trousers, with matted hair and bare feet, talking to the empty air. They look at the empty space beside me and they feel a hollow dread. They think I am alone.How can I tell them? How can I explain to them that I am the only one on this crowded road who is never, ever alone?”

Lakshmanan laughed again. The same gentle soft strained laughter.

“Each one of them is alone. They shout inside their mind, they cry inside their mind, they walk like empty shells. I am the only one who has Amma walking with me always, awake, asleep, alive and dead. They lose their mothers and spend forty years weeping into the dark, looking at faded black-and-white photographs framed on wall hooks. They lose their gods to stone sanctums that close their brass doors at noon and at night. They have to buy tickets, stand in barricades, push past policemen, and pay fifty rupees just to catch a two-second glimpse of a black stone idol through smoke and oil lamps.

I don’t need a ticket. I don’t need fifty rupees. The stone gods stayed inside the sanctum, but my mother walked out with me. She is whispering again. She says the sun is setting behind the hill. She says it is time to find a dry corner under the bus shelter before the night buses start rolling in.”

Lakshmanan paused. He locked eyes with me. He had a questioning look on his face.

"You have other patients waiting for you, don't you? You have that look in your eyes. The look people get when they remember their clocks, the other patients waiting for them, their trains, their houses with bolted doors. It is alright. I will go. Thank you for walking with me. Thank you for not jumping over me like that rock in the dirt."

Now Lakshmanan looked to the empty chair.

"Come, Amma. Take my hand. The sky is turning grey. Let us go find where the chicken sleep tonight. Rama, Lakshmana, and Rukmini must be waiting in the dark, cluck-cluck-clucking for their grain. Let us go home."

Chapter 8

The burden of shame

"It is your turn to go see the doctor now. You may go in"

"No, please let the next token go in. I will wait"

"This is the fourth time you are doing this. Why? Are you waiting for someone? Why don't you go? Aren't you getting late?"

"No…it is alright. I am not in a hurry. Please send the next token"

The young man in black T shirt, and black pant, had a restless look on his face. He went and sat in the bench. The staff nurse was irritable. He was skipping his turn repeatedly. Why is he doing that?

Pradeep had light skin tone, with jet black dense thick hair on his head and face, the stark contrast enhancing all his facial characteristics. What could have otherwise been considered a very handsome face was now lined with dense lines of anxiety. There were dark rings around his eyes and the angle of his mouth was continuously twitching in nervousness. He was fidgety, twisting a

piece of paper that he held in his hands round and round. He was wearing a small backpack. It was not clear what he was waiting for. Ten minutes went by.

"Pradeep, will you go now? Or do you still want to skip the queue?"

"Please send the next token"

The staff nurse sent the next person and Pradeep sank back into the bench.

Pradeep's mind was in a turmoil. He kept nervously looking at the gate of the clinic, as though he was expecting someone to come. Some ten more minutes went by.

"Pradeep all tokens for this morning are over. You are the only one remaining. Do you want to go in now?"

Pradeep got up hesitantly and walked into the consultation room.

"Good afternoon doctor"

Dr. Keshav welcomed Pradeep with a smile. Pradeep went in and sat in the patient's chair.

"Tell me young man. What brings you to the clinic today?"

"Doctor…it is a confidential secret. Can I tell you here? Can anyone hear us?" Pradeep looked all around to see if anyone was watching or hearing from outside the room. There was a nervous look on his face, which persisted from the time he entered the room.

"Don't worry about it. You can tell me anything. It will remain between these four walls. I wont talk about it to anyone without your permission."

Pradeep lowered his voice to less than a whisper and mumbled something.

"I cannot hear you, Pradeep. Do not worry. Tell me clearly. Nobody can hear us."

Pradeep got up and checked out of the window just behind Dr. Keshav. He also walked up to the clinic door and checked that it was indeed shut. Then he came and sat down heavily. "No doctor. I am losing semen during sleep"

"I understand. What else? Do you have any other problems?"

"Because of losing semen during sleep, I am extremely weak. I am losing my memory. I am always nervous, restless and agitated. I have low energy"

"Have you seen any doctors regarding this? Have you taken any treatment for this?"

"I have spent close to a lakh of rupees on treatment for this condition doctor. I have taken treatment for more than 4 months now. But it is not stopping. I am only getting weaker"

"Where are you taking treatment?"

"I am getting treatment with a traditional medicine doctor. The doctor did so many tests. He did blood test, urine test, sperm test and all kinds of tests. He says I have a semen related disease for which I must take treatment."

Pradeep opened the small dark blue backpack that he was wearing. Out came a thick plastic folder with a lot of papers inside. He kept the folder on the table in front of me and pushed it towards me.

"These are all the test reports that I have done over the past 4 months doctor"

I opened the folder and pulled out the thick bundle of test reports. There were more than 50 sheets of reports there. There were so many biochemical and hematological tests, many of which I did not even know existed. There were four different semen analyses, done once a month. There were several urine tests, stool tests, electrocardiograms, echocardiogram, X rays, ultrasound scans of the abdomen, ultra sound scans of the scrotum and testes. All the tests were normal. There were red ink pen marks used to underline even many normal blood, urine and semen test results.

"Why have these been underlined? Do you know Pradeep?"

"The traditional medicine doctor told me, they are all abnormal tests for which I must take treatment"

There was absolutely nothing abnormal in any of the results.

"Do you have any other problems, Pradeep?"

"Doctor, I have another strange problem. I don't know how to explain to you?"

"You can tell me anything."

"I don't know the correct and decent way to say it doctor"

"Don't bother about decent way of saying it. Tell me how you know to say it and I will ask you if I don't understand"

"After I finish passing urine some drops of urine are remaining in my urine passage and they keep dripping throughout the day and my underwear gets wet doctor"

“Anything else Pradeep?”

“That’s all doctor. I want help. I want to stop losing my semen during sleep. I also don’t want my urine to drip all day long. Sometimes it makes my stink like urine. I want all that to stop.”

The afternoon sunlight slanted through the slatted blinds of the consultation room, cutting sharp geometric lines across the polished wooden desk. Outside in the corridor, the persistent chatter of outpatients had finally thinned to silence. Dr. Keshav closed the thick plastic folder, placed both palms flat over the mound of fifty irrelevant laboratory reports, and gently pushed them to the far corner of his desk.

Pradeep watched the movement with wide, panicked eyes. His jaw clenched, and his gaze darted toward the discarded papers as though the doctor were tossing away the only evidence of a fatal condition. His fingers resumed their frantic twisting of the crumpled appointment token, turning the slip into a tight, damp roll of paper. The nervous twitch at the corner of his lips grew sharper.

Dr. Keshav took off his reading glasses and leaned back, his posture open and unhurried.

“Pradeep,” the doctor began, keeping his voice low, steady, and devoid of judgment. “Let us set these reports aside for a few minutes. Before we discuss blood values, scans, and medicines, I want to know about you. Tell me about your life outside this clinic. Who is at home with you? What does your typical day look like?”

Pradeep shifted uncomfortably in the molded plastic chair, looking down at his lap. He seemed unaccustomed to being asked about himself rather than his symptoms.

“My family... we are very close-knit, doctor,” he murmured, his voice tentative. “Traditional and orthodox. It’s my parents and my two elder brothers. But both of my brothers got married over the last few years and moved out to live in their own homes. So now, it is just me living with my mother and father.”

“And your brothers?” Dr. Keshav asked gently. “What kind of dynamic do you share with them?”

A bitter, self-deprecating smile touched the young man’s lips. “They are both brilliant. Overachievers, really. My eldest brother cleared the Group II state services exam on his very first attempt and is a state government officer; my second brother went to Trichy Engineering college and is now a senior director in a private multinational company. Right from childhood, they brought home gold medals, topped their classes, and made my father proud.”

He stopped, swallowing hard. The hollow tone of long-standing comparison weighed down every syllable.

“And you?”

“I was never like them, doctor,” Pradeep confessed, his voice shrinking. “I struggled through school. I barely scraped through a mechanical engineering degree from a local tier-three college with average marks. Every dinner table conversation was about what my brothers had achieved, and how I had failed to carry the family name forward.”

“And your father?” Dr. Keshav watched the young man’s face closely. “How did he handle your growing years?”

Pradeep visibly recoiled, his spine stiffening against the chair as if preparing for an impending blow.

“My father ruled our house like a military camp,” he said, the memories rushing forward with painful clarity. “There was an unbending rule for every minute of our day. Wake up at five in the morning, do prayers, study till breakfast, study after dinner. No going out with friends after sunset. No sports, no movies, no casual conversations. Zero freedom. If we made a minor mistake or scored two marks less on an exam, the walls would shake with his shouting. My elder brothers somehow had the intellect to withstand it; they escaped through their academic achievements and built their own lives. But I couldn’t escape. My parents made sure I knew I was the family disappointment. Even today, when my father looks at me, his eyes say I am useless, weak, and spineless. Every negative word he speaks feels like an iron hammer coming down on my head.”

“And your work environment now?”

“It’s no different, doctor,” Pradeep sighed, his shoulders slumping further under the weight of his black T-shirt. “I work in operations at a logistics firm. My reporting manager is a replica of my father, overpowering, aggressive, and short-tempered. If there is a delay in a shipment, even when the vendor is entirely at fault, he screams at me in the open bay in front of all my colleagues. I never find the courage to defend myself. I just stand there, hang my head, and apologize. I feel completely inadequate. In the office, on the street, at home... I feel smaller than everyone else. I constantly wonder why I was born so weak.”

Dr. Keshav took a slow breath, noting the dark circles etched beneath Pradeep’s eyes, the hollow cheeks, and the pervasive self-loathing that had defined his entire adult life. The clinical picture was crystallizing rapidly.

“Pradeep,” the physician said, his tone softening with deep empathy. “The weakness you describe... you don’t believe it comes only from self-doubt, do you? You carry an enormous burden of guilt. You feel your body is physically failing you, and you connect that failure directly to losing semen in your sleep. Where did this fear of losing semen or having sexual feelings come from?”

At the word “sexual feelings”, Pradeep’s breath caught in his chest. His head snapped toward the clinic door, verifying once again that the bolt was in place. His hands gripped his knees tightly.

“Doctor... it is a terrible sin,” he whispered, his vocal cords trembling. “I committed a horrible sin when I was fifteen years old. I haven’t spoken of it to another person.”

“Whatever it is, it is safe here,” Dr. Keshav assured him, leaning forward across the desk. “There is nothing shameful about being human.”

A tear slipped from Pradeep’s eye, tracing down his cheek.

“It was a Sunday afternoon during my summer holidays,” Pradeep recounted, his voice cracking with old, unresolved terror. “My parents were supposed to be out at a family function. I was alone in the house. I had these intense physical urges that I couldn’t understand, and I went into the bathroom. I was curious... and I began masturbating. But the door latch was loose. My father had returned early to pick up a forgotten document. He pushed the door open.”

Pradeep closed his eyes, shuddering as though the scene were playing out right in front of him.

"The expression of raw disgust and fury on his face... he dragged me by the collar into the living room. He beat me with his leather belt until he was breathless. He screamed that I was filthy, degenerate, an animal with no morals or shame. He brought my mother in and made me stand there with my shorts down in front of them while he humiliated me. That evening, he drove me to the town's ancient Shiva temple. It was peak prayer time, crowded with hundreds of people. He forced me to strip to my waist, drop onto the stone floor, and perform anga pradakshanam, rolling on the rough granite all the way around the outer praharam, crying and begging God to cleanse my soul."

Pradeep wiped his face with the sleeve of his shirt, his chest heaving with silent, painful sobs.

"When we got back home, my father pointed his finger at my face and made me take an oath," Pradeep continued, his voice trembling. "He said, 'Listen to me carefully, you worthless boy. Semen is the concentrated essence of your life. It takes hundreds of drops of blood to create a single drop of semen. It is sacred. It must never, ever be wasted until the night of marriage, and it must never be spilled outside a woman's womb. If you spill it like dirt, your body will decay from within. Your spinal fluid will dry up, your memory will fail, your brain will rot, and you will become an impotent, living corpse.' Doctor, those words were carved into my mind like fire. From that day onward, I never touched myself again. Not once in ten years."

"How did you cope with your natural urges all these years?" Dr. Keshav asked, deeply moved by the psychological brutality the young man had endured.

“I fought them like a demon,” Pradeep whispered. “Whenever an erotic thought crossed my mind, I pinched my arms, took freezing cold baths, starved myself, or chanted religious hymns until I fell asleep exhausted. I forced my mind into total submission. But four months ago, I woke up in the middle of the night and found my underwear wet. I had emitted semen in my sleep. I had a full-blown panic attack right there on my bed. When it happened again a week later, I thought my father’s curse was coming true. That’s when I found that traditional practitioner.”

“And what did he tell you?”

“He echoed my father word for word,” Pradeep said bitterly. “He told me my body was leaking vital life-force. He ordered all these expensive blood tests, semen tests, and ultrasounds, drew red ink across the pages, and told me that unless I paid him thousands of rupees for secret herbal decoctions, my spine would hollow out and my nervous system would collapse. I spent nearly a lakh of rupees. Every morning I wake up feeling dizzy, my memory is slipping, my hands shake, and now even drops of urine leak into my trousers during the day. I feel like I am dying from the inside out.”

Dr. Keshav sat silently for a long moment, allowing the space to absorb the raw pain of the revelation. The clinical diagnosis was unmistakable: Pradeep was in the throes of severe Dhat syndrome, a deeply ingrained, culture-bound psychosomatic condition born from intense sexual repression, authoritarian domestic abuse, and toxic mythology surrounding male bodily fluids.

Dr. Keshav reached out and placed a firm, grounding hand over Pradeep’s trembling arm.

“Pradeep. Look up at me.”

Pradeep lifted his head, his dark eyes brimming with desperate vulnerability.

"Take a deep breath and hear me clearly," Dr. Keshav said, each word deliberate and measured. "You are not rotting. You are not dying. You are not diseased. And above all else, you are not a sinner."

Pradeep stared at him, utterly stunned, as though the doctor had spoken to him in a foreign language.

"Let us throw away the myths and talk about pure biological facts," Dr. Keshav continued, taking a blank sheet of paper and drawing a simple diagram of the male reproductive system. "Semen is not produced from your blood, nor is it made of spinal fluid or brain matter. It is produced continuously by your testes, seminal vesicles, and prostate gland, composed of simple water, sugars, proteins, and zinc. It is an ordinary bodily secretion, no different in its biological nature than your saliva, tears, or gastric juices."

Pradeep watched the pen move across the paper, his breath hitching. *"It... it doesn't come from the spine?"*

"Not a single cell of it," Dr. Keshav affirmed. "Your body produces sperm every single second of every single day. If you do not release it through intercourse or masturbation, where do you think that fluid goes? The body cannot store an infinite volume. When the reservoirs are full, the nervous system naturally, safely triggers an involuntary release while you are in your deepest state of REM sleep. In medicine, we call this a nocturnal emission. Globally, people call it a wet dream. It is entirely benign, healthy, and universal. It is physiological proof that your reproductive system is mature and functional, not that it is decaying."

"Then... why am I so exhausted, doctor?" Pradeep asked, his voice trembling with a flicker of desperate hope. "Why does my head feel heavy? Why can't I concentrate at work?"

"Because you have been living inside a psychological prison for ten straight years," Dr. Keshav said gently. "You have spent a decade walking on eggshells around a domineering father, enduring the insults of a tyrannical boss, measuring yourself against your brothers' shadows, and constantly policing your own natural bodily urges with terror. The chronic sleeplessness, the physical exhaustion, the brain fog, and the shaking hands are the classic symptoms of severe, untreated generalized anxiety and depression. It is the crushing burden of fear and shame that is draining your energy, Pradeep. Not a few drops of seminal fluid."

Pradeep swallowed, staring down at the anatomical sketch. *"And... the urine dripping in my clothes after I leave the toilet?"*

"A purely mechanical matter," Dr. Keshav explained with a warm smile. "The male urethra has a natural anatomical curvature before it exits the body. At the end of urination, a few drops of fluid linger in that bend. When a person is intensely anxious, their pelvic floor muscles remain chronically tense and spasmed. As soon as you finish, pull up your trousers, and relax slightly, those trapped drops dribble out. It is known as post-micturition dribble. It is harmless. That traditional practitioner took advantage of your terror, drew red lines across perfectly healthy test results, and exploited your trauma for financial gain."

A heavy, transformative silence settled over the room. Pradeep looked down at his open hands, then turned his gaze toward the thick blue folder filled with fifty worthless test sheets.

Slowly, the rigid tension that had locked his jaw and curved his shoulders began to break. The frantic twitch at the corner of his mouth subsided. A long, shuddering breath escaped his chest, followed by another, as if he were taking his very first uninhibited breath of clean air in a decade.

"I didn't destroy myself..." Pradeep whispered to himself, the realization dawning over him like morning light. "I didn't ruin my life."

"You did not ruin a single thing, Pradeep," Dr. Keshav said warmly. "You were simply a terrified fifteen-year-old boy who was handed an intolerable amount of shame and ignorance, with no safe person to turn to for guidance. The real work begins now. We are going to heal this wound at its root. I am going to connect you with a clinical psychologist for structured cognitive behavioral therapy. Together, we will help you unlearn these destructive myths, process the trauma of your upbringing, rebuild your self-esteem, and teach you how to stand up for yourself, both at your workplace and in your home."

Dr. Keshav tore a sheet from his prescription pad and wrote down the names of a gentle, short-term mild anxiolytic to restore his sleep cycle, alongside the clinic hours for his counseling sessions. He slid the small slip across the desk.

Pradeep took the prescription slip with both hands, his fingers remarkably steady. He looked down at it, then rose slowly to his feet. He did not reach for the thick blue folder of laboratory reports; he left it abandoned on the edge of the desk, a discarded monument to four months of needless agony.

Standing tall, his handsome features finally liberated from the suffocating mask of anxiety, Pradeep bowed his head with deep, reverent gratitude.

"Thank you, doctor," Pradeep said, his voice clear, grounded, and steady for the first time that afternoon. "You didn't just explain medicine to me today. You gave me my life back."

Hidden burdens and silence

Chapter 9

One illness three perspectives

It is fun working with school children. They are a bundle of joy. They have boundless energy and enthusiasm. I look forward to going to the school every day. I work as a housekeeping helper in Sri Saradha school in the city. It is a 45 minute commute from my home to the school. I leave home around 6.00 AM, take the town bus and reach before 7 AM. The ground floor corridor, classroom and restrooms are my responsibility. I must sweep and mop the floors, clean the dustbins and check that the toilets have adequate running water in the taps. By 8 AM school starts and from then on the noise is relentless. Though the work is physically demanding, I cannot ask for a better way to spend my days, and earn a livelihood out of it.

As I entered the ground floor cleaning closet at 7.05 AM, I saw the floor supervisor already there before me. None of the other staff covering the first, second and third floors had come yet.

"As usual you are the first to enter…" the floor supervisor sounded angry.

“Sorry ma’am, got a bit held up in the bus, the conductor did not give me balance money.”

I rushed to the corner, picked up my broom, mop and bucket and started walking out to carry out my cleaning duty.

“Don’t go yet. I want to meet all of you briefly before we start our work for the morning.”

“Yes, ma’am. What is the matter?”

“Let the others join”

Slowly the other three housekeeping staff turned up. The supervisor stood with her hands folded. She raised her voice and said, “Next week, a medical team from the private hospital nearby is coming for school health check up for the kids. We must arrange the 4th standard classrooms in the east side of the ground floor. Five classrooms will be required. We must clean and arrange the desks and tables such that a medical check up can happen in those classrooms. Jothilakshmi, I want you to make a list of essential cleaning supplies that you will require and submit the list by this evening”

After this we all moved to fulfill our respective jobs. I filled my bucket with clean water, poured the floor cleaning liquid with a pleasant fragrance of lavender. I dipped my mop into the water, swirled the mop round and round till the mop was wet and then pulled it out of the water. I squeezed the excess water into the bucket, applied the mop on the floor and started dragging it to clean the floor.

School health check up is a busy activity. The 600+ children studying in the school will be examined by the team of 10 doctors and 6 nurses from the nearby private hospital. They identify any health

problems in the children and refer them to the private hospital for further tests and treatment. Most parents who send their children to our school are from the middle class status. They barely find the means to pay the school fees. None of them can afford follow up treatment and care at the private hospital. So most of them do not follow up on the suggestions given by the doctors. As I finished mopping the corridor, I picked up the large black waste bag and went into each class one by one and emptied the dustbins into the bag. We sweep and clean the classrooms immediately after school finishes at 3.30 PM. So the classrooms are relatively clean early in the morning. But by evening the classrooms look like war zones with litter thrown all around.

After I finished emptying the trash cans, I took the large black bag to the garbage corner. Pushpa, the first floor cleaning staff, was standing there emptying her bag.

"Jothi, did you finish breakfast? Shall we go and eat?"

"No Pushpa, I did not bring breakfast today. As usual I fast on Fridays. So I will just have some tea. When shall we go?"

"Come, let us go now"

"Have you checked your floor rest rooms? I will check mine and come. Wait for me"

I walked to the ground floor rest room complex and checked the running water in the taps. The water was flowing alright. I walked out from the rest room, joined Pushpa and went for my tea.

"This time, please show that swelling to the doctors who come for the check up next week" said Pushpa.

I caressed the lemon sized swelling on the left side of my neck. It had started as a small one last year, the size of a pea. Over the past one year, I had noticed that it gradually increased in size. Three months ago Pushpa had noticed it and asked me about it. Only after she pointed it out, I went home and saw it in the mirror. Though it was as big as a small sized lemon, the presence of a thick layer of neck fat had nicely concealed it so long. I hadn't even noticed it. After Pushpa pointed it out and I saw it in the mirror, I couldn't stop thinking about it, touching it or feeling it in my neck.

"Yes, I will show it to the doctors. I will ask them what the swelling is."

"Don't ignore it, nowadays people get a lot of cancers. You must get it checked out. If it is cancer, then better you get it treated as soon as possible"

"Don't you dare utter that word. It cannot be that. I am a God fearing woman. I fast on Mondays for Sivan, Thursdays for Sai baba, Fridays for Mari amman and Saturdays for Venkatesa perumal. I am hard working. I don't eat unnecessary things. How can I get that thing" I shouted at Pushpa. She shouldn't even utter that C word to me. Nobody in my family has it, it has not happened to anyone in any of our previous generations. How come suddenly I will have that? It is not possible.

"Ok, Ok. I am not saying it is cancer. All I am saying is for you to show it to the doctor and have it checked up"

I prepared the list of cleaning supplies required for the school health camp and met the supervisor. She forwarded the list to the school administration. Tomorrow, I have to go with the store manager to purchase the items. The supervisor appointed me as

in-charge of the school health camp. After sweeping and cleaning all the classrooms in my floor, I packed up and left for home.

I have three daughters, Poorni is in 12th standard, Priya in 10th and Kamali is in 7th standard. All three of them are hard working girls. They are intelligent and perform well in school. Poorni will be writing the NEET exam this year to get into medical college. Priya and Kamali are too young to decide what they want to study. My husband Ravi drives a share-autorickshaw in the city. He leaves early in the morning and returns only after 10 PM. As I entered home at 6 PM, all four of them were there already.

"What a surprise? All of you are home? Ravi, when did you come?"

As I kept my bag in my room and entered the bathroom to wash and freshen myself up, Poorni rushed to the bathroom,

"Amma, today is Appa's birthday. Have you forgotten? We all decided to go to the temple"

I had completely forgotten. It was Ravi's 50th birthday. I cleaned myself up and changed into a nice pink saree and did my hair, got ready and came out.

"Ravi, shall we go to the Murugan temple, and from there to the beach? After that we will have dinner outside and come home."

All of them were ready to leave and so headed out. It was a happy and fun outing. We make it a point to go to the beach almost once or twice every month. All five of us love going to the beach and enjoying the evening breeze there. We love the place, and mostly each other's company when we are there. Our beach outings make us forget all our pains, difficulties, worries and troubles and recharges us for the rest of the month, till we go back to the beach.

We all returned home exhausted after a fun evening out. The girls changed and went to lie down in the terrace. They all sleep there. On most days, Ravi and I also sleep on the terrace. But some days I sleep in the room alone. I decided to sleep alone today. As Ravi took his pillow and mat and started to go out he turned and looked at me,

"Jothi, how is that neck swelling? Have you seen the doctor about it?"

Ravi had noticed the neck swelling two months ago and has ever since been nagging me to see a doctor about it.

"I will see…I will see…" I replied and turned to my side to get into sleep.

Ravi stopped and moved towards me. He sat down and placed a gentle hand on my head. He caressed my head and said, "Jothi, you know I have nobody other than you. If anything happens to you, I won't ever forgive you for not taking care of yourself. If you don't go and see the doctor, I will take you by force." His voice was gentle, firm, worried and loving, all at the same time. I held his hand, gave him a loving look and reassured him. He went to the terrace to sleep.

The next few days in school went very busy in preparing for the school health check up program. We cleaned and prepared all the 4th standard classrooms for the health camp. We set up the height rods, weighing machines, torch lights, tables, chairs, medicine dispensing counters and sign boards in all the classrooms.

"Jothi, tomorrow, as soon as the doctors and their team arrive, I want you to give them all water. Then serve them tea and biscuits. After refreshments they will start the health screening camp. Every

1 hour, please keep serving them some water in glasses. Towards the end of the camp at 1 PM, we will take them out for lunch. Is that clear?" The supervisor was giving us final instructions just before we headed home on the day prior to the camp.

As I entered home Poorni walked to me, "Amma, I have to pay the exam fees tomorrow. 2500 rupees. Tomorrow is the last day. Only if we pay tomorrow, they will give me the hall ticket for the board exams."

"Yes, appa said he will arrange for the money. He will bring it today. Don't worry."

As I went to the kitchen to prepare dinner, my thoughts were full of worries about Poorni. She was growing up too fast. Just now it felt like she was a baby, and now she is writing her final school leaving exam. Next year we must plan for medical college fee and other expenses. And soon Priya and Kamali will grow up and come to college. And not too far from now, they will all start working and be ready for marriage. My stomach started twisting in knots with the worry about how we were going to manage all their lives and futures effectively. Ravi walked in and handed over the money to Poorni for her to pay the exam fees.

"Ravi, I am really worried about how we are going to fulfill the educational dreams and aspirations of our girls."

Ravi held my hands and said, *"One thing at a time Jothi, one worry at a time. Tomorrow show your neck to the doctor. That is our priority"*

I got ready early and rushed to the school by the 5.30 AM bus. I reached school by 6.30 and the other staff were already there. We had set everything ready in the 4th standard class rooms yesterday evening. I took the broom and did some more cleaning of the room

space. I took a piece of cloth and wiped the doctor's consultation tables clean. By 8 AM the doctors reached. I served them water and tea. The camp started. The children filed in like an assembly line. First a nurse would register their names. Then she would check their height and weight and write it down on their health cards and hand over the card to the children. Next in the assembly line was the eye check up. The optometrist would check the eye power by asking the children to read alphabets from a distance. From there the children would move to the doctors. After the doctors check them, they would go to the nurse who would write down everything, give them referral slips if they had to be sent to the private hospital for further follow up. As I watched the assembly line moving, with perfect discipline, I was surprised whether it was the same children who would bring the roof down on other days. Somehow "medical check up" made even the most boisterous children silent and serious.

Around 1.30 PM the camp concluded. As the doctors were packing up and ready to leave, I walked up to the middle aged doctor who was sitting right at the top of the table. He seemed to be the senior most in the group. I walked up to him hesitantly, "Sir, may I consult you briefly for a minute?"

"Ok, come here and sit down" The doctor was not too keen. It was already a long day, and they had seen so many children continuously over the past 5 hours.

"Nothing doctor, just wanted to ask you whether this swelling is something to worry about." I showed my neck swelling and asked. I did not want to drag the story and came right to the point.

The doctor adjusted his black shell glasses and looked at my neck. His eyes were fully focused on my neck swelling. Then he stood up

walked behind me, and held the top of my head with his left hand and kept his right hand on the swelling and gently started touching and moving it. His hand was firm, cool and rubbery. It went on and on touching and rolling the swelling.

"Swallow for me" he said.

I swallowed. He repeated, "Swallow for me again"

I couldn't swallow. My mouth was dry. There was no saliva in my mouth. What would I swallow?

"Can I drink some water?"

"NO... just swallow…swallow" he had raised his voice.

I tried hard to swallow, but nothing was there in my mouth to swallow and it started hurting my throat when I tried.

The doctor got frustrated, the pressure of his hand on my neck increased mildly. I felt absolutely powerless and surrendered to his hands. He walked to his chair and sat down.

"It is a thyroid swelling. We have to do a scan and a needle aspiration test to see if it is cancer"

When I heard him say that my mind froze. The C word kept buzzing in my ears. I did not know what happened after that. My mind was filled with chaos. He gave a piece of referral slip in my hand, got up and walked away with a tired smile. I had expected an answer for our worry about the swelling, but walked out of the camp with more serious worry. I finished up the rest of the cleaning in an autopilot mode, packed up my bag and went home.

As I entered home, Kamali, my little one came and hugged me. "Amma, amma…guess what? I won the first prize in throw ball!" I threw a half smile at her and freed myself from her hug. "What happened Amma? Are you alright?" I did not answer as I walked into my room. I changed into my home clothes and went to the bathroom to wash my face. As my hand poured water on my face and washed it I could feel the cool water run down my face and neck. I touched my neck and there it was. Till this afternoon it was just something that needed to be checked out, but now when I touched it started pricking. I started feeling a burning sensation all over its surface. There was a sensation of hundreds of ants crawling all over it. I scratched at the swelling. But the tingling and the burning did not go away. As I saw myself on the mirror, the swelling was there and nothing had changed. But the sensations over the swelling were overwhelming now. I took many palms full of water and washed the swelling, desperately trying to wash away the burning sensation and the ants crawling all over it. I wiped my face and neck and walked into the room. I did not feel like cooking any dinner. I lay down curled myself up and remained like that in the dark. I must have dozed off like that. I got up startled when I felt Ravi's warm hand on my forehead. "Are you ok Jothi? Are you running a fever? What happened?" Ravi's voice was loaded with a gentleness and worry. I held his hand and brought it to my face and covered my face with his hand and broke down into his hands and cried.

"Ravi, doctor says it is cancer"

Ravi did not say anything, he just covered me in his warm embrace. I buried myself in his arms. The familiar warmth engulfed me in a protective cover. The girls came in and they all joined the embrace. There was a dense cover of sadness and gloom all around.

The next day Ravi and I were seated in the private hospital waiting area with the referral slip scribbled out by the doctor in the school camp. The staff nurse called out my name, "Jothilakshmi…" We got up and followed her and entered an airconditioned consultation room. We felt out of place there, a housekeeping staff and share auto driver, in a posh private hospital amidst rich upper class patients in their fancy clothes and expensive bags. The doctor was a young woman in a silk saree with expensive looking jewels and make up. She examined me and did not even talk to Ravi or me. She just scribbled something on some papers and gave it to the staff nurse and told her, "take them to billing and process payments for blood work up, ultrasound scan of the neck and an ultrasound guided fine needle aspiration test of the swelling"

"Doctor, can this be cancer? Is this cancer?" I couldn't stop myself from asking. I was desperately waiting to hear from her that this is not cancer.

"It could be cancer, it could not. Go get the results and come back 2 days later. I will tell you"

Her words stabbed me in my heart. As I walked out with the staff nurse, my feelings had changed. I was no longer just anxious and worried about the swelling, I was angry. The staff nurse made us sit outside the billing counter and went to process our tests.

I pulled at his shirt sleeve, "Ravi, let us go. I don't want to be here anymore. We may get some answers here, but we are never going to get any respect. Look at how they are all looking at us and moving away like we are some dirty smelly vermin. Let us leave now"

Ravi got up reluctantly. He knew that once I had made up my mind, and once I had a logical argument, he can never win against it. We walked out and went home.

That evening I decided to go out for a walk. I went to the temple. My friend Punitha sells flowers outside the temple. It is my routine to go to the temple and hang out with Punitha for a while after that.

"The doctor treated us like some animals who do not have any feelings. As a family we are all so worried, why is it that they can't even say a reassuring word. She barely said four words to us, but the only word she threw at me was cancer. She said it like it meant nothing at all, and my stomach churned."

Punitha held my hand. She cut out a small strand of jasmine flowers and gave it to me to wear on my hair.

"Come with me tomorrow to see the new doctor who has come to the Allamandi hospital. You will get answers."

"I am done seeing doctor after doctor. They wont do anything differently. They will all say the same thing."

"Trust me and come with me tomorrow. This is different. You will understand. Just give me one chance"

I decided to go with Punitha, only because she is my oldest and best friend and anyways the next day was a holiday for me.

There was something calming about the clinic. It was a small red brick cottage with a thatched roof. It had a homely charm. The big banyan tree, and almond tree just in front of the clinic were spreading their shade and providing a nice space to sit just outside the clinic. We registered my name in the clinic and came and sat down below the tree shade. There were many patients before us. The whole place was buzzing with activity. So many patients, their attenders, moving here and there, getting tests, getting medicines, injections, and coming out of the clinic. When our turn came,

we got up and walked into the clinic. The clinic was a small room with a simple table and chair in the middle under an old creaky fan. The doctor was a middle aged man, tall, thin, wearing a dark green kurta and black pant. He welcomed us with a gentle smile. In the middle of the buzz and activity of the clinic, the doctor did not seem to be in any hurry. I opened up immediately,

"Doctor, I have this swelling in my neck. I came to show it and ask you what it is"

The doctor asked me some questions and I answered them. He then got up and walked behind me and gently touched the swelling in my neck from behind. I could not see him, but felt his gentle warm hands explore the swelling so gently. He then picked up a glass of water and handed it over to me. He said, "Keep this water in your hand and when I ask you to swallow, take a sip and swallow it. I need you to swallow so that I can see if the swelling moves when you swallow. It will give me crucial information" I obeyed whatever he said without uttering a word. Within a minute he finished his examination and came and sat on his chair. He smiled at me and started speaking,

"There is a definite swelling in your neck. It is a swelling from a gland in your neck called the thyroid gland. The swelling is soft, it is moving when you swallow and there are no lymph nodes in your neck. This usually means it is nothing serious. Meaning it is unlikely to be cancer"

When I heard this I felt a massive wave of relief wash all over me. I remembered standing in the water in the beach and the waves washing me over. I smiled broadly at the doctor.

“I see you are so relieved. You must have been very much worried that this is cancer”

The doctor went on saying things like he was reading my mind.

“I have seen two other doctors before this. They both used the word cancer. I got so worried when I heard that word.”

“I understand how scary it can be. If you notice what I said, I am not saying you do not have cancer. I am saying it is highly unlikely to be cancer. But we can do some tests and find out. I will write a prescription for some blood test and fine needle aspiration test. You can get them done in the nearby government district hospital for free and bring me the results. I will then talk to you and we can take the treatment forward.”

“Doctor, I understand what you said. Other doctors told me it could be cancer. But you are the first one who tells me what you think and why. They showed me that I was standing on a cliff and could fall, but you showed me that there is a way to climb down the cliff”

“That is a nice way of putting it. Why don’t you get the tests done and come back to me by next week?”

As Punitha and I left the clinic, I felt like a heavy weight was lifted off my chest. For two days fear had frozen my legs, but now I had a map in my hand. I hurried toward the bus stand, eager to get home to Ravi and tell him that tomorrow morning, I was going to the government hospital.

Chapter 10

Two pots per family

There was a big row of colorful plastic pots arranged one behind the other on the sidewalk. The various colors, red, orange, green, blue, yellow, pink, led to the village water tank. The large plastic tank, black and intimidating, was empty inside, awaiting the tanker lorry that would come and fill it once in two days. People in the village started piling up the pots on the sidewalk last evening. 200 pots can be filled, on some good days, 220, not more and not less. The water tanker will come again after 2 days. Only two pots of water was allowed per family. As the sun was rising in the eastern horizon, the village was slowly waking up. In just an hour and half, this place will come alive with typical water collection drama. Meher got up from her mat on which she was pretending to sleep. Subconsciously she arranged her night dress, took a dupatta cloth and put on her chest, and walked out of her small house out on to the street. Her hair was loose and running down her back in curls. Her face was oily and eyes were sunken and hollow with dark circles around. The creases and crinkles on her face belied her 21 years and made her look much older. As she walked towards the

almost empty metal container of water on the side of her house to wash and clean herself up, her walk was slow, tired and sad.

“Hey…Barkat, take my pot and put it in the line. Wont you?”

“Meher akka, you must have put it there last evening. Where were you?”

“You know where I was? I was in the hospital. Take it now and put it there. Don’t talk like some big muthalaali amma”

“OK… give me. I will quietly sneak it into the line when nobody is watching”

Meher sped up, ran into the house and brought out a dark red plastic pot and handed it to Barkat. The village had still not fully woken up. Barkat quietly took the pot and started running towards the line to silently place it there.

Meher emptied the metal container of water, washed her face and mouth and stood up. She went and sat down on the small cement portico just outside her house and stared blankly at the sky.

Meherunissa was the last child of 8 siblings, the only daughter after 7 elder brothers. She was the dearest in the whole family. Ahmed Basha and Khairun Bee were not well to do, but provided reasonably well for all the children. They sent them to the Panchayat school and educated them till 10 years of age. When Meher turned 10 years, she was sent away to Gudiyattam to study in the Madarasa Niswaan to receive her Aalima certification. Two of her elder brothers had become Maulanas in and around Gudiyattam. So Basha bhai was at peace sending her away for her religious education. A devout practicing muslim family, they were tightly knit and followed all the rules laid down by their religion. Meher returned home with her

Aalima certification when she was 15.

"Inshallah! We must start looking for a nice boy for Meher to marry. How much longer can we keep her here at home."

"Bhai… let us not hurry. The girl has just come home. I want to keep her with me for some time" said Khairun.

"Nako…Begum…we must get her married. Look at her. She is so beautiful. Keeping such a beautiful girl at home is like keeping a ticking time bomb tied to the waist. I will go and talk to Maulvi at the mosque. We must get her married soon"

Almost all conversations at home were about getting Meher married before she turned 16. But Meher was so happy to be back home. There were no other girls her age in the village in the Kil Masoodi street. There were Hindu girls in the main village, but she was not allowed to go and spend time there. She liked to sit in the backyard of her house and watch the birds, the insects, dogs, cats and goats. She would play with them and just sit there and watch them for hours after all household chores were over. One day Khairun asked Meher to accompany her to the town market to get some grocery.

"Wear the burkha. I am not taking you out without it."

"Ammi…the weather is so hot. I will just put on a Hijab and come. Please Ammi.."

"No, Wapa will kill me if he knows I took you out without burkha. Put it on now"

Meher wore the burkha. They got onto the line bus to go to the town.

Meher and Khairun sat in one of the middle seats in the bus. Three stops later two young boys from the Mangalam village boarded the bus.

“Machan…get the ticket.”

“No machan…I did not bring money”

“Ok wait…let us talk to conductor anna..”

“Why waste time… he will throw us out. Come let us get down and walk”

Even as the bus was running, the two boys jumped down from the bus and ran.

Meher saw this and watched them as they ran along with the bus for some time. The happiness, and energy of youth was enchanting for her. The tall boy had a head full of dense jet black hair which was flying in the wind. He was laughing and his perfectly arranged big white teeth were all showing. His happiness was infectious and made Meher smile. She peeped out of the window and kept watching him till the bus turned and she could not see them anymore.

As time went by Khairun started sending Meher to the town on her own to get vegetables, and grocery. Meher looked forward to her visits. On most occasions she would see the tall boy with beautiful hair, sometimes sitting near the tea shop in their village, sometimes in the footboard of the bus, happily talking and laughing, and sometimes working in the fields by the roadside. The more she saw him, the more her heart started pining to talk to him, know him more and go close to him. But Meher was silent. Silence is very deceptive. It seems quiet, but when it is quiet outside, there is a

huge turmoil inside. Did he finish studying school? Did he drop out? What does he do for a living? Does he just while away time like that? Is he a responsible boy? What kind of a person is he? She had so many questions. She wanted to know. But she was also terribly scared. She did not even know if he noticed her. Suppressing all her curiosity and interest inside her black burkha, Meher got down from the bus and walked to the market. She went to the Kasim Ali grocery store and started picking up the needed items. As she was just moving out of the cereal aisle she heard a familiar voice, "Machan…is she from Kil Masoodi theru?"

Meher turned and saw the tall boy with another guy. When he is there, her eyes do not notice anything other than him. Her heart started fluttering and she bent her head down and quickly moved ahead.

"What machan…she is running away like this? Doesn't she want to talk to me?" He spoke loud enough to make sure that Meher could hear her.

Meher stopped in her track and did not turn. She just stood there. Noticing this he rushed forward,

"What is your name?" he asked.

Meher's heart was beating fast. She started sweating inside the burkha. She wanted badly to reveal her face, see him at close distance, and just talk to him. He was standing so close that she could feel the warmth. Without turning to look at him she whispered "Meherunissa"

"I am Murugan. I know you have been seeing me. I want to see you too"

Meher's breath got caught in her mouth. "Follow me and come to the juice shop near the bus stop" she whispered and went to the billing counter to pay for her grocery.

There was an urgency in Meher's steps and she moved fast to the billing counter. She noticed he did not follow her. She paid the bill and walked out of the store. She turned one time to see where he was. He was standing there in the same cereals aisle. He was watching her and their eyes locked. He moved as though he was shaken from a reverie and followed her.

They sat opposite each other in the juice shop. He ordered sweet lime soda for both. They sat there silent. The juice arrived. He did not touch the juice. Meher slowly removed the front flap of the face cover of her burka so that she could drink the juice. As she revealed her face Murugan looked at her and locked eyes. His eyes scanned her entire face. There was no expression on his face. After a full minute he broke out of his trance and started sipping his sweet lime soda. "Please have your juice" he said with a crack in his voice. Meher sipped her juice. Her heart was racing fast. As the juice slowly tracked down her throat and she swallowed it, he was watching her throat move. She noticed it and lowered her eyes.

"What do you do?" Meher asked.

"I work in my father's fields. I studied up to 10th standard and then dropped out. We have land and we do our own farming."

Meher's mind raced like a mad horse. She immediately knew this won't work out. She got up and rushed out.

"What happened? Don't go! Come back!" Murugan walked behind her. Then hastily stopped by the billing counter and put 200 rupees on the counter and followed Meher to the bus stand.

"Why did you walk away?"

"Don't you understand or are you pretending not to?"

"You think I don't know why you're running? Because of your street and mine? Because of my father's fields?"

"Yes"

"You are the most beautiful girl I have seen. The moment you lifted that black cloth, it felt like revealing the god's statue after full decoration during our village festival. All these differences do not matter to me. Do you like me."

Meher wanted to say yes, she wanted to break free from all the social constraints. She wished they were somewhere more private where she could let loose and tell him what she felt for him. Her bus came and she just silently walked to the bus and boarded it.

She lost sleep, and appetite. All she could think of for the whole next week was Murugan and his charming smile. When she closed her eyes, she could only think of how he would laugh without any restraint. The way he flipped his hair, ran his fingers through them and his half smile with one raised eyebrow were constantly flashing in her mind. Through all this she failed to notice that her feet were swelling up. She failed to appreciate the sharp fleeting headaches. She dismissed it as a part of her inner turmoil and conflict. But one day the headache was unbearable.

"Ammi, shall we go to the doctor? My headache is very severe."

"Ok, let us go tomorrow. Now I will make some kashayam for you. Just have that and go to sleep"

The next day Meher and Khairun went to the local clinic. It was a small clinic at the corner of the road. Three of Khairun's children including Meher were all born here. It was run by a non governmental organization that works for women's health in the local area. Fifteen to twenty years ago the clinic was a thriving maternity hospital, busy and active. When the government health facilities improved, they took over all the care in the local villages and the rural clinic had significantly reduced their operations. Now the clinic was running as a primary health care facility. Khairun was familiar with the staff nurses and doctors in the clinic.

"Please come Khairun Bee. How are you? Long time" said the doctor.

"Good morning doctor. I came for treatment of my daughter"

"Don't tell me this is Meherunissa? Oh! God! She has grown into this beautiful young woman. I last saw her some 10 years ago I think! Hello my child! How are you?" the doctor showed genuine surprise and interest.

"I am ok doctor. I came to see you for my severe headache."

"Can you tell me where is it aching"

Meher showed her entire head. The doctor checked her blood pressure. He then examined her eyes.

"Khairun Bee, Meher here has very high blood pressure. She is too young to have such a high blood pressure. I am a bit worried. We must do some blood tests and find out what is going on"

"Ya! Allah! BP? How come doctor? She is only a child"

The doctor wrote down some tests and gave it to them. Meher and Khairun Bee went to the laboratory to get the tests done.

As they waited for the results Meher's mind was racing. Is this all because of Murugan? Maybe if I agree and accept my feelings for him all this headache and BP will go away. Should I just go, meet him and talk to him? As her thoughts kept flying, the headache came repeatedly in waves. She closed her eyes and sat silently trying to remove the images of Murugan from her mind and the headache that was gnawing at her.

"Khairun Bee, Meher has kidney disease. It seems to be quite severe. She is too young to have a kidney disease. I suggest that you go to the government hospital and get detailed tests and scans to find out the cause for the kidney disease."

"Allah! Kidney disease? Nobody in our family has it doctor? Meher's wapa is also perfectly healthy and he has only diabetes. How did our Meher get this" saying this Khairun Bee broke down.

Meher sat there silently. Her mind was still fighting hard to keep away thoughts of Murugan.

"I will write a letter and give you. Please take that and go meet the kidney specialist in the government hospital. Meanwhile I will put Meher on a tablet to reduce the blood pressure."

Khairun Bee got up and walked away. Meher was not done. She wanted to ask the doctor whether her feelings and emotions could have an impact like this? She lingered.

"Yes Meher, is there anything you want to talk to me about?"

"Yes doctor. It is something personal. Can I talk to you now?"

"Of course. Please sit down"

"Doctor of late, I am having some emotional issues. Is it possible that my problem is because of that?"

"Would you like to explain to me about these emotional issues"

Meher stayed silent for some time. The doctor realized that she did not want to reveal more information than that.

"That is ok if you don't want to reveal more information. Yes, emotional issues can have an impact on the body. But emotional issues don't usually cause the kidney disease that you seem to have. So it is better to get it tested."

"I don't want to subject my parents to all this worry and trouble doctor. So I want to try and see if I can take care of my emotional problem. If I do that, will this thing will go away on its own"

"I understand your concern. But you must give me some more information for me to understand and advice you."

Meher thought for some more time.

"Doctor, what I am going to tell you is completely confidential. Can you keep it to yourself?"

"Of course. Anything you say to me is safe. I won't speak about it to anyone"

"I am seeing this boy from the nearby village. I like him a lot. But he is Hindu and from a rich family. So I am very much conflicted doctor. Could this headache be because of that?"

The doctor seemed unprepared for this question. He thought for a little while and then said, "I don't think such emotional issues and conflicts can cause kidney disease. Nevertheless let me read about it and find out. Why don't you do two things. One, go to the government hospital and get a detailed testing done. Two, meet the guy and tell him how you feel. Then let us see how things go."

Meher thanked the doctor and walked out. There was no way she would go up front and talk to Murugan about her feelings. At least not till he came up to her himself again. He may never come back to her after how she treated him last time.

The visit to the government hospital the next day was long, tiring and loaded with a lot of information. The doctors wrote a lot of notes in her case report after doing several blood tests and scans. They started her on several medicines.

"Your daughter has chronic kidney disease of unknown etiology. This means we don't know why she has the kidney disease. We must take the kidney tissue for biopsy if we must find out about it. However, for now there is no cure for this. We can only keep her blood pressure under control and see that the kidney disease does not progress any further."

The news was a big blow to the Ahmed Basha family. The next day all seven elder brothers and their families rushed to the village. They all sat protectively around their little sister.

"Let us go to Chennai and see the big doctors. There must be something wrong"

"Nowadays they do kidney transplants. Let us get one for our little Meher"

“Where did she get this? Why did Allah do this to our family?”

They were all expressing their anguish in various ways.

“Stop talking all negative things. Nothing bad will happen to our Meher. I think we should arrange her Nikah soon” said Khairun Bee.

This brought a lot of excitement into the discussion. What was a very grim discussion till then became celebratory and happy. The wives all went to the kitchen to cook some mutton biriyani to celebrate the decision.

Meher could not take in all this rush of information. She was just diagnosed with a serious medical condition. Her family wants her to be married now? How can she enter into a marriage with all this? And what about Murugan? Her headache flashed like a severe sharp bolt!

For the next three days, the biryani pots simmered, relatives arrived on sputtering mopeds, and the front yard of Ahmed Basha’s house was swept clean for visitors. In the late afternoon, Khairun sent Meher back to Kasim Ali’s grocery store to purchase extra grocery.

Her legs felt like leaden sacks of wet sand. At the junction where the line buses slowed to navigate the potholed bend, Murugan was leaning against the peeling blue pillar of the tea stall. His jet-black hair caught the slant of the late sun. The moment he saw the black burkha approach, he straightened, stepping toward the gravel curb, his eyes searching the dark slit of her veil.

Meher’s throat tightened into an arid knot. “Go tell him how you feel” the clinic doctor’s voice echoed in her mind.

She took a single step toward the ditch separating the road from the tea stall. But as she inhaled to call out, the air caught behind her ribs. Behind Murugan lay his father's wide, fertile paddy tracts; behind her lay seven brothers, a community elder drafting alliances, and a clinic record filled with the words "chronic" and "incurable". If she told him she loved him, she would offer him a sick body and a social disaster. If he reached for her hand, he would hold a burden, not a life. Till last week it was just the religion and economic status that were barriers, but now there was the kidney disease also.

Murugan raised his hand, gesturing toward the juice stall towards the market. Meher stopped. She pulled the black veil tighter across the bridge of her nose until only a sliver of her vision remained. She turned her eyes downward to the cracked dirt, quickened her step past the tea shop without a whisper, and boarded the idling bus toward Kil Masoodi street, leaving him stranded by the roadside.

Two days later, Khairun Bee led Meher back to the clinic.

The room was cool and smelled of soap and damp ceiling plaster. The doctor looked up from the case record, adjusting his glasses.

"Her blood pressure has settled slightly with the medicines," the doctor said, laying down the cuff. "When are you going for the kidney biopsy test at the government hospital?"

Khairun Bee sat forward on the wooden chair, resting her palms on the desk. "Doctor, we will go next month. Right now, there is an urgent matter. An alliance has come from Ambur. A respectable family, leather merchants. We want to know... can she be married?"

The doctor paused, his hand remaining on the green file. "Khairun Bee, I explained this to you. Meher's kidneys are failing. She will need lifelong medications, strict monitoring, and eventually,

dialysis and even kidney transplant. Marriage involves pregnancy, household labor, emotional stress. Pregnancy with this degree of renal compromise carries extreme risks for both mother and child. More than anything she herself is just a child!"

"Every girl gets married, doctor," Khairun said, her voice dropping to an anxious murmur. "If we delay, people will ask questions. A girl sitting at home with medicines and nobody will take her. We will manage her food. We will give her the tablets secretly. The groom's family does not need to know every small detail."

"You cannot conceal this," the doctor said firmly, his gaze shifting from the mother to Meher, who sat motionless, her eyes fixed on the clinic floor. "The groom and his family must be informed of her diagnosis. How would you feel if someone gave their daughter to one of your sons concealing their clinical diagnosis? She cannot enter a marriage carrying a hidden, life-altering illness. If complications arise, the betrayal of trust will destroy her far worse than an unmarried status ever could."

Khairun Bee stood up abruptly, pulling her mundhanai over her shoulders. "Doctors always speak of the worst. Inshallah, Allah will cure her once she settles into her own household. Come, Meher."

The clinic door clicked shut behind them.

Five years later, the boxes and bags arrived first. They bore Meher's wedding gifts and articles, brought back from Ambur and unloaded onto the porch of Ahmed Basha's house. No brothers gathered to cook biryani. The courtyard was silent. The luggage stayed by the inner wall, flanked by three large plastic carrier bags crammed with blister strips of anti-hypertensives, iron supplements, and nephrology outpatient booklets with torn covers.

No words were exchanged across the threshold. The whispers in Kil Masoodi street took care of the rest: "A bride returned before her fifth anniversary; an alliance dissolved because the well was dry before it was ever dug; a family deceived by silence."

The eastern sky had turned a pale, bruised violet.

On the cement portico, Meher sat watching the street stir to life. Her 21-year-old frame felt brittle, her swollen ankles aching against the hard ground. A sudden, sharp metallic clatter broke the morning stillness. Down the sidewalk, the two-hundred-odd plastic pots—red, yellow, green, and pink, rattled as the first women arrived. Voices rose in sharp, territorial shouts. Hands shoved; pots tumbled sideways, rolling into the dry roadside gutter; accusations flew about whose vessel had arrived first in the dark and whose place had been stolen. A dull rumble vibrated through the earth as the diesel tanker lorry lumbered around the corner, its massive tires raising a plume of gray dust.

Barkat ran past her gate, carrying two empty buckets, shouting over his shoulder, "Akka! The tanker is here! The valve is opening!"

Meher did not move. She watched the black, cavernous community tank sit high on its brick pedestal, hollow and indifferent, waiting for the brief, violent torrent that would never be enough for everyone. Down below, the women shoved, yelled, and fought for their allotted two pots, their hands scraping the plastic rims, desperate to capture a measured ration of water before the valve ran dry for another two days.

Chapter 11

Hiding the inevitable

She was waiting outside the consultation room as I walked into the clinic. The elderly woman wore a dark blue cotton saree with white floral patterns all over its body. Her salt-and-pepper hair was oiled, combed back, and tied into a tight bun. She was staring blankly at the whitewashed wall in front of her, the hum of the overhead ceiling fan casting rhythmic shadows across her weathered features. There was no expression on her face.

I walked slowly towards the room, the heels of my slippers clicking against the cold mosaic floor. As I got closer, she must have heard my footsteps; she turned her head and looked towards my side. I hadn't seen her before. She also did not have the look of familiarity on her face either. I crossed her and entered the room. She must have realized that I was the doctor on duty, for instinctively, she stood up. I noticed her out of the corner of my eye just as I was crossing the threshold, but I did not bother to turn back and acknowledge her gesture. The timing was awkward, it made me seem aloof, as though I couldn't care less about an elderly woman

rising in deference. But I meant no disrespect. I had simply built momentum, crossed the doorway, and lacked the mental grace to retrace my steps for a polite nod.

I dropped my backpack onto the side stool, arranged my prescription pad and stethoscope on the wooden tabletop, and sank heavily into my chair. Monday mornings have always been an uphill battle for me. Right from my primary school days, when the ironed uniform felt like a prison after two days of untamed play, the transition back to work frayed my nerves. Medical college had long since obliterated the romance of relaxed weekends, replacing them with sleepless calls and endless ward rounds, but the visceral phantom of Monday morning dread had remained stubbornly intact.

The woman had remained standing outside, hovering at the doorframe before taking a few hesitant steps inside. Just as she reached the wooden patient chair and pulled it back, another woman, much younger, perhaps in her late twenties, wearing a hurried salwar, rushed into the room, panting slightly as she joined her.

"We came for a review," the younger woman said without pausing to catch her breath. "They asked us to come back today."

I looked up from my desk calendar, squinting. "Have I seen you before? I don't remember having seen you."

"Not you," the younger woman replied briskly, adjusting her dupatta. "We came on Saturday. We saw another doctor here. She gave us some tablets and did some tests. She asked us to come back today for treatment."

"Do you have the notebook from your Saturday's visit?"

The younger woman blinked, glanced down at her empty hands, and turned to the elderly woman. "Mmm… no… we did not bring it."

A familiar prickle of irritation spiked behind my temples. In a charitable primary care center like ours, multiple duty medical officers rotated through shifts. The only thread tying patient care together across the days was the physical case record, a notebook, carried faithfully by the patients themselves. Without it, we were essentially blind.

"Why didn't you bring the notebook?" I snapped, letting my exhaustion bleed into my voice. "Now I have to start all over again."

"Don't worry, doctor," the older woman intervened softly, speaking for the first time. Her voice was thin, raspy with age, yet gentle. "We came for dizziness, nausea, and vomiting. The doctor did some tests, gave some injections. It became alright. She asked us to come back today just for a routine visit."

"How I wish things were so simple!" My voice rose, cutting through the sterile room. "Dizziness, nausea, and vomiting can be caused by a hundred different conditions. I need to figure out what you were treated for and what treatment was given to you."

The older woman offered an apologetic gesture, holding up her wrinkled right hand. "It was a white tablet and two small this-size injections…" She pinched her thumb and index finger together, indicating two glass ampoules no larger than an inch.

"Almost all tablets are white in color, and nearly all injections come in exactly that size!" I retorted, throwing my hands up in exasperation.

The daughter did not back down. Her eyes flashed with defensive anger. *"Then it must not be that hard for you to figure out, isn't it?"*

"All right, let us not waste time," I said through clenched teeth. "Tell me what were your problems when you came here on Saturday."

"How many times to tell you, doctor?" the daughter shot back, her tone sharp. "Dizziness, nausea, and vomiting. That is all!"

"Yes, you told me that. I want more information!"

"Unless you tell me what information you want, I don't know what to tell you!"

We were circling each other in an absurd, unproductive loop. I leaned back against the chair, shut my eyes, and drew in three deep, steadying breaths. The daughter was entirely right. They were laypeople, frightened and unfamiliar with clinical algorithms. It was not their job to parse the diagnosis clearly; that was my burden. It was unfairly petty of me to punish them for my Monday exhaustion.

I opened my eyes, deliberately softening my posture and voice. *"Do you have diabetes or high BP?"*

"Yes, doctor," the daughter replied, her own demeanor easing marginally. "Amma has both. She takes regular medicines for that."

"Let me take a look at her."

I stood up, walked around the wooden desk, and clicked on my penlight. I checked her eyes for pallor, her tongue for dehydration, and examined her mouth. I had her follow my fingertips and her eyes moved normally. When I wrapped the velcro cuff around her frail arm, her blood pressure read a reassuring 124/80 mmHg. Her pulse was regular at 74 beats per minute.

"Do you remember what tests were done?" I asked, sliding the stethoscope around my neck. "Blood tests? An ECG?"

"*Yes, they did blood tests and also took an ECG,*" the older woman confirmed quietly.

"Wait here for two minutes. Let me verify the logbooks."

I stepped out of the room and walked briskly down the narrow corridor to the adjacent diagnostic side-room. The clinic's duty nurse, Sister Mary, was sorting through slides. I pulled open the hardbound laboratory register and flipped back to Saturday's entries. The elder woman's name was listed: Kalyani Ammal, 64 years old.

The entry showed a random blood glucose check via glucometer, 138 mg/dL, and a normal urine strip test. In the central ECG log, her tracing was recorded as unremarkable without any features of heart problems.

I leaned against the counter, piecing together the breadcrumbs. A senior hypertensive diabetic woman comes in with acute spinning sensations, retching, and vomiting. The doctor, most likely Dr. Shailaja, who covered Saturdays, had run standard safety nets: blood sugar, cardiac tracing, perhaps administered medicines to relieve the vomiting and dizziness. The symptoms resolved.

It pointed towards an inner ear problem with dizziness and vomiting.

Relieved to have arrived at a neat, harmless conclusion, I walked back into the consultation room, pulling my chair closer to the desk.

"I have a reasonable idea of what the problem was," I said calmly, looking at both of them. "Inside our ears, we have a delicate

balancing organ. Sometimes, small problems in this organ can lead to spinning, nausea, and vomiting. The medicines given on Saturday suppressed that. That's why you feel better."

"What should we do now, doctor?" the daughter asked, leaning forward.

"Nothing much," I smiled, picking up my pen. "Are you feeling better now?" I directed the question to Kalyani Ammal.

"Yes, doctor. Feeling much better," she murmured, placing her hands on her lap.

"Then that is all. You don't have to do anything more. Just continue your daily blood pressure and diabetes tablets."

I began writing out a prescription note on a fresh slip, preparing to call the next patient, when the daughter dropped a sudden, heavy sentence onto the table:

"But the doctor on Saturday asked us to come back and said we must get a scan and get admitted to the hospital. She said she would give a letter of referral for our admission."

The pen stopped dead against the paper.

I blinked, looking up. *"Admitted? For what?"*

"She didn't explain everything," the daughter said, her voice turning defensive again. "She told Amma, 'You must come back on Monday morning without fail. We have to send you to the government headquarters hospital for a scan and an admission.' That's why we took leave and came here early!"

A cold, uneasy draft seemed to seep through the window. Why would any competent physician advise hospital admission and a scan for a self-resolving bout of inner ear problem? Had Dr. Shailaja noticed something that I had overlooked? A stroke of some sort?

"I don't think you need an admission now," I explained carefully, trying not to alarm them. "You seem to have recovered from whatever happened the other day. Your examination is entirely normal."

"How can we be sure that it won't happen again?" the daughter demanded, her eyes wide with mounting panic. "Why did that doctor ask us to get admitted if it was nothing? If something happens to her at home tonight, what will we do?"

I swallowed hard. Her accusation, sharp and protective, struck a nerve. The lingering remnants of my Monday morning irritability evaporated completely, replaced by a dull, throbbing dread. If I discharged her and she subsequently suffered a stroke at home, I would be professionally and morally responsible.

"Give me a moment," I said, rising from my seat. "Let me call the doctor who was on duty on Saturday. It is better to hear it directly from her."

I stepped into the quiet space behind the examination screen, took out my phone, and scrolled through the clinic contact list until I found Dr. Shailaja's number. She picked up on the third ring.

"Dr. Shailaja? Good morning. Sorry to disturb your day off."

"Good morning, Doctor. What happened? Everything okay at the clinic?"

“I have a patient here in front of me from your Saturday shift. Kalyani Ammal, sixty-four. Came with vertigo, nausea, vomiting. You ran an ECG and sugar test. She says you told her to come back today specifically to get an admission referral and a CT or MRI scan.”

There was a pregnant pause on the other end of the line. The only sound was the rustle of papers.

“Kalyani Ammal…” Shailaja murmured thoughtfully. “The one from Melpakkam?, quiet lady?”

“Yes, that’s her.”

“Doctor, I didn’t ask her to get admitted for her vertigo.”

I frowned, shifting the phone to my other ear. “What do you mean? What else was there?”

“Her dizziness was easy to treat; I gave her an injection of Stemetil and two doses of betahistine, and she was completely fine within forty minutes. But while I was palpating her abdomen during the general survey, I felt a distinct, hard, non-tender lump in her right upper abdomen. Liver edge was hard and irregular. I didn’t want to terrify her on a crowded Saturday afternoon. I discreetly told her that she needed an ultrasound scan and an inpatient evaluation at the district center, and wrote a preliminary note in her note book.”

My stomach dropped into a hollow pit.

“She… she didn’t bring the book, Dr. Shailaja.”

“Oh God,” Shailaja breathed softly. “She didn’t bring it? I wrote the entire findings inside, suspected liver cancer…”

“She told me she only came back for the dizziness,” I said. “She never mentioned a single word about abdominal pain, weight loss, or an examination of her stomach.”

“Please examine her abdomen.” Dr. Shailaja urged. “The daughter probably had no idea. The mother might have downplayed it entirely.”

“Thank you, Dr. Shailaja. I’ll take over from here.”

I ended the call and stood motionless for several long seconds behind the privacy curtain. This wasn’t a case of missed inner-ear pathology; it was an elderly woman clutching onto a minor symptom because confronting the deeper, heavier reality was too terrifying to bear.

I stepped back out into the consultation room.

Kalyani Ammal sat with her head lowered, her thin hands clasped tightly against the rough cotton of her lap. The daughter was tapping her foot impatiently against the floor tiles.

“Well, doctor?” the daughter asked. “Did you speak with her?”

“I did,” I said gently, pulling my chair slightly closer to Kalyani Ammal. “Amma, could you please lie down on the examination couch for just two minutes? I need to check your stomach.”

The older woman looked up. For a fraction of a second, the blank veneer broke, and a profound, quiet sorrow flickered across her dark eyes.

“Why stomach, doctor?” the daughter asked, puzzled. “She had dizziness in the head.”

"Let me just be thorough," I answered softly.

Kalyani Ammal slowly stood up, walked to the examination couch, and carefully hoisted herself onto the synthetic mattress. I drew the privacy curtain around us, shielding her daughter's view for a moment.

"Amma, relax your knees and breathe through your mouth," I whispered.

She complied silently. I uncovered her abdomen. Her frame was noticeably wasted under the broad pleats of her saree, ribs prominent, skin lax from recent, significant subcutaneous fat loss. When I placed my warm palm below her right ribcage and asked her to take a deep breath in, my fingertips met a distinct, stony hard swelling there.

She simply gazed up at the fluorescent tube on the ceiling with an eerie resignation.

I rested my hand beside hers. "Amma, how long have you known about this?"

Her lips trembled. She didn't look at me, but her voice was barely above a whisper. "Three or four months. It started as a dull heaviness. Then clothes began hanging loose on me."

"Did you tell your daughter?"

Tears welled along the outer creases of her eyes, spilling into her graying hairline. "Her husband lost his job in the textile mill six months ago. They have two school-going daughters. They survive on her small tailor's income. If I told her I was terribly sick, if I let them run from hospital to hospital spending money they don't

have… they would sell whatever little gold she has left for her children."

The weight in the room suddenly felt suffocating.

"On Saturday," she continued, her voice breaking slightly, "when the room was spinning and I was retching, I couldn't hide it anymore. My daughter brought me here by force. The young doctor touched my belly and asked me all those difficult questions. She told me I needed big hospital admissions and scans. When we walked home, I told my daughter the doctor had only asked us to come back on Monday for a routine injection. And this morning… I intentionally left the file hidden on top of the kitchen shelf. I knew that by rotation, some other doctor would be here. I didn't want you to see what she had written."

I stood by the edge of the bed, feeling a profound pang of remorse for the irritable arrogance I had carried into this room just twenty minutes earlier. I had been annoyed by a forgotten file, while this woman was quietly orchestrating her own neglect to shield her child from financial ruin.

"Amma," I whispered, taking her hand between both of mine. "Ignoring this won't make life easier for your daughter. If you collapse tomorrow, the heartbreak and the burden on her will be ten times worse. Love isn't just protecting them from hardship; it's letting them stand beside you when you need them."

She wiped her cheeks with the edge of her pallu and nodded slowly, unable to speak.

"Let's sit down and talk to her together. All right?"

She took a long, trembling breath and pushed herself up from the couch.

When we stepped back to the desk, the daughter took one look at her mother's tear-stained face and sprang to her feet. *"Amma? What happened? Why are you crying? Doctor, what is wrong with her?"*

I pulled out the spare chair and motioned for the daughter to sit.

"Sit down, please," I said, my voice steady, respectful, and firm. "Your mother's dizziness from Saturday was harmless, and it has already resolved. But there is another issue that we must address with absolute honesty."

Over the next ten minutes, I laid out the truth without sugarcoating the severity, but without stripping away hope. I explained the enlargement of the liver, the unaddressed weight loss, and why Dr. Shailaja had urgently recommended higher evaluation.

The daughter sat paralyzed, her eyes widening in disbelief as she looked between me and her mother.

"Amma… you knew?" the daughter cried, her voice cracking into a ragged sob. "You were feeling this for months and you kept quiet? You told me you were just fasting on Fridays!"

"Look at our house, Geetha," Kalyani Ammal said, her voice shaking. "How could I put this on your head? How could we afford big city hospitals?"

"Do you think money matters more than you?" Geetha broke down, dropping her forehead onto her mother's lap. "Who will I have left if something happens to you? Why did you hide it from me?"

The consultation room, usually filled with mundane discussions of antacids and cough syrups, was suddenly hallowed by the raw ache of love. I let them sit in that embrace for a few moments, offering tissue paper and a glass of water from my own tray.

When their tears subsided, I pulled my prescription pad back toward me.

"You are not alone in this," I said softly to Geetha. "And you don't have to sell anything. I am writing an urgent, direct referral to the Department of Surgical Oncology at the Government Medical College Hospital. Everything, the CT scan, the blood work, the biopsy, and any surgery or therapy needed, is entirely covered under the Chief Minister's Comprehensive Health Insurance Scheme."

Geetha wiped her eyes, her face filled with hesitant hope. "*Will they take care of her properly, doctor? We hear government hospitals are so crowded…*"

"The unit chief at the Medical College is Dr. Ramanathan," I assured her, looking her directly in the eyes. "He was my professor in medical school. He is one of the finest surgeons and most compassionate men I have ever known. I will personally write a sealed letter to him, and I will call his resident this morning before you reach there. You will not be wandering the corridors aimlessly. You will go straight to his ward."

I spent the next quarter of an hour composing a thorough clinical summary and a referral letter. I signed the letter with my registration number, slipped it into an official clinic envelope.

When I handed the envelope to Geetha, she took it with trembling hands, clutching it against her chest like an anchor.

Kalyani Ammal stood up slowly from her chair. This time, I did not wait for her to acknowledge me. I stood up immediately from behind my desk, stepping around the table to face her at eye level.

"Go to the hospital today, Amma," I said gently. "Listen to Dr. Ramanathan. Let your daughter take care of you. You've spent your whole life carrying her; allow her to carry you for a few weeks."

The old woman looked into my eyes. The blank, vacant expression that had greeted me in the corridor that morning was entirely gone. In its place was a quiet, luminous warmth.

She lifted both her trembling hands, pressed her palms together in front of her chest, and bowed her head. "Thank you, doctor. God bless you."

"Take care, Amma."

I walked them to the threshold of the room, watching as the young woman linked her arm firmly through her mother's, holding her upright as they walked down the sunlit corridor toward the clinic exit.

Outside the window, the morning sun had burned through the gray early haze, washing the courtyard in a bright, amber light. The noise of the busy street outside seemed less grating now, the heavy weight of the morning vanished. I took a deep breath, walked back to my desk, straightened my stethoscope, and called for the next patient.

Solitude

Chapter 12

This is where it happened

Balan was a 75 year old man living in a village at quite a long distance from the clinic. At one time his family was big with six sons, three daughters and his wife. One by one he gave away his three daughters in marriage. Then all his sons migrated out of the village to the town for work. Ten years ago Balan's wife died of breast cancer complications. With that Balan was left all alone in the village fending for himself in his big house, too big for a single elderly man.

We had planned to conduct an outreach clinic in Balan's village. We packed our medicines, equipment and reached the village. There was a huge banyan tree right at the entrance of the village. Balan was sitting right beneath it surrounded by a couple of other older men talking, when we entered the village. As soon as he saw us he got up and came rushing towards us,

"The nurse told us you are coming today. So nice to see you. Come and sit down for a bit before they arrange the clinic."

I was happy to see Balan and went and sat down near him. Our staff went to the elementary school in the village to set up the clinic there. It was a Saturday and so school was closed. We were going to conduct our camp there.

As Balan and I sat there under the tree, a man from the nearby tea shop brought three glasses of tea and gave it to Balan, his friend and me. I took the tea and sipped on it. It was watery, very low on milk, high on sugar, with no traces of any aroma of tea. That is the typical village tea in these areas. Even as I was sipping on the tea, a young boy rushed from the tea shop with three pieces of hot fried bonda in torn pieces of newspaper and handed each of us a piece. Tea and bonda early in the morning is standard breakfast in these areas.

"You must come to my house for lunch after the clinic. I will prepare something simple for you."

"Why do you take the trouble? We will go back to the clinic and have our lunch"

"No, how can I let you go without having lunch? You are visiting me for the first time. I will surely make something for you. Do you like chicken biriyani? Shall I make some?"

"I am vegetarian. Please don't take the trouble."

"So what if you are vegetarian, I will make vegetable biriyani for you. Don't argue. You are coming."

A few months ago during one of our routine clinic visits Balan had invited me to his home for a meal. I had politely agreed, never intending to actually go. But here I was. I had nothing against sharing a meal with Balan, but did not want to trouble him. Now it

looked like I did not have a choice. After having the tea and bonda, I got up and walked to the elementary school where the camp was prepared. It was a non communicable disease screening camp. We had informed people above 30 years to come and get tested for diabetes, hypertension and heart diseases. We had brought with us finger stick glucometer test, blood pressure apparatus and a battery operated paper-less ECG machine that would send the tracing directly to my mobile phone where I can read it and give my opinion. The outreach camp went on smoothly. It was busy and we saw more than 250 adults that morning. Some of the people from the village were regular visitors of our clinic. But most of them did not know us as our clinic was far away from this village. Some of them had seen me sitting with Balan in the morning. I realized that Balan was an important person in the village. Association with Balan had given me the legitimacy that I couldn't have expected if I had gone there on my own. By the time we finished the clinic, the staff nurse and helper wanted to leave as their home was a nearby village. We said our goodbyes and I started walking to the Banyan tree. The time was 1.30 PM and there was nobody under the tree. The tea shop was also closed. The shop owner was lying down just outside the tea shop under the shade of a tree on his bench. I went to him and asked him,

"Ayya, how do I go to Balan ayya's home?"

"Ahh…yes, he told me to direct you to his home. You walk straight that way, you will find a small stream. Just opposite to the stream you will find a big pucca house. That is Balan for you. Do you want me to come with you?"

"No, that will not be necessary. I will find my way"

I started walking in the direction shown by the tea shop owner. There was no stream in sight. There were dense shrubs and plants on either side of the road and the road went in loops and bends. Suddenly when I crossed a bend, the stream came into sight. I had walked for almost 5 minutes. Just opposite to the stream, just as the man had said there was a huge house, two storied, painted in bright fluorescent orange and blue. The façade of the house had the name "Sundari Vilas" written in bright bold blue letters in Tamil. Balan had told me Sundari was the name of his wife. It was unmistakably Balan's house. I had seen the entire southern stretch of the village and Balan's house was the biggest in this whole area. The house had a big metal gate which was partly open. There was a nice big garden in the portico with various trees and plants including several hibiscus shrubs, a few lemon trees, a guava tree, a few papaya trees and a few drumstick trees. He must surely have some help in maintaining this garden.

I walked in past the gate and towards the door. There was a double door made of teak wood, with elaborate carvings. There was a big brass knocker with the face of a lion carved on it. The house, the door and the knocker all indicated old world charm and style. As I neared the door, a strong aroma of biriyani hit my nostrils and my stomach started grumbling. After that tasteless tea and bonda in the morning I had not had even water. I thought I will knock the door and took hold of the knocker, and the door opened. It was not locked. I called out "Balan ayya. Are you there?"

"Welcome! Welcome to our home. Please come inside" the voice came ahead of Balan as he walked slowly from the right side of the home into the huge living room. The fragrance of the food was coming from the right side room, most likely the kitchen. The living room was huge, but empty. There were just two old wooden chairs

in the middle of the huge living room. There was a bulky cathode ray television set of the old variety sitting atop a wooden stool just near the two chairs. The room was echoing heavily because of its massive size and empty interior.

"Sit down. I will finish setting up the eating area and we will go into the dining room and eat there. Do you want to wash up in the bathroom?" he pointed towards the back door at the extreme end of the living room. I wanted to use the rest room and also wash up. So I went in the direction. Behind the back door there was a wide open space. It was in stark contrast to the beautifully and meticulously maintained front garden. It was a dense thicket of wild plants and shrubs. In one corner there was a compost pit which was open and surrounded by flies and mosquitoes even in bright daylight. On the other side of the dense shrubs plastic wrappers, papers, used bottles, plastic containers, coconut shells and all kinds of garbage was thrown all around. After walking a little distance through these shrubs and garbage there was a bathroom and toilet. I went in and used the facilities and came back to the house.

"Come doctor. Right here" Balan led me to the kitchen area. He had laid out two banana leaves on the floor and had placed a big vessel with steaming fragrant biriyani, a smaller vessel with onion raitha and a big plastic bucket full of fried papads. We both sat side by side and served the food and ate it. It was a delicious vegetable biriyani, one of the most tasty I had eaten in a long time. I was amazed at what a wonderful cook Balan turned out to be.

"I don't have any help to clean up after. So do you mind clearing up the banana leaf when you finish?"

"Of course, sure."

“Here, have some water. This is cumin infused water. It is good for digestion.”

I had water, cleared up the banana leaf, removed small specks of rice that had spilled on the floor and went to the backdoor. Balan followed close behind me.

“Just fling the banana leaves into the compost pit.”

I tossed it into the pit, washed my hand and came back to the house. Balan followed behind me and we both sat on the chairs in the living room.

“Did you like the food?”

“It is the best biriyani I have tasted”

“What is vegetable biriyani? It is nothing. You must taste my mutton biriyani. People cannot stop eating! But you say you don’t eat meat.”

I smiled. We sat there silently.

“Come, I will show you around my home.” Saying this Balan got up and started slowly limping towards the left side of the house. There was a big corridor and I could see four doors, two on one side and two on the opposite side.

“These are four rooms where my sons and daughters live when they visit me. They keep the doors locked.” Saying this Balan raised his eyebrows at me. I knew Balan had strained relationship with all his sons. I did not say anything.

Towards the extreme end of the corridor there was an open room. Balan walked into it and I followed.

“This is the room where Sundari and I lived. I used to live here even after she died. But not anymore.”

A double King-size cot stood against the south wall, and a heavy wooden wardrobe dominated the north.

“This is where it happened,” Balan said, looking up at the ceiling fan. “Two years ago. I thought the dizziness had passed, but the moment I climbed onto the stool and reached up, everything spun. I lost balance and fell down. I heard a massive crack in my hip and the pain was unbearable.”

Balan had sustained a hip fracture and was brought to our clinic. He had no attenders with him other than a distant cousin sister’s young grandson. I had referred him to the orthopedic department of the government general hospital in the nearby town some 40 km away. Balan had undergone surgery and had returned after 20 days in the hospital. Balan had paid the young boy handsomely to care for him during the hospital stay and to keep him company in the house for almost a month after. His sons and daughters visited him in the hospital, and home a few times, but did not provide any long term care.

“After I came back home, I decided to move to the right side of the house. This side is far, and quite lonely. Even if something happens and I shout, nobody can hear me.”

Balan led me back through the corridor to the living room. Further down the living room to the right of the back door there was a small flight of stairs. It led to the second story of the house.

“Do you want to see the top floor? I cannot climb since the time of the hip fracture. There are 5 rooms there and a huge living room. You can go and see it if you want”

I declined the offer politely. Then Balan led me to the right side of the house where the kitchen was. Just opposite the kitchen was a small room, less than half the size of the big room that Balan identified as his erstwhile bedroom on the other side. There was a small wooden cot in one corner of the room. There was a small easy chair made of plastic and wooden table in another corner. The wooden table had a small table fan on top. There were several bottles of medicine and small plastic boxes filled with tablets on the table.

"This is where I live now. It is close to the kitchen. Easily accessible to the living room. The room is much smaller and I am comfortable in the small room"

"Don't you find it difficult to go to the back yard for the toilet and bathroom?"

"Yes, that is my biggest problem nowadays. My hip hurts bad and it is difficult to navigate the uneven back yard during night times"

Balan showed me to the extreme corner of the right corridor and there was a wooden chair in the corner. It had a commode attached beneath the seat.

"I use this" Balan looked embarrassed and ashamed to show me the chair.

The chair commode stood testimony to Balan's prostate enlargement, the subsequent surgery he had to undergo and the loss of urinary control that happened as a result of the surgery.

After the little tour, we both walked back and sat in the living room.

"A few years after my wife died, all my relatives started looking for another woman for me to marry. They said I needed someone to manage this huge house. They brought many women. They were all interested."

"Why didn't you re-marry?"

"My brother's son brought this young woman, 35 years old. She is a widow. Her husband died in a road accident. She did not have any children. She did not have any support. They all asked me to marry her. But I was 70 years old at that time. How could I marry a woman half my age? She was younger than all my sons."

"I understand. It is not possible to get into that kind of a marriage. What happened then?"

"She was a destitute woman. She had absolutely nobody to care for her. So I adopted her as my own daughter instead. I looked for a suitable guy and got her married to him. I conducted the marriage in a grand manner and gave her gifts and money to set up her home. She is happy now"

I stood silently looking at Balan with amazement and deep appreciation.

"I am thinking of giving away this house and moving to a smaller place. It is painful to think about leaving, but I do not have a choice. I am unable to manage this house."

"Do you have anyone to help you clean and maintain this place?"

"Yes, I have a servant lady, who comes and cleans up the house. But I am not talking about that kind of maintenance. You see, the entire top floor is unoccupied. So many useless rowdy fellows climb up

the roof from the back yard and use the top floor for bad activities. They drink, they play rummy games and even bring women there for a good time. I am unable to control that."

"Can't you complain to the police?"

"What will police do in this village? All these men who are doing these activities are my own relatives and natives of this village. If I put them in jail, tomorrow if I die, nobody will even conduct my funeral. I am dependent on these people for everything."

"But how can you allow this to happen?"

"What do you think I can do? Everyone is waiting for me to die. Today if I die, my sons and daughters will come and raze this house down and sell the property, divide their shares and go away. The most dignified thing for me to do would be to move away when everything is still alright and write off the property to my children. Let them do what they want with it."

After some time, I took leave and left from Balan's house. The time was nearing 6 PM. As I walked toward the bus stand, two young men with liquor bottles wrapped in plastic turned down the alley toward Sundari Vilas. We passed each other without a word.

Chapter 13

Mystery of the missing pills

Kantha is a feisty old woman, bubbling with happiness each time she came to the clinic. She had a diminutive stature and walked with a hunch. But her walk always had a rhythm, like a gracious dance. Her black and white hair would always be immaculately oiled, parted in the middle, and tied into a neat bun. Her voice, loud and sonorous, she would splash a shower of saliva every time she spoke. A very matriarchal figure, everyone in the clinic loved her and respected her. She knew this very well and used it to her absolute advantage.

"Hey, Shantha, bring me a cup of tea when you give to the staff won't you?" she would demand of the housekeeping staff.

"How much longer are you going to make me wait?" she would shout at the staff in the front desk managing the crowd and allowing patients for consultation as per their token numbers.

Sometimes she would bring small gifts like a little ball of tamarind that she collected from the big tamarind tree near her house, or a bag full of blueberries from the tree in her garden. She would

proudly hand it over to the staff nurse and command, "This is not just for you, you must distribute it fairly to everyone."

Kantha had difficulty in walking and used a locally fashioned cane as a support. She never shied away from using it to gently hit us and reprimand us when she felt like it. The very sound of Kantha's voice was enough to make the entire room come alive with cheer and happiness.

"Daaktaru, you are not giving me enough medicines to last the whole month. You make me come again and again. Why are you doing this to me?"

Kantha was in the clinic almost 20 days ahead of when she was scheduled to come to get her prescription refill for her diabetes and hypertension medicines.

"You were here just 10 days ago, and I wrote a prescription for a whole month? What happened to all the pills?" I asked.

"Aah! Why would you not ask? You make it sound like I ate all the pills myself. What do you think they are, pills or some snacks?"

"You tell me Kanthamma…where are the pills?"

"Don't you understand what I am telling you? You did not give me enough pills to last me the whole month."

I took her case record and walked across to the pharmacy with Kantha quickly catching up behind me. I went to the pharmacist and asked her to show me the bill book for the date on which Kantha had come to get the previous prescription refill. She searched for the bill and there it was.

“Metformin 60 tablets, Glimepiride 60 tablets, Amlodipine 30 tablets, B complex tablets 30….there…this is the bill. We have given you enough to last a month and you have also paid for it” I pointed the bill book and showed it to her.

“Why are you showing me? If only I knew to read all this, why would I come and depend on you like this? Take the book away.”

Kantha sounded loud and rude, but she did not mean it that way. We know how she spoke and we understood.

“You know what I am saying Kanthamma…we have given you enough tablets to last you a month. Where are the remaining pills?”

Kantha got annoyed and sat down in her chair with a heavy sigh. She did not want to continue arguing any further. Forty pills of Metformin, 40 of Gimepiride and 20 each of Amlodipine and B complex tablets were unaccounted for. I did not want to keep wasting much time asking her about the whereabouts of the pills.

“OK, leave it, you must have misplaced it somewhere. Do you want to buy more to use the rest of the month?”

“What? Me, and misplacing the tablets? Impossible! How dare you call me careless”

Kantha got very angry with that word ‘misplaced’.

“They call me snake eyes. Anyone misses anything, they come to me to look for it. I have even found misplaced minute golden screws of ear-rings from the dirt. You are saying I misplaced the tablets?”

I did not have time for the argument as many people were waiting to be seen.

"Ok, I take back the word misplaced. I will write out another fresh prescription. You do not have to pay for this. Just collect the pills and keep them carefully"

Kantha understood that I was closing the discussion as there was a huge crowd waiting outside. She walked out with a frown on her face.

Around 1 PM all staff went for lunch. We all sit together in the duty room on the floor in one big circle, open our respective lunch boxes and eat. Often we share the food and the boxes go around the circle when everyone tastes a bit of each other's food. As we were eating lunch I started the talk about Kantha's tablets.

"Did you notice how angry and upset Kanthamma was this morning?"

"I have seen her angry, but never so serious and upset" said the pharmacist.

"I know, she was so angry and was on the verge of tears. I thought it was a bit of an over-reaction" said the staff nurse.

"I don't think it is an over-reaction. I think her pride got hurt when I said that she must have misplaced it. She is a highly disciplined and careful lady. So it must have hurt her" I added.

"She must have kept it somewhere and forgotten" said the housekeeping staff.

The discussion went on for some time and then it died out. We started talking about other things, especially the upcoming international women's day celebrations. Then we finished lunch and went back to the clinic.

Days rolled by and in about ten days Kantha was back in the clinic. As she walked in, the usual energy and enthusiasm were missing. Kantha's face was shrouded in worry. Even when she was very sick, she never lost the sparkle in her eyes. But today it was completely missing.

"Good morning Kanthamma…what brings you to clinic today? Are you ok? You don't look your usual self."

"Daaktaru… you are playing tricks on me. This time also you gave me fewer pills than usual. I don't have any more tablets remaining."

It was strange. Because the other day, Kantha had come straight back to my room from the pharmacy, showed me the pills, made me count them and show her and took it from me. I knew clearly that I had given her 40 each of Metformin and Glimepiride and 20 each of Amlodipine and B complex. But she was saying it was missing.

"What are you saying Kanthamma…I counted and gave you that day. You saw it yourself. How can it go missing? You are surely misplacing it somewhere and forgetting about it."

"No, I said No. I do not misplace my tablets. Will you stop blaming me?"

It felt like Kanthamma was experiencing some form of memory problem. Maybe her long standing diabetes and hypertension have led to some form of dementia. Was she keeping her tablets some place and forgetting about them?

"Shall I come home and talk to your daughter in law? Shall we sit together and figure out what is happening?"

Kantha lived close to our clinic, barely two kilometers away. Some days she even walked from her home to the clinic. I knew her son and daughter in law very well. They were active members of the community and good people. I started getting worried about Kantha's missing pills and wanted to have an open discussion with her son and daughter in law to understand what exactly was happening.

"You can come. When have I stopped you from visiting? When will you come? My son will be available only after 6 PM. Can you come after that?"

"OK, I will drop by this evening as soon as I finish clinic and close up."

Kantha took a prescription for the missing tablets and walked away with a dull demeanor.

"Sister, can you wind up the clinic and lock up? I will go to Kanthamma's house and come back later in the evening. You please leave the quarters key with Shantha akka and leave." I said this and started walking towards Kantha's house. It was a nice long 2 KM walk. The evening was pleasant. There was the typical evening rural scene all around. People were returning from the fields with sickles and aluminum basins used to carry mud. Children were playing in the mud roads, running and screaming with joy. Cows and goats had started returning from grazing all day in the fields. Motor bikes were also whizzing past me with people who had gone to work in the nearby town returning home. The sun was setting slowly in the horizon and it had painted the sky a mix of bright orange, pink and yellow. As I reached Kantha's home, I could see her grandchildren playing in the courtyard. Kantha was sitting on her coir cot just outside the home, cleaning rice that had to be cooked for dinner that night. She was struggling hard and

peering deep into that rice, what with her failing eye sight. She did not notice my coming. The children saw me and shouted out to her, "Aayah…doctor has come" and ran away. She slowly looked up, saw me, placed the plate of rice on the cot and got up and came towards me. I greeted her, "Vanakkam Kanthamma…I came as promised."

"Come come, Daaktaru… sit down. Will you have some tea?"

"I just had coffee in the clinic before I left. I came just to see you and talk to your son and daughter in law"

"Ok..Ok…I will call her. Please sit down"

Kantha walked into the house to bring her daughter in law. I had been to Kantha's house before. But there were some interesting changes. They had put up a tank under ground just adjacent to where I was sitting. The Panchayat water was supplied just outside the house in a tap. They had connected this tap to this underground sump to collect the water. This arrangement was not there the last time I had come. I also noticed a small window air conditioner, probably 1 ton, jutting out from the side window in the bedroom. Kantha's son had moved to a new job recently and it was leading to some improvements in the quality of their life. As I sat there waiting for Kantha, I looked up the tamarind tree just outside Kantha's house. It was a big, old tamarind tree. There was a beautiful shade spreading all around the courtyard of Kantha's house. On top of the tree there were three monkeys. Two adults and a baby. They were sitting there and one adult monkey was grooming the other. The baby was jumping here and there playfully. Kantha walked out with her daughter in law behind her, "Ahh…I see you have spotted our friends on top of the tree. Those monkeys are a real menace. We can't keep any food outside. They will immediately pounce and grab it. We must be extremely cautious"

I greeted Kantha's daughter in law. "Vanakkam, Parvathy. How are you? How is Velu?"

"Vanakkam Doctor. Velu is fine, we are all fine. Amma told us that you will be coming today to talk about her. Please sit. Let me get you something hot to drink. Some tea…" saying this Parvathy ran into the house. I sat down on Kantha's coir cot and she sat next to me.

"Come with me, let me show you where I keep my tablets" said Kantha and got up and walked towards a door on the right side of the house. I walked behind her. She opened the door and invited me in.

"Don't you latch the door?" I asked noticing that the door was slightly ajar when we went near it.

"What is the need to lock the doors Daaktaru? In our areas there is no theft!"

It was a clean and bright room with a small wooden cot to the right side. On the extreme corner at the foot end of the cot was a small chair and table. On the left side there was a big shelf on the wall. It was an open shelf. There were four racks. The second rack was at eye level for Kantha. She pointed to that rack and asked me to look. I had spent years untangling crumpled plastic bags brought in by patients, blister packs shredded at random, loose capsules rolling around at the bottom. But Kantha's shelf was an apothecary's dream: four neat, transparent tubs standing at eye level like disciplined soldiers. They were neatly and systematically arranged. I was surprised to see it. It was inspiring. Kantha was watching me as I watched her pill shelf with awe and wonder. *"I told you, I keep my pills very meticulously organized. Do you see now? Are you convinced that I did not misplace my pills?"*

I did not know what to say. When the pills are so well organized, even a person with dementia is unlikely to misplace the pills. I was clueless about what was happening to Kantha's pills.

Parvathy called out from the courtyard, "Doctor, I got you your tea. Please come and sit here. Let us sit and talk."

We walked out to the courtyard. The children were not there anymore. They had moved inside and were sitting with their books and notebooks doing their homework.

"Velu said he will be late. Please tell me. He asked me to get the information from you and inform him"

"Nothing serious. I just wanted to talk to you about the missing pills that Kanthamma is complaining of"

"Yes Doctor, she told us also. It is strange how the pills went missing. We are unable to find an explanation. That is why we were wondering if the clinic gave lesser pills by mistake"

"No Parvathy, last time, I personally counted and gave the pills myself. I was wondering if Kantha is having some memory issues? Is she forgetting things? Is there anything off or strange about the way she is talking or doing things nowadays?"

Kantha was listening quietly. She did not interfere.

"No doctor! Amma is the same. Nothing has changed. She gets up early in the morning, does her small work around the house. Says her prayers, walks to the village temple and helps in the kitchen. Nothing has changed"

"I am worried it might be some minor memory related issue because of her long standing diabetes and hypertension. Please

bring her back to the clinic next week. I will run some tests to find out how things are. Maybe we can also visit the neurologist in the government hospital to get an evaluation."

Kantha, who had been sitting patiently until now, grew angry when she heard what I said. "Are you saying I am going mad? Are you saying I am losing my mind? No way! I am as sharp as I always have been"

Precisely at that time a motor bike came and parked inside the courtyard. Velu had returned from work.

"Doctor, so nice to see you. I thought I will miss you, but glad that you are still here. How are you?"

"Hello Velu! So nice to see you too. I was just finishing and leaving"

"Ohh no! You must have dinner and go."

"Not today. I will come another time. The staff has to leave, I must go and take over the quarters keys from her."

Velu sat down in front of us.

I said, "I was discussing with Parvathy and Kanthamma about the missing pills. I was just explaining how it could be a mild memory problem."

Just as we were talking there was a sound of someone running. I turned and saw the baby monkey standing outside Kantha's door. I pressed my hand on Kantha's and whispered, "Don't make any drastic moves. Let us see what that little monkey is doing" We all turned towards the room, stayed quiet and watched the little monkey. The monkey played around for some time and with both hands pushed at Kantha's door. The door gently gave way

and opened. The little monkey royally walked inside. There was nobody else in the house. Kantha got agitated when she saw the little monkey walk into the room. She started to get up to run towards the house. I held her back and whispered to her, "Wait, let us watch what is happening. I think we have an answer for the puzzle of the missing pills." Even as I was saying this the little fellow walked out with one red strip of B complex tablets. The monkey was playing with it tossing it up and down and trying to split open the blister pack and take the pills out. I restrained Kantha with my hands indicating that we should let the little fellow go. Velu and Parvathy were also watching spellbound. The monkey took the red blister pack of pills, jumped up and ran away behind the house.

Slowly all four of us got up and walked into the room. The pill boxes in Kantha's shelf were slightly disorganized. The little fellow had perfectly opened the door, opened the box, picked up the colorful pills and come out. This must have taken many weeks of practice for the little monkey. "Ahh…no wonder. Some days I have noticed that the boxes were lying haphazard. Once it was even lying open. But I never thought someone was coming and taking the pills like this. That too a monkey"

"Kanthamma…we have figured out what was happening to the pills. All we need to do now is to keep the pills in a safe place. You won't miss the pills anymore."

"Daaktaru…this is such a relief. Maybe the monkey's parents have diabetes…" saying this Kantha started laughing. Her cheerful self was back. Velu, Parvathy and I joined her and we stood there for a few moments sharing the absolute relief of figuring out what went wrong with her pills.

Chapter 14

Taste of Home

Vedagiri is a 55 year old gigantic man from the affluent section of the village near our clinic. He would always walk into the clinic authoritatively. When he enters all other patients intuitively get up, move away and give way for him to walk straight into the consultation room. Even the clinic staff regulating the crowd would not be able to say anything to stop him from barging in. He had a booming voice and walked with the authority of owning every space he entered. Always dressed in impeccable white shirt and dhoti, a few streaks of grey hair near his ears and the shiny bald pate were the only give away of his age. Every year come summer, Vedagiri would gift an entire gunny bag, weighing 20-25 kilograms, full of luscious banganapalli mangoes to the clinic. He also doled out a lot of freebies, gifts and money to the clinic staff for various festivals and celebratory occasions like Pongal, Deepavali and birthdays. This gave him a sense of entitlement at the clinic. He never hesitated to cut the queues of waiting patients, or demand small favours of the staff in the clinic.

Vedagiri walked into the clinic closely followed by a thin built man in an old orange round neck T shirt that had small holes near the neck region. He was wearing an old khakhi shorts. The man had hair that was dyed red in color and there was an old wet rag that was tied around his left hand. The rag was stained with blood. His face was grimacing in pain. The strong smell of brake oil was mixed with sweat and blood. Vedagiri barged into my room in his usual style and bellowed,

"Good morning doctor, this boy cut his hand during work in the rice mill. Take a look"

With Vedagiri I was used to receiving instructions and not requests. Vedagiri pushed the meek young man forward into the room and in front of me. He pushed him down to seat him in the chair in front of me. The young man gave into all his pushing and shoving without a word or any form of protest. The young man was trembling as I approached his hand. I took his hand in mine and gently started unraveling the wet rag. He pulled his hand back.

"Allow me to see your hand. I want to see how deep the cut is" I said in Tamil.

He gave me an unknown stare, a blank look, as though he hadn't understood anything I said.

Vedagiri shouted at him the same thing "Stay put, doctor will see your hand" and caught hold of his upper left arm tightly and held it.

"Eta khulo na, rokto porbe" he whispered. With all the O's and Ba's I immediately understood it had to be Bengali. But I did not understand what he was saying. I looked into his eyes.

"blood…blood…" he kept repeating and holding his hand back. He was trying to tell me that I should not open it there, as it was bleeding. I gestured him to get up and walk with me to the treatment room. We both walked into the treatment room. Vedagiri was not too far behind. In the treatment room, I kept a tray ready to manage any severe bleeding and opened the wet rag cloth.

As the rag cloth came off it revealed a nasty gash that ran right across the left palm from the base of the left thumb all way to the base of the left little finger. Over the gash was a mish mash of herbal paste, blue ink, crushed tablets, coffee powder, all of which villagers use commonly to arrest bleeding, and blood. There was a slow trickle of blood that was dripping down from the wound. It was a rather deep wound and required suturing.

"How did this happen?" I asked the young man.

He kept staring at me blankly. Vedagiri replied, "He was cutting up the paddy to thresh them to remove the grains. Accidentally he chopped the sickle into his palm"

"When did this happen?"

"Early this morning"

"Looks like you have applied all kinds of things to the wound"

"Yes, these fellows are brainless fellows. They will apply anything and everything on the wounds" shouted Vedagiri and laughed loudly.

The young man's head was bowed low and he avoided any eye contact with me or with Vedagiri. He just sat there, his injured left hand shaking. I looked at his face and his facial muscles were

twitching, probably in rage. I would be angry too, with a boss like Vedagiri.

"Can you leave the room now? I want to clean his wound and suture it" I told Vedagiri firmly. Reluctantly he left the room. The moment Vedagiri left I could sense the young man loosening up and relaxing a bit.

"Sister, could you please bring the suturing tray? Also a bucket of tap water and mug for washing the wound please"

The staff nurse prepared the treatment room table for a thorough washing of the wound and suturing. I took a mug of tepid tap water and started gently washing all the dirt and grime from his hand. He winced in pain as I kept rinsing the wound. This was time for a conversation with the young man.

"Tumhara naam kya hai?" I asked

Instantly the young man's eyes lit up. Hearing just those few Hindi words inquiring his name, in a largely Tamil speaking area must have lit the bulb of familiarity in his brain. He smiled widely despite the pain.

"Hindi maloom?" he asked – do you know Hindi?

"Haan thoda Hindi maloom." Yes I know a little Hindi.

His smile slowly faded and he started narrating his story.

"Deba. My name is Deba. I come from Bengal. You know Kolkata?"

"Ofcourse, I know West Bengal and Kolkata. Where are you from in West Bengal?"

“Purulia. You know Purulia?”

“I don’t know that place. Have never been. When did you come to Tamil Nadu?”

“Eight months ago. I came for work”

The jerky conversation now started flowing smoothly. Deba was starting to get comfortable. By now the wound was washed clean.

“Deba, I am going to give you a small injection in your hand to make it not hurt when I suture it” I managed to say this in broken Hindi that I knew.

He understood and nodded his head.

After I injected the local anaesthetic and covered up his palm with a sterile cloth, I prepared for the suturing of the wound. This would take 10-15 minutes. I had some more time for small talk.

“When was the last time you went home?”

There was a long silence in response to this question. I looked up and noticed the expressions on Deba’s face had changed. He was in pain and there were tears flowing down the sides of his face from his eyes. I placed a comforting hand on his shoulder. The silent tears turned into uncontrolled sobs. The young child inside Deba started crying longing for home, familiar spaces, scents, sounds and people.

I finished suturing and cleaned up the wound and dressed it up with a clean bandage.

“Next month is Durga Pujo right? Are you going home?”

He sat up and his face lit up hearing the words Durga Pujo.

“Daktar Babu… Pujo is the happiest part of my life.”

Despite the fractured communication, Deba took on a fantasy trip through the large pandal in Deba’s village. The boys waking up early in the morning with the beating of the dhaak drums. The drums reverberating through their thin bodies. In the evenings all the boys dancing during the aarti. The taste of Sondesh, Rosgolla and all the milk sweets, lingering in his tongue! “I am going home for Pujo” Deba was in a trance as he narrated this. His Hindi was broken, as was mine. But the intensity of our emotions could not be blocked by the lack of language skills.

Deba jumped down from the treatment room table and stood up briskly.

We walked back to the consultation room. Vedagiri was not there anymore. He was not the person to wait for someone. Maybe Deba had to just walk back to the rice mill on his own, a difficult 4 KM walk in the hot afternoon sun.

One week later I saw Deba again in the clinic. He had come for inspection of his wound and dressing. The dressing looked dirty and soiled.

“Have you not changed the dressing? It looks dirty”

Deba smiled at me and did not reply.

“Have you been working with this hand all along?”

Again Deba smiled.

His silent and all-knowing smiles felt like he was telling me *"Don't you know the answer for these questions? Why do you ask questions for which you know the answers?"*

"Come let us go to the treatment room and get the wound checked out"

We walked into the treatment room. This time Deba did not need any instructions. He went straight to the treatment table and climbed and sat on it. He started opening the dressing himself. I could see an eager look on his face, as though inviting me for a conversation.

"Do Tamil people celebrate Durga Pujo?" Deba asked.

"No Deba, we do not celebrate Durga Pujo, but we have an equivalent called Navaratri"

Deba smiled and listened.

"Do you miss eating home food?"

"Ahhh… Ayya feeds us the food that they eat at their home. It is ok."

His response was not enthusiastic. It was obvious that he was just managing with the food.

"There is a Kali baari in Chennai. Some of us went there last month. They served our home food there."

"Ohh yes, that must have tasted like home food. You must have liked it"

"Ahhh…nah Daaktar Babu…Would you say all Tamil food is home food? Home food is home food. Just because it is Bengali food, it cannot be home food"

Deba's words hit hard. I was doing what most people would do in such a situation, confuse regional identity with comfort levels.

Deba laughed heartily and jumped down from the table. He nodded, smiled and left the clinic.

Deba came back four days later for suture removal. This time there was another friend with him. The friend was the same height and build as Deba. He was wearing the thick orange round neck T shirt with holes around the neck. It was the same one Deba was wearing the other day. The young man was silent and stood calmly by Deba's side as I slowly removed Deba's sutures.

"Deba, the wound has healed nicely. Just take it slow for the next few days. Don't do heavy work."

"Daaktar Babu, I am already doing a lot of heavy work" saying this Deba laughed.

I gave him a friendly pat on the back.

"Who is this Deba? Your friend?"

"This is Khemu daaktar babu"

I looked at Khemu and smiled at him. I noticed that Khemu had dense rashes all over his neck, upper chest, arms, and hands. Throughout the time he was standing there in the treatment room he was scratching himself.

"Khemu, may I ask you something? You seem to be having a rash. It seems to be itching a lot. How long have you had it?"

Khemu jumped at the question in all earnestness and started explaining his symptoms. It was like he was waiting desperately for an opportunity to talk about it.

"Daaktar Babu…it is a very bad rash. Many of us boys working here have it. It is itching like anything. We cannot sleep at night. All of us have it"

"Come closer" I called to Khemu and examined the rash. It was intense scabies, an infestation fueled not by carelessness, but by confinement. I knew telling them not to share clothes or to boil their bedding was useless advice when eight boys slept shoulder-to-shoulder on the floor of a single mill room. Still, I wrote down medicines for Khemu. Deba and Khemu got their medicines and left.

The next morning as I entered the clinic there was a huge crowd just outside the clinic. It was a Sunday morning. Sundays are usually busy days. As it is a holiday all working people prefer to come for consultation on Sundays.

"Sit in the benches in the order of your token numbers" the staff managing the crowd was shouting.

There was heavy noise and everyone was saying something or the other. The cacophony was loud and tense.

"They should not be allowed to go before us. We are locals"

"First they came and took our jobs…then they spit pan all over the place and made our place dirty…and now they want to beat us in the queue to our own hospitals. No way"

"They can see after we all finish"

The local regulars were shouting one over the other.

There were six young men, the army of the six led by Deba, seated on the bench right in front.

The staff was agitated. She said, "They came before you. They have the first 6 tokens. You must wait for your turn"

The skirmish became louder. The crowd control staff ran to me and implored with her eyes.

I did my Vanakkam gesture to all the locals in the crowd and they all reciprocated it and moved aside for me to enter the clinic. When I came near Deba I put a friendly hand on his shoulder and asked, "Deba, how is your hand?" in my broken Hindi.

"I am fine daaktar babu" said Deba and smiled shyly.

I smiled brightly at him and asked, *"You brought your friends"*

Deba had a serious expression on his face, "Yes daaktar babu..they all have what Khemu had…so I thought they can see you"

I turned to the staff regulating the crowd and said, "Sister, send Deba and his friends as per token order" and walked in.

All the noises and sounds outside went silent. The locals did not say anything.

Chapter 15

Divine blessing

By eight o'clock, the red-oxide verandah of the community health centre was already humming with the low, continuous cadence of life that characterizes a village clinic: the squeak of worn chappals on cement; the impatient rustle of laminated outpatient record cards; the soft, rhythmic patting of an infant being coaxed to sleep by a young mother; and the occasional sharp reprimand of a village elder telling a restless toddler to sit still on the wooden benches.

Then came the sound that had become an indelible marker of the past three weeks: the dragging, uneven scrape of new slippers worn awkwardly, along the corridor floor.

Scrape. Pause. Scrape. Pause.

It was a cadence born of calculation, an involuntary rhythm dictated by pain and preservation. Every three feet, the sound stopped, punctuated by the dull thud of an old wooden walking stick made from a whittled tamarind branch, cut too short so that the bearer had to bend his torso far to the left to plant it securely.

When the green curtain was pushed aside, Dayalan stood framed in the opening.

He was seventy years old, but in the agrarian belt of the plains, seventy is not a number that speaks of graceful retirement; it is etched into the flesh like the rings of a weathered tree. His frame was slight, his collarbones standing out like twin curved handles beneath a washed-out, collarless shirt that had long lost its original color to hard well-water and harsh soap. His skin was the color of dry teak, cross-hatched by thousands of fine, deep crevices around the eyes and along the hollows of his sunken cheeks. Over his narrow shoulders lay a faded, coarse cotton thundu, folded lengthwise, its fringes frayed into uneven threads.

His weight was pitched entirely onto his right hip, his right knee locked straight to bear his total mass, while his left foot hovered an inch above the floor tiles, cocked outward at an unnatural, defensive angle.

“Vanga, Ayya,” I said, rising halfway from my wooden chair to reach across the corner of the consultation table.

He did not look up immediately. His gaze was fixed with desperate concentration on the three paces of floor between the doorway and the low patient stool beside my desk. With every inch he gained, his jaw tightened, the cords of his neck standing out like taut wire, his lips compressed into a thin, bloodless line. As he finally reached the wooden stool, he caught the rounded edge of the consultation desk with his gnarled right hand.

When his hips met the wood of the stool, a long, trembling exhalation escaped his throat, a sound that was half hiss, half groan, carrying the accumulated exhaustion of a man who had fought for every single yard of ground he had crossed that morning.

“Ayya, breathe,” I said gently. “Rest a minute.”

He lifted his head then. His eyes were cloudy and brimming with a profound, unadorned weariness. He offered a faint, fleeting movement of his lips, the shadow of an apology for the noise of his entry, the instinct of a poor man who feels he is an imposition simply by taking up room in a clean, clinical space.

“The pain just doesn’t go away, Doctor,” he whispered in Tamil, his voice rasping from the dry morning air. He leaned his forehead against his stick for a brief second. “In the morning, when I have to swing my legs out of the coir cot, my heart sinks. I sit there on the edge of the cot for ten minutes, just looking at the floor. The moment the sole touches the matting, it is as though someone has driven an iron spike straight up through the ball of the foot. I cannot put it down. I try to hop, but my right knee trembles with the load. Doctor, I don’t know what to do. I don’t know when this will leave me.”

The affliction that had brought this seventy-year-old man to a state of near-total immobilization was, by standard clinical textbooks, entirely mundane: a single corn, scarcely larger than a dried chickpea, seated squarely over the ball of the great toe of his left foot.

To an inexperienced observer or an urban practitioner accustomed to seeing lesions through the sterile barrier of private consultation suites, a corn is a minor nuisance, a mechanical consequence of ill-fitting shoes, easily corrected by orthotics, salicylic acid plasters, or a brief office procedure. But in the social reality of this rural community, where existence is sustained entirely by manual movement, a foot lesion is not a minor complaint; it is an economic catastrophe. The foot is the laborer’s only capital asset. When the

foot fails, the entire fragile architecture of daily survival collapses with it.

For three weeks, Dayalan had been coming to our outpatient room. Before he ever arrived at the health centre, he had done what almost every elderly villager without savings does when pain strikes: he had sought out a traditional healer down the lane, an old man referred to as the 'six fingered magician' as he had six fingers in both his hands, who doubled as a local surgeon for minor boils and thorns.

The practitioner had seated Dayalan on an upturned wooden crate beneath an oil lamp, pulled out a rusted, well-stropped straight razor, and cut down the thick yellow hard tissue. But he had sliced too deep, digging blindly toward what he called the "root" of the corn. The razor had left behind a raw, lacerated wound surrounded by an inflamed halo of angry, swollen tissue. Instead of relief, the intervention had transformed an annoying mechanical pressure point into an exquisite, throbbing torment that made the bearing of weight painful.

When Dayalan had first hobbled into our clinic three weeks earlier, the wound had been bleeding, crusted over with dried brick powder and turmeric that he had applied at home to stop the bleeding.

We had instituted conservative medical management with advice to change over to soft footwear, apply topical creams that soothe the wound and painkillers. But a corn does not heal merely because an ointment is spread across its surface. It requires the elimination of pressure, or rest. And for Dayalan, rest was an impossible luxury.

“Let me look at it, Ayya,” I said, rolling my stool back and pulling a small stainless steel dressing trolley toward us.

I knelt down on the red-tiled floor before him. It was a posture that always caused Dayalan distress; in the deep, unspoken caste and class hierarchies that still governed the surrounding hamlets, an educated man, a doctor, no less, did not kneel at the feet of a solitary gardener dressed in a threadbare shirt and torn chappals. Every time I reached for his ankle, he made a frantic, involuntary motion to pull it away, his hands fluttering in front of his knees as if to shield me from the uncleanness of his poverty.

“Ayya, irunga,” I murmured, my voice low and level, holding his lower calf with firm, reassuring warmth to anchor him. “Stay still. Let me see it.”

With practiced slowness, I lifted his left foot and rested his heel gently against the folded green surgical drape spread across my knee.

The foot in my hands told the story of half a century of hard, bare labor. The sole was not soft; it was like thick, dried leather, stained deep brown and ochre by decades of contact with the iron-rich red soil of the fields. The heels were lined with deep, vertical fissures—cracks so ancient that the red dirt had become permanently embedded within their walls, forming dark, branching rivers across the gray skin. His toes were slightly clawed from years of walking on uneven furrows, gripping the earth for traction against the mud.

And there, right in the center of the ball of the foot, sat the wound. The central core was dense, hard, and translucent like horn, surrounded by a jagged collar of macerated, peeling skin that had turned milky white from the ointment. The margins were angry and red, swollen with the friction of his unending, limping steps.

I reached for a sterile swab soaked in normal saline and began to clean away the residue of yesterday's paste. As the cool cotton touched the inflamed border, Dayalan's whole body stiffened. A sharp, shuddering gasp caught in his throat, his toes curled rigidly downward, and his thin fingers dug into the wooden edges of the consultation stool until his knuckles cracked.

"Porumai, Ayya," I whispered, not looking up, keeping my touch as feather-light as humanly possible. "Patience. I know it burns. I am cleaning only the edges."

"I know, Doctor... I know," he managed to breathe, his words coming out in shuddering fragments as he stared up at the whitewashed ceiling. "I know you are doing it for my good. It is my body that is weak."

Over those three weeks of morning dressings, piece by piece, the silent reality of Dayalan's life had revealed itself in the small room. It did not come out as a structured grievance or an appeal for pity; it surfaced in the quiet, matter-of-fact observations of an old man answering simple clinical inquiries about how far he had walked, what he had eaten before taking his tablets, and why his bandage was so often caked with mud.

He lived less than a kilometer from the clinic, in a settlement of narrow alleys tucked behind the dry irrigation tank. His shelter could hardly be called a house; it was a low, precarious hovel constructed from discarded tin sheets. The roof was not tile or thatch; two years prior, when the monsoons had threatened to tear away his rotting palmyra leaves, he had scraped together two hundred rupees to buy an old, discarded PVC political flex banner from a local village leader's henchman. The banner, bearing the giant, sun-bleached portrait of a grinning politician and faded electoral slogans about

progress, was weighted down with broken clay tiles and stones to keep the wind from lifting it.

"During the light drizzles, it holds," he had told me on his second visit, his tone devoid of irony. "During the heavy rains last November, the water collected in the sagging belly of the plastic and started pouring through the seams right onto the corner where I roll out my mat. But right now, the sun is high and dry. The rains are months away. Why worry about rain when the sky is clear?"

Six years ago, the thin scaffolding of his domestic life had broken completely. His wife had suffered a sudden, massive chest pain in the middle of the night. By the time he had managed to wake the neighbors to fetch an auto-rickshaw, her hands had turned cold, her breath quiet, and her struggle ended before they had even reached the main road. Since that night, the small hovel had known only his own solitary breathing and the rustle of dry leaves blowing across the dirt threshold.

His only daughter had married a small-scale construction coolie and moved far away to the southern borders of the neighboring district, where stone quarries offered intermittent daily wage work. She was a dutiful daughter, but her own life was a relentless arithmetic of survival, two growing school-age children, a husband who often went without work during the dry months, and a rented one-room brick shed near the quarry pits. Once a month, she would board three different connecting government buses, traveling four hours through the dust and heat, to spend an hour with her father. She would bring a plastic bag containing a handful of dried fish, two packets of cheap washing powder, and three or four hundred rupees squeezed out of her husband's weekly earnings to help him buy everyday essentials like soap, and medicines.

Those visits were the solitary calendar by which Dayalan measured time.

Between those visits, his life was held together by an intricate, fragile network of village charity and his own stubborn refusal to become a beggar.

The village Panchayat council, recognizing his age and his destitution, had three years ago given him a small, informal chore: watering the saplings and ornamental shrubs planted along the compound wall of the Panchayat office building. Every day, morning and evening, he would lift the heavy galvanized iron bucket from the hand pump in the corner of the yard, fill it to the brim, and carry it across the clearing, splashing water around the roots of the bougainvillea, the neem saplings, and the potted crotons outside the council president's room. For this, the administrative clerk handed him two thousand rupees in cash at the end of every month, a sum that represented his entire earned dignity, his sole claim to being an active, functioning member of the society.

His sustenance came from a parallel stream of benevolence. A wealthy charitable trust run by an industrialist from Chennai operated a free kitchen on the outskirts of the village, serving a hot afternoon meal to the destitute, the elderly, and the physically disabled on all days except Sundays.

Every morning at eleven, before the midday heat reached its peak, Dayalan would begin his trek along the dirt path toward the trust's compound. He would carry a battered aluminum plate and a stainless steel tiffin carrier tied together with a length of yellow plastic cord. He would stand in the quiet queue of men and women, holding out his plate to receive whatever the cooks had ladled out:

sometimes tamarind rice flecked with dry red chilies, sometimes a thick, fragrant sambar rice with drumsticks, sometimes lemon rice fragrant with mustard seeds.

He never ate the food there. He would carry the hot vessel back to his hovel, sit down cross-legged on his woven mat, and divide the contents into two precise, equal portions. The first half he ate at noon, washing it down with water drawn from the public standpipe. The second half was carefully covered with a brass plate and set aside in the corner of his tin shed, guarded against ants with a ring of ash, to be eaten in the dark at eight o'clock at night.

On Sundays, when the charitable kitchen stayed closed, he dressed in his cleanest white shirt and walked two kilometers down the highway to the Assemblies of God church. He was not a baptized Christian, but he sat quietly on the rear stone bench during the liturgy, watching the candles flicker on the altar, his hands folded in his lap. After the service, the church members served a warm meal of rice and chicken curry to whoever sat in the courtyard, and Dayalan ate with grateful reverence before beginning the long trek back home.

Two thousand rupees. A plate of afternoon rice halved for dinner. A walk to the Panchayat well. A walk to the trust kitchen. A Sunday walk to the church.

This was the entire perimeter of his existence. It was narrow, harsh, and lived at the absolute margin of subsistence, but it was his. It possessed a steady, honorable rhythm that kept him from extending his hand to strangers on the road.

And now, a single circular knot of inflamed corn, no larger than a coin, had brought that entire delicate universe crashing down.

For the past three weeks, he had been unable to go for his Panchayat office work. Worse still, he could no longer make the eleven o'clock journey to the trust kitchen. On some days, the twelve-year-old grandson of a neighbor who lived three shacks down would take his aluminum container and bring it back filled, tossing it onto his porch with the hurried indifference of a child eager to go play marbles. On two occasions, a kind-hearted woman who cooked at the trust kitchen had detoured past his lane on her bicycle to drop off a small packet wrapped in banana leaf.

I had asked him gently the previous week.

He had looked down at his lap, his fingers tracing the frayed seam of his dhoti, and had said nothing. His silence had been more eloquent than any lamentation. On those other days, when no child came and the cook took a different path home, Dayalan had simply tightened the towel around his stomach, drank three tumblers of well-water to quiet the gnawing ache in his belly, and lay down on his coir cot waiting for the sun to set.

"Doctor," Dayalan said, his voice cutting through the quiet hum of the consultation room as I gently blotted the cleaned margins of his wound with sterile gauze.

I looked up. His eyes were wide, fixed upon me with a desperate, penetrating urgency that seemed to bypass every ordinary social barrier between doctor and patient.

"This month... my daughter did not come," he said. His voice was steady, but there was a tremor running beneath the words like the vibration of a strained cable. "She could not come. She took ill. She has a high fever, and her chest is heavy with cough. She had to use a neighbor's mobile phone to send word through the tea shop at

the corner of our lane. The tea shop man walked over to my shed yesterday evening and gave me the message. She told him... she told him that she cannot travel this month. She said she will try to come next month, if God gives her strength. I only hope... I only pray she gets well soon."

There was no need for him to explain what her absence meant. The monthly parcel of money was not coming. The three or four hundred rupees that paid for his kerosene, his matchboxes, his tea leaves, and the subsidized consultation fees and dressing charges at our clinic did not exist. He had arrived at the health centre that morning with empty pockets, dragging his injured foot along the edge of the road, fully aware that he had nothing to offer for the care he was receiving.

I held his foot still in my palms. The silence stretched between us, thick and heavy with the shared knowledge of his utter vulnerability. In that moment, the sterile clinical boundary that separates the professional clinician from the suffering human being in front of him felt like an absurd, cowardly defense.

Without breaking the rhythm of my work, I reached across to the corner of the table with my left hand, picked up the blue ballpoint pen, and drew his outpatient file toward me. On the lower margin of the prescription sheet, right beneath the instructions for saline washing and analgesics, I wrote in bold, unhesitating strokes:

No payment for patient. Billing to MO.

I capped the pen and placed it down. Dayalan had watched the movement of the pen, though he could not read the English script. He looked back at my face, his eyes searching.

“Will the pain ever reduce, Doctor?” he asked, his voice falling into a plea so naked, so raw, that it made my own chest ache. “Is there anything else you can do? An injection? A stronger medicine? Something to cut this pain away today? I just need to walk to the Panchayat office, Doctor. The croton plants are drying up in the sun. The clerk told me yesterday that if I don’t water them by tomorrow evening, they will strike my name off the register. If I lose that, Doctor... what will become of me? How will I stand before anyone?”

I looked at him, seated on that low wooden stool, his fragile shoulders hunched under the weight of his seventy years and his unyielding poverty, and I felt a crushing sense of professional and personal inadequacy.

The body heals along its own stubborn, unalterable timeline. A deep ulcer under a weight-bearing joint cannot knit its cellular bridges overnight. It requires weeks of non-weight-bearing rest—the very thing this man could not provide without starving. I had no miracle injection. I had no magical medicines that could transform raw, lacerated nerve endings into hardened leather in twenty-four hours.

I reached out and laid both my hands firmly over his thin, bandaged ankle, letting him feel the physical weight and warmth of my presence.

“Ayya,” I said, looking straight into his tired eyes, speaking with deliberate, measured slowness. “Listen to me carefully. The pain will go. I give you my word on that. But you must understand how the body works. The foot is not like the arm or the shoulder. The entire weight of your body presses down onto this tiny circle of skin every time you take a step. It takes time, Ayya. We have to give it

time. But the skin is growing back. The inflammation is less today than it was last week. You will walk again without this stick. You will carry your water cans again. You will go back to your garden. Trust me on this."

He looked down at my hands holding his foot. His jaw worked silently, his lips trembling slightly as he tried to swallow down the rising knot of panic and despair. He did not argue. He did not rail against the unfairness of his fate. He simply sat there, absorbing my words like parched soil taking in the first drops of rain, trying to find within them enough strength to endure another twenty-four hours of agony.

Suddenly, a thought struck me. I looked at his lined face, remembered his desperate worry for his daughter, and pulled my hands back.

"Ayya," I asked, "do you have your daughter's phone number with you? The number of that neighbor?"

He blinked, taken by surprise, as if the concept of a telephone in that room was completely outside his frame of reference. *"I... I have it, Doctor. The tea shop brother wrote it down for me on a piece of paper so that if someone came by who had a phone, I could ask them."*

"Take it out," I said, reaching into my apron pocket and pulling out my mobile phone. "We will call her right now."

For a moment, Dayalan sat utterly frozen. Then, with trembling, unhurried fingers he reached deep into the right-hand seam pocket of his faded trousers. He fumbled inside for what seemed an eternity, and pulled out a crumpled square of paper.

It was no larger than a postage stamp, folded over upon itself three times, its edges worn soft and translucent from the sweat of his pocket and the constant reassurance of his touch. He handed it to me with both palms open, as though he were surrendering a sacred relic.

I tapped the numbers on the paper, into my keypad, hit the call button, and switched on the speaker. The rhythmic, mechanical warble of the dial tone echoed sharply off the whitewashed walls of the consultation room. Dayalan leaned forward, his entire body rigid, his eyes fixed on the illuminated glass screen of the telephone as if it were an altar.

Ring... Ring... Click.

A woman's voice crackled through the small speaker—strained, raspy, and breathless against a background of clattering pots and the distant roar of a stone-crusher engine.

"Hello? Yaaru?"

"Amma," I spoke clearly into the microphone. "Do not be alarmed. I am the doctor speaking from the community clinic near Dayalan's village. His daughter had called from this number. Is it possible for him to talk to his daughter?"

The line went silent. Through the speaker faint shouting could be heard "Selvi, Selvi, the doctor is calling about your father…" Someone came and picked up the phone.

There was a sudden, sharp intake of breath on the other end of the line. "Doctor-a? Enna... enna aachu en appavukku? What happened to my father? Is he unwell? Did his foot..."

“Nothing has happened, Amma,” I interrupted gently, keeping my tone calm and steady. “He is safe. His foot is healing. But he was worried about you because he heard you were unwell. He wanted to hear your voice. I am handing the phone to him now.”

I held the phone toward him, but Dayalan did not immediately take it. He stared at the black rectangular device with a mixture of reverence and terror, his hands hovering beside his ears.

“Take it, Ayya,” I smiled, pressing the smooth plastic casing firmly into his calloused right palm. “Put it to your ear. Speak to your daughter.”

His fingers curled around the phone with agonizing care, treating it as though it were made of spun glass. As he brought it to his ear, his lips parted, but no sound came out. His chest rose and fell in violent, uneven heaves.

“Appa?” the voice came through the receiver, small and metallic, but unmistakable. “Appa, neengala?”

At the sound of that single word Appa, the dam broke.

A low, guttural sob ripped through the old man’s chest, a sound so raw, so primitive, that it seemed to come from the very depths of his withered frame. The tears that had been lingering behind his cloudy lenses flooded over his eyelids, running freely through the dry channels of his wrinkles, dripping off his jawline onto his faded cotton shirt.

“Selvi...” he cried out, his voice cracking into a high, trembling wail. “Amma... Selvi... Are you alright? Are you breathing properly? How is your fever? Did you take medicine? Tell me... don’t hide anything from me...”

I stood up quietly from my chair. The intimacy of that moment was vast and sacred, a territory where no professional outsider belonged. I walked across the room, pushed aside the green curtain, and stepped out onto the verandah, pulling the cloth closed behind me to give him privacy.

Outside, the clinic corridor was busy. But through the thin weave of the green curtain, Dayalan's voice carried above the institutional hum. It was no longer the voice of a broken, discarded laborer begging for pain relief; it was the voice of a father, fierce, protective, pouring every drop of his remaining life force through that phone to shield his sick child from harm.

"Don't worry about me, Amma," he was saying, his voice dropping into a desperate, hurried rhythm of reassurance. "I am fine! Look at me, I am sitting in the doctor's room! The doctor is taking such good care of me. He cleaned my foot with his own hands. The pain is completely gone! I am walking properly now. Tomorrow I am going back to the Panchayat office to water the plants. I have plenty of rice. People are bringing me food every single day. There is no trouble here, Selvimma. None at all! You just rest. Drink hot water. Don't worry about the money. Don't think about traveling until your chest is clear. God is there. The doctor is here. Your appa is strong..."

He was lying. He was lying with an absolute, breathtaking nobility, transforming his starvation into abundance, his agony into strength, and his abandonment into care, all to spare his sick daughter a single second of helplessness.

The conversation lasted perhaps two minutes. Then, the soft rustle of the curtain announced him.

“Doctor... mudinjidhu... it is over,” he called out, his voice shaking.

I parted the curtain and stepped back inside the consultation room.

The transformation in the man before me was nothing short of miraculous. The stooped, beaten posture that had dragged itself into the clinic half an hour earlier was gone. His spine had straightened against the back of the wooden stool. His head was held high. The gray, ash-like pallor of defeat had vanished from his cheeks, replaced by a warm, flushed vitality. His eyes were red, swimming with tears, but they were no longer deadened by despair; they burned with a luminous, fierce clarity.

He held out my phone with both hands, presenting it back to me as though he were returning a borrowed kingdom.

“She sounded better, Doctor,” he whispered, wiping the tears from his cheeks with the frayed fringe of his thundu. “Her voice was clearer at the end. She promised me she will drink boiled water and rest today. She said she will come the moment her fever leaves.”

“I am glad, Ayya,” I said, taking the warm phone from his hands and placing it on the desk. “Now you must do your part. You must not worry. Let your mind be at peace, and your foot will heal faster.”

I reached for the roll of clean white gauze, wrapped his foot in a secure, protective figure-of-eight bandage, anchored it with surgical tape, and gently lowered his leg so his heel rested safely on the cool tile floor.

“There,” I said, looking up at him with a warm smile. “We are done for today. Go to the pharmacy counter. The sister will give you the painkillers and the ointment. You don’t have to pay anything at the

counter. Just take the medicines and go straight home. Rest your foot today. No watering the plants until tomorrow."

Dayalan did not move toward the door.

He slowly gathered his weight, planted his sound right foot firmly on the floor, and leaned his torso forward over his wooden walking stick, levering himself upward with deliberate, agonizing care. He stood tall, balancing his slight frame upon that single good leg, refusing to let his left sole touch the floor.

Then, he did something that caused the air to leave my lungs.

He let the wooden walking stick drop. It clattered loudly against the floorboards, rolling against the metal leg of the examination couch.

Freeing both his hands, he brought his palms together in front of his chest, pressing them flat against one another in the ancient, universal gesture of Vanakkam, a salutation not of social deference, but of deep, unadorned veneration. He bowed his head so low that the back of his neck, with its prominent vertebrae standing out like stones in a dry creek, was completely exposed.

Great, silent tears broke once more from the corners of his eyes, falling unchecked down through his gray stubble, splashing onto the starched white front of his shirt.

"Ayya, enna idhu..." I began, instinctively reaching out to steady him, thinking his balance was failing. "What are you doing? Pick up your stick—"

"Doctor," he interrupted. His voice was no longer a whisper; it was thick, resonant, vibrating with a profound, solemn authority that filled every corner of the small room. "Let this pain in my foot go

away whenever it pleases. If it leaves tomorrow, let it leave. If it stays with me until my last breath, let it stay. That is secondary. That is just flesh and bone, and flesh must rot anyway."

He took a half-step forward, his right knee trembling with the immense strain of holding his seventy-year-old body upright.

Slowly, deliberately, his right arm rose into the air. His hand was large, the skin blackened by years of sun, the palm lined with deep, calloused trenches from the friction of hoe handles and watering buckets. It was the rough, unadorned hand of a village coolie, smelling of damp earth, well-water, and cheap washing soap.

The hand hovered in the air above my seated form, trembling slightly with age and emotion.

In that suspended second, the entire architecture of my professional world dissolved. There was no medical degree, no clinical detachment, no social distance of class, caste, or education. There was only an old man who had looked into the abyss of his own destitution and found within himself an ocean of grace, and a physician younger than him whose hands were suddenly empty of all remedies except his own capacity to receive.

Without a single thought of hesitation, without any self-conscious awareness of my role, I bowed my head forward until my chin rested against my chest.

His calloused palm came down firmly upon the crown of my head.

The touch was not light; it was heavy, warm, and steadying. It landed with the weight of an anchor dropping into still water. The rough ridges of his working fingers pressed through my hair against my scalp, radiating an intense, searing heat that seemed to travel

instantly down the length of my cervical spine, spreading across my shoulders and sinking deep into the center of my chest.

"May the Lord of the Seven Hills protect you," Dayalan whispered, his voice cracking with an unbearable tenderness. "May Ezhumalaiyaan keep you, your children, and your people in complete health and happiness all the days of your life. May no sorrow ever cross the threshold of your home. May these hands of yours, these hands that touched a poor man's dirt, always carry life and healing. May you live a hundred years in peace, my son. May God watch over you."

The words were not an ordinary polite parting; they were an asirvatham, a benediction pulled up from the bedrock of the human spirit.

Beneath the pressure of his palm, a violent, involuntary shiver rippled across my skin. My heart began to pound against my ribs with terrifying force. A sudden, suffocating tightness seized my throat, cutting off my breath, and hot, uncontrollable tears sprang into my eyes, burning behind my closed lids.

The room around us seemed to vanish entirely. The whirr of the ceiling fan ceased to exist; the chatter of patients on the verandah was swallowed up by an absolute, terrifying silence. Time contracted into the small circle of warmth where his skin met mine.

For what felt like minutes, neither of us moved. We breathed together in the quiet room, the seventy-year-old gardener with his palm resting on my scalp, and the clinician bowing before him in silent, trembling reverence.

Finally, slowly, the warmth lifted.

His hand drew away. I heard the soft rustle of his thundu as he straightened himself.

I lifted my head slowly, blinking through the blur of my own tears, and reached for a tissue from the desk to wipe my face.

Dayalan did not say another word. He bent down, picked up his tamarind walking stick from the floor, and tucked it beneath his left arm. He gave me a single, quiet nod of absolute understanding, a look that acknowledged everything that had just passed between us without needing the clumsy vehicle of language.

He turned toward the door.

I rose from my chair and walked to the entrance of the room, holding the green curtain back with one hand, watching him as he moved down the central corridor of the clinic.

Scrape. Pause. Scrape. Pause.

The uneven rhythm of his blue rubber slipper was still there. The hitch in his left hip still lifted his shoulder with every third footfall. The physical reality of his lesion remained unvanquished by the morning's encounter.

Yet he did not walk like a broken man.

He walked down that long, red-oxide corridor with his chin lifted high, his frail chest expanded against the frayed fabric of his shirt, moving steadily through the shaft of bright, golden sunlight that slanted through the open archway at the building's entrance. The other waiting patients on the wooden benches, the young mothers, the farmers with their sprains, the old women waiting for their

hypertension pills, fell silent as he passed, parting their feet to give his dragging slipper a clear, unobstructed path.

At the top of the outer verandah steps, he paused for a moment beneath the blazing morning sky. He adjusted the folded thundu over his narrow shoulder, planted his tamarind stick firmly upon the first stone step, and stepped down into the dust of the village road, carrying both of our spirits out into the vast, luminous heat of the world.

Chapter 16

The silent saint of the temple town

I like my solitude. I enjoy silence. But when I am done being alone and silent, I like to occasionally go out to the temple and just sit there and watch people as they move about playing the role of a devotee. My favourite spot in the temple is the massive flight of grand stairs that lead up to the dance performance theatre of the temple. Constructed some 1000s of years ago, this dance theatre has intricately carved pillars and an elevated pedestal on which the artist performed. People would sit anywhere in the theatre, and they could all view the artist without the pillars obstructing the view. That was the brilliance of the architecture. Sitting on that stairs gave me a perfect vantage point. I could see pilgrims who entered the temple from the main gopuram to my left, and follow them through the temple courtyard between the main gopuram and the sanctum to the right, and finally watch them as they disappear into the much smaller gopuram into the sanctum. On festival days it would be crowded and people would appear like rows and rows of ants marching along the courtyard. On other days, people would trickle in randomly. There are three shops in the courtyard, a vendor selling flowers, fruits, coconuts, betel

leaves and vilva leaves for the worship, another vendor selling clay lamps filled with clarified butter with cotton wicks and a third vendor selling sweets and savories offered to the God inside the temple, being sold as prasadam. Mondays, Tuesdays and Thursdays are always good business days for these vendors as devotees buy their goods for offering to the Gods. After offering prayers to the Gods, I liked to sit in my vantage spot and watch people as they go about their work. Around noon after the prayers, the temple priest feeds some of us regulars, the food that is offered to the God. It is usually tamarind rice, curd rice, and on occasional days it is sweet Pongal. After sharing that meal with other fellow devotees in the temple I return home, back to my solitude and silence.

In this divine temple town, one never goes to bed hungry. There is always food offered in the temple at noon and at night. There is an ashram of a holy saint nearby, where food is served to devotees three times a days on all days, free of cost. There are hundreds of other householders in the town who readily feed the poor, needy and travellers passing by the temple town without asking for details or money. The owner of the house where I live, never creates trouble if I default on my monthly rent payments. I pay the rent when I have money, and just pay a visit to his house and explain my situation on other months. I have no wife, no children, no family to call my own. Nobody is born without a father and a mother, so I must have had them too, but I don't know them, nor do I vaguely remember meeting or being with them. On the days that I give up the practice of solitude and silence, and am not in the temple either, I go to do some manual labour in the fields of land owners in the villages nearby. I enjoy sweating and working in the hot sun in the fields as much as I like my solitude and silence. I cut and remove the weeds from the paddy fields, I till the land with the help of bulls, I sow the seeds and water the plants. I also help in

harvesting the paddy, threshing it and removing the grains. When I am engrossed in this work, I lapse into solitude and silence. My body moves vigorously with physical labour and the mind remains absolutely quiet. At the end of such a hard day's work, I go home, bathe, go to the holy saint's ashram, have the hot kanji and sleep like a log of wood. My life is simple, I have minimum needs, I have no pressures.

One day I decided to go to the Reddiyar fields to do agricultural labour. I got up early at 6 AM, went to the fields nearby to finish my morning duties, took bath, got ready and came back home. As I was getting ready to leave to the bus stand where the agents of Reddiyar fields would come and pick us up, I felt a sudden stabbing pain in my head. Suddenly the whole world started reeling below my feet. I lost my balance, my vision blacked out and I fell with a loud thud.

"Dr. Arul Murugan, kindly report to the emergency room…" The public announcement of the hospital was going on. Dr. Arul Murugan was the Emergency Duty Medical Officer on call that day in the government district hospital.

Having finished his specialization in emergency medicine, he had joined government medical service and had been posted to his home district.

"Tell me about the case doctor"

"Good morning sir. This is a 45 year old man, brought by the emergency medical technician just 10 mins ago. He was found unconscious at home by the neighbours. They say it must have happened within the past one hour. Non responsive, pupils are dilated and asymmetrical. Shallow and laboured breathing. May require intubation" said the duty doctor.

“Prepare the intubation tray, get a ventilator ready. Alert the anaethesia team. He will also require a CT scan of the brain immediately”

As Dr. Arul Murugan went closer to the bed and looked at the patient, a look of recognition passed across his face.

“This is Jeeva… everyone in this town knows Jeeva… Hurry hurry…let us mobilize him for the CT Brain immediately”

Dr. Arul Murugan skillfully inserted the endo-tracheal tube into unconscious Jeeva’s throat, and fixed it to a bag and started pumping air into his lungs. The junior doctor and he moved the trolley towards the CT scan console. The radiography team took over and wheeled Jeeva along with the trolley into the CT room. Within moments Jeeva’s brain images appeared on the screen.

“Massive intra-cranial hemorrahge. Bleeding inside the brain… Fortunately no midline shift. There is no immediate threat to life” the radiologist sitting in front of the screen remarked.

“Thank you doctor, we are wheeling him back to the emergency room to stabilize him now” Dr. Arul Murugan said and started taking the trolley with Jeeva on it back to the emergency room.

Back in the emergency room, the staff nurses fixed Jeeva up on to the ventilator. The anaethesia team took over and adjusted the ventilator settings. The ventilator started hissing, pumping air rhythmically into Jeeva’s lungs. The staff nurses surrounded Jeeva and started setting him up with tubes to feed him, give him intravenous fluids, drain his urine and some wires to record his pulse, blood pressure and electrical activity of the heart. Within minutes Jeeva was completely surrounded by tubes, equipment and gadgets, totally unrecognizable to an outsider.

“Jeeva has no relatives. I don’t know whom we can talk to. Who brought him in?” Dr. Arul Murugan asked.

“The emergency medical technician brought him in doctor. Shall I call him?” said the staff nurse.

“Please call him sister. Let me ask him”

The emergency medical technician came in. Dr. Arul Murugan asked him about any relatives, or anyone responsible for Jeeva. The emergency medical technician had no clue.

“I know Jeeva has nobody. We have to take care of him in the hospital” said Dr. Arul Murugan.

It was well past ten in the night when Dr. Arul Murugan finally pushed through the front door of his home. The scent of steamed idlis and fresh coriander chutney met him in the hallway, a comforting warmth that contrasted sharply with the cold antiseptic air of the government hospital.

His wife, Meenakshi looked up from the dining table as he set down his medical bag with a heavy sigh. She read the shadow of fatigue across his face immediately.

“You look troubled, Arul,” she said, rising to pour him a glass of warm water. “Was it a difficult shift?”

Arul sank into a wooden chair, rubbing the bridge of his nose. “We had an admission this morning. Jeeva... you know him, don’t you? The man who sits on the grand stairs near the temple dance hall?”

Meenakshi paused, the brass tumbler held mid-air. “Jeeva? The quiet man who never asks anything of anyone? What happened to him?”

“A massive brain bleed. He collapsed alone at home. He is completely comatose, hooked up to a ventilator, breathing only because of the life-support systems.” Arul looked up, his voice cracking with a rare vulnerability. “The worst part isn’t the bleed, Meenu. It’s that in that entire crowded hospital, he has nobody. No family. No one to hold his hand or sign his consent forms. When I looked at him lying there, lost in all those wires, it felt as though he had simply slipped away from the world unnoticed.”

Meenakshi stood quietly for a long moment, the silence between them settling like fine dust. Then, she walked over and placed both hands firmly on his shoulders.

“He has not slipped away, Arul. And he is not alone.”

Arul turned his head, questioning. “What do you mean?”

“The hospital requires a guardian, doesn’t it?” she asked softly, her eyes clear and resolute. “Tomorrow morning, I am going with you. I will sign whatever papers need to be signed. I will be his guardian, Arul. A man who has lived gently in our town all these years will not fight for his life without someone standing by his side.”

By eight the following morning, Meenakshi sat on a low plastic stool right beside Jeeva’s bed. She smoothed the hospital sheet over his chest, gently adjusting the edge of the blanket around his weathered hands of a man who spent his life clearing paddy weeds and tilling stubborn earth. Taking out a small paper package of sacred ash from her handbag, she pressed a pale white streak gently onto his forehead. Closing her eyes, she whispered verses of Thiruvasagam, her voice blending into the persistent hiss of the ventilator.

By mid-morning, the ward began to shift. The usual hospital stillness fractured as quiet, hesitant footsteps echoed outside the glass doors.

The vendor who sold vilva leaves and coconuts at the temple gate arrived first, his hands wrapped in damp cloth, clutching a small garland of fresh vilva leaves. Behind him came the old lamp-seller, the faint aroma of clarified butter lingering on his white veshti.

“Doctor thambi,” the flower vendor called out softly, catching Arul Murugan as he walked between beds. “Can we see him? Just from the doorway?”

Arul stared at them, startled. “How did you all know?”

“Word moves fast when an empty spot appears on the temple steps,” the lamp vendor murmured, his palms folded together. “He never missed the Pradosham day prayers. When he wasn’t there yesterday, we went looking. Doctor, please tell us he will wake up. We brought prasadam from the inner sanctum. We have performed an archana in his name.”

Arul Murugan felt a lump rise in his throat as he granted permission. One by one, the vendors stood at the foot of the bed, whispering prayers, leaving the fragrant holy vilva leaves on the side table. Arul stood back by the nurse’s station, watching in silent astonishment as the quiet solitude Jeeva had cultivated over decades began to unveil a vast web of unseen connections.

Around midday, the glass doors swung open again. An elderly woman, draped in the coarse saffron saree worn by the resident devotees of the holy saint’s ashram, leaned heavily on a bamboo walking stick. Her weathered face was etched with deep lines of worry. The moment her gaze landed on Jeeva’s motionless frame beneath the machine, she collapsed onto her knees beside his bed.

“Jeeva, my child...” she cried, her voice cracking with raw, unvarnished grief as tears streamed down her cheeks. “Wake up. Who will help carry the heavy rice sacks to the kitchen before dawn? Who will sit in the quiet corner and eat with such peace?”

She reached trembling fingers out to touch his cold feet, weeping openly without restraint. “Lord, spare this innocent soul! Take what little breath I have left, but give this boy his life back!”

The emotional weight in the room was overwhelming. Two junior nurses lowered their heads to wipe away tears. Meenakshi knelt beside the old woman, wrapping an arm around her shaking shoulders and whispering words of solace, while Arul Murugan stood rooted to the spot, deeply shaken by the intensity of the woman’s love for a man who had possessed nothing.

Before the ashram mother could be led out to rest, another visitor arrived. Dressed in a simple cotton saree, carrying the unmistakable poise of a village matriarch, the wife of the land owner from the Reddiyar fields stepped into the unit. She carried a small silver pendant touched with kumkum.

“Doctor,” she addressed Arul, her voice steady but her eyes brimming with warmth and concern. “My husband sent me as soon as we heard. When Jeeva did not report for the weeding season at dawn, we knew something terrible had happened.”

She walked over to the bed, gazing down at Jeeva with immense tenderness. “In all our years running the agricultural estates, we have never seen a soul like him. He was the most sincere, hard-working man in our fields. When other laborers took shelter from the midday heat, Jeeva would be out there, quietly moving his hands, lost in his work, asking for nothing beyond his honest daily

wage. He would never complain, never gossip, never show greed. He is a gem of a man. If the hospital needs anything, medicines, special doctors, money, the Reddiyar family will bear the entire cost. Just bring him back to us."

Later that evening, after the visiting hours had concluded and the ward had settled back into its muted evening routine, Arul Murugan and Meenakshi stood together on the quiet hospital balcony, looking out over the illuminated gopuram of the distant temple.

"I have practiced medicine for years, Meenu," Arul murmured, his gaze distant, "and I thought I understood people. I thought I knew what an abandoned life looked like. Jeeva told everyone he preferred his solitude and silence. He had no wife, no children, not a single blood relative to claim his name. I truly believed he was utterly alone. I thought you and I are his only care givers"

He turned to his wife, his eyes reflecting the soft evening twilight.

"Yet today, I realized how blind I was. Though he lived in silence, his presence carried so much weight. He never raised his voice, yet the whole town listened for his footsteps. He had no family, yet a mother from the ashram wept for him as her own son. He owned no land, yet the landowners hold him in reverence. He is wanted. He is cherished. So many pure souls are pulling him back from the brink with their tears and their prayers."

Meenakshi smiled softly, leaning her head against his shoulder. "Love doesn't always announce itself with noise, Arul. Solitude is only an outward circumstance. In his silence, Jeeva sowed seeds of goodness wherever he went. Now, the harvest of those prayers has to bear fruit."

The dawn that followed brought a sudden, decisive shift in the ICU.

As Arul Murugan began his morning rounds, the nurse on duty waved him over urgently, her eyes wide. “Doctor! Come look!”

On the monitor, the spiky green spikes of the electrocardiogram were beating to a calmer, steadier cadence. More strikingly, the ventilator’s alarm chimed softly—not in panic, but signaling that the patient was beginning to trigger his own breaths, fighting past the mechanical cycle.

Beneath the white tape holding his endotracheal tube, Jeeva’s eyelids twitched. His fingers, resting over the crisp sheet, curled inward, grasping weakly at the fabric. A faint, low groan escaped his throat.

“Jeeva?” Arul Murugan called out, his voice sharp with professional focus yet layered with personal hope as he took his pupil torch. “Jeeva, can you hear me? Squeeze my hand if you can hear me.”

The rough, callused fingers on his right hand moved, slowly tightening around the doctor’s palm.

Over the next forty-eight hours, the recovery unfolded with astonishing speed. The swelling in the brain subsided, the ventilator was successfully weaned and detached, and the tangle of tubes gave way to a simple oxygen cannula resting beneath his nose.

When the dark, heavy veil finally tore away from my mind, consciousness did not return as a gentle morning dawn, but as a dull, jarring ache that anchored me fiercely to this world. My eyelids felt like leaden weights, fluttering open against a white, blinding glare that stings my hazy vision, and the very first breath I drew

was met with a harsh, agonizing scrape, a raw, burning, grating sensation deep in my throat, the leftover trauma of a plastic tube that had forced life into my chest while I was gone.

Every inch of my flesh was stiff, sore, and throbbing, as though every muscle had been turned to hardened clay, an overwhelming exhaustion settled so deep into my bones that even drawing air felt like tilling stubborn soil under the midday sun. Where was I? This was an unfamiliar area. It looked like the district hospital. Yet, rising beneath this physical agony was an astonishing, inexplicable stillness, a tranquil river of profound peace washing over my spirit, because the cold, sterile air of this hospital room was filled with an unmistakable, overwhelming warmth.

Through the blurring mist of my eyes, shapes resolved into faces, and I realized I was completely enveloped by an ocean of pure human kindness; standing right beside my bed was a gentle woman with sacred ash in her hair who smiled at me like a caring guardian, flanked by a young doctor. Was that Dr. Arul Murugan? The young boy who used to run in the temple? His eyes were shining with triumphant relief, while just beyond the glass partition I saw the familiar, wrinkled face of the ashram mother wiping away joyful tears, the land owner's wife from the Reddiyar fields pressing her palms together in heartfelt gratitude, and the temple flower vendor holding up a small sprig of holy vilva leaves with trembling hands.

A quiet pang of panic fluttered through me amidst the tenderness, for all my life I have guarded my solitude like a sacred treasure, and in this crowded, noisy display of affection, my soul yearned desperately to retreat. I wanted nothing more than to slip away from their gazes, to flee back into my silent rented room, to return to the simple rhythm of my life where I belonged. I wanted to walk through the temple gates, sit on the high granite steps of the

thousand-year-old dance theatre, and silently watch the devotees move in rows like ants beneath the towering gopuram; I craved the hot, fragrant tamarind rice ladled into my hands at the holy saint's ashram, and the quiet dignity of sweating beneath the open sky, removing weeds and threshing paddy in the Reddiyar fields until my mind fell completely silent.

But when I silently resolved to stand up, to slip out of these tangled sheets and walk back to the quiet life I knew, my body refused to obey; a terrifying numbness gripped the left side of my body, and when I willed my left fingers to twitch, nothing responded. My left arm lay entirely motionless, as limp as a severed branch, and my left leg felt impossibly heavy, frozen like a great stone slab buried in the earth, refusing to shift even a fraction of an inch against the mattress. Trapped between a body that can no longer walk away and a room overflowing with an unasked-for, boundless love that refused to let me be forgotten, I could do nothing more; my throat choked on words that did not form, and in complete, helpless surrender to this strange new dawn, I slowly, quietly blinked.

Chapter 17

Masala Milk

Every Tuesday morning at precisely quarter to nine, the rusted iron gate of the rural clinic shuddered as if struck by a small artillery shell.

This was not an earthquake. It was merely Bala braking his second-hand Hero Splendor.

The motorcycle was held together primarily by grease, black electrical tape, and divine mercy. Perched pillion on this mechanical relic was Mr. Elumalai, eighty years of age, sitting completely side-saddle, holding a bamboo walking stick in his left hand like a king's sceptre, and waving his right hand to every stray dog, roadside tea-seller, and bewildered cow along the bazaar road.

"Dei…Bala! Brake gently!" Elumalai's roar could drown out the twin-stroke roar of a tractor. *"Do you want my back bones to jump out of my throat and scatter across the road?"*

"Thatha," nineteen-year-old Bala mumbled, his face turning the precise shade of a ripe local tomato. He was already mortified. Three

young schoolgirls in green pinafores were staring at them from across the road. Bala lowered his head, wishing he disappeared *"I told you to hold my waist. You were waving at the vegetable vendor."*

Elumalai hopped off the back of the bike with an agility that made an absolute mockery of his bamboo walking stick. He was lean, dark as roasted coffee beans, clad in an immaculate white veshti with a gold-thread border, and a pastel blue safari shirt that had four button pockets—all of them bulging with mysterious bits of paper, dried betel nuts, and mint lozenges. His snow-white moustache was twirled at the ends into two defiant needles.

Bala, whose hands were permanently stained with black machine oil from the tractor repair shed down the highway, wiped his palms nervously on his jeans. "Thatha, please. Today at least, just sit in the waiting hall quietly. Don't start."

"Start what?" Elumalai adjusted the crisp fold of his veshti with grand innocence.

"The last time head nurse Valli threw a steel kidney tray at you."

"She didn't throw it at me, she dropped it because my smile was so charming," Elumalai retorted, puffing out his narrow chest. "Now go. Go to your grease-pit. Earn some rupees so we can buy groceries. And remember, on your way back from the town, take the diversion near the TASMAC liquor shop. A quarter of the green bottle. Not the red one. The red one tastes like kerosene mixed with mosquito coils."

"Thatha! The doctor said no alcohol!" Bala whispered urgently, looking around as the clinic's sweeper began dragging her broom across the veranda.

“The doctor doesn’t know, Bala. When he was born, I was already drinking brandy. Go! Don’t be late for the workshop. An unemployed grandson is an insult to the family honour.”

Bala sighed, a long, heavy, defeated sigh that sounded far too old for a nineteen-year-old boy, and revved his motorcycle, shooting a trail of blue smoke toward the sky as he fled.

Elumalai turned around, spun his walking stick in a jaunty circle like Charlie Chaplin, and marched straight into the clinic through the swinging doors.

Inside, the clinic was humming with the usual morning chorus of babies wailing, coughs echoing, and the faint, unmistakable smell of floor cleaning liquid and antiseptic soap. But the moment the door swung open, the entire nurses’ counter froze.

Nurse Sarala, twenty-four, in her clean white saree, saw the white moustache first and groaned theatrically. “God protect us. The 80 year old hurricane has arrived.”

“Good morning, my lotus blossom!” Elumalai proclaimed, abandoning his walking stick entirely and carrying it under his arm like a swagger stick. He leaned against the waist-high wooden partition, propping his chin on his hands, beaming with a smile that showed twenty-four surprisingly intact teeth. “Look at you, Sarala. Are you trying to give this old man a heart attack before he even sees the doctor?”

Sarala tried to maintain a stern professional scowl, but her lips twitched. “Elumalai thatha, please. Take token number seven and sit down on the bench. Don’t crowd the counter.”

“Token number seven? Impossible. Seven is an unlucky number for romance. Give me token number one. Or better yet, give me your hand in marriage, and we will tear up all the tokens together. We can run away to Ooty. Have you ever seen the mist rolling over the hills?”

From behind the filing cabinet, Nurse Valli, who was forty-five and had witnessed three decades of local rascals, poked her head out with an ink-stained ruler. “Elumalai thatha! Stop it now! Stop pestering these poor girls. If you have so much romantic energy, why don’t you find a nice girl for that quiet grandson of yours? The poor boy looks at the floor whenever he steps inside this gate!”

“Bala?” Elumalai scoffed, waving a dismissive, aristocratic hand. “The boy is made of wood, Valli. Absolute timber. A block of teakwood. I look at him and I wonder if the hospital swapped him at birth. He has no song in his soul! He talks to motors, he whispers sweet nothings to brake shoes. If I don’t flirt on his behalf, the family lineage will end like a dead-end street.”

Sarala giggled, leaning across the counter. “That’s because Bala has manners, thatha! He is handsome, tall, and shy. If he smiled at a girl the way you do, she might actually say yes. But you, you are a nuisance! You should be chanting Rama Rama in your age, not flirting with young girls!”

“A man who chants prayers has given up on life,” Elumalai declared proudly. “A man who looks at pretty eyes is keeping his circulation alive. Look at my pulse!” He thrust his bony wrist across the counter toward Sarala. “Feel it! Steady as a temple drum. Come, check it. Take all the time you need.”

“Go sit down, you old man!” Valli barked, though she was chuckling into her clipboard. “Go, before Doctor Vikram comes out and hears your nonsense.”

“Doctor Vikram…,” Elumalai murmured, winking at Sarala as he finally took token number seven. “Smart doctor. But entirely too stingy with his prescriptions.”

Ten minutes later, the wooden door of the consultation room swung open, and Doctor Vikram poked his head out. He was an earnest, sharp-eyed physician in his early thirties, whose hair was prematurely thinning.

“Elumalai thatha,” Doctor Vikram called out. “Come inside.”

Elumalai immediately hunched his shoulders, dragged his right foot as if it had suddenly transformed into fifty kilos of solid granite, and leaned heavily upon his bamboo cane. He let out a theatrical, trembling groan that turned heads across the waiting hall.

“Aiyo... Doctor... slowly, slowly. Life is departing my bones.”

Doctor Vikram rolled his eyes, holding the door open. *“Save the drama for the local drama troupe, thatha. Two minutes ago I heard you telling Sarala that you could marry her.”*

“A temporary urge doctor…,” Elumalai said smoothly, gliding past him into the consultation room and dropping into the wooden patient chair with an agonizing sigh. “Love can conquer mountains, but my creaky joint conquers love.”

Vikram sat behind his desk, clicking his ballpoint pen. He pulled Elumalai’s case file toward him. It was remarkably thick for a man who had never undergone surgery. Most of it consisted of clinical

notes scrawled in hurried blue ink: Patient demands analgesics. Vital signs normal. Refuses lifestyle modification. Avoid sleeping pill prescriptions.

"So," Vikram said, looking at the old man over his spectacles. "What is it today? Let me guess. The body pain that only appears after sunset? The backache that vanishes when the village temple festival starts?"

"The knees, Doctor. The knees," Elumalai whimpered, clutching both knees through his white veshti. "Like two rusty grinding stones rubbing together. Grrr-grrr-grrr. Day and night. I cannot sleep. I cannot walk. I wept like a child. Ask Bala!"

"Bala isn't here to lie for you," Vikram noted. "And your blood pressure today is 125 over 80. Your pulse is 72. You have the cardiovascular system of a young man. Let me see your knees."

Vikram stood up, walked around the desk, and knelt down. He manipulated Elumalai's right knee. He bent it, extended it, and pressed the joint lines.

"Ouch! Aiyo! Muruga!" Elumalai yelled, wincing dramatically.

"Thatha…," Vikram said, entirely unimpressed. "I'm pressing the muscle on your calf, not the joint."

"The pain is there also, Doctor! It travels! It is a very clever pain."

Vikram let out a dry laugh and returned to his chair. "You don't have severe arthritis, thatha. You have mild age-related wear and tear. You just want pills."

Elumalai's eyes instantly lit up. He leaned across the desk, lowering his voice to a conspiratorial whisper. "Doctor... just a small sheet of

those white tablets. You know the ones. The ones in the silver foil with the red stripe. The round white ones."

"Paracetamol?"

"Yes! Paracetamol! Ah, what a beautiful word. Sounds like music. Pa-ra-ce-ta-mol. Just write twenty tablets. Thirty if your heart is generous today. My joints are thirsty for it."

"No," Vikram said flatly, capping his pen.

"Doctor! Why this cruelty?"

"Because," Vikram leaned forward, pointing his pen at Elumalai's chest, "I know exactly what you do with them. You take two paracetamol tablets, and wash them down with half a tumbler of TASMAC brandy!"

"That is medicine!" Elumalai argued passionately. "That is an ancient recipe! The alcohol opens the veins, the tablet soothes the nerves."

"Paracetamol and alcohol together are poison for your liver. You take paracetamol like candy because you say it gives you a 'light feeling' in your head. That 'light feeling' is not health, thatha. That is getting high on drugs!"

"Doctor, please," Elumalai wheedled, clasping his hands together in supplication. "Just ten? Five? Two tablets for emergencies? What if a terrible storm comes and the bridge floods and my knees lock up like rusted padlocks?"

"Not a single pill," Vikram said firmly. He tore off a prescription slip. "I am not giving you any oral painkillers. None. Zero. If I see you

swallowing painkillers with liquor, I will call the village headman and have Bala lock you in the shed."

Elumalai slumped back into the chair, his face a portrait of profound tragedy, as though he had just been sentenced to life imprisonment. "You have no pity, Doctor. A young man with a stone where his heart should be. When I die of knee agony, my ghost will come and haunt you."

Vikram smiled. He wasn't entirely heartless; he knew the old man had lost his son and daughter-in-law fifteen years ago, had raised the timid boy Bala with fierce devotion, and lived a solitary, quiet life in a small village house where laughter was the only thing keeping the silence at bay. But he also wasn't going to let the old man destroy his liver.

"I am not leaving you in pain," Vikram said, scribbling on the pad. "I am prescribing you an ointment. A gel."

Elumalai squinted suspiciously. "What gel? Doctor, but it is the knees that are dying."

"A topical painkiller. Diclofenac gel. It comes in a blue and white tube. You take a small pea-sized amount, do you understand me? A pea-sized amount, and you rub it gently onto the skin over your knees twice a day. The medicine goes through the skin directly into the joint. It does not go through your stomach. It does not go to your liver. And most importantly," Vikram tapped the desk with his knuckle, "it will not give you any 'high'"

Elumalai picked up the paper, turning it over as if searching for a hidden clause. "Rubbing? Just... rubbing?"

“Just rubbing. On the skin. External use only. Can you read what it says?”

“I can read Tamil and English, Doctor, don’t insult my schooling,” Elumalai muttered sourly. “External use only. Blue tube. Very well. If modern science has reduced its miracles to cold grease, I will endure it.”

“Good. Give this to Bala. Let him collect it from the pharmacy outside. And don’t flirt with Sarala on the way out; she has a lot of work to do here.”

“Flirting is not an activity one schedules, Doctor,” Elumalai said with dignified poise as he stood up, entirely forgetting his limp until he reached the doorway, where he hastily resumed dragging his leg. “It is an involuntary reaction to beauty.”

For the first four days, all was peaceful at the rural clinic.

Doctor Vikram saw hundred patients a day, treated scabies, diagnosed viral fevers, dressed agricultural lacerations, and scolded diabetic elders who insisted that mangoes were natural and therefore could not contain sugar.

Then, on Friday morning, the clinic doors parted timidly.

Bala stood there, clutching his greasy mechanic’s cap in his hands. He was still wearing his navy-blue work shirt, his sleeves rolled up over forearms smudged with diesel oil. He hovered near the nurses’ desk like a ghost afraid of intruding on the living.

“Bala?” Sarala called out, her voice softening immediately. Unlike his grandfather, who demanded total attention, Bala seemed to occupy as little space in the universe as humanly possible. “What happened? Is Elumalai thatha sick?”

"No, sister," Bala murmured, shifting his weight from one foot to the other. "He... he sent me to get another tube of that gel medicine."

Doctor Vikram, who was walking out of the injection room with a stethoscope around his neck, stopped dead in his tracks. He checked his watch, then looked at Bala.

"Another tube? Bala, come here."

The boy walked over slowly, keeping his eyes glued to the tiled floor. "Yes, Doctor."

"I gave you a thirty-gram tube of diclofenac gel on Tuesday morning. Today is Friday. A tube that size should last at least three weeks if used twice daily on both knees. Did he drop it? Did it leak?"

"No, Doctor," Bala said, reaching into his pocket and pulling out the tube.

Vikram took it. The aluminum tube was flattened completely, rolled up tightly from the bottom with mechanical precision, and squeezed so dry that not a microscopic speck of gel remained inside. It was completely empty.

Vikram stared at it. "How on earth did he use thirty grams of gel in three days? Did he bathe in it?"

"I don't know, Doctor," Bala admitted, looking genuinely distressed. "He just told me, 'Go to the clinic, tell the doctor my knees are still crying out, and bring another tube.' He made me promise not to come home without it. He said if I didn't bring it, he wouldn't let me inside the house."

Vikram rubbed his chin. Diclofenac was absorbed systemically in very low amounts through the skin, but thirty grams in seventy-two

hours was an absurd quantity. Was the old man smearing it across his back, his shoulders, his hips? Was he using it like sesame oil for an oil bath?

"All right," Vikram said reluctantly. He went to the dispensary counter and signed a chit for a second tube. "*Take this. But tell him to use it sparingly. A thin layer. He doesn't need to apply it generously.*"

"Thank you, Doctor," Bala whispered, taking the tube as if it were a fragile bird, and scurried out the door.

Seven days later, Bala was back.

This time, he didn't even wait at the counter. He stood by Doctor Vikram's open door, looking like a man carrying an unexploded bomb. He pulled two empty tubes from his pockets and set them silently on the doctor's table. Both were rolled down to the cap, utterly drained.

Vikram dropped his pen.

"Two tubes? In one week?"

"He told me to ask for three this time, Doctor," Bala said, his voice trembling slightly with shame. "He said the small tubes are an inconvenience to his daily routine."

"Bala, what is he doing with this gel?"

"I swear, Doctor, I don't know! He keeps the tube in his room. In his wooden cupboard where he locks his ration card and his spectacles. Every evening, he closes the door. When I knock, he says, 'Go away, Bala, I am performing medical therapy.' Then he comes out thirty minutes later, humming old MGR cinema songs,

grinning from ear to ear, and sits on the veranda looking like the king of the world!"

"Diclofenac gel has a sharp, medicinal, wintergreen scent. Does his room smell like an ointment factory?"

Bala paused, cocking his head. "Now that you mention it, Doctor... no. Not really. The room smells like fried onions and his usual snuff tobacco. But outside on the porch, he smells... of warm freshly boiled milk"

Vikram's physician instincts, honed by years of dealing with crafty village elders, twitched violently. Something was terribly wrong.

"Bala," Vikram said, standing up and placing a hand on the young mechanic's grease-stained shoulder. "Listen to me very carefully. Tonight, when your grandfather performs his 'medical therapy', you are not going to sit outside. You are going to look through the window. Or you will listen through the wooden slats of the door. You will find out exactly what he does with that tube. If he is doing something dangerous, we need to know. Do you understand?"

Bala swallowed hard. Spying on his grandfather felt like high treason. Elumalai might have been an eccentric, shameless flirt, but he was also the man who had carried Bala on his shoulders through knee-deep monsoon mud when the boy had typhoid at age six, refusing to put him down until they reached the hospital.

"I will try, Doctor," Bala whispered.

"Don't try. Find out. Otherwise, no more tubes. Understood?"

"Understood."

The following morning was a Saturday, and the clinic was relatively quiet. The morning sun was warm, filtering through the neem trees in the courtyard, casting dappled shadows on the clinic floor. Sarala was sorting through case records, while Doctor Vikram was enjoying a rare cup of hot filter coffee in his office.

The heavy double doors didn't just swing open they flew back against the wall with a theatrical clatter.

"Doctor Vikram! The saviour of the poor and needy! The healer of the downtrodden!"

Elumalai swept into the clinic.

He was not carrying his walking stick. He was swinging it like an umbrella. He was wearing his best cream-coloured shirt, a crisp white veshti tied with a double loop, and a streak of fresh holy ash across his forehead. He practically danced down the corridor.

"Good morning, Sarala, my morning rose!" Elumalai shouted, tipping an imaginary hat. "Did you miss me yesterday? I dreamt of you! We were on a boat in the Ooty lake, and you were feeding me sweet mango slices!"

"Thatha, hush!" Sarala laughed, covering her mouth. "Doctor is inside! And he has been waiting for you!"

"Of course he is waiting! Who wouldn't wait for a ray of sunshine?"

Elumalai pushed open the consultation room door without knocking and strolled inside, seating himself with a flourishing twirl of his veshti. Bala slipped in behind him, closing the door softly and pressing his back against the wall, head bowed, the picture of absolute despair.

Vikram put down his coffee cup. He folded his hands on the desk. He looked at Elumalai, whose eyes were bright, dancing, and entirely devoid of any arthritic agony. Then he looked at Bala.

"Bala," Vikram said quietly. "Did you see?"

Bala looked up for half a second, let out a tiny, choked sound that was half-sob, half-squeak, and covered his face with both hands. "Doctor... please don't make me say it. Please. I will die of shame. The whole village will laugh at us."

"Bala, speak," Vikram commanded, though his own curiosity was now burning at fever pitch.

"Tell him, Bala!" Elumalai broke in, completely unbothered, his chest puffed out like a proud rooster. "Why are you hiding your face like a new bride? It is an achievement! A discovery! I have discovered an entirely new medicine!"

Vikram turned his full gaze onto Elumalai. "What did you do, thatha?"

Elumalai leaned forward, resting his forearms on the desk. He dropped his voice to an intimate, theatrical whisper.

"Doctor. You told me the gel was medicine, correct?"

"Correct. For external use."

"You told me it goes straight into the system to relieve the pain, correct?"

"Through the skin, yes."

"Well," Elumalai smiled, a wide, dazzling, completely unrepentant grin. "I thought to myself: the skin is thick. The skin is stubborn. The

skin has to deal with sun, rain, dust, and mosquito bites. Why make the medicine work so hard to soak through layers of old, leathery skin? Why take the long, winding dirt road when you can take the four-lane national highway?"

Vikram felt a sudden, terrifying cold dread grip the pit of his stomach. His medical degree had prepared him for septic shock, compound fractures, and snakebites, but it had not prepared him for the terrifying ingenuity of an eighty-year-old village romantic.

"Elumalai thatha..." Vikram's voice was barely a squeak. "What did you do?"

"Every evening at seven o'clock," Elumalai explained, gesturing with his hands like a master chef explaining a delicate recipe, "I take a steel tumbler of fresh cow's milk. Boiled. Not too hot, mind you, just warm enough to dissolve the ingredients. I add two spoonfuls of sugar. And then..."

He paused for dramatic effect.

"And then, Doctor, I unscrew your little blue tube, and I squeeze about two inches of that beautiful, clear diclofenac gel right into the milk!"

Vikram's jaw went slack. The pen slipped from his fingers and rolled off the desk, bouncing across the floor with a tiny plastic click.

"You... you what?"

"I stir it!" Elumalai said cheerfully, miming a vigorous stirring motion with an imaginary spoon. "With a steel spoon! Whisk, whisk, whisk! At first, it doesn't like the milk. It sits at the bottom like a little jelly fish. But if you whip it with determination, Doctor, it dissolves

completely. It gives the milk a lovely, smooth, slightly thick texture. Almost like masala milk! A little minty, a little tingly on the tongue. Very refreshing!"

Bala groaned from the corner, sliding down the wall until he was practically squatting on the floor. "He drinks it every night, Doctor. He sits in his easy chair, drinks the whole glass, licks his moustache, and five minutes later he starts singing old MGR songs at the top of his lungs."

"And then?" Vikram managed to choke out, his medical brain running wildly through toxicological databases, half-expecting liver failure, gastric perforations, and immediate cardiac arrest. "What happens then?"

Elumalai threw his head back, his eyes sparkling with pure, unadulterated ecstasy.

"Aahhhhh, Doctor!" Elumalai sighed, clasping his chest with both hands. "The high! The glorious, heavenly high! My toes begin to tingle! A warm wave washes over my belly like a sea breeze at Marina Beach! My knees? What knees? I don't even have knees anymore! I feel like I am floating two inches above the cane chair! The roof of the house disappears, and I can see the stars! When I follow it up with just half a glass of TASMAC brandy... oh, Doctor! It is like Lord Shiva himself came down from Kailash, patted me on the shoulder, and said, 'Elumalai, my friend, forget your eighty years; tonight you are twenty-one again!'"

Silence descended upon the consultation room.

A heavy, thick silence, broken only by the ceiling fan that clicked rhythmically on its downrod: tick-tick-whir, tick-tick-whir.

Doctor Vikram stared at the old man. He looked at the clear, bright eyes. He looked at the steady hands. He looked at the upright posture, the twirled white moustache, the glowing cheeks.

Then he looked at the empty tubes on the desk.

Diclofenac diethylamine gel. Inactive ingredients: carbomer, isopropyl alcohol, propylene glycol, liquid paraffin, fragrance, water.

The isopropyl alcohol and propylene glycol, combined with the hot milk, sugar, and his psychological expectation of a painkiller, washed down with government-proof liquor, had produced a bizarre, minty, placebo-fuelled, mildly intoxicated concoction that had done nothing to kill him, but had entirely convinced the old man that he had discovered the elixir of eternal youth.

The absurdity of it began in Vikram's chest, a small, bubbling tremor that rose through his throat. He tried to swallow it. He pinched the bridge of his nose. He bit the inside of his cheek until he tasted copper. He was a professional. He was a physician. He could not, under any circumstances

A muffled snort escaped his lips.

Outside, the door was slightly ajar. Nurse Sarala and Nurse Valli had been listening at the crack.

From the hallway came a sudden, high-pitched shriek of laughter from Sarala.

That was the dam breaking.

Vikram buried his face in both hands and let out a helpless, roaring burst of laughter that shook his entire desk. He laughed until tears

squeezed out from the corners of his eyes, running down his cheeks and soaking into his collar. He leaned back in his chair, gasping for air, pointing a trembling finger at Elumalai, unable to speak.

In the hallway, Valli was clutching the counter, cackling so loudly that two patients in the waiting room stood up to see if an emergency delivery was taking place. Sarala was bent double, slapping the wooden partition with an empty file folder, laughing so hard she couldn't breathe.

"Masala milk!" Vikram wheezed, wiping his streaming eyes with the sleeve of his white coat. "Masala milk! With topical ointment! Mad thatha! You magnificent, crazy mad thatha!"

Elumalai looked around the room, thoroughly pleased with the reception. He smoothed down his moustache with immense pride, nodding graciously as if taking a bow at the conclusion of a magnificent concert.

"You see?" Elumalai said to the room at large. "A good idea is always appreciated by intelligent people. Even modern medicine must bow before practical experience."

"Thatha," Vikram said, trying desperately to recover his professional composure, though his shoulders were still shaking with chuckles. "Listen to me. Listen very, very carefully. If you drink that gel again, Lord Shiva will not come to you. Lord Yama will! You will burn a hole through your gut! Do you understand? It is for the skin! Skin only! S-K-I-N!"

"Doctor, please," Elumalai waved a dismissive hand. "The stomach is an organ of great resilience. Mine has survived village feast mutton, illicit arrack, and fifty years of my late wife's spicy dried-fish curry. A little white ointment is like baby food to it."

“No more tubes,” Vikram said, slamming his hand down on the desk, though he was still grinning. “Not one. If you ever ask Bala for diclofenac gel again, I will personally prescribe you castor oil. Three bottles. To be taken with warm milk every single morning. Let us see how high you fly on castor oil.”

Elumalai’s face fell instantly. The jaunty sparkle dimed just a fraction. “Castor oil? That is very mean, Doctor.”

“Try me,” Vikram warned, pointing an accusing finger. “Now, stand up. Both of you. Out of my office. Bala, take him home. If he goes near the medicine cabinet, lock him in the shed.”

Bala, whose face had transitioned from pure mortification to a reluctant, broad grin, grabbed his grandfather by the elbow. “Come on, Thatha. Doctor has spoken. No more masala milk.”

“A tragedy,” Elumalai declared loudly, standing up with majestic grace and turning toward the door. “A dark day for the rural clinic. True genius is never understood in its own time.”

He swung open the door and stepped out into the corridor.

Sarala was still wiping tears of mirth from her eyes. As Elumalai passed the nurses’ counter, he paused, leaning over the wooden rail with his customary roguish twinkle.

“Well, Sarala,” he murmured, his voice dropping into a velvety purr. “Since the cruel doctor has taken away my masala milk, I have nothing left to comfort me in my old age. What do you say? Shall we run away to Ooty tomorrow? I will even let you ride the Hero Splendor.”

“Thatha!” Sarala cried, throwing a roll of cotton wool at him, her face radiant with laughter. “Go home! Go home before Bala leaves you behind!”

“He wouldn’t dare,” Elumalai said, catching the cotton ball mid-air with an easy flick of his wrist and placing it dramatically over his heart. “Without me, who would bring poetry into his miserable, grease-stained life?”

He marched down the sunlit veranda, twirling his cane like a baton, whistling a jaunty tune from an ancient cinema reel. Behind him walked Bala, shaking his head, smiling despite himself, carrying the keys to the rusted motorcycle, ready to drive the grandest, most incorrigible flirt in the district all the way back home.

Realities of rural medicine

Chapter 18

Sounds of the stethoscope

Maimoon would always walk into the clinic with her grandson Samad. 54 year old Maimoon was a patient with diabetes and hypertension and took medicines regularly. She lived in our village and had a small meat stall in the nearby town. Her business was small. She would bring just 4-5 broiler chicken, cut them up and sell them and on Sundays she would bring two goats, slaughter them and sell the meat. Her stall would be open from 7 AM till around 12 noon after which she would come home. Maimoon lived alone with her grandson. Her son and daughter in law died due to stampede in a political rally and from then it was just she and Samad.

"Doctor, sometimes I get so worried about Samad. He is only 8 years old now. You must keep me hale and healthy for as long as it takes for me to educate and settle him in life" Maimoon would often tell me.

It was a calm Sunday afternoon. Maimoon and Samad came to the clinic as usual. I liked talking to Samad, a very smart young boy, full of energy and enthusiasm.

"Samad, have you finished all your homework for tomorrow's school?"

"Yes doctor, I finished. One math homework and one science homework."

Samad was in 5th standard in the local primary school. Maimoon did not know much about his educational attainments as she herself had never gone to school. But Samad's teachers appreciated him for his smartness in math and science.

"Doctor, can I touch this and see?"

He gingerly moved his hands towards the digital BP apparatus.

"Go ahead! Do you know what it is?"

"You use it to check patients' BP. I have seen you using it. Can you check my BP?"

"Your hand is too small Samad. I need a much smaller cuff to see your BP. We cannot use this on you. It will hurt."

"It is ok doctor. Please just one time…just one time…"

Samad was jumping up and down with childish enthusiasm and was starting to throw a mini tantrum. I smiled at him and made him sit on the chair opposite me. I took his hand and guided his hand through the BP cuff. The cuff was too big for his tiny hand. I did not inflate the cuff. I put my stethoscope on his elbow and pretended to hear the sounds of blood flowing there. Samad's eyes widened with curiosity. He watched my actions intently.

"How much….how much… tell me doctor…how much" Samad

started chanting!

"Your BP is normal Samad" I said and removed the cuff and rolled it up and put it back on the table.

Samad was thrilled. His eyes were now on my dark blue stethoscope.

"May I please listen to that?"

I got up, moved closer to his chair and placed the stethoscope gently on his ears. Then I gently tapped on the diaphragm of the stethoscope. Samad jumped up from his chair in absolute delight. He whispered, "Do that again…" I tapped gently again and he broke into a wide smile. Then I put the diaphragm on his chest. Samad listened intently. The smile slowly faded and transformed into amusement and awe. He was spell bound. His face had so many excited expressions, like a child riding the merry-go-round for the first time. After some time the magical look on his face faded and he came back to the present. I took off the stethoscope. Samad smiled at me widely.

"That was beautiful doctor. I heard lab-dab-lab-dab. It was nice"

Maimoon had to leave and so she tugged at his arms pulling him away from the clinic room.

"Samad…that is enough. Don't disturb doctor. We must go now" she reprimanded.

"Ayah! No…I will be here with doctor. You go"

I was thrilled to see Samad's enthusiasm.

"It is OK Maimoon bee. He can be here. I will send him during lunch time"

Samad became a regular in the clinic. Almost every Sunday and other holidays Samad would turn up. He would hang around in the clinic. The staff nurses would give him small errands. "Go to that storeroom and bring the blue box of tablets." "Go to the storeroom and bring that packet full of cotton" "Take this patient and make him lie down in the treatment room." Samad would happily oblige. Slowly the hours he spent with us became longer. He would also join us and have lunch with us at the clinic. By the time he came to 9th standard he became very familiar with the clinic and clinic activities. On some days when the staff handling the tokens and registrations was on leave Samad would even note down the names of the patients and issue tokens to them till we find a substitute to come and fill in for her. When one of his friends or school-mates was sick he would accompany them to the clinic and take care of them. He performed extremely well in school and got top marks in his class. It was time for the tenth board exams.

"Samad, you must now think about going to the nearby town for your +1 and +2. What group do you want to study? Math, Science, Computer Science? Math, Science, Biology? Math, Commerce?" I asked one day.

"Doctor, why do you even ask? I want to do Biology and take up medicine just like you."

It was a huge task for someone from the rural background like Samad to take up medicine and become a doctor. There were huge costs involved. Maimoon Bee could barely give him three square meals a day. I did not want to throw water on his dreams.

"Do your tenth board exams well. Let us figure out how to handle higher education."

Samad passed 10th board exams with the distinction of being first in his school and in the entire district. The village school had only up to 10th standard. He had to move to the higher secondary school in the town, which would mean traveling 10 KM daily to school. I had spoken to an educational trust located in the nearby city about 70 KM from their village. They were willing to take Samad to a boarding school for +1 and +2 and also simultaneously prepare him for the medical eligibility and entrance exam. All arrangements were made and Maimoon, her sister's son and I were in the town bus stand sending off Samad to the city.

"Samad, take care. You are a young man now. Study well. I know you will." I said.

Samad stood with a firm look on his face. He was fighting difficult emotions. This was the first time he was leaving the village to stay away. He had never left his grandmother or the village before. Maimoon was also fighting similar emotions. Tears were streaming down her cheeks. But she maintained her composure and stood there.

"Ayah! Take care of yourself. I will come every month"

"Don't worry about me Samad. I will be fine. You must not come here and hide behind my mundhanai anymore. You must be brave and concentrate on your studies" Maimoon said and waved Samad off.

"Doctor, did you hear what Ayah is saying? Take care of her doctor. Thank you so much doctor." Saying this Samad ran to me and gave me a hug. The embrace was warm and sentimental. I was moved to tears. I squeezed Samad into a nice bear hug and sent him off.

Subsequently Maimoon also moved out of the village to go and live

with her sister's son. She came to take leave.

"Doctor, what will I do here all alone. Now that Samad is also studying in the city, my sister has also been inviting me to come and live with her for a long time. So I am planning to live there for some time. Can you write down my medication list and give me a referral to the government hospital there?"

I wrote down a referral and sent her off with good wishes. I did not see her after that. Life moved on. I would randomly think of the enthusiastic kid who would hang around the clinic running errands. But those memories became less and less frequent.

Five years later, one Sunday afternoon I was seeing patients in the clinic. A tall young man walked into the clinic and sat in front of me. He was a handsome young man with sharp eyes and a square jaw. The dense hair on his head was neatly combed back in waves. He wore a white shirt that was nicely pressed and tucked in and a beige colored pant with a thick black belt.

"Good morning doctor, do you remember me? Samad" He introduced himself.

I was pleasantly surprised. He had grown so tall and had completely transformed into a young man. I was hit by a heavy wave of nostalgia.

"Samad! Wow! Long time! How are you? I did not even recognize you"

"I am fine doctor. How are you? A really long time indeed."

"How is Maimoon Bee? Is she still with her sister's son?"

"Ayah is now living with me doctor. I live in the nearby town"

There was so much to catch up. However there was a big crowd waiting outside and I could not spend much time.

“Shall we catch up a little bit later. What brought you here?”

“Doctor, I just came to meet you and say hi…that is all…”

“Come back later, there is so much we must talk” I said and got engrossed with other patients.

Later that evening as I wound up the clinic and left to the bus stand to get my bus to the town, I found Samad sitting in the bus stand. He stood up as he saw me coming.

“I was waiting for you doctor”

“Hi Samad! It was such a pleasure meeting you suddenly this afternoon. How are you? What are you up to nowadays?”

“Doctor, I finished my +1, +2 in the boarding school. I could not clear the medical entrance and eligibility exam. So I joined emergency medicine technician course in the government medical college. I completed the course two years ago. Now I am working as an emergency technician in the ambulance service.”

I looked at Samad with admiration for sticking to his interest in medicine.

“How do you find your work? Is it hectic?”

“Not really doctor. I enjoy my work.”

“That is so good to know”

“I will bring Ayah to meet you next week doctor”

The bus came just as we were talking. We both boarded the bus. Samad bought the tickets for both of us and when I offered to pay for my ticket, Samad looked at me smiled and showed a gesture to indicate that he got it. It was such a proud moment to see the young man being so responsible and mature.

The following week Samad brought Maimoon for a visit.

"Maimoon Bee, how are you? I am so pleasantly surprised to see what a fine young man Samad has grown up to become."

"I am fine doctor. He now takes me to the big hospital in the town and that is where I get my medicines and treatment. He has taken up all responsibilities of our home now. Soon I want to find a nice girl and get him married. Once that is done, I can go to Jannat as soon as Allah calls me!"

Samad patted Maimoon gently on her arm, "Ayah! Don't talk like that. You must be around to see me have children. What is all this talk about maut?"

It was a beautiful day. We shared many light hearted moments recollecting the past.

Six months rolled along and one day Samad walked in with an invitation to his wedding. Samad was going to marry Fareedha, a young 20 year old girl from a village 40 KM from our place.

"The marriage is in the town, and I would be honored if you came doctor. Please do make it."

The wedding hall was an open-air shamiana pitched beside the town's community mosque, bathed in the soft glow of fairy lights and fragrant with jasmine, and simmering biryani. It was simple,

unpretentious, and crowded with the warmth of extended family, neighbors from the village, and a few uniformed colleagues from Samad's ambulance depot.

Samad looked striking in an ivory raw-silk kurta and matching pyjama, a soft golden border running along his collar. The boyish enthusiasm that once filled the clinic corridors had settled into the quiet dignity of a working young man, though his eyes darted constantly toward the entrance, looking out for familiar faces. He saw me and his eyes widened. It was the same wide eyed boy from back in the clinic days!

In the separate enclosure lined with embroidered satin curtains, Fareedha sat surrounded by the women. She was draped in a deep emerald-green bridal silk saree with rich zari borders, her hands intricately patterned in deep amber mehendi. Her mother and sisters fussed around her, adjusting her delicate sheer veil and smoothing the single gold chain that she was wearing. Maimoon Bee sat on a low cushioned armchair right next to her, dressed in a neat lavender silk saree, her silver hair tucked tidily under her headscarf. Her weathered face, etched with decades of hard early mornings at the meat stall, was lit with an unburdened, luminous peace.

The ceremony began with the solemn recitation of verses from Quran by the town Qazi. The gathering fell into a respectful silence as the terms of the Nikahnama were drawn up. When the appointed witnesses went across to the ladies' side to seek Fareedha's formal consent, her soft, clear acceptance repeated three times, carried a gentle ripple of smiles through the partition.

When the Qazi turned back to Samad with the signed document and asked for his declaration, Samad took a breath. His gaze briefly

caught Maimoon sitting proudly across the room, then lingered on me standing alongside his colleagues. His voice was steady, resonant, and clear as he confidently expressed his acceptance three times.

The hall instantly resonated with collective whispers of mubarak, mubarak accompanied by warm smiles and pats on Samad's back. Rose water was sprinkled from slender steel flasks, misting the air with coolness, while plates piled high with sugar-candy and toffees were passed among the guests.

Once the formal religious rites concluded, the divider was drawn aside for the elders' blessings. Samad and Fareedha stood side by side on the small stage, framed by garlands of white jasmine. When Maimoon Bee walked up, leaning lightly on her walking stick, Samad stepped down to help her onto the platform. Fareedha instinctively bent to touch the older woman's feet for blessings, but Maimoon caught her by the shoulders, pulling both bride and groom into a firm embrace. For Maimoon, this was not just a wedding; it was the quiet fulfillment of a desperate prayer. I walked to the couple and embraced Samad. My heart was filled with pride and happiness. I wished the very best for him.

Eight more months passed and Samad came to the clinic. Fareedha walked shyly behind him.

"Doctor, I have some good news to share. Fareedha and I are becoming parents. She is 7 months in the family way"

I was thrilled to hear that but did not have any words to express my excitement.

"Doctor, I want you to check her and bless us"

Fareedha lay resting on the examination cot, her head propped comfortably against the thin clinic pillow. Outside, the midday heat pressed against the windowpanes, but inside the consulting room, the slow hum of the ceiling fan kept the room still and calm. Her hand rested gently over the curve of her belly, her face softened by the quiet anticipation of an expectant mother.

I unhitched the dark blue stethoscope from around my neck. The tubing had grown familiar with years of use, but it carried the very same shade of deep navy that an inquisitive eight-year-old boy had once reached out to touch.

Fitting the earpieces into place, I warmed the diaphragm between my palms and placed it gently over the right lower quadrant of Fareedha's abdomen.

For a few moments, there was only the dull friction of cloth and the slow swoosh of maternal blood flow. Then, sharp and rhythmic, it came through the binaurals: a galloping, unmistakable cadence. Rapid. Resolute. Alive.

My hand stayed steady on her abdomen, and instinctively, my eyes lifted from the examination table.

Standing on the other side of the cot was Samad.

Our eyes locked across the narrow space. In that sudden, suspended glance, the clinic room dissolved. The tall, broad-shouldered emergency technician in his neatly ironed trousers faded away, replaced by an eight-year-old boy in school shorts, standing on his tiptoes with eyes wide as saucers.

"May I please listen to that?"

I could almost see his little fingers gripping the edge of the wooden desk, jumping up and down in absolute delight as the cold metal touched his chest. I could hear the awe in his thin, unbroken voice: "That was beautiful doctor. I heard lab-dab-lab-dab." And behind him, the faint memory of Maimoon Bee, tugging his elbow with meat-stained hands, praying for nothing more than enough borrowed time to see this boy whole and grown.

Samad's eyes welled with moisture, but he didn't blink. A faint, knowing smile touched the corners of his lips. He didn't need to ask what the sound was; he had lived it. The very rhythm that had sparked his boyhood wonder in this very room was now beating inside his wife, carrying his family's future forward.

Without removing the earpieces, I nodded at him, letting the unspoken bridge of fifteen years settle between us. Then, gently lifting the headset, I held it out across the cot, offering the dark blue tubing into his hands. Samad took the earpieces with trembling, steady hands and pressed them into place. As the sound of his child's heart filled his ears, a tear broke loose and tracked silently down his cheek.

Chapter 19

All in its own time

The morning alarm in my room in West Mambalam did not wake me; it merely gave sounds to the tireless routine that was about to start right at 3.30 AM. In the dark, before the water pipes began their metallic groaning and before the city stirred with milk vans and sanitation sweepers, my mind was already out on the highway, dreading the miles.

I lay beneath the yellowed blades of the ceiling fan, watching its cyclical sweep cut through the humid shadows. My limbs felt heavier than the mattress. For two years, this had been the cadence of my days. A hasty splash of lukewarm water on my body, the ironed smoothness of a formal cotton shirt that never stayed crisp past the railway station, the weathered canvas back pack packed with a stethoscope, a notebook and pen, and a strip of antacids for my own burning stomach.

On good days, days that felt increasingly like distant, faded photographs, there was a quiet nobility in this pilgrimage. I would board the train thinking of healing as a sacred errand. I would

romanticize the countryside: the emerald paddy fields opening like green carpets beneath the pale dawn, the flock of egrets trailing behind wooden ploughs, the pure, unhurried air that supposedly washed clean the smog of Chennai. I would tell myself that in that forgotten patch of red earth sixty kilometers southwest, where the asphalt grew fractured and died into dirt, I was a lifeline. I was the one doctor, the repository of hope, the solitary bulwark between a destitute village and the cruel indifference of disease.

Today, however, the mythology was dead.

Today, as I stepped down the stairwell into the humid street of Mambalam where the smell of stale exhaust hung thick in the morning haze, the journey felt like sheer servitude. It felt like an ancient, inherited punishment. I was an ox, tethered by the thick rope through my septum, yoked to an iron plough that dug deep into the hard, sun-baked clay. Behind me stood an invisible master, cracking a switch against my flanks, driving me forward to till land that belonged to someone else, to turn over soil that would yield grain I would never taste, all before the planting had even begun. Slog. Grind. Turn. Return. With no end except the slaughterhouse of indifference.

The train journey from Mambalam to Chengalpattu, and the bus travel from there to the rural clinic, was an endurance trial of the spirit. The state transport bus, a rattling metal carcass painted faded green, groaned under the weight of clerks, laborers, flower sellers, and schoolteachers. I wedged myself into a window seat on the sunny side, the faux-leather upholstery split open to expose brittle, decaying foam that pricked at my thighs.

As the bus lurched onto the highway towards the clinic, diesel

fumes crept through the rattling glass panes, settling in the back of my throat like soot. Every pothole sent a jolt up my spine, a jarring punctuation mark to the thoughts that gnawed at my self-worth.

What am I doing with my life? What am I doing with these degrees?

Not very long ago, in medical college I had the same dreams as every other person in my class. I wanted to wear good clothes, travel in a nice car, and get to an airconditioned hospital chamber. I wanted to see complicated patients, think through difficult algorithms, and make life saving clinical decisions. I wanted a secretary to run behind me with fully booked appointments, trying to wriggle in a patient through a loose crack in the schedule. All my medical college years were spent dreaming of such a life. All the lectures, clinical demonstrations, library studies, poring over pages and pages of medical text books were all supposed to lead to such an important career and life. But it never prepared me for this tiring drudgery.

Out there, in my dream corporate hospital, medicine was an art of precision, style and clinical accuracy; But out here in the field it was an exercise in holding back an ocean of human sorrow with a plastic spoon.

The bus turned off the main arterial highway, leaving the smooth blacktop for the rutted, bone-breaking village link road. Fine, ochre-colored, suffocating dust billowed through the open windows, settling on my hair, my eyelashes, the collar of my shirt. Outside, the landscape flattened into scrubby drylands dotted with thorny seemai karuvelam bushes and dry ponds where cracked mud curled up like dried fish scales. It was a thirsty, neglected land, and its people mirrored its exhaustion.

By the time the bus dropped me at the village junction, my mouth tasted of copper and grit. The sun was barely two fingers above the horizon, yet the heat had already gathered an oppressive, predatory weight. I hoisted my heavy back pack, the strap digging cruelly into the muscle of my left shoulder, and began the five-minute walk down the lane toward the clinic.

My feet moved on instinct, but my mind dragged ten paces behind, screaming in silent protest.

Why do I come here?

The question had become a recurring parasite, burrowing deeper into my consciousness every single week. Am I truly making any difference at all?

The honest answer, the one that made my chest tighten with a hollow, nauseating ache, was an agonizing no.

I did not save lives here. To say I saved lives would be a grotesque lie. Ninety-five percent of the people who waited on the veranda of my clinic were suffering from conditions that required neither an expensive degree nor my presence. They had the ordinary, unglamorous afflictions of poverty and neglect. Seasonal viral fevers that ran their course in four days regardless of my pills. Fungal infections blooming in the folds of their skin from working waist-deep in stagnant ditch-water, which would clear up with soap and dry air, luxuries they could not afford. Scabies among the children because five slept on a single mat. Osteoarthritis in the knees of old women who had carried seventy-pound headloads of firewood since they were twelve, their cartilage ground to dust by the mere act of survival.

What could I give an eighty-year-old grandmother whose spine

was curved like a sickle? A blister pack of paracetamol. A bottle of thick, sickly-sweet red vitamin syrup that was little more than flavored sugar water. A placating lie: "Take this twice daily after meals, Paati. It will soothe the ache."

It was a performance. A ritual. A placebo dispensed to ease my own helplessness as much as their pain. Most of them didn't even need the chemical compounds inside those blister packs; they came simply because the clinic was a space where someone had to sit in front of them, look them in the eye, and listen to the inventory of their miseries.

They came to tell me about the son who had migrated to Tiruppur to work in the textile mills and hadn't sent money in seven months. They came to tell me about the daughter whose in-laws were demanding another sovereign of gold before they would bring her back from her maternal home. They came to weep over crop loans, over the village liquor shop that swallowed their husbands' daily wages, over the shame of an empty rice pot. My consultation room was not a place of clinical diagnosis; it was a secular confessional, a septic tank into which a broken village dumped its collective grief.

And when they weren't weeping, they were angry.

They had every right to be angry, but their rage, blind and desperate, found its easiest target in me. I was the face of the system, the sole representative of an authority that had abandoned them to drought and darkness.

I remembered yesterday with burning clarity. An old man, his eyes clouded with mature, milky cataracts, had slammed his fist on my wooden desk until the hand sanitizer bottle rattled. He had stood

there in the doorway, shaking with an incoherent, trembling fury, shouting at the top of his lungs:

"What kind of doctor are you? Look at this place! No scanning machine! No blood tests! You hand me these little chalky white tablets for my chest pain? If I had five hundred rupees in my hand, do you think I would step foot into this shed? I would take the express bus to the big hospital in Chengalpattu! I would go where real doctors work, where they have machines that beep, where they give injections that actually cure a man! We come to you because we are beggars, and you treat us like beggars!"

His words had hung in the stagnant air of the clinic long after his family had dragged him away. You treat us like beggars. The accusation had carved straight through my ribs, not because it was true, but because his despair was so violently accurate. He didn't want my empathy. He wanted the miracles of the modern world, the gleaming chrome and blinking lights that money bought in the city, and all I had to offer him was a wooden table, a stethoscope cold against his skin, and kindness. What is kindness but a consolation prize to the loser in the race?

With every step toward the clinic, the weight of the invisible yoke pressed harder into my shoulders. My head pounded. I felt entirely stripped of dignity, a hollowed-out vessel masquerading as a professional, trapped in a pointless cycle of rural stagnation while my batchmates from Madras Medical College were posting photos from fellowship conferences in London, Chicago, and Melbourne.

I should resign, I thought, the bitterness turning sour on my tongue. I should leave this place to rot on its own terms. I should take a quiet job in an urban polyclinic, sit in an air-conditioned cabin, treat wealthy neurotics with mild indigestion, and never see a dirt

road again.

Lost in the venom of my own despair, I rounded the final bend of the red path.

The clinic was a single-story brick structure painted in bright red colour, roofed with corrugated tiles that turned the interior into an oven by midday. Surrounding it was a low, whitewashed boundary wall topped with iron wires, and an old, wrought-iron double gate that swung open to admit patients.

Except today, the gate was not open.

Right across the narrow iron threshold, sprawled in absolute, defiant majesty, sat an enormous water buffalo.

I stopped dead in my tracks.

She was an absolute mountain of an animal. Her hide was dark as slate, coated in a thick, dried armor of grayish river silt that had cracked into geographical patterns across her flanks. Her enormous belly was pressed flat into the cool dirt of the gateway, her front legs neatly tucked beneath her brisket, her massive, sweeping horns curving backward like the crescent sickles of a village farmer. She occupied the entrance with mathematical precision; her broad skull rested near the left post, while her heavy, mud-caked haunches barricaded the right. There was not a single inch of clearance on either side. A stray cat could not have squeezed through without brushing against her bulk.

I stood there in the blinding dust, my back pack sagging in my hand, staring at the beast. It felt like the final, mocking insult of an intolerable morning. The universe, having already crushed my

spirit on the bus ride, had now materialized a two-ton, breathing wall of stubbornness to physically bar me from the very misery I had dreaded entering.

"Hey!" I shouted, taking a step forward and clapping my hands loudly. "Shoo! Thallu! Erumai Maadu! Get out of the way!"

The buffalo did not move a muscle. She did not even acknowledge the sound. Her large, wet, dark eyes remained half-lidded, gazing serenely through me toward the distant scrub trees. Her black snout, moist and beaded with droplets, flared once, letting out a warm, slow puff of air that stirred the dust at her hooves. Her jaws were working with leisurely, hypnotic regularity, rhythmically grinding a wad of cud from side to side—crunch, slide, grind, pause; crunch, slide, grind, pause.

"I said move!" I snapped, my voice tightening with an irrational, bubbling rage.

I took two hurried steps toward the hedge, searched among the thorn bushes, and found a thick, fallen branch of a neem tree. It was four feet long, heavy enough to serve as a cattle staff. I stripped off the smaller twigs with a furious jerk, walked back to the gate, and brought the blunt end down hard against her rear flank.

Thwack.

The sound was hollow, like striking an old, stuffed leather sofa.

The buffalo did not flinch. She did not jump. She simply flicked the tassel of her long tail, swatted a horsefly from her haunch with lazy, effortless precision, and continued to chew.

"Get up, you wretched creature!" I yelled, dropping all decorum,

prodding her ribs with the stick with all the strength left in my arms. “Get up! Patients will be here in twenty minutes! The clinic keys are in my pocket! Get up!”

The stick bent against the thickness of her hide, nearly splintering in my hands. The buffalo slowly rotated her head toward me. Her gaze was fathomless, utterly vacant of malice, yet completely impervious to my will. It was the look of an ancient, immovable element of the earth—a mountain enduring the drumming of a woodpecker. She closed her eyes entirely, lowered her chin to the dust, and let out a soft, dismissive snort.

My heart was racing, my shirt now thoroughly plastered to my back with sweat. The absurdity of it was suffocating. Here I was, a man with twelve years of schooling, five and a half years of rigorous clinical training, five years of clinical practice experience, three years of post graduate study in a premier institution, certified by the National Medical Commission to diagnose illnesses and prescribe medicines, standing in the dirt, screaming at a farm animal that weighed four times my weight, completely powerless.

Across the narrow lane, beneath the thatched awning of the village tea stall, the morning crowd had been watching this spectacle with quiet, humorous fascination.

The stall was run by Vedachalam, who stood behind an enormous, hissing brass boiler, pouring milk between two steel tumblers in long, frothing arcs. Sitting on the weathered wooden bench out front were three regulars: Murugan, a dryland farmer whose weathered, sun-darkened skin looked like cured leather; Selvam, a burly young man who drove a rented tractor during the plowing season; and old Thangavelu, the retired village tailor, whose thick, wire-rimmed spectacles hung from his neck by a dirty piece of twine.

Seeing the young city doctor engaged in mortal combat with a sleeping buffalo, Murugan set his half-empty glass of tea on the bench, wiped his mustache with the back of his hand, and chuckled.

"Doctor," he called out, his voice rich with rural amusement. "You cannot treat a buffalo like a city dog. That stick will only make your arms tired. Leave her to us."

He stood up, hitched his faded blue-checked lungi above his knees, and strode across the road with the broad, rolling gait of a man who dealt with stubborn beasts every day of his life. Selvam and the tailor followed, eager for a diversion before the heat of the day drove everyone indoors.

"She belongs to the milkman down by the tank," Murugan said, assessing the animal with an appraising squint. "A good milker, but stubborn as an old mother-in-law. Brute force won't do it. You have to tempt them. Even beasts have their weaknesses."

Murugan hurried around the back of the clinic wall, where the drainage from the hand-pump nourished a lush, wild patch of grass. He returned in a moment carrying an enormous, dripping bundle of the tender shoots in his arms, the roots still clinging to wet black loam.

He knelt in front of the buffalo, maintaining a cautious distance from the sweep of her horns, and thrust the fragrant green bouquet toward her wet muzzle.

"Look here, Thaye," Murugan cooed in a gentle, singing voice, as though he were coaxing a recalcitrant toddler. "Look what I have for you. Tender grass, fresh from the water. Sweet and green. Come on, rise. Just three steps to the ditch, and the whole bundle is yours.

Up, up, my golden one... come along..."

He waved the grass under her nostrils, backing away slowly toward the roadside, creating an enticing green trail.

The buffalo opened one heavy eyelid. She flared her nostrils, drawing in the sweet, earthy aroma of the fresh cuttings. My breath caught in my throat; for a second, I thought the simple bribery of food would work. I waited for her front hooves to gather under her bulk, for the mountain to shift.

Instead, the buffalo simply extended her long, leathery gray tongue, hooked a small clump of the grass from the very tip of Murugan's bundle, pulled it into her mouth, and began to chew.

Murugan waited. She chewed, swallowed, and then closed her eye again, tucking her snout deeper into her front legs. She had accepted the tribute; she had rejected the transaction. She was not moving an inch.

"Pah!" Selvam barked, stepping forward with a contemptuous scowl. "You talk to her like she's a temple cow, Murugan! She's just a dumb, lazy brute. Kindness is wasted on cattle. They only understand one language, and that's the fear of death!"

Selvam looked around the roadside until he found what he was looking for: a jagged, heavy lump of gray granite, the size of a man's skull, left behind by the road-widening crew. He hoisted the rock high above his right shoulder with both hands, his biceps flexing, his face contorting into an exaggerated, terrifying mask of fury.

"Out of the way!" he roared, lunging toward the beast with a violent stamp of his bare feet that sent dust spraying into the air. "Ei! Saavu-

graki! Get up before I crush your spine! Get up!"

He brought the rock down through the air with terrifying speed, stopping it mere inches above the buffalo's skull, shouting curses at the top of his lungs, his voice echoing off the tiled roof of the clinic. The performance was violent enough to make my own heart leap into my throat; if a man had lunged at me like that with a boulder, I would have fled across the fields.

The buffalo didn't even flinch.

Her cud-chewing continued, uninterrupted, unhurried. Her breathing remained deep, long, and steady. Her ears gave a single, dismissive flick, as though Selvam's roaring were nothing more than the buzzing of an annoying gnat. The rock, the screaming, the posturing, the threats of immediate destruction, to her, they were entirely irrelevant. She existed in a reality where Selvam's rage held no currency.

Defeated and looking foolish, Selvam lowered the rock, his chest heaving, his face dark with embarrassment. "She's deaf," he muttered, kicking the dirt. "Or mad."

"No, no, it's not fear she needs, it's confusion!" shouted Thangavelu, the tailor. He had unfurled a large, black, bat-winged umbrella. He ran up to the gate, frantically popping the umbrella open and closed in front of the beast's face—snap, click, snap, click—while shouting shrill, high-pitched nonsense syllables: "Hup-hup-hup! Get up!! Run!"

By now, two schoolboys in khaki shorts had stopped to watch. One of them found an empty kerosene tin in the ditch and began beating it rhythmically with a dry bamboo stake, creating a deafening, metallic clatter that set all the stray dogs in the lane to barking.

For forty-five minutes, the threshold of the clinic was transformed into an absurd, sweaty carnival of human futility.

We were four grown men, two boys, and an assortment of sticks, rocks, grass, umbrellas, and noise, screaming ourselves hoarse under a rising sun that was already turning the morning into a furnace. We coaxed, we bribed, we threatened, we pleaded, we banged on metal, we jumped up and down in the dust.

And through it all, the obstacle remained absolute.

The buffalo simply lay there, immovable as the granite hills of Chengalpattu, perfectly content in her stillness, digesting her morning meal, indifferent to the desperate schemes of men who believed that the world must move whenever they commanded it.

I stood on the periphery of the madness, clutching my bag, my temples throbbing with a blinding, white-hot headache.

I looked at my watch. It was past eight-thirty. Already, three women carrying infants had gathered down the lane, sitting in the meager shade of a neem tree, waiting for the clinic to open. An old man with a bandaged leg was limping slowly toward us, leaning heavily on a wooden crutch.

The pressure inside my chest reached a breaking point. It wasn't just about the gate anymore. It was about everything. It was about my mother's disappointed voice when I left the house even before the day broke; it was about the years spent studying while my friends built fortunes in corporate jobs; it was about the endless, thankless stream of patients who would soon cross this threshold to complain that I was not enough, that my medicine was not enough, that this clinic was an insult to their human dignity.

I felt a sudden, terrifying urge to drop my bag in the dirt, fall to my knees, and weep like a child.

The futility of trying to move this animal was the exact same futility I felt every day inside that whitewashed room. I was trying to shove an unyielding world into a shape I desired, and the world was simply sitting there, chewing its cud, refusing to budge.

"Stop," I whispered.

No one heard me over the clatter of the kerosene tin.

"Stop!" I shouted, louder this time, my voice cracking with exhaustion. "All of you, just stop!"

The tailor paused, the umbrella half-open in his hands. The boy lowered his stick from the tin can. Murugan and Selvam turned to look at me, their faces dripping with sweat, bewildered.

"Leave her," I said, my voice dropping to a dull, defeated murmur. I dropped the neem stick into the weeds. "It's no use. Just leave her alone."

Selvam spat into the dust. "Doctor, we can fetch a tractor from the mill. We can tie a heavy nylon rope to her hind legs and drag her into the ditch—"

"No," I said, shaking my head slowly. "No ropes. No tractors. We are done."

I walked over to the edge of the road, where the ancient roots of a massive banyan tree erupted from the red earth like thick, gnarled serpents. I dropped my heavy canvas bag between two roots, sank down onto the rough bark, and leaned my head back against the massive trunk.

I was finished fighting.

The villagers stood around awkwardly for a moment, looking from the immovable buffalo to the defeated doctor sitting in the dirt. Realizing the spectacle was over, they slowly drifted away. Selvam tossed his rock back into the trench with a muttered curse. Thangavelu folded his umbrella with a sharp click, and the men trudged back across the lane toward the tea stall, their sandals slapping softly against the dirt.

A profound, unnatural silence descended upon the road.

The screaming was gone. The clattering tin was silent. The dust, kicked up by an hour of frantic, desperate thrashing, began to drift slowly downward, settling in a soft, golden layer over the weeds, the road, and my polished black shoes.

The heat hummed quietly in the air. From the high branches of the banyan tree, the rhythmic, metallic trill of cicadas rose and fell like a slow pulse. A gentle breeze, smelling faintly of dried straw and cow dung, drifted across the fields, cooling the sweat that was drying on my neck.

For the first time since I had stepped off the bus, I stopped thinking about what I was supposed to be doing. I stopped looking at my watch. I stopped measuring the passing minutes against an imaginary standard of professional efficiency.

I simply sat. And I watched.

The buffalo was still there, of course. But stripped of our frantic shouting and desperate demands, she no longer looked like an enemy, nor did she look like an obstruction deliberately placed there to torment me.

She looked... peaceful.

Her hide rose and fell with a rhythm as steady as the tide. She was breathing in the morning air, untroubled by past regrets or future appointments. She was completely, unapologetically rooted in her own existence. She had not blocked the gate out of malice, or spite, or defiance; she had simply found a patch of earth that felt cool in the morning shade, and she had claimed it.

We had brought an entire arsenal of human anxiety to bear against her: the seduction of sweet grass, the terror of crushed stone, the madness of shrieking umbrellas. We had insisted that she must move now, this second, because our schedules demanded it, because the world would fall apart if the clinic doors did not swing open at precisely nine o'clock.

And she had ignored every single bit of it, because nature does not run on human timetables.

Ten minutes drifted by in that heavy, shimmering stillness. The world felt paused, suspended in amber.

Then, without any external warning, without a single sound from the road, the buffalo stopped chewing.

Her ears, which had been flat against her skull, twitched forward. She took a deep, shuddering breath, her ribs expanding until her hide stretched taut, and let out an enormous, rumbling groan, a sound that seemed to come from the very bedrock beneath her belly.

Slowly, deliberately, she shifted her weight. She extended her rear hooves backward into the dirt, planted her front knees firmly into the earth, and with a tremendous, muscular heave of her immense shoulders, she began to rise.

Her rear quarters came up first, a mountain of black muscle lifting toward the sky. Then, with a grunt that stirred the dust around her muzzle, she straightened her forelegs and stood fully upright.

She was magnificent in her full height. She stood in the center of the threshold, arched her long spine, and stretched her body from horns to tail, letting out a low, satisfied snort. Then, with a vigorous, shuddering shake of her entire frame, she rattled the dried mud from her flanks, sending a shower of gray dust cascading to the ground like rain.

She did not look at me. She did not look at the iron gate she had held hostage for an hour.

She took one slow, deliberate step forward onto the lane. Then another. With the unhurried, rhythmic majesty of an empress who owned the earth, she turned left and began to amble slowly down the margin of the road, heading toward the cool, muddy waters of the irrigation tank where her herd was grazing in the distance.

Within thirty seconds, she was fifty paces away, her tail swinging like a pendulum, her heavy black silhouette melting into the morning heat shimmering off the road.

The gate was empty. The iron latch hung loose, swinging slightly in the morning breeze. The threshold was completely, undeniably clear.

It was as though the obstruction had never existed at all.

I remained seated on the banyan roots for a long, quiet time, staring at the patch of disturbed dirt where she had lain. The imprint of her heavy belly was still visible in the dust, along with the scattered, crushed remnants of Murugan's green grass.

A strange, quiet laughter began to bubble up from deep inside my chest, not the bitter, sarcastic laugh of cynicism, but a clean, light sound that washed through the dark corridors of my mind like water.

All that sweat. All that screaming. All that righteous, furious indignation.

We had nearly broken our backs, our voices, and our dignity trying to force that animal to move. We had threatened her with destruction and tempted her with riches. Yet none of our violent interventions had moved her by a single fraction of an inch. She had moved only when she was ready. She had risen only when her rest was finished, when the internal clock of her own massive, quiet body signaled that it was time to walk.

The gate hadn't required an army. It hadn't required a boulder.

It had simply required time.

I looked down at my hands, resting open on my knees. The tension that had coiled like an iron spring in my neck and shoulders had dissolved. The phantom yoke—the agonizing, suffocating feeling of being an ox driven beneath the whip of an uncaring master, had broken.

How blind I had been.

I had spent months tormenting myself with the thought that my work here was meaningless because it did not produce dramatic, immediate triumphs. I had looked at the unending stream of poverty, the chronic ailments, the old people whose broken bodies I could not rebuild, and I had felt like a failure because my pills could not perform miracles.

I had been standing in front of human suffering just as I had stood in front of that buffalo: screaming, prodding with little sticks, demanding that complex, ancient, heavy realities immediately rearrange themselves to suit my desire for professional validation.

I thought of the old man who had shouted at me yesterday, demanding modern machines and expensive city doctors. His rage was not an indictment of my skill; it was simply the heavy, immovable sorrow of his own fading life, a burden he had carried for decades until he had nowhere left to set it down except upon my desk. Why had I felt the need to fight that? Why had I taken his pain and turned it into a weapon to flog my own self-worth?

The vast majority of human ailments, both of the flesh and of the spirit, are like that resting buffallo.

The viral fevers do not vanish because a doctor wills it; they break when the immune system, in its own mysterious, methodical cadence, finishes its quiet war within the blood. The torn ligament does not knit because of an injection; it knits cell by microscopic cell, indifferent to the patient's impatience or the doctor's schedule. The grief of a mother who has lost a child, the bitterness of an abandoned father, the terror of a farmer watching a drought-stricken sky, these are not puzzles to be solved with a clever clinical algorithm. They are heavy, brooding presences that sit across the threshold of human life.

You cannot batter them out of the way with anger. You cannot always bribe them into disappearing with false cheer.

Sometimes, the highest duty of a physician is not to cure, not to conquer, not to perform theatrical miracles with stones and sticks. Sometimes, the only gift we have to offer is the humility to sit by the roadside, to keep watch, to bear witness, and to hold the space

open until the sorrow, in its own slow, heavy, inscrutable time, finds the strength to rise and wander away.

I stood up from the banyan roots. The air was hot, but the suffocation in my lungs was gone. I picked up my old bag, brushing the red dust from its worn seams, and walked across the empty road.

I pushed the iron gate open. It creaked on its rusty hinges, a familiar, welcome sound.

As I climbed the three whitewashed steps onto the clinic veranda, the old woman with the cough looked up from her place on the concrete floor, her hands folded in a quiet greeting.

“Doctor,” she murmured, her voice like dry leaves. “We thought you weren’t coming today.”

I unlocked the wooden door, swung it open to let the morning light flood the dim, quiet room, and smiled at her.

“I was delayed, Paati,” I said softly, setting my bag upon the wooden desk and reaching for my stethoscope. “Come inside. Tell me…”

Chapter 20

The debt of life

At sixty-five, Maragatham measured barely four feet and ten inches, her spine slightly curved from a lifetime of bending over earthen stoves, lifting heavy cooking vessles, and washing them at the stone cistern. Her silver-streaked hair was coiled into a loose, practical knot at the nape of her neck, perpetually damp with sweat and scented with dried jasmine flowers and coconut oil.

Across the low-walled courtyard sat Mani. At seventy, he was no taller than his wife, his frame spare and dried out by decades of dry-land farming, resembling an aged tamarind root, gnarled, tough, but deeply anchored. A pair of thick, scratched spectacles sat crookedly on the bridge of his crooked nose, tied behind his ears with thin cotton twine so they would not slip when he leaned over the farm fence or weeded the brinjal patch.

To anyone passing the blue wooden gate of their tiled-roof house in the quiet outskirts of the village, they looked like two halves of a weathered seed. They moved in an unspoken, synchronized rhythm. When Maragatham sighed, Mani would reach for the

metal tumbler of boiled water; when Mani coughed against the morning chill, Maragatham's hand would already be reaching into the wooden spice chest for crushed pepper and dried ginger.

They had brought seven lives into the world, three sons and four daughters. Once, the long mud-brick corridor had echoed with squabbles over aluminium plates, crying infants rocked in cotton saris suspended from rafters, and the frantic bustle of marriages and ear-piercing ceremonies. But time had acted like a slow, patient sieve. The children grew, studied, married, and drifted away to the humming district towns and concrete suburbs where schools had English names and apartments had security guards. All seven were settled, respectable, and occupied. They sent money by wire transfer every quarter and visited during Pongal and Deepavali, bringing store-bought sweets in glossy cardboard boxes. For three days, the old house would groan under laughter and luggage, and then, with the roar of taxi exhausts and promises to call on Sundays, silence would settle back over the clay tiles like thick dust.

Maragatham and Mani were left alone. And in that loneliness, they did not wither; they simply closed the perimeter around one another.

"Maragatham, it is past eight," Mani called out from the doorway, his voice thin and raspy. He held a steel saucer containing two small white tablets and a capsule half-red, half-yellow. "Leave the broom. Enough of all your work. Take the medicine."

Maragatham did not stop sweeping. The dry rush of the broom against the mud courtyard continued rhythmically. "Wait, ayya. Just five minutes. If I don't sweep these fallen leaves now, the wind will scatter them right back onto the porch."

Mani walked down the stone steps, his slippers slapping against his heels, and stood directly in her path. “Every day the same battle. You think these tablets are sweets I hand out for fun? The doctor in the hospital said your blood is sweet like sugar syrup and the pressure is very high. Take it.”

She straightened up, wincing slightly as her lower back protested, and wiped her brow with the faded edge of her cotton sari. A defiant smile softened the deep creases around her mouth. “You worry too much, ayya. Look at me. Do my hands shake? Am I fainting? I cooked the rice, I ground the coriander on the stone, and I walked to the temple pond and back at dawn. Why do you look at those laboratory papers as if they were horoscope charts written by Yama himself?”

“Because the numbers don’t lie, woman!” Mani barked, though his eyes betrayed his panic. “Five hundred! That’s what the machine said last month. Five hundred! The doctor looked at me as if I were starving you or poisoning you. ‘Periyavarey,’ he told me, ‘with sugars like this, blood vessels turn to glass. And her pressure—one hundred and seventy! How can a human heart pump against a wall of stone?’ That is what he asked me. What answer do I have?”

“Those doctors only know how to read little black needles and digital meters,” Maragatham retorted lightly, taking the pills from his palm anyway and tossing them into her mouth. She chased them with a gulp of water from the tumbler he held out. “They don’t know what it takes to run a house. A body that moves is a body that lives. When I lie down dead, my pressure will be zero. Until then, let me do my work.”

“Don’t speak of dying,” Mani muttered, his throat tightening. His hand lingered on her wrist, feeling the dry warmth of her skin. “You

know I cannot even find my spectacles without you. Who will boil my water? Who will sit on the threshold in the evenings? Don't say such words."

Maragatham looked into his rheumy, terrified eyes and her tone softened. She patted his trembling hand with her rough fingers. "Nothing will happen to me. God still has chores left for me here. Go, wash your feet. I will set the cold rice and buttermilk for you."

Yet beneath her blithe defiance lay an exhausting truth she never confessed. For the past two weeks, a strange, sour heaviness had taken root behind her breastbone. It was not a sharp cut, but a dull, spreading weight, like a sack of damp grain resting on her chest whenever she hauled water from the well. She had blamed it on indigestion, chewing seeragam seeds and dried ginger after meals, fiercely willing the ache to dissolve before Mani noticed the gray pallor creeping onto her temples.

The rupture came on a Tuesday night, two hours past midnight.

The village was submerged in the thick, suffocating darkness that precedes the monsoon rains. The ceiling fan creaked on its iron hook, slicing the hot, stagnant air with a low, rhythmic moan.

Mani woke to an unnatural sound. It was not the familiar creak of a door or the distant bark of a stray dog, but a wet, rattling gasp.

He reached out blindly in the dark. The straw mat beside him was cold.

"Maragatham?" he whispered, his chest tightening instantly.

No answer came, only another ragged, suffocating intake of breath

from the floor near the wooden pillar. Mani scrambled off the cot, his knees cracking, and fumbled for his glasses on the bedside stool. His hands were shaking so violently he knocked over a metal jug, which clattered loudly against the floor. He struck a match, his fingers burning before he managed to light the small kerosene lantern.

The yellow wick flickered to life, casting long, grotesque shadows against the lime-washed walls.

Maragatham was sitting slumped against the pillar, her knees drawn up, both hands clutching her throat. Her face was drenched in a cold, oily sweat that caught the lamplight. Her lips, usually pink from betel leaf, were a ghastly, bruised violet. Her eyes were wide, vacant, staring into the dark corner of the rafters as if an invisible intruder were pressing both knees into her chest.

"Maragatham!" Mani cried out, falling to his knees beside her. The stone floor bit into his joints, but he did not feel it. He grabbed her shoulders; they were clammy and freezing despite the stifling heat of the room. "Maragatham! What is it? Speak to me! Is it your stomach? Where does it hurt?"

"Ayya..." she breathed, the word barely a scrape of sound against her dry tongue. "The... the air... it won't go in. It feels like... like someone is stepping on my ribs. Ayya..."

"Hold on. Hold on, I am here. Don't close your eyes!" Mani shouted, his voice cracking into a high-pitched, child-like shriek.

He stumbled across the room to the wall niche where his old button phone lay plugged into a frayed charger. His fingers were stiff with terror. He pressed the speed-dial button for their eldest son, Murugan, who lived twelve kilometers away on the outskirts

of the town where he worked as a supervisor in a granite quarry.

The line rang. Once. Twice. Three times. Every electronic chime felt like a spade scooping earth over a grave.

“Pick up, Murugan, pick up, for God’s sake, pick up...” Mani wept aloud, rocking on his haunches.

“Hello? Appa?” Murugan’s voice was thick with sleep, edged with mild irritation. “What is it at this hour? Is everything alright?”

“Murugan! Run! Bring the car and come!” Mani wailed, abandoning all restraint. “Your mother is dying! She cannot breathe! She is turning blue on the floor! Come quickly, my son, please, please run!”

There was a sudden rustle of sheets on the other end, followed by the clatter of a knocked-over chair and a woman’s alarmed query in the background. “Appa, don’t panic! I am taking the neighbor’s car. Keep her upright. Don’t let her lie flat! I will be there in twenty minutes!”

Twenty minutes stretched into an eternity carved out of raw terror. Mani dragged Maragatham onto his lap, propping her back against his narrow chest. He wiped her brow with the hem of his veshti, murmuring prayers, incoherent promises to village deities, and desperate apologies. “I should have stopped you from sweeping, Maragatham. I should not have let you walk to the pond. Please, just breathe. Take a deep breath. Look at me. I am here. Don’t go away.”

Her eyes fluttered. Her small fingers reached up and weakly tangled themselves into his shirt. She could not speak, but her grip was desperate, pleading, holding onto him as if he were the only solid

rock in a violently churning sea.

Headlights swept across the frosted glass windows, blinding and yellow, accompanied by the violent crunch of gravel outside. The front door burst open, and Murugan ran in, his shirt half-unbuttoned, his face pale beneath the stubble.

"Amma!" Murugan cried, dropping to his knees. He slipped his arms beneath her small frame and lifted her. She weighed almost nothing, a bundle of brittle bones and faded cotton. *"Appa, open the back door of the car! Move!"*

They threw her into the back seat. Mani climbed in beside her, pulling her head into his lap, cradling her skull against his ribs while Murugan reversed the car out of the narrow lane, the engine howling as he floored the accelerator toward the rural clinic five kilometers away.

The rural primary clinic was a squat, whitewashed concrete building bordered by overgrown bushes. At three in the morning, only a single yellow tubelight buzzed outside the casualty entrance, casting a pale, sickly light over the cracked asphalt.

Murugan honked the horn continuously, the blare shattering the nocturnal quiet of the village road. He leaped out, threw open the back door, and scooped Maragatham into his arms, carrying her through the rusted screen doors.

"Sister! Doctor! Someone come out!" Murugan roared into the empty hallway.

A middle-aged staff nurse, Sister Philomena, her white uniform saree rumpled from the night shift, emerged instantly from the observation room. Her eyes took in the scene in a fraction of a

second: the gray, clammy face of the woman, the wide, terrified stare, the shallow, rapid heaving of the chest.

"Put her on the trolley here! Immediately!" she commanded, her voice cutting through the panic with sharp, practiced authority.

Murugan laid Maragatham down. Mani stumbled in behind them, his hands shaking so violently he had to lean against the lime-washed wall to keep from collapsing. His spectacles had fogged up with sweat, blurring the room into smeared halos of harsh light.

"Amma, look at me," Sister Philomena said firmly, wrapping a black blood pressure cuff around Maragatham's limp upper arm with a swift, rhythmic rip of Velcro. She shoved the stethoscope earpieces into her ears and pumped the rubber bulb.

The dial needle trembled. Philomena's brow furrowed. She released the valve, picked up a lancet, pricked Maragatham's ring finger, and touched a glucose strip to the dark bead of blood. The meter gave a high-pitched beep.

HI (>500 mg/dl).

"BP is 210 over 120," the nurse muttered under her breath. She grabbed a bundle of colored wires from a rolling cart. "Don't move her. I am taking the ECG right now."

With practiced, mechanical speed, she swabbed cold blue gel onto Maragatham's chest and ankles, slapping the suction bulbs into place. The machine whirred, spitting out a narrow ribbon of pink grid paper with a rhythmic, scratching chatter. Philomena stared at the paper as it curled into her palm. Her eyes widened slightly; the jagged lines climbed upward in high, distorted peaks, tombstone ST elevations indicating a massive heart attack.

She dropped the paper on the metal cart, turned toward the inner corridor, and ran toward the duty doctor's quarters, shouting, "Doctor! Doctor Mohan! Run to casualty! STEMI! Massive heart attack!"

Mani did not know what STEMI meant. He only knew that the nurse's voice carried the edge of a siren. He crept toward the trolley, his bare feet cold on the tiled floor.

"Maragatham?" he whimpered, reaching out to touch her limp, cold toes.

Her face was distorted, lines of agony carving deep chasms around her eyes and forehead. A thin line of frothy saliva gathered at the corner of her lips. She could no longer turn her head, but her eyes slid toward his voice. Her lips moved, soundless.

Murugan was pacing like a caged beast, running his hands through his uncombed hair, cursing into his phone as he dialed his brothers in the city. "Senthil, wake up! Amma has collapsed. We are at the rural clinic. It looks very bad. Wake up everyone!"

The inner door flew open, and Dr. Mohan hurried in, still buttoning his white apron over a faded polo shirt. He was a young doctor, thirty-two years old, posted to the rural clinic two years prior, a man known in the surrounding ten villages for his patience and his quiet, unhurried bedside manner. But tonight, there was no slowness in his step.

He snatched the ECG strip, his eyes sweeping across the jagged ink tracings. He grabbed his stethoscope, pressed the cold diaphragm to Maragatham's chest, and listened to the wet, bubbling breath sounds filling the bases of her lungs.

“Acute pulmonary edema with anterior wall myocardial infarction,” Mohan said crisply to Philomena. “Draw up forty milligrams of furosemide IV stat. Crush four tablets of soluble aspirin, clopidogrel three hundred, and atorvastatin eighty. We need to load her immediately. Bring high-flow oxygen, ten liters via face mask!”

“Doctor...” Mani stepped forward, his hands clasped together in an agonizing gesture of supplication. “Doctor, please. Is she... is my Maragatham going to live? What has happened to her?”

Mohan looked up, noticing the old man for the first time. He saw the frayed cotton dhoti, the twine holding the broken spectacles, the raw terror vibrating in the fragile old hands. Mohan’s voice dropped from clinical sharpness to gentle, measured gravity.

“Periyavarey,” Mohan said, resting a firm hand on Mani’s shoulder. “Your wife is having a major heart attack. A massive one. Her heart is struggling to pump, and fluid is backing up into her lungs. That is why she cannot breathe.”

“Heart attack?” Mani whispered, the words tasting like lead. “But she was sweeping the courtyard this morning, Doctor! She was cooking!”

“I know,” Mohan said softly. “Her sugars and blood pressure have been very high for years. The damage has been happening quietly inside. Now, listen to me very carefully. I am giving her emergency medications right now to thin her blood and take the fluid off her chest. But this clinic does not have a heart treatment facility. We cannot open the blocked blood vessels here. You must take her to the city hospital, to the tertiary cardiac center right now. Every minute we waste, heart muscle is dying.”

“Can she survive the journey, Doctor?” Murugan interrupted, his

voice trembling from the doorway.

"If we give the loading doses and put her on oxygen in the 108 ambulance, she has a fighting chance," Mohan said, already assisting Philomena as she forced the dissolved slurry of aspirin into Maragatham's mouth with a plastic syringe, urging her to swallow. *"Go, call the ambulance. It is stationed just down the road!"*

Within four minutes, the piercing, dual-tone wail of the ambulance tore through the dawn mist outside the clinic. Paramedics wheeled the heavy stretcher inside. Maragatham, now fitted with an emerald-green oxygen mask that fogged and cleared with her ragged gasps, was strapped down and lifted into the back of the vehicle.

Murugan turned to his father. "Appa, you get in the ambulance. I will follow right behind in the car. Keep this bag with her ration card and Aadhaar card."

Mani climbed into the cramped, vibrating interior of the vehicle, his knees shaking. The paramedic slammed the double doors shut with a sharp, heavy thud that sounded like a prison gate locking. The siren spun up into an ear-splitting howl, and the ambulance lurched forward into the gray light of morning.

The ride was an unyielding nightmare of violent turns, vibrating metal, and flashing red reflections against the wet windshield. Mani sat on the low bench, clutching Maragatham's hand with both of his own. Her skin was still wet and cold, but through the tight, transparent mask, her eyes remained fixed on him.

"I am here, Maragatham," he yelled above the scream of the siren and the roar of the diesel engine. Tears were running freely down his hollow cheeks, dripping from his chin onto their intertwined fingers. "Look at me. Look at your ayya. We are going to the big

hospital. The big doctors will fix it. You just hold on to my hand. Don't let go. If you let go, I am finished. You hear me? Do not let go of my hand!"

Beneath the plastic mask, her lips trembled, and her fingers gave a tiny, desperate squeeze.

The city hospital rose like an impenetrable fortress of glass, steel, and sterile marble. It was a place of dizzying speed, polished surfaces that smelled of chlorine and floor wax, and hurried young people in scrub suits speaking into wireless headsets.

Maragatham was whisked through automatic double doors that slid apart and snapped shut with cruel finality, cutting Mani off at the threshold.

"Sir, you cannot come inside! Stand outside in the waiting corridor!" a security guard barked, holding up a palm against Mani's chest.

Mani bounced off the guard's arm, stumbling back onto the cold linoleum floor of the hallway. He watched the metallic wheels of the trolley vanish around a distant corner, surrounded by six figures in blue scrubs.

Murugan arrived twenty minutes later, breathless, his pockets bulging with papers. The next two hours dissolved into a blur of bureaucratic urgency. Murugan was summoned to counters to provide signatures, swipe bank cards, produce identity photocopies, and purchase heavy plastic bins filled with sterile syringes, arterial needles, and heparin vials from the pharmacy downstairs.

Mani remained rooted to a steel bench beneath a flickering fluorescent light. His hands were clasped between his knees. The noise of the tertiary hospital terrified him, the constant paging of doctors over the intercom, the shrill alarms of monitors echoing

from behind closed doors, the weeping of another family three benches down. He felt small, microscopic, an illiterate speck of dust swept into an unfeeling machine.

At six in the morning, the heavy swing door of the Intensive Coronary Care Unit pushed open. A tall, sharp-featured cardiologist in green scrubs walked out, pulling his blue paper cap from his damp hair.

Murugan surged forward. “Doctor! How is she?”

Mani scrambled to his feet, hovering behind his son’s shoulder like a shadow.

“Are you the sons?” the doctor asked, his voice brisk, clinical, stripped clean of warmth by exhaustion. “The patient had a massive heart attack. The loading dose given at the rural clinic bought her some time, and the IV nitroglycerin has brought her pulmonary edema under control for now. She is stabilized, conscious, and out of immediate danger.”

A deep, tearing sob escaped Mani’s chest. He dropped his head, his hands flying to his mouth. “Thiruchitrambalam… Thiruchitrambalam”

“However,” the doctor continued, his tone cutting straight through Mani’s relief, “the danger is far from over. Her heart function is down to twenty-eight percent. The heart muscle is stunned. We need to take her immediately to the catheterization laboratory for an urgent coronary angiogram. If we find a localized block in the main artery, we will deploy a stent and open it up right away. You need to sign the high-risk consent.”

“A stent?” Murugan asked, checking his watch with a nervous glance. “Will that cure it completely, Doctor?”

“It will restore blood flow to the dying heart muscle if the anatomy is favorable,” *the cardiologist replied crisply*. “We have the cath lab ready. We take her in now. Sign here.”

He handed a clipboard with four printed sheets covered in dense English text to Murugan. Murugan glanced at the clauses, he did not even attempt to read it. His jaw tightened. He turned to his father.

“Appa, the doctor says they have to put a tube inside her to clear the pipe. They need your signature since you are the husband.”

Mani stared at the paper. The English letters danced like black ants across the white sheet. He had studied only up to the fourth standard in the village schoolhouse before his father pulled him out to graze bullocks.

“Is it safe, Muruga?” Mani asked, his voice shaking. “Will it hurt her? Is it the right thing?”

“Appa, they are the biggest doctors in the district! What else can we do? Sign it!” Murugan insisted, his voice frayed by impatience and stress.

With a trembling hand, Mani took the offered pen. He did not know how to sign his name in English. In slow, laborious strokes, he drew his name in Tamil script on the dotted line: **மா. மணி.** His thumb left a faint sweat stain on the paper.

“Good. We are shifting her now,” the doctor said, taking the board and turning sharply on his heel.

Mani watched the door swing shut. He turned to his son, his eyes swimming with tears. “Murugan, stay with me. My legs are like

water. I don't know what these machines are. Sit with me until she comes out."

Murugan's phone vibrated violently against his thigh. He pulled it out, looked at the screen, and grimaced. He stepped aside, speaking into the receiver in a hushed, frantic tone: "Yes, sir. No, sir, I am at the hospital, but my brother Senthil is on his way... No, the cement shipment will be unloaded, I will call the transporter..."

He hung up, exhaled sharply, and rubbed his face. "Appa, look... the factory manager is creating an issue. The audit team is coming today. Senthil and Ramesh are driving from Villupuram, but they won't reach here until afternoon. I have to go to the site for just two hours to clear the trucks and hand over the keys. Then I will come straight back."

Mani stared at his son, his breath catching in his throat. "Now? You are leaving now? Maragatham is inside that room with knives and tubes, and you are going to the stone quarry?"

"Appa, be practical!" Murugan snapped, frustration breaking through his angry face. "Who is going to pay the bills here? Do you know how much this ICU costs per hour? If I lose my job today, how will we pay for her medicines? She is in the cath lab; they won't let you see her anyway. Just sit on this bench. Senthil will be here by two o'clock."

Before Mani could summon the words to plead, Murugan shoved a plastic folder containing Maragatham's identity cards into his father's hands, patted his shoulder once with an awkward, hurried touch, and hurried down the corridor toward the exit.

The glass doors slid closed behind him.

Mani stood entirely alone in the center of the echoing hall. The glossy floor tiles reflected his bare, dusty feet. He looked at the closed gray doors of the catheterization lab. He sat back down on the hard steel bench, pulled his knees close to his chest, and began to wait.

Forty-five minutes passed like drops of boiling oil falling on raw flesh.

Every time the door groaned open to discharge a ward boy carrying trash bags or a nurse pushing a metal cart, Mani would leap to his feet, his spectacles slipping down his nose, peering desperately into the fluorescent-lit chasm beyond.

Finally, the double doors parted, and the cardiologist walked out, accompanied by an assistant holding an unrolled film sheet against the ceiling light. The doctor looked tired, his mouth set in a grim, unyielding line.

Mani rushed forward, his hands folded. "Doctor... Doctor, my Maragatham? Did you clear the block? Is she OK? Can I see her?"

The cardiologist stopped. He looked at the old man, glancing left and right. "Where is the son who was with you earlier?"

"He had to... he had work, Doctor," Mani stammered, feeling somehow guilty for his son's absence. "He is coming back. Tell me, Doctor. I am her husband. Tell me."

The doctor sighed, a weary exhalation that drained all hope from the corridor. He pulled down the plastic transparency and tapped on it with a ballpoint pen. Mani saw only dark, branch-like shadows that resembled tangled tree roots.

“We cannot stent her,” the doctor stated flatly.

Mani’s world tilted. “Cannot? Why, Doctor? Did you drop the tube? Is it broken?”

“No,” the doctor answered, his patience wearing thin under the weight of a long morning roster. “Her coronary anatomy is totally diffuse and diseased. It is not just one simple block that we can squash with a balloon and a metal spring. She has severe triple vessel disease. The Left Anterior Descending is ninety-five percent blocked with heavy calcification. The Circumflex has two serial eighty percent blocks. The Right Coronary is completely occluded. The vessels are too small, too brittle from years of uncontrolled diabetes. If I try to force a wire through that calcium, the vessel will rupture on the table and she will die right in front of us.”

Mani blinked through his scratched lenses, trying to parse the torrent of terrible foreign syllables. “Rupture? Die? But... but you said you would fix it! You said the stent would make her breathe!”

“I said if the anatomy was favorable,” the doctor corrected, his voice firm and cold. “It is not favorable. The only option to save her life is an open-heart procedure. Coronary Artery Bypass Grafting—CABG. A bypass surgery.”

The word hit Mani like a physical blow. In the village, bypass surgery was spoken of in the same hushed, terrified whispers reserved for incurable cancers. It meant sawing open a human chest like a slaughtered goat, draining the blood into a machine, and slicing veins from the legs. It was an operation that only the rich survived, or so the village elders always said.

“Surgery?” Mani cried out, his voice cracking, ringing across the quiet corridor. Tears spilled over his lids, soaking into the gray

stubble on his cheeks. “Bypass? Cut her open? Doctor, she is an old woman! She is barely five feet tall! She cannot survive such a cut! Why could you not remove the blocks? Tell me! Did we do something wrong? Is it because I brought her late? Did I delay on the road? Tell me, Doctor, what did we do?”

“It is not about delay,” the cardiologist said, stepping back slightly from the old man’s hysterical grief. “It is the nature of her diabetes. The blood vessels have degenerated over twenty years. Look, Periyavarey, I have three more patients waiting in the lab. I cannot stand here giving a lecture on pathology. If you want her to live, you need to consult the cardiothoracic surgical team. The bypass will cost somewhere around four to five lakhs. Talk to your sons. Decide quickly. Keeping her in this CCU without intervention is just waiting for the next attack.”

“Doctor, please! Listen to me!” Mani lunged forward, trying to grasp the physician’s white coat. “Can’t you just try to push the stent? Just one stent? We will pray! I will give you everything I have…”

“I cannot do the impossible, Periyavarey,” the doctor said, cleanly disengaging his sleeve from Mani’s grip. “I am a physician, not a magician. The decision is yours. Talk to your family.”

The doctor turned and vanished behind the electronic doors. The latch clicked shut with a dead, metallic finality.

Mani was left standing alone, his outstretched hands grasping empty air. He looked down at his trembling palms. The hospital around him continued its cold, humming indifference. Orderlies pushed laundry bins past him; nurses marched by with clipboards; a television screen in the ceiling corner broadcasted a colorful advertisement for baby soap.

No one looked at him. No one cared that his entire universe, the woman who had shared his home for forty-eight years, was lying behind those walls with vessels like shattered glass.

By the time Senthil and Murugan arrived at two in the afternoon, they found Mani curled on the floor beside the steel bench, his forehead pressed against the cool wall tiles, weeping silently.

The sons held a hurried conference near the staircase. Senthil, who worked as a clerk in a private transport firm, read the discharge summary and the surgical estimate sheet.

"Four lakhs," Senthil whispered, his face drawn. "Even with our savings combined, we cannot raise four lakhs by tomorrow. And what if she doesn't survive the knife? At sixty-five, with her sugars at five hundred, what surgeon will guarantee she wakes up from the anaesthesia?"

"The doctor said keeping her here is costing eight thousand rupees a day just for the bed," Murugan said, staring at the floor. "Appa wants to take her home. He is terrified they will cut her to pieces here."

They made the decision with the cowardice common to families crushed between unaffordable private medicine and impending death. They signed the 'Discharge Against Medical Advice' form.

By sunset, Maragatham was bundled back into a hired taxi, frail, semi-conscious, smelling of iodine and hospital tape, and driven back along the rutted asphalt roads to the village.

The morning sun broke through the neem trees outside the rural primary care clinic, painting golden slats of light across the cracked veranda floor.

Dr. Mohan was seated at his modest wooden desk, writing a prescription for a young mother whose child had a wheeze, when the screen door creaked open.

A small, pathetic procession entered.

Mani was practically carrying Maragatham. He had his left arm looped tightly around her waist, supporting nearly all her meager weight. Her feet dragged slightly, her head resting limply against his shoulder. Her skin had not regained its color; it remained an ash-gray hue, her breath coming in shallow, guarded gasps.

"Mani Appa?" Mohan stood up immediately, dropping his pen. "What are you doing here? She was supposed to be in the cardiac ICU!"

Mani did not speak. He maneuvered Maragatham to the wooden examination couch, gently easing her down onto the thin mattress. He lifted her feet with agonizing tenderness, placing them on the cot, and tucked the faded edge of her sari over her bare ankles.

Then, he turned around.

Mani took two steps toward Mohan's desk, sank to his knees on the bare concrete, and buried his face in the doctor's lap.

A sound tore from the old man's chest that Mohan would remember for the rest of his life, a raw, strangulated howl of pure, unadulterated helplessness. Mani's shoulders shook with violent tremors, his hands clutching Mohan's white apron, soaking the fabric with hot tears and nasal mucus.

"Save her, Doctor..." Mani wept, his words tumbling out like broken pottery. "Save my Maragatham. They threw us out. The big doctors... they looked into her chest and said her vessels are made

of stone. They said they cannot put the stents. They said they have to cut her chest open. They asked for five lakhs of rupees. Five lakhs! Where will I find five lakhs, Doctor? I don't even have five thousand in the post office! My sons looked at the papers and their faces turned white. They brought us back home."

From the examination couch, Maragatham turned her head. Tears were leaking silently from the corners of her eyes, tracing silver paths down into her gray hair. She did not weep loudly; she only looked at Mani's bowed, shaking back with a look of profound, devastating sorrow.

Mohan did not pull away. He did not point to his soiled coat. Instead, he leaned forward, wrapped his arms around the trembling old man's shoulders, and pulled him upward, holding him tightly against his chest.

"Mani Appa, stand up. Look at me," Mohan said softly, his voice thick with emotion. "Stand up. Don't fall at my feet. Stand up."

He hauled the frail old man up and forced him into the wooden patient chair beside the desk. Mohan pulled his own chair closer. He reached out with one hand and held Mani's calloused, shaking palm, while with the other, he reached across the couch and took Maragatham's cold, fragile fingers, joining all three of them in an unbroken circle of human warmth.

"Listen to me, both of you," Mohan began, his voice calm, steady, cutting through the panic like an anchor dropped into a storm. "Listen very carefully. The doctors in the city did not lie to you, but they did not explain it to you properly. Maragatham's heart is like a garden that has three main irrigation channels bringing water from the well."

Mani wiped his spectacles on his shoulder, sniffing, listening with the desperate intensity of a condemned man.

"Over the years," Mohan explained, drawing a simple sketch on the back of a prescription pad, "the mud and weeds have settled thick inside those three pipes. The city doctor tried to push a pipe through to clear the mud, but the pipe walls are too old and brittle. If he pushed harder, the wall would collapse. He didn't fail because of something you did, Mani Appa. You didn't cause this. And Maragatham didn't cause this. It is just the way the river has dried up."

"Then... is there no hope, Doctor?" Mani asked, his lips quivering. "Will the garden die?"

"No," Mohan said, looking directly into Maragatham's fearful eyes. "Because we don't need to force open those ruined, rocky channels. What the heart surgeon does is take a small, clean, healthy vein from her leg, channel that she isn't even using fully, and he stitches it above the block and below the block. It is a bypass. Like when the main highway through the village is under repair, and the buses take the bypass road around the town to reach the terminus. The blood doesn't care about the old channel. It will take the new bypass bridge, and her heart muscle will drink water again."

Maragatham swallowed hard, her voice a fragile whisper from the pillow. "Doctor... will they... will they cut my chest in two?"

"They will make an opening, Amma," Mohan said truthfully, his thumb gently caressing her knuckles. "I will not lie to you. It is a major surgery. But you will be completely asleep. You will not feel a single cut, not a single stitch. There is an entire team of doctors

whose only job during those few hours is to keep you safe, to breathe for you, to watch every drop of blood. Thousands of people older than you, frailer than you, undergo this surgery every single week and walk back home to their families."

"Doctor," Mani stammered, his fingers tightening on Mohan's arm. "You speak with the tongue of God. But what about the five lakhs? The city hospital said five lakhs! We don't have it. My sons... they have their own children, their school fees, their house rents. They cannot bear this huge expense."

Mohan smiled, a quiet, determined smile. He reached into his coat pocket, pulled out his personal mobile phone, and unlocked it.

"Do you have her Chief Minister's Comprehensive Health Insurance Card? The green plastic card?"

Mani blinked. "The... the card the village administrative officer gave three years ago? We have it. It is in the trunk box at home."

"That green card is worth everything right now," Mohan said. "The government scheme covers the entire cost of coronary artery bypass surgery in empanelled hospitals. You do not have to pay five lakhs. You do not have to pay the surgeon's fee, the theater fee, or the ICU bed charges. The government pays it."

Mani stared at him, stunned into disbelief. "They... they pay for poor people like us? The big operations?"

"Yes," Mohan replied. "The big commercial hospital where you went did not want to bother with the government paperwork because the reimbursement takes time. But my closest friend from medical college, Dr. Anand, is the chief cardiothoracic surgeon at the Mission Trust Hospital in the next district. It is a private charity

hospital, and Anand is a great surgeon. He operates under this scheme every single day."

Without waiting, Mohan dialed a number. He put the phone to his ear, tapping his desk impatiently.

"Anand? Mohan here... Yes, my friend, I am fine. Listen, I have an emergency case. A sixty-five-year-old lady from my rural center, Mrs. Maragatham. Massive anterior MI three days ago, stabilized, EF twenty-eight percent. Angio done at City Heart Center shows critical TVD calcified LAD, diffuse Cx, totally occluded RCA. Not candidate for PCI. They DAMA-ed her because they couldn't afford five lakhs... Yes. She is right here in front of me with her husband. They are terrified, Anand. I need you to take her under the CM scheme... Can you? Today?"

Mohan listened, nodding, his face relaxing into deep relief. "Bless you, my friend. I will send her in our ambulance with a nurse right now. Her husband is with her. Please, treat them like my own parents."

Mohan hung up. He looked at Mani, whose tears were now flowing from an entirely different reservoir.

"Go home," Mohan said gently. "Take the green card. Pack two clean cotton dhotis and a towel. The 108 ambulance will take you directly to Dr. Anand's unit. He is waiting for you."

Mani stood up, his whole body trembling. He reached into his shirt pocket and pulled out a rolled, dirty handkerchief, untying a knot with his teeth. Inside were three crumpled hundred-rupee notes and a handful of worn coins.

"Doctor... for your fee... for the consultation..."

Mohan caught Mani's wrist, folded the handkerchief back over the money, and closed the old man's fingers over it. "Keep it, Mani Appa. You will need tea on the journey. Just bring her back to me walking on her own feet. That is my fee."

The Mission Trust Hospital was completely different from the glass palace in the city. Its walls were painted a quiet cream color, the corridors were lined with wooden benches, and large tamarind trees shaded the courtyards.

UDr. Anand met them at the entrance of the pre-operative ward. He was a broad-shouldered man with Mohan's same gentle, listening eyes. He did not look at Mani as an illiterate villager; he pulled up a stool, sat down directly in front of the old man, and spent forty minutes explaining the procedure in pure, unhurried Tamil, using a plastic model of a heart to show where the new blood vessels would go.

For the first time in four days, the ice of terror around Mani's heart began to thaw into resolve.

Yet, a rural family navigating a major tertiary hospital, even under complete government subsidy, soon discovers the invisible financial leaks of such an ordeal. The surgery itself was free, the ICU was free, and the primary medications were covered. But there were the non-formulary disposable skin staplers, the specialized spirometer for lung exercises, the sterile wound dressings that had to be purchased outside, and the cost of Mani's own survival, two hundred rupees a day for canteen meals, a dormitory cot to sleep in, and local travel.

By the fourth day after the successful surgery, when Maragatham

had been safely moved out of the ICU with three new bypass grafts beating steadily beneath her bandaged breastbone, Mani hit a wall.

The pharmacy counter presented him with a bill for specialized postoperative antibiotics and nutritional supplements that the government scheme did not stock: nine thousand eight hundred rupees.

Mani had exhausted the meager contributions his sons had sent. Murugan had stopped answering his calls after sending two thousand rupees via bank transfer, pleading financial ruin. Mani stood outside the hospital gate in the scorching afternoon sun, clutching the yellow billing slips, the heat radiating through his worn rubber slippers. His mind raced frantically. Sell the two goats? It would take three days to find a buyer in the village market, and the pharmacy needed the money by evening to release the discharge medications.

With trembling fingers, he pulled out his old button phone and dialed the number written on the torn margin of Mohan's old prescription.

"Doctor Mohan?" Mani's voice was a frail, ashamed squeak.

"Mani Appa! How is Amma? Anand texted me this morning, he said she walked four steps to the window today!"

"She is... she is walking, Doctor," Mani choked out, tears burning his eyes. *"She looks like she has returned from the underworld. Her face has color again. Doctor... I am ashamed. I want to die of shame for calling you like this."*

"What is the matter, Mani Appa? Speak clearly."

“The hospital... the special medicines that are not in the scheme... the bill is nearly ten thousand rupees. I have run to every relative. I have called my sons. They have turned their faces away. If I cannot pay, they will not give the discharge medicines to protect her new heart. Doctor... can you... can you lend me this money? I swear on the feet of the deity in our village temple, I will work as a coolie, I will cut wood, I will sell my brass pots, but I will return every paisa to you. Please don’t let her die now after coming this far.”

There was a three-second silence on the other end of the line, a silence that felt to Mani like an executioner raising his axe.

Then Mohan spoke, his tone sharp with mild scolding. “Mani Appa, why are you talking about dying of shame? Are we strangers? Listen to me. Go to the cashier’s office. I am doing an online transfer to Dr. Anand’s hospital welfare fund right now from my phone. It will take two minutes. Go stand in the queue. The money will be there.”

“Doctor...”

“Don’t speak. Just go get the medicines. I will see you both when you come back to the village.”

Three weeks later, the morning air in the rural clinic was sweet with the fragrance of blooming jasmine.

The wooden screen door opened, and Maragatham walked in.

She walked slowly, carefully, her back held straight, her hand resting lightly on Mani’s forearm for balance, but she was walking on her own feet. The sickly, bruised violet hue had vanished from her lips, replaced by the faint, natural rose of healthy circulation. Her silver hair was neatly combed, pinned back with fresh white flowers, and her eyes were bright, clear, and alive.

Behind her, Mani carried a small brass container and a woven palm basket covered with a clean white cloth.

"Doctor," Maragatham said, her voice clear, melodious, and steady.

Mohan looked up from his desk and broke into a wide, luminous grin. He pushed his chair back and stood up. *"Look at you! Come, come, sit down."*

He helped her into the chair. He picked up his stethoscope and placed the diaphragm against her chest, right beside the neat, pink, healing vertical surgical scar that peeked out from the neckline of her sari.

He closed his eyes and listened.

Lub-dub. Lub-dub. Lub-dub.

The sound was strong, rhythmic, clear as a temple bell. The wet, terrifying crackles that had choked her lungs three weeks ago were completely gone. The blood was surging through Dr. Anand's bypass grafts, feeding every corner of her resurrected heart.

"Perfect," Mohan whispered, opening his eyes and smiling warmly. "The wound is healing like dry mud after the rain. Blood pressure is one hundred and twenty over eighty. Sugars are one hundred and thirty. Mani Appa, you are taking proper care of her."

Mani beamed, his chest swelling with immense pride. "I don't let her touch the broom, Doctor! I wake up at five, I boil the tea, I chop the vegetables. If she even looks toward the water well, I shout at her!"

"He treats me like a glass doll," Maragatham complained playfully, but her hand stayed wrapped over Mani's fingers on the edge of

the desk, their grip eternal, unbreakable. “He doesn’t even let me carry a plate to the sink. Doctor, you gave me my life back. If not for you holding this old man when he was howling on your floor, I would be ash in the cremation ground today.”

“God did the work, Amma. Dr. Anand did the cutting. I only gave directions,” Mohan deflected humbly.

“No,” Mani said firmly, his eyes shining with profound reverence. “God does not walk on two legs with a stethoscope. You do.”

He set the brass container on the desk. “She made this for you. Thin ragi porridge and steamed keerai. No salt, no oil, just like you told her to eat. She insisted on cooking it herself for you.”

They sat together for nearly an hour, not as physician and patients, but as three human beings who had looked together into the dark abyss of mortality and walked back into the sunlight. They spoke of the village rains, the harvest, the grandchildren who still called on Sundays, and the quiet beauty of growing old without fear.

When they finally stood to leave, Mani looked at Mohan with a strange, lingering intensity. He did not say anything more about money. He only folded his hands, bowed low, and walked slowly out into the midday heat, holding Maragatham’s hand every step of the way.

Four months slipped away.

The scorching summer heat broke, giving way to the gray, gusty monsoon winds of September. Dr. Mohan had traveled to the state capital to attend the annual two-day State Physicians Conference, a grand, sterile affair hosted at the glittering convention center of a five-star hotel near the airport.

Inside the cavernous, air-conditioned hall, surrounded by recessed spotlights, plush velvet carpeting, and massive projection screens displaying high-resolution statistical charts, three hundred doctors in bespoke suits and formal neckties listened to dry lectures on pharmacological advancements and randomized clinical trials.

At eleven in the morning, during the tea break, Mohan's phone began to vibrate in his trouser pocket.

He stepped into the marble-floored foyer, near the towering glass entrance where doormen in livery were opening taxi doors, and pulled out his phone. The screen showed an unknown, unlisted mobile number.

"Hello? Dr. Mohan speaking."

"Doctor?"

The voice was faint, breathless, crackling with static, but the desperate, raspy timbre was unmistakable.

"Mani Appa?" Mohan asked, surprised, taking a step toward the glass doors. "Mani Appa, is that you? Is everything alright? Is Amma okay?"

"Maragatham is fine, Doctor! She is healthy! She is sitting on the veranda grinding rice!" the old voice gasped through the earpiece. "Doctor... are you inside that big glass palace? The one near the airport bus stop?"

Mohan frowned, confused. *"What? Where are you speaking from?"*

"I am standing right outside the glass door, Doctor," Mani whispered sheepishly. "The man with the big red turban and the golden stick won't let me step on the clean floor. He says it is only for big people.

Can you... can you come out for just one minute?"

Mohan hung up the phone and hurried toward the massive revolving glass doors. He pushed through into the humid, rain-scented September air.

There, standing near the ornamental fountain by the driveway, was Mani.

The sight of him made Mohan stop in his tracks, his breath catching in his throat.

Mani looked impossibly small against the towering, multi-story glass facade of the five-star hotel. He was wearing his best clothes, a bleached white cotton dhoti, slightly yellowed with age, and a full-sleeved khadi shirt that had been pressed with a heavy charcoal iron, its folds sharp and stiff. On his feet were the same dusty, cracked rubber slippers. His glasses were still held together by the frayed cotton twine. Tucked beneath his left arm was a faded yellow cloth bag, a manja pai, bearing the faded green advertisement of a village fertilizer depot.

His face was drenched in sweat, his thinning hair plastered to his forehead, but the moment his eyes caught Mohan in his crisp trousers and blazer, a wide, triumphant, utterly sheepish smile broke across his wrinkled face.

"Mani Appa!" Mohan ran forward, catching the old man by both elbows. "What in God's name are you doing here? In the city? How did you find me?"

Mani chuckled, a raspy, proud little sound. He wiped his face with a crumpled towel he pulled from his waistband. "It was not easy, Doctor. Not easy at all."

“Did you come alone?”

“Alone,” Mani nodded. “I took the four o’clock passenger train from our village station. It reached the central junction at nine. Then I took a city bus to your residential street.”

Mohan stared at him, bewildered. “My house? How did you know where I live?”

Mani smiled slyly, tapping his temple. “Remember the day Maragatham had the attack? When you wrote down the names of the medicines for the ambulance, you wrote them on the back of a hospital slip. On the same paper you scribbled your home address and personal phone number just in case we needed your help. I kept that paper in my tin box. I showed it to the bus conductor.”

“But I wasn’t at home!”

“I found that out!” Mani said, his eyes dancing with the thrill of an impossible detective trail. “Your front door had a heavy iron lock. The neighbor lady told me you had left at seven in the morning in an autorickshaw. So I walked to the three-wheeler stand at the corner. I asked the drivers, ‘Which of you took a young, handsome doctor with a leather bag this morning?’ The driver named Selvam recognized you! He told me, ‘I dropped the doctor at the grand conference hall near the airport.’ So I gave Selvam two hundred rupees, he was a very kind boy, Doctor and he drove me all the way here!”

Mohan stood frozen on the hotel driveway, listening to this seventy-year-old, illiterate man who had traversed eighty kilometers of rail, crowded city buses, urban neighborhoods, and autorickshaw stands, navigating a monstrous metropolis he had never visited in his life, armed only with a scrap of paper and an indomitable will.

“Mani Appa…but why?” Mohan asked, his voice shaking with awe and disbelief. “Why did you do this? If you needed to see me, you could have waited until Monday when I returned to the village clinic! Why did you spend your money and break your bones traveling all this way?”

Mani’s playful smile vanished. His face smoothed into a solemn, sacred stillness that seemed to quiet the roar of the city traffic behind them.

He reached beneath his arm and brought out the faded yellow cloth bag. It had a neat cotton drawstring pulled tightly around its neck.

Mani held the bag with both hands, extending it forward as if he were presenting an offering before the sanctum sanctorum of a temple.

“Doctor,” Mani said, his voice dropping into a deep, reverent whisper. “You gave me back my Maragatham. You gave me back my mornings. You gave me back the sound of her bangles when she brings my tea. Without you, I would be sitting alone in an empty house waiting to die.”

Mohan looked down at the yellow bag. Through the thin cotton, he could feel the distinct, heavy rectangular shape of currency notes.

“The ten thousand rupees you sent to the hospital,” Mani continued, his eyes welling with clean, luminous tears. “You didn’t ask for a receipt. You didn’t ask when I would return it. You just gave it because your heart is made of gold. But my father taught me that a debt taken to save a life is a debt that weighs upon the soul until the earth claims us. I could not sleep, Doctor. Every night when I looked at Maragatham breathing beside me, I saw your face.”

“Mani Appa, I told you that wasn’t a debt” Mohan began, his throat tightening terribly.

“It is a debt of honor, Doctor,” Mani interrupted gently, refusing to lower his hands. “For four months, I did not sit idle. I woke up at four every morning. I watered the vegetable gardens of the big landlords. I guarded the paddy drying on the asphalt road at night. Maragatham and I sold the tender coconuts from our two trees. We saved every ten-rupee note, every coin. It is all here. Exactly ten thousand rupees. Not a single rupee less.”

Mohan looked from the yellow bag to Mani’s face. He saw the cracked thumbs, the dust embedded beneath the fingernails, the sheer, towering dignity of an old man who possessed nothing in the world except his honor, his love for his wife, and his gratitude.

In that moment, the five-star hotel behind them, with its chrome elevators, its air-conditioned halls where doctors debated million-dollar clinical trials and career advancement, seemed completely trivial, hollow, and small compared to the immense, crushing weight of that little yellow fertilizer bag.

Mohan reached out. His hands were shaking. He did not refuse the money; to refuse it would have been an unforgivable insult to the old man’s sweat, love, and sacred labor.

He wrapped his fingers around the yellow bag. As he took it, he reached forward and pulled Mani into a tight, fierce embrace right there on the hotel driveway, not caring that the liveried doormen were staring, not caring that his conference colleagues in their sharp suits were stepping out into the garden and watching.

Mohan pressed his face against the rough, starch-stiff khadi of Mani’s shoulder, weeping openly.

“Thank you, Mani Appa,” Mohan whispered, his voice broken with emotion. “Thank you.”

Mani patted the doctor’s back with his rough, sun-baked hand, a quiet, soothing rhythm that felt like a father comforting a son.

“Now, Doctor,” Mani said gently, stepping back with a wide, bright smile, adjusting his twine-tied glasses. “Go back inside to your meeting. Don’t let the big doctors wonder where you went. I have to catch the two o’clock passenger train back to the village. Maragatham will be waiting with the tea.”

Chapter 21

Fortress of hope

It was nearly noon when the wooden door creaked open, hesitating halfway.

A man stood framed against the harsh tube-light glare of the hallway. He was forty, though the sunken hollows beneath his cheekbones and the graying stubble across his sunken jaw suggested a life five or ten years ahead of his age. He carried his weight unevenly, gripping the doorframe, his left foot hovering an inch above the floor, wrapped in a bundle of grimy, oil-stained cotton rags.

Behind him, partially obscured by the man's faded blue lungi, was a shadow that suddenly darted forward to take charge.

"Careful, Appa. Watch the step. Put your hand on my shoulder," a voice chirped, bright and musical, carrying the kind of unblemished lightness that simply didn't belong in a clinic heavy with the smell of betadine and gangrene.

A boy, no older than eight, guided the grown man toward the patient stool. He was dressed in an oversized white button-down school

shirt that hung down past his thighs like a tunicked coat. Its buttons were hopelessly mismatched; the top placket had been jammed into a middle hole, pulling the fabric taut across his collarbone while leaving the bottom hem askew. His shorts, patched at the knee with coarse blue thread, were faded khaki.

Yet what arrested me was not the comical disorder of his attire, but the boy's face. He turned toward me, wiping a bead of sweat from his forehead with the back of his wrist, and split his face into a smile so radiant, so completely devoid of defensive reserve, that the drab gray clinic suddenly seemed washed in morning sunlight.

"Sit, Appa. Don't put weight on the heel. Sit straight," the boy ordered gently, coaxing the man onto the vinyl stool.

The father, whom the case sheet introduced as Sampath, sat with an audible hiss of air through his teeth. He kept his eyes glued firmly to the floor tiles. He was a slight, desiccated man, his shoulders drawn inward as if trying to shrink away from the room, from the shame of illness, from the clinical gaze itself.

"Good morning, doctor," the boy said, standing straight as an arrow beside the stool, his hands folded neatly behind his back like a student.

"Good morning, young man," I said, putting my pen down. "And good morning, Sampath. What brings you to see me today?"

Sampath didn't look up. His hands, rough and cracked from years of daily wage masonry, twisted nervously in his lap. He gave a faint, indistinct moan and turned his head slightly toward the boy, his brow furrowed in wordless plea.

Ramesh picked up the signal instantly.

“Appa has a wound on the bottom of his left foot, doctor. It started three weeks ago. A thorn outside our fence went through his slipper. He pulled the thorn out, but the skin turned yellow, then purple, and now it smells bad. He couldn’t go to the brick kiln this week because he cannot put his foot down.”

I looked from the boy’s earnest brown eyes to the silent father. “Is that right, Sampath? Three weeks?”

Sampath gave a short, timid nod. “Aama... yes, doctor. Just a small thorn. I thought it would dry up if I kept it wrapped.”

“We washed it with well water and tied it with an old towel, doctor,” Ramesh added, his voice carrying the firm scold. “I told him we should come to the hospital on Monday itself, but he said the buses are too crowded.”

I couldn’t help but smile faintly, though a quiet ache was already settling into my chest. “Well, Ramesh, you were right. He should have come sooner. Let’s look at his history first.” *I pulled the outpatient book toward me.* “Sampath, are you a known diabetic?”

Sampath looked down, rubbing his thumbs together. “No, doctor. Not now.”

Ramesh let out an angry scowl. He looked at me with an apologetic grin. “Doctor, he has sugar. He is lying. Three hundred and forty was the sugar level.”

I blinked. “Three hundred and forty?”

“Yes, doctor. He takes metformin five hundred milligrams, one tablet in the morning after kanji, and one at night. But last month the dispensary in our panchayat ran out of the white ones, so he

has only been taking the evening dose."

"Have you ever been on insulin injections?" I asked, testing the waters.

"No, never," Sampath mumbled quickly, shaking his head. "No needles."

"Appa, why are you lying to the doctor?" Ramesh sighed, shaking his head with an exaggerated roll of his eyes that had the practiced cadence of an old married couple. "Doctor, last year around Deepavali time he had a swelling on the other foot. We went to the taluk hospital, and the lady doctor there gave him two bottles of insulin. Ten units from each bottle in the morning before breakfast, eight units at night before dinner. I learned how to give the insulin and I only injected him daily. Then we stopped after the wound healed."

I stared at the child. He was standing on tiptoe to rest his chin comfortably on the edge of my consultation desk. His brown eyes were clear, bright, entirely unburdened by self-pity. A child of seven for he could not have been older than that last year had memorized drug names, unit doses, and the delicate logistics of insulin administration.

"Ramesh," I asked softly, "who taught you all of this?"

"Nobody taught me, doctor," he said, beaming as if I had praised his handwriting. "The government hospital nurse told me once and I learned. If I don't check, he takes the blood pressure pill instead of the sugar pill, and then his head spins when he walks out into the sun."

“What blood pressure pill is he on?”

“Enalapril. Five milligrams. The yellow one with the line in the middle. Half a tablet every morning.”

I sat back in my chair, looking at the silent father and the radiant boy. Sampath’s face was an open wound of guilt and exhaustion. He looked at his son not with authority, but with an overwhelming, almost reverent dependence that made my throat tighten.

“Alright,” I said, rising from my chair. “Let’s take him into the treatment room. We need to unwrap that cloth and clean the wound.”

“I’ll help him walk,” Ramesh said immediately, slipping his small head under his father’s large arm.

The dressing room was quiet.

“Sampath, climb onto the examination table,” I instructed, snapping on a pair of sterile latex gloves.

The man struggled to hoist his frame onto the high examination bed. Every movement caused a visible shudder to ripple through his shoulders. Ramesh hovered at his side, holding his father’s slippers by their worn rubber straps, setting them neatly together against the wall before turning to stand beside the head of the bed.

“Dei, thambi,” the nursing assistant, Sister Mary, said gently from the sink, “you go wait outside in the corridor, okay? There’s a ceiling fan out there, and you can drink some water. We will dress your father’s foot and call you.”

The boy didn’t move. His smile softened, but his jaw set with an immovable, quiet gravity.

“No, sister. Appa will be scared,” Ramesh said simply. “He will not cooperate. If the pain gets bad, he pulls his leg away. I have to be there with him to hold him. Otherwise, the doctor won’t be able to finish the dressing.”

Sister Mary frowned, glancing at me. “Doctor, it’s not good for a child to see this. It’s an open ulcer. There might be pus. He will faint.”

I looked at Sampath. The forty-year-old man had turned his face toward his son, his eyes pleading, his lower lip trembling like that of a terrified child in an unfamiliar room.

“Doctor...” Sampath’s voice was barely a rasp, stripped of whatever adult dignity he had left. “Let him stay. Please. Without him, I cannot bear it.”

I looked at the boy. His oversized white shirt was fluttering slightly under the breeze of the ceiling fan. He took out a folded, faded cotton kerchief printed with little blue flowers from his pocket and smoothed it flat with his palm.

“Let him stay,” I told Mary. “Stand here by your father’s shoulder, Ramesh. Don’t look at the foot. Look at his face.”

“I know, doctor,” the boy said softly. “I always look at his face.”

I took a pair of blunt bandage scissors and began cutting through the grimy rags wrapped around Sampath’s foot. Layer after layer peeled away, stiff with dried exudate and dried blood. When the final layer came off, the sour, sickening stench of rotting flesh and infection filled the small room.

It was a diabetic foot ulcer. On the foot just below the great toe

lay a deep, crater-like lesion, nearly four centimeters across. The margins were calloused and undermined, the base a mottled mix of unhealthy gray slough and dusky granulation tissue. A thin trickle of pus oozed from the deep tissue pocket underneath.

"We need to debride this slough," I told Mary in a low voice. "Hydrogen peroxide, betadine wash, and a size 15 scalpel."

The moment the cold stream of saline and hydrogen peroxide hit the raw edges of the wound, Sampath arched his back with a ragged, guttural howl that seemed to tear straight from his lungs.

"Ammmmaaa! Ayyooo!"

His right hand shot out blindly, searching the air, and found Ramesh's small left hand. Sampath didn't merely hold it; he clamped down with the desperate, bone-crushing panic of a drowning man grasping a log of wood in a stormy sea. I watched in alarm as the boy's small fingers went white under the brutal constriction, the blood squeezed entirely out of his capillaries until the skin turned a bruised, mottled purple-red.

"Sampath, don't squeeze him so hard!" Sister Mary gasped, reaching out to break the grip.

"No, sister, it's okay!" Ramesh said through his teeth.

The boy didn't flinch. His little feet dug into the floor tiles, his heels bracing against the weight of his father's writhing body. The pain in his own crushed hand must have been excruciating, but not a single whimper escaped his lips. Instead, he took the blue-flowered kerchief in his free right hand and began dabbing away the thick beads of sweat pooling on his father's temples, wiping the hot tears

streaming down the man's hollow cheeks.

"Look at me. Look at my eyes. It's almost over. The doctor is cleaning the pus out. If the pus stays inside, the foot will rot. You want to walk to the temple next month, don't you? Look at me, Appa. Don't look down there."

Sampath's chest heaved. He buried his face against the boy's oversized sleeve, weeping openly, groaning each time my blade scraped away the rotten debris. The man was forty, yet in that small, sunlit room, he had become the child, and the eight-year-old boy stroking his hair had become the ancient, unshakeable parent.

I worked as fast as my hands would allow, cutting away the dead skin, irrigating the wound, and packing the cavity with ribbon gauze soaked in antiseptic solution. Throughout the entire ten minutes, the boy's hand remained locked in that vice-like grip. I saw a solitary tear well up in the corner of Ramesh's left eye, borne purely of physical pressure, but he blinked it away furiously before it could fall, refusing to let his father see even a flicker of weakness.

"Done," I said finally, securing the outer gauze with wide strips of adhesive plaster. *"We are done, Sampath."*

The tension left Sampath's body all at once. He collapsed back onto the pillow, his breathing shallow, his face gray with shock and relief. His fingers slowly unclenched, slipping away from his son's hand.

Ramesh stood there for a moment, his left arm hanging limp at his side. His fingers were swollen, deep red and purple indentations carved into his tender skin where his father's hand had dug in. He flexed them slowly, wincing just once behind his teeth, and then immediately rubbed the small hand against his shorts to bring the blood back.

He looked up at me, and like a sunrise breaking over an abandoned field, that bright, incredible smile returned to his face, untouched, unbroken.

"See, doctor?" he whispered proudly, as if sharing a secret. "I told you. He cannot bear pain. But he didn't pull his leg away even once."

I helped Ramesh guide his father back out to the long wooden bench in the verandah. Sampath sat heavily, leaning his head back against the lime-washed wall, his eyes closed in deep exhaustion.

Before I could walk back to my desk to finish writing his prescription, I felt a gentle tug on the pocket of my white coat.

I turned. Ramesh was looking up at me, his face serious now, the schoolboy replaced entirely by the head of a household seeking counsel.

"Doctor," he asked, pulling a crumpled scrap of paper and a short stub of a pencil from his pocket. "Tell me what I must do."

"What do you mean, Ramesh?"

"What medicines should I buy from the medical shop? Which ones are free here, and which ones must I get outside? What should I feed him? Can he eat ragi koozh, or will it make his sugar go up? Does this dressing have to be changed every day? If we come every day, the bus ticket is fourteen rupees for Appa and seven rupees for me. That is forty-two rupees both ways. Can I clean it at home with boiled water if you show me how?"

The questions poured out of him with such rapid-fire practicality that I stood frozen, a profound, suffocating sorrow settling in my

chest. This child should have been asking about marbles, about whether the school sports day would have a running race, about whether he could have an orange ice lolly from the cart outside the gates.

Instead, he was calculating bus fares, glycemic loads, and wound care logistics.

I dropped to one knee so that my eyes were level with his. Up close, I could see a smear of blue ink on his collar, and the sweet, milky scent of a young child still clung to his skin, contrasting sharply with the hospital smells around us.

"Ramesh," I asked, keeping my voice as gentle as I could manage, "where is your mother?"

The boy's smile flickered, just for a microsecond a shadow passing over a lit lamp before settling back into its cheerful, practiced curve.

"Amma is at home, doctor," he said easily, his voice light. "She stays in the village."

"Why didn't she come with your father today?"

"She had work," he said, looking away toward the hospital gate where an auto-rickshaw was sputtering to a halt. "Appa needs me more. I know his medicines better than anyone."

"And what about school, Ramesh? Don't you go to school?"

"I go to the government primary school near the tank," he said proudly, tapping his chest. "Third standard. My teacher is Malliga miss. She knows I have to bring Appa to the clinic today. She gave me permission. I will copy the notes from my friend's notebook tomorrow morning."

Before I could ask anything more, he heard his father groan on the bench. Instantly, the boy turned on his heel. “Appa is calling. Thank you, doctor. Please give me clear prescription”

I went back to my desk, my fingers trembling slightly as I wrote the prescription for broad-spectrum antibiotics, insulin, and sterile dressing materials. I walked outside and handed the slip directly to Ramesh. He studied it, nodded with serious approval, folded it four times into a tiny square, and tucked it deep into his pocket.

Then, wrapping his thin arm firmly around his father’s waist, the little boy no taller than the grown man’s hip began the slow, agonizing walk toward the bus stop, bearing the full weight of his family’s survival on his small, unevenly buttoned shoulders.

The image of that little boy haunted me through the night. As a rural medical officer, one becomes hardened to poverty; it is the constant background noise of the profession, like the hum of a refrigerator. You see neglected wounds, delayed presentations, and families ruined by a single bout of illness. But there was something about Ramesh’s smile, a shield of pure, luminous grace carried into the dark heart of adversity, that I could not shake.

The following afternoon, my schedule took me out of the clinic for a mobile outreach clinic in the surrounding villages. We had finished screening elderly patients for cataract and hypertension under the shade of an old banyan tree in Keelur when the local community health worker, a middle-aged woman named Selvi, wiped her brow with the end of her sari and looked down the dusty lane.

“Doctor, you treated a man named Sampath yesterday, didn’t you? From the kiln?”

I looked up from my register. *"Yes. The diabetic foot ulcer. With the little boy."*

"His house is just down this lane," Selvi said, pointing toward a narrow dirt track with mud-brick huts with thatched roofs. "His mother was asking if the doctor could check his dressing. He couldn't walk to the bus stand today. The foot is throbbing."

"Pack the dressing kit, Selvi sister," I said, rising immediately. "Let's go."

We walked down the sun-baked path. The heat radiated from the earth in shimmering waves, drying the throat with every breath. Keelur was a poor settlement, mostly inhabited by seasonal brick kiln laborers and dry-land agricultural workers.

We stopped before a modest dwelling. The walls were made of unplastered mud, cracked by the summer sun, supporting a low roof of woven coconut thatch and corrugated tin sheets weighed down with old tires. Yet, despite the poverty, the small swept yard in front of the house possessed an extraordinary, deliberate neatness.

On the narrow, sun-drenched mud sill of the front window, five old, battered plastic toy cars were arranged in a meticulous, perfectly straight line, their chipped paint facing the road like sentinels.

To the side, strung between two crooked neem trees, a thin coir clothesline swung gently in the dry breeze. Hanging from it was the white button-down shirt I had seen yesterday, freshly washed and scrubbed until the collar was bright, drying beside a pair of faded khaki shorts. And there, beside the low wooden threshold, sat a pair of tiny, size 5 white canvas school shoes, scrubbed with chalk to hide the worn patches on the toes, their laces neatly tucked inside.

It was unmistakably Ramesh's house. A sanctuary of childhood order built amidst structural collapse.

"Sampath?" Selvi called out. "Sampath-pa, the doctor is here."

From within the dark, cool interior of the veranda, a frail voice answered. "Come in... please come in."

I stepped across the threshold, ducking my head under the low roof.

Sampath was lying on a thin reed mat spread over the packed cow-dung floor. His left leg was elevated, propped carefully on an upside-down red plastic vegetable crate cushioned with a folded lungi. Next to him sat an elderly woman with silver hair pulled back into a sparse knot, her face etched with a thousand fine lines of sorrow. She was grinding dried turmeric on a flat stone.

"Vanakkam, doctor," the old woman said, scrambling to her feet with difficulty, her hands trembling as she adjusted her cotton sari. "You came all the way to our house... we don't have a chair to offer you."

"Please sit, Amma," I said, pulling up a low wooden plank and sitting beside Sampath. "How is the foot today, Sampath?"

"The throbbing has come down a little, doctor," Sampath said, his voice softer, shyer than it had been in the harsh fluorescent light of the hospital. "The tablets you gave... Ramesh made me take them at six in the morning with hot water."

I knelt and inspected the outer dressing. It was clean, dry, and intact. Ramesh had evidently protected it from the dusty floor by

tying a clean plastic bag over the bandage when his father needed to use the latrine.

“Where is Ramesh?” I asked, looking around the small room.

The old woman let out a long, shuddering breath and sat back down by her grinding stone. “He is at school, doctor. He ran out at eight in the morning. He had the kanji before he left, fed his father, bathed his younger brother Suresh, and walked Suresh to the anganwadi center before running to his own class.”

I looked at the woman, then at Sampath, whose eyes had once again found the floor.

“Sampath,” I began gently, “yesterday, Ramesh told me his mother was at home. But she isn’t here, is she?”

A heavy, suffocating silence descended upon the small room, broken only by the dry rasp of the neem leaves scraping against the tin roof outside.

Sampath turned his face toward the mud wall. A single tear escaped his eye, tracing a clean path through the gray dust on his cheek.

“She left us four years ago, doctor,” the old mother answered for him, her voice cracking with an ancient, unresolved bitterness. “When Sampath fell sick. First came the coughing blood in his spit. The doctors said it was TB. Then they tested his blood and said his sugar was dangerously high. The kiln owner stopped calling him for work. The money stopped coming.”

She wiped her eyes on the corner of her sari, her shoulders shaking. “His wife... she looked at him, she looked at the two babies, and she couldn’t bear the thought of a life nursing a dying man with no money. One morning, she packed her trunk while they were

still asleep. She told the neighbors she was going to her mother's village for a festival. She never came back. We heard later she married a lorry driver in the neighboring district."

I looked at Sampath. The man's chest rose and fell in silent, rhythmic agony. To be abandoned by the world because of your poverty is cruel; to be abandoned by the person who promised to stand beside you because your body has broken is a wound deeper than any scalpel could ever reach.

"Ramesh was four years old when she left," the grandmother continued, her voice dropping to a whisper. "He remembers her. But he never speaks her name. If anyone in the village asks him where his mother is, he just smiles and says, 'Amma is at home.' He says it so that people won't look at his father with pity. He hates pity, doctor. That little boy has more pride in his little finger than all the elders in 8 surrounding villages."

"And the house?" I asked, looking at the spotless floor, the scrubbed brass vessels stacked neatly in the corner.

"I do what I can," the old woman said, holding up her gnarled, arthritic hands. "My joints are swollen like bitter gourds. I can barely lift the water pot from the well. Ramesh does it. He wakes up at five. He sweeps the yard. He fetches four buckets of water from the common pump. If I fall sick, he boils the water, buys bread from the tea shop on credit, and sits by my side pressing my legs until I fall asleep. He tells me, 'Paati, you rest. I am here. Nothing will happen to Appa, and nothing will happen to you.'"

"He carries too much," Sampath whispered, his voice thick with self-hatred. "A boy his age should be flying kites. He should be playing kabbadi in the dust. Instead, he is cleaning my sores. He is

smelling my rot. I am a curse to my son, doctor. A living corpse tied to his neck."

"Don't speak like that, Sampath," I said firmly, though my own eyes were burning. "You are his father. You are his whole world."

"That is what terrifies me," Sampath choked out. "What if I die? What will happen to my boys?"

Before I could answer, the stillness of the afternoon was shattered by the sound of rapid, scuffing footsteps coming down the dirt lane, accompanied by a high-pitched, breathless singing.

"Appa! Appa! Look what I got!"

Ramesh burst through the doorway like a whirlwind of kinetic energy. His school bag, a torn canvas sack with a picture of a faded cartoon superhero, was slung over one shoulder. His face was streaked with sweat and red village dust, his hair wild and standing on end.

He stopped short when he saw me sitting on the plank, his eyes going wide with surprise.

"Doctor uncle!" he gasped, his chest heaving from the sprint. "You came to our house?"

Then, remembering his manners, he instantly dropped his bag onto the mud floor, kicked off his worn rubber slippers at the threshold, and stood straight, smoothing down his clothes with both hands.

"Vanakkam, doctor," he said, breathless, that luminous, unstoppable smile breaking across his features once more. "Is Appa's foot worse? Did the bandage come off? I tied a plastic cover over it, I swear!"

“No, Ramesh,” I laughed, feeling a sudden, immense warmth flood my chest. “The foot is fine. The dressing is perfect. I was nearby for the camp and just came to see how you were managing.”

“I am managing very well, doctor,” he said proudly. “Look, the teacher gave me a star today for mental arithmetic!” He thrust a small, grubby palm forward. Drawn on the back of his hand in purple ballpoint ink was a lopsided, five-pointed star. “Five out of five. I did the multiplications in my head without writing them down on the notebook.”

“Go wash your face, da,” Sampath said, the gloom in his eyes instantly dissipating, replaced by an unmistakable light that only his son could kindle. “The doctor has been sitting here in the heat.”

“I’ll wash, Appa. One minute!”

Ramesh dashed through the rear door toward the small bathing enclosure behind the hut. We could hear the violent splashing of cold water, the clatter of a tin mug, and vigorous snorting as he scrubbed the dust from his eyes and ears.

Less than two minutes later, he bounded back in, his face shining wet, water dripping from his chin onto his collar. He didn’t even reach for a towel. He went straight to the corner of the room where a small clay pot sat covered with a steel plate. He lifted the lid, scooped a generous mound of leftover cold rice into a steel plate, ladled a spoonful of watery drumstick kozhambu over it, and sat cross-legged on the floor by his father’s side.

He ate with the ferocious, beautiful hunger of an eight-year-old child, mixing the rice with rapid, practiced fingers, shoveling it into his mouth while never once taking his eyes off his father.

“Did you take the white tablet at twelve o’clock, Appa?” he asked between mouthfuls.

“I took it, da,” Sampath said, a faint smile touching his lips. “Paati gave it to me.”

“Good. And you drank the boiled water? Not the well water?”

“Boiled water only.”

Ramesh finished his food in less than four minutes, licking his fingers clean with absolute relish. He took his plate to the backyard, washed it at the tap, and came back inside, wiping his wet hands on his shorts.

He looked toward the open doorway. Outside, down by the dry irrigation canal, the high, joyful shouts of village boys drifted in through the heat. The clatter of wooden sticks against an old rubber ball a game of gully cricket was beginning.

Ramesh’s eyes lingered on the doorway. His small body leaned forward, vibrating with the natural, primal urge of an eight-year-old boy to throw himself into the dust, to run until his lungs burned, to scream with laughter over a dropped catch.

He turned back toward the room, his eyes falling upon the small plastic medicine strips arranged on the window sill beside his toy cars, and then upon his father’s bandaged leg resting on the red crate.

He didn’t sigh. He didn’t complain. He simply walked over to the mat, leaned down, and gently adjusted the folded cloth under his father’s ankle, ensuring the heel wasn’t pressing against the hard plastic edge.

“Appa,” Ramesh shouted toward the door as he turned to leave, his voice ringing out clear, bright, and commanding through the quiet village afternoon. “I am going to play cricket with Murugan and Velu! I will come back before six o’clock, and then I will do your foot dressing with the boiled warm water and the yellow powder like the doctor showed us!”

“Go, da,” Sampath said softly, his voice trembling with an emotion too profound for words. “Go play.”

Ramesh sprinted through the doorway, his bare feet slapping against the warm earth, a blur of motion chasing after the sunlight, his laughter trailing behind him like a benediction.

I sat on the wooden plank in that dim mud hut for a long time after the dust from his heels had settled.

In medicine, we spend years learning the biochemistry of survival. We study the molecular structure of insulin, the bacteriology of chronic ulcers, the hemodynamic mechanics of collapse, and the pharmacokinetics of recovery. We train ourselves to look for pathology, to see the rot, to measure the decline, to anticipate the inevitable failure of human tissue.

Yet sitting in that room, looking at the straight line of toy cars on the window sill and the clean white shirt drying in the wind, I realized that modern medicine often misses the very engine of healing.

Sampath was not alive because of the antibiotics and insulin I had prescribed, nor because of the surgical debridement I had performed with my sterile scalpel. Those were merely tools, clumsy scaffolding erected around a fragile frame.

Sampath was alive because an eight-year-old boy had decided, with an absolute, unshakeable purity of heart, that he was responsible for his father's wellbeing.

Ramesh was not a victim of his circumstances, though the world had dealt him a hand that would have crushed most grown men. He had taken abandonment, poverty, chronic disease, and despair, and had transmuted them through the sheer alchemy of love into a daily, joyful duty. In a broken world where adults so often abandon their responsibilities when the road turns steep, this small child had chosen to stand like an ancient granite pillar, holding up the heavens so that his father might have room to breathe underneath. Did Ramesh even know that he was doing all this? Who is to say?

I stood up, slinging my medical bag over my shoulder.

"Sampath," I said, reaching down and placing my hand firmly on the man's thin shoulder. *"Listen to me carefully."*

The man looked up, his hollow eyes searching mine.

"Your body is weak right now," I said, my voice quiet but unyielding. *"Your pancreas is tired, and your foot is hurt. But you are the wealthiest man in this entire village. Do you hear me? You possess a treasure that kings would surrender their crowns to have. Do not dare speak of yourself as a living corpse. You do not have the right to surrender. You have to eat your food, you have to take your insulin, and you have to heal that foot. Because one day, that boy is going to grow into a man, and you must be standing on your own two feet, healthy and strong, to watch him conquer this world."*

Sampath stared at me, the breath hitching in his throat. Then, slowly, with an effort that seemed to pull from the deepest reserves

of his bruised soul, he straightened his back. The defeated slump of his shoulders fell away. He nodded, once, firmly, his jaw setting with a newfound resolve that mirrored his son's quiet strength.

"I will walk, doctor," he whispered, wiping his eyes with the back of his sleeve. "I will walk for him."

I stepped out of the hut into the bright, blinding glare of the afternoon sun. Down by the dry canal, I could see the boys playing in a cloud of golden dust. A ball was struck, soaring high into the blue sky.

And there, running beneath it with arms outstretched, his head thrown back in pure, unadulterated joy, was Ramesh. He caught the ball against his chest, tumbled into the dry grass, and leaped to his feet with a triumphant shout that echoed across the open fields.

He was only eight years old. He was a nurse, a parent, a provider, and a warrior. But right now, under the vast rural sky, he was a boy catching a ball in the golden hour a child whose boundless love had turned a humble mud hut into an impenetrable fortress of hope.

Chapter 22

Sermon of the parakeet

The clinic always smelled of three distinct things by five in the evening: the sharp, clinical bite of spirit swabs, the damp red-oxide flooring that had absorbed the sweat of a hundred barefoot farmers, and the sweet, lingering musk of drying neem flowers drifting in through the rear wooden windows.

It was an old building, constructed during the late 1980s when lime mortar and thick granite lintels were still favored over rapid-curing cement. It stood at the edge of the semi-rural sprawl where the asphalt highway surrendered its arrogance to unpaved dirt lanes. For twelve years, it had been my world. Within its white-washed walls, lives were measured not by grand academic milestones or lives saved, but in micro-victories: an ulcer that did not turn black, an asthmatic child who slept through the humid night without wheezing, an old grandmother whose systolic pressure dropped from two hundred to a modest one hundred and forty.

By five-thirty, the rusted iron gate swung shut. The last patient—an elderly weaver with cataract-milky eyes and the leathery, trembling

fingers of chronic nicotine addiction had collected his small paper pouch of yellow and white tablets, touched his heart in silent benediction, and disappeared into the twilight.

My temples throbbed with a dull, persistent ache. It was not merely the exhaustion of seeing eighty-two outpatients in six hours; it was the deeper, heavier weight of an invisible stone lodged beneath my sternum, placed there twenty-four hours earlier in an air-conditioned auditorium eighty kilometers away.

I locked the brass padlock on the medicine storeroom, unbuttoned the stiff top collar of my cotton shirt, and walked through the back kitchen entrance into the yard.

The yard was small, walled off from the open scrubland by a crumbling boundary of unbaked clay bricks. And in the center of that courtyard rose the neem tree.

It was older than the clinic, older perhaps than the village settlement itself. Its trunk was thick, its bark deep-ridged and silver-gray, weeping beads of pale, bitter amber resin where the summer storms had cracked its skin. Its canopy was an immense, shimmering dome of serrated green needles, so dense that even the blistering midday sun was refracted into a soft, underwater emerald light. Whenever the wind swept in from the eastern dry plains, the tree didn't merely rustle it sighed, an ancient, rhythmic inhalation that seemed to draw all the heat and sorrow out of the earth and exhale it back as clean, bitter oxygen.

At the base of the trunk, between two massive surface roots that curled like sleeping pythons, the staff had smoothed a small patch of earth and placed a flat river stone. It was my sanctuary. When the tragedy of poverty became too thick to swallow, I sat there,

leaned my spine against the rough bark, and listened to the weaver birds, the cuckoos, and the wild parakeets that nested in its heights.

Today, however, the shade felt thin. The humiliation of the previous day had followed me back from the city, coiled around my ribs like barbed wire, tightening every time I breathed.

I sat on the cold river stone, pulled my knees to my chest, and rested my forehead on my arms.

"The trouble with men who wear neckties," a voice remarked from just above my right ear, "is that they mistake the length of their tie for the depth of their wisdom."

The voice was not loud. It possessed the light, scratchy percussion of dry seeds shaking inside a dry gourd, but it was unmistakably crisp, rounded with an odd, archaic clarity.

I did not jump. In the deep, humid exhaustion that settles into a rural doctor's bones, the boundary between the waking world and the country of dreams becomes remarkably porous. I slowly lifted my head, blinking against the amber shafts of setting sunlight that filtered through the leaves.

Perched on a curved, low-hanging branch barely two feet from my shoulder was a rose-ringed parakeet.

He was not large, perhaps the length of a man's forearm from crown to tail-tip, but he was colored with an intensity that defied ordinary biology. His plumage was the brilliant, luminous green of young paddy fields right after the first monsoon rain, vibrant enough that the air around his feathers seemed to cast a faint, emerald halo. Around his slender neck was a sharp, perfect ring: half velvety black, half the delicate, pale pink of a freshly split pomegranate. His

beak was a curved talon of deep, polished coral.

Most arresting, however, were his eyes. They were not the blank, skittering black beads of an ordinary bird. They had pale gold irises ringed with an ancient, contemplative intelligence, unblinking and deep as temple wells.

He tilted his head sideways, inspecting me first with the left eye, then with the right.

"You smell of tincture and sulking," the parakeet said, clicking his upper mandible against the lower with a sound like a small dry twig snapping. "Mostly sulking. It is an undignified scent for a man who knows how to sort out a headache."

I stared at the bird. A rational corner of my clinical mind whispered of sleep deprivation, dehydration, perhaps early heat stroke from the long summer work day. "I am talking to a parrot," I murmured aloud, rubbing my palms over my burning eyes.

"And a rather poorly educated one at that, by medical institutional standards," the bird replied smoothly, shifting his weight from one scaly yellow foot to the other. "I have no MD in community medicine. But I have lived in this neem tree since your grandfather was a boy who still wet his shorts, and I have listened to four generations of village doctors moan about their lot."

"I am not sulking," I said defensively, the instinct to justify myself overriding the sheer impossibility of the conversation.

"Ah," the bird chirped, fluttering his wings once. A faint shower of bitter, microscopic neem pollen drifted down onto my hair. "Then you always sit with your jaw clamped like that, lips pouting and your pulse visibly hammering against your carotid artery? You

were away for two days. You went to the great city of concrete and glass. You took the brown train and red bus. You took your blue notebook. You looked like an eager schoolboy going to receive a prize. And you returned looking like a stray dog that has been hit with a wet broom."

The memory, prodded so bluntly, erupted through my defenses. The barbed wire around my chest twisted tight.

"I was at the National Conference of Primary Care Physicians," I said, my voice cracking slightly. "At the Grand Chola. Four hundred doctors from all over the country. Marble floors, air-conditioning that chilled the water in your glass before you could drink it, registration kits made of most expensive artisanal jute."

"A magnificent nest for crows," the parrot remarked, preening a single flight feather with mathematical precision. "And what did the chief crow have to say to the smaller birds?"

"He was an endocrinologist," I muttered, leaning my head back against the trunk, staring up into the tangled canopy where the parakeet sat. "Dr. V. K. Ramanathan. Emeritus professor from the central institute. He arrived in a car that cost more than this clinic's annual budget for three years. He stood at the podium in a tailored three-piece suit, his slides projected on screens the size of village cinema halls. He was speaking on the new paradigm of diabetes management."

"New paradigm," the bird echoed, rolling the syllables around his tongue as if tasting an unfamiliar berry. "A heavy phrase. Usually means an old trick with a shiny ribbon bowtie."

“No,” I sighed, shaking my head. “It wasn’t a trick. That was the terrible part. He was brilliant. He showed graphs clean, devastating lines of clinical trial data. He spoke about the SGLT2 inhibitors and the GLP-1 receptor agonists. He showed survival curves: forty percent reduction in cardiovascular death, preservation of renal function, halting the progression of diabetic nephropathy, dramatic reversal of microalbuminuria. He said that continuing to treat diabetic patients with only metformin and sulfonylureas was no longer just conservative it was practically clinical negligence. He called all those who did that ‘glorified quacks’. The science was spotless. It was beautiful.”

“Then why are you sitting here with a face like a dried bitter gourd?” the bird asked, hopping down to an even lower branch, so close I could feel the faint breeze of his tail feathers.

“Because one month’s supply of those new medicines costs three thousand five hundred rupees,” I said, the words bitter as crushed neem bark in my mouth. “Three thousand five hundred. Do you know what the average family earns in this village, parrot? An agricultural laborer makes eight hundred rupees a day during harvest, if it rains. During the dry months, they weave palm mats or dig irrigation ditches under the rural employment scheme for two hundred and fifty rupees. Sampath, the brick kiln worker whose foot ulcer I have been dressing for two months, his weekly household budget for food is eight hundred rupees. If I write him a prescription for the medicine Dr. Ramanathan showed on his glowing screen, Sampath would have to choose between buying that single blister strip of tablets or buying rice for his two boys and old mother.”

“So,” the bird said, “you do not prescribe it.”

“I cannot prescribe it! I prescribe generic metformin at twenty paise a tablet. I prescribe glimepiride at thirty paise. I treat their blood pressures with amlodipine and hydrochlorothiazide. I manage them with drugs that cost fifty rupees a month! I have read the international journals. I know the new drugs protect their kidneys better. I know the new drugs would give them five more years without heart failure. But they cannot buy them! The nearest government tertiary hospital with subsidized stock is eighty kilometers away, and they run out of inventory by the second week of every month!”

“A reasonable, practical sorrow,” the parrot observed, his golden eye fixed on mine. “Poverty is an old sickness. It is older than your stethoscopes. But this is not what broke your spirit yesterday. You have known the price of rice and the price of pills for twelve years. What happened in that cold room?”

The memory flared, burning white-hot behind my eyes. I could still hear the low, cultured hum of the air-conditioning, the polite tinkle of porcelain tea cups on brass saucers outside the hall doors.

“There was an open floor discussion,” I whispered, my fingers digging into the dry earth between the roots. “The microphone was passed around. City consultants stood up, one after another, praising the lecture, discussing whether they preferred empagliflozin or dapagliflozin for patients with an ejection fraction below thirty percent. It was a polite, glittering salon of modern medicine. And then... I stood up.”

“Ah,” the parrot clucked softly. “The lone goose honks in the courtyard.”

“I didn’t honk,” I said, a tremble in my throat. “I held the microphone.

My hands were shaking because the microphone was heavy and cold. I told him... I said, 'Sir, your data is impeccable. But this is a conference for primary care physicians. Half of us work in villages and peri-urban slums. How do we apply these guidelines when eighty percent of our population pays out of pocket, and three thousand rupees is a catastrophic expenditure? If we push these drugs, our patients drop out of care entirely because they cannot afford the refill, and their sugars rebound to four hundred. How do we bridge this chasm between evidence-based perfection and rural reality?'"

"And the chief crow?" the bird asked, tilting his head until his coral beak pointed straight at my heart.

"He laughed," I said, and the humiliation felt as fresh as if the sound had just bounced off the walls of the auditorium. "It was a small, dry, cultivated chuckle. He leaned over the lectern, looked down at me through his gold-rimmed spectacles, and said into the speaker: 'Doctor, with all due respect, that is the classic defeatist mentality of the rural practitioner. Equity is not something you wait for the government to hand you on a silver platter. If you truly believed in the standard of care, you would advocate for your patients. You would negotiate with pharmaceutical representatives for patient assistance programs. You would educate your patients on the long-term cost-effectiveness of avoiding dialysis versus the upfront cost of therapy. Have you even tried prescribing them? Or have you surrendered your clinical ambition because it is easier to hand out twenty-paise pills and feel like a martyr? The inequity in our healthcare system does not exist solely because of drug pricing, colleagues. It persists because primary care providers in the periphery lack the will, the effort, and the ambition to demand modern standards for their rural poor.'"

The silence of the clinic yard rushed in to fill the space where my words ended.

Even the wind seemed to have paused in the neem branches. The emerald glow around the bird's plumage deepened, vibrating with a subtle, electric luminescence that seemed to hum at the edge of hearing.

"The whole auditorium murmured," I whispered, the shame hot against my eyelids. "Some people nodded. A few smiled into their coffee cups. He made me look like an uneducated quack who was denying his patients modern science out of sheer laziness. He made it seem as though if I only worked harder, if I only cared more, I could make poverty vanish from my consultation room. I sat down. My ears were burning. I couldn't even stay for lunch. I caught the afternoon bus back. All through the four-hour ride, while the bus rattled over potholes, his words rang in my head: You have surrendered your clinical ambition. It is easier to hand out twenty-paise pills and feel like a martyr."

A tear, hot and heavy, broke from my eye and slipped down my cheek, dropping onto the dry river stone.

"What if he is right, parrot?" I asked the empty air. "What if I am just a mediocre doctor hiding in a forgotten village, rationalizing my mediocrity behind the excuse of poverty? What if my patients deserve better than a man who can only offer them thirty-year-old drugs and clean bandages?"

The parakeet did not mock me. He did not flutter or hop away.

Instead, he stretched his wings outward a breathtaking span of emerald and gold that caught the last dying ray of the setting

sun and then slowly folded them back against his sides. When he spoke again, the scratchy, dry tone of his voice had transformed. It resonated with the deep, bronze reverberation of an ancient temple bell struck at midnight, echoing within the hollows of my own skull.

"कर्मण्येवाधिकारस्ते मा फलेषु कदाचन।

मा कर्मफलहेतुर्भूर्मा ते सङ्गोऽस्त्वकर्मणि॥"

The Sanskrit syllables rolled through the quiet courtyard with crystalline precision, each vowel hanging in the twilight air like a drop of liquid silver.

I blinked, staring at the small creature. "The Gita..."

"The Gita," the parrot replied softly, his ancient golden eyes holding mine with an intensity that made the hair on my arms stand up. "Second chapter. Forty-seventh verse. You have heard it chanted at funerals, sung on radios, printed on calendars behind grocery counters until its edges became blunt and meaningless. But listen to it now, doctor. Strip away the incense and the harmonium, and hear what it actually tells you."

The bird took one step closer along the branch, leaning down toward me.

"Karmany-evādhikāras te—your right, your authority, your sacred jurisdiction begins and ends strictly with the action itself. *Mā phaleṣhu kadāchana*—never, under any celestial sky or earthly roof, does it extend to the fruit."

"I am not asking for a fruit," I protested weakly. *"I was asking for a way to heal them…"*

"You were asking for a result," the parrot interrupted, his voice firm as polished marble. "And worse: you were asking for an outcome you could weigh, measure, and present to a room full of strutting peacocks in the city so they would clap their wings and say, 'Look at this noble, progressive doctor from the mud lanes!'"

The words hit me like a splash of cold well water. I recoiled slightly. "That is unfair."

"Is it?" The bird tilted his head, his coral beak gleaming in the gathering indigo twilight. "Examine your own heart, healer. Why did the city doctor's words cut into you like a rusty knife? Did they cut you because your patient Sampath's foot suddenly hurt more? Did they cut you because the twenty-paise metformin stopped lowering blood sugars? No. They cut your pride. They wounded your ego, the delicate, perfumed ego of the righteous rural doctor who secretly wanted the high-born scholars of the capital to acknowledge his sacrifice."

I opened my mouth to dispute him, but the breath died in my chest.

In the ruthless clarity of the magical twilight, the veil of my self-delusion parted. He was right. Behind my genuine grief for my patients' poverty, there had been a subtle, parasitic hunger for validation: the desire to be seen by the academic elite not as an obsolete country apothecary, but as an enlightened, modern practitioner who was tragically misunderstood. Dr. Ramanathan had not merely challenged my therapeutic protocol; he had refused to grant me the moral medal I had quietly expected for my rural martyrdom.

"The physician in the air-conditioned hall lives in a kingdom of paper and light," the parrot continued, his voice softening now,

carrying the cool, fragrant rustle of the neem canopy above us. *"He lives in the clean world of clinical trials, where every variable is controlled, every patient is compliant, and every disease follows the textbooks. He measures his success by the elegance of his survival curves. It is easy to be an apostle of perfection when you never have to smell the pus in the rag."*

"He doesn't know what it's like," I murmured, my voice trembling.

"Of course he doesn't," the bird said. "And why should he? That is his arena; this is yours. But your error, doctor, was in demanding that his arena bless yours. You took your mud-stained boots into his marble temple and asked him to tell you that your mud was holy. When he told you your mud was merely dirty, you wept like an orphan."

The bird hopped down from the branch entirely, landing with feather-light grace upon the edge of the river stone right beside my knee. Up close, I could see the minute, intricate geometry of his plumage each feather a masterwork of green silk, fitting into the next without a single gap, oiled, waterproof, resilient against the storms.

"Hear the rest of the verse, physician," the parakeet said, leaning his small head until his warm, black-and-pink collar brushed against the fabric of my trousers. "*Mā karma-phala-hetur bhūḥ*—do not let the fruit of your labor be your motive. When you stand over Sampath's foot tomorrow morning, why do you clean it? Do you clean it so that an international registry can record a successful limb-salvage rate? Do you clean it so that the district medical officer writes you a commendation? Or do you clean it simply because there is a wound in front of you, and your hands possess the skill to wash away the rot?"

“Because the wound is there,” I said, the truth rising from my gut, unadorned by theory. “Because if I do not wash it, the flies will lay eggs in it, and he will lose his leg.”

“Then wash it!” the bird snapped, clicking his beak with fierce joy. “Wash it with normal saline that costs thirty rupees a bottle! Dress it with honey and betadine if the silver-impregnated hydrogels are locked in city warehouses! Give him the generic metformin that costs twenty paise! It is not the ultimate medicine of the twentieth-first century? So be it! It is the medicine that can enter his mouth tonight without starving his children tomorrow! That is your duty. That is your dharma.”

A profound stillness seemed to settle over the courtyard. The ambient noises of the evening the distant honk of a lorry on the highway, the barking of a village mongrel, the rattling of utensils in the tea stall down the road faded into a gentle, non-intrusive hum, as if the neem tree had dropped a dome of silence around us.

“And what of his accusation?” I asked, looking down at the bird. “That I have given up? That I have surrendered my efforts?”

The parrot turned his head, looking up into the vast, darkening dome of the neem branches above us.

“Look at this tree,” the parakeet whispered.

I looked up. The leaves were moving in a breeze I could no longer feel on my skin, shimmering like thousands of green fish swimming against a purple tide.

“This tree has stood here for two hundred years,” the bird said. “In the great drought of eighty-two, when the village well went dry and the cattle died in their tethers, this tree did not say, ‘I cannot

produce five thousand sweet mangoes like the orchards of the river valley, therefore my living is a failure.' It did not refuse to grow because the soil was dry red clay instead of alluvial silt. It sank its roots through forty cubits of solid granite rock until it found the secret, bitter water hidden in the bowels of the earth. And what did it do with that bitter water? Did it hoard it? It made these bitter green leaves. And those leaves cast a cool shadow. A weary bullock cart driver rested his back against this trunk at noon. A stray dog whelped her puppies in the hollow of its roots. A pair of sunbirds built their nest from its dry twigs. And a foolish, weeping doctor found a stone to sit on when his vanity was bruised by a peacock in the city."

The bird looked back at me, his golden eyes burning with an ancient, unbearable compassion.

"The neem does not ask to be a mango tree, doctor. It does not apologize for its bitterness. It simply yields its shade to whoever walks beneath it, and when the leaves turn yellow, it lets them fall without asking the wind where it is carrying them. That is *Mā te saṅgo 'stvakarmaṇi* do not attach yourself to inaction. Do not say, 'Because I cannot do the absolute best, I will do nothing at all.' You do the maximum possible within the boundaries of the field given to you. You give every ounce of your intellect, every drop of your tenderness, every clean strip of gauze in your cupboard. And then... you let the result go. You surrender it to the wind, to the river, to the great, unfathomable turning of the world."

The tears that came now were different. They were not the burning, acidic drops of humiliation or wounded pride. They were cool, sweet, washing away the grit that had settled into the corners of my soul.

I closed my eyes. The stone beneath my thighs felt warm now, as if the heat of the afternoon had settled deep into its mineral marrow. The smell of the neem blossoms above was intoxicating, clean and astringent, purging the foul ghost of carbolic acid and self-pity from my nostrils.

"I wanted to be great," I whispered into the darkness of my folded arms. "I wanted to be a great doctor."

"You are already a doctor," the voice murmured, softer now, fading like the rustle of dry silk across stone. "Greatness is a garment that men invent to hide their nakedness from each other. Be a neem tree. Drink the bitter water of this village, turn it into shade, and leave the measuring of the canopy to the crows."

I sat in that fragrant, velvet darkness for a long time.

My breathing slowed, matching the long, rhythmic exhalations of the branches above. The tension that had held my shoulders rigid since yesterday dissolved, muscle by muscle, tendon by tendon, sinking down into the red earth through the soles of my sandals. The memory of Dr. Ramanathan's polished lectern, his three-piece suit, his glowing survival curves—all of it seemed to shrink, drifting away like dry leaves down a canal, until it was nothing more than a tiny, distant speck of dust against the vast, star-strewn sky.

When I opened my eyes, the twilight had deepened into night.

The moon had risen above the clinic roof—a crisp, crescent sliver of silver that cast sharp, intricate shadows of the neem foliage across the packed clay yard.

The branch beside my shoulder was empty.

I stood up. My knees popped in the silence, but the leaden heaviness in my chest was completely gone. In its place was a light, clear, spacious quiet—the kind of stillness that fills a house when an unwanted guest has finally packed his bags and departed.

I reached out and laid my palm against the rough, fissured bark of the neem trunk. It was warm to the touch, vibrating with the silent, unseen ascent of sap from the deep granite beds below. At my feet, resting squarely in the center of the gray river stone, lay a single, perfect parakeet feather: bright emerald green, tipped with the faintest crescent of gold.

I picked it up. It weighed nothing at all. I slipped it carefully into the breast pocket of my shirt, right behind my stethoscope.

The morning sun had barely crested the palmyra palms when the rusted iron gate creaked open.

A slow, uneven dragging sound echoed down the corridor, followed by the familiar scuff of worn rubber slippers.

The door moved inward.

Sampath stood there, leaning heavily on a bamboo staff he had fashioned from an old fence post. He looked tired; the skin around his eyes was dark with the sleeplessness of a laborer who had spent the night guarding a painful limb. Behind him, holding his father's waist with both hands, was his eight-year-old son, Ramesh, his hair combed flat with coconut oil, his oversized white school shirt buttoned crookedly as always.

"Vanakkam, doctor," Sampath murmured, hovering at the doorway, hesitant to bring the dust of his life into the room.

“Come in, Sampath. Come, sit,” I said, rising and pointing to the patient stool.

Ramesh guided his father forward, his face instantly lighting up with that luminous, unblemished grin that no poverty had yet managed to dim.

Sampath hoisted his frame onto the examination stool with an audible groan, lifting his left foot carefully. The dressing was grimy from the bus floor, but the plastic cover Ramesh had tied around it had kept the road dust away from the margins.

I snapped on my gloves. I took the scissors and cut through the outer layers.

When the wound was exposed, I leaned down to examine it. It was still a deep, ugly crater over the foot. But the dusky, purulent slough at the center had thinned. At the deep margins of the ulcer, tiny, pinpoint specks of bright red tissue were beginning to show—fragile, microscopic granulations, no larger than mustard seeds, reaching upward through the raw flesh like sprouts of grass breaking through scorched soil.

The foot was not cured. It would take weeks, perhaps months. It would require endless boiling of water, constant surveillance of his diet, and meticulous compliance with his twenty-paise metformin and his ten-rupee bottle of iodine.

A day ago, looking at that wound, I would have felt the cold, paralyzing sting of Dr. Ramanathan’s voice: Have you surrendered your clinical ambition? It is easier to hand out twenty-paise pills and feel like a martyr.

Today, there was no voice. There was only the wound.

I picked up the bottle of saline. I poured the cool stream over the raw red flesh, watching the irrigation wash away the dried exudate. Sampath hissed through his teeth, his hand reaching out blindly. Ramesh stepped forward instantly, sliding his small, sturdy palm into his father's white-knuckled grip, whispering his soft, steady rhythm: "I'm here, Appa. Look at my eyes. Think about the ginger tea."

I did not think about cardiovascular risk reduction curves. I did not think about international guidelines, nor the glitzy halls of the Grand Chola, nor the applause of consultants in tailored suits. I did not think about whether this man would live to be seventy or whether his kidneys would hold out until his grandchildren were born.

Those were the fruits. They belonged to the wind, to the river, to the mysterious machinery of nature.

My jurisdiction was here: four centimeters of raw skin, a bottle of iodine, a strip of cotton gauze, and two hands trained to be steady.

I packed the wound with gentle, deliberate care. I laid the sterile pads over the tissue. I wrapped the white roller bandage around his arch, up over the ankle, anchoring it with smooth, confident turns until the foot was cocooned in clean, protective white.

"All done, Sampath," I said, peeling off my gloves and dropping them into the waste bin.

Sampath exhaled a long, shuddering breath, his shoulders relaxing. He reached down and touched the clean bandage with tentative, reverent fingertips. "It doesn't throb like before, doctor. The burning

is less."

"Keep it dry," I told him, writing out his prescription for the week: metformin, glimepiride, and a course of generic amoxicillin. *"Take the tablets after meals. Eat ragi and green vegetables. No white rice twice a day. And let Ramesh look at the pills before you swallow them."*

"I will check every single one, doctor," Ramesh said solemnly, tapping his chest with that uncontainable, radiant pride.

Sampath stood up, leaning on his bamboo staff. He pulled a crumpled ten-rupee note and a small handful of two-rupee coins from the knot in his lungi, placing them carefully on the corner of my consultation table. Then he clasped his hands together, his eyes glistening with unshed tears.

"May God keep you healthy, doctor," Sampath whispered, his voice thick with gratitude. "For poor people like us... you are the only shelter we have."

He turned and began his slow, limping journey back down the corridor, his small son walking close beside his hip, supporting his weight.

I did not touch the coins on the desk. I walked to the rear window of the room and looked out into the courtyard.

The morning sun had fully crested the clinic roof, washing the ancient neem tree in brilliant, liquid gold. A sudden gust of wind swept across the open dirt plains, rushing through the yard. The immense green dome swayed, its millions of serrated needles shivering with a soft, roaring exhalation, shedding a brief, fragrant shower of white blossoms upon the earth below.

High up on the curved branch above the river stone, a flash of emerald green caught the light a wild parakeet, its wings outstretched against the vast rural sky, taking flight toward the open horizon, completely unconcerned with where it would land.

I pressed my hand against the breast pocket of my cotton shirt, felt the delicate spine of the green feather resting safely behind my stethoscope, and turned back to open the door for the next patient.

Acknowledgments

This second book is dedicated to my parents Shri. R. Gopichandran and Smt. Bhuvaneswari Gopichandran. My mother was so proud to see my first collection of short stories, she went around promoting it among her friends and relatives. She is not very fluent in English, but still read each story, slowly, consulting me for the meanings, interpreting them with me. I hope to soon write these for her in Tamil, which she reads keenly and easily. I am immensely grateful to my teachers Dr. K.P. Misra, Dr. Usha Sriram, Dr. Arjun Rajagopalan, Dr. Jayaprakash Muliyil, Dr. K.R. John, Dr. Jasmine Helan Prasad, Prof. Satish Kumar Chetlapalli and the innumerable gurus who have touched my life and left it changed permanently for the better.

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I am grateful to my erstwhile students, current friends, who read the book and told me that it helped them see their own work differently. Though I strongly believe creative pursuits do not need to have a purpose, this sentiment expressed by these young doctors made me think that the book might have served its purpose in a very small way.

Lastly, I am immensely grateful to all the patients who let me respectfully and honorably enter their personal spaces and travel with them through their illness journey. When I am unwell, I usually stall. I analyze, self-diagnose, self-medicate and at all costs avoid visiting a doctor. Colored by a high awareness of the functioning of my own body, and the high level of cognitive biases, errors of judgment and uncertainty that is inherent in the clinical process, I have a certain level of trust deficit in other doctors. On the other hand, day after day, relentlessly when I sit in my clinic and when a villager comes and sits by my side to consult me, they seldom demand my credentials, cross examine my thinking or weigh the intellectual capacity with which I am operating on that day. They just submit their pain, suffering, and difficulties in my hands with absolute trust. Their trust is not innocence, ignorance, or naivete; their trust is heroic. I come from a position of power and privilege but still find it hard to trust my colleagues. But the rural farmer in my clinic reposes immense trust, knowing well that they are powerless, and that to me is an act of absolute bravery. I salute all of them and am acutely humbled by their trust. It increases my sense of purpose and responsibility towards them.

About the Author

Vijayaprasad Gopichandran is a physician, public health researcher, and bioethicist whose writing draws deeply from more than two decades of practicing medicine at the grass roots. He earned his MBBS from Madras Medical College, followed by an MD in Community Medicine from Christian Medical College, Vellore, and a PhD from SRM University with an INSPIRE Fellowship from the Government of India.

His doctoral research focused on a subject central to both medicine and storytelling: trust in the doctor-patient relationship. Over the course of fifteen years in community health and twenty-four years in primary care, Dr. Gopichandran has worked extensively alongside marginalized and rural communities, serving with the Rural Women's Social Education Center (RUWSEC) in Chengalpet and the Omayal Achi Community Health Centre. He previously taught as an Assistant Professor of Community Medicine at ESIC Medical College, Chennai.

Beyond clinical and academic spheres, including serving as an editor for the Indian Journal of Medical Ethics and publishing over a hundred research papers, his literary work is shaped by the quiet dramas of the clinic. Sitting across from thousands of patients in rural outposts and bustling outpatient rooms, he observes the fragile spaces between vulnerability, healing, ethical doubt, and enduring human connection.

He lives in Chennai, India and practices in rural Chengalpet and Thiruvallur.

Also by the Author

Hearing the Unspoken: Stories of Health, Illness and the Human Condition

By Vijayaprasad Gopichandran

Before a symptom can be catalogued, measured, or treated, it must first be felt, and often, the deepest parts of suffering remain unvoiced.

In Hearing the Unspoken: Stories of Health, Illness and the Human Condition, Dr. Vijayaprasad Gopichandran turns his clinical gaze inward and outward, exploring the delicate architecture of medicine beyond prescriptions and pathology. Drawing from decades of experience at the frontlines of community health and primary care, this collection delves into the quiet, complex encounters between doctors and patients.

Through deeply empathetic narratives, the book examines:

- The profound emotional weight of illness carried in silence by patients and families.
- The ethical, relational, and emotional vulnerabilities faced by healers.
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